

2023

Match 1

Gujarat Titans 182 for 5 (Gill 63, Hangargekar 3-36) beat Chennai Super Kings 178 for 7 (Gaikwad 92, Rashid 2-26, Shami 2-29) by five wickets

Ruturaj Gaikwad marked his return from a wrist injury with a sublime 92 off 50 balls, and set Chennai Super Kings on track for a 200-plus score, but a middle-overs slowdown, triggered by Alzarri Joseph, limited them to 178 for 7. That total looked even more subpar when Shubman Gill extended his rich form across formats with another half-century. But his dismissal and IPL debutant Rajvardhan Hangargekar's variations at the death gave Super Kings an opening. It came down to Titans needing 30 from the last three overs, and despite the absence of Kane Williamson, who injured himself in the field, and David Miller (national duty), they completed the job in familiar fashion with Rashid Khan and Rahul Tewatia finding the crucial late boundaries.

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Moody: Players like Rashid are always involved in the hottest moments of the game

Impact of Impact Player rule

Williamson's knee injury, sustained while attempting to save a six off Gaikwad's bat, tested Titans' batting depth and perhaps didn't allow them to use the Impact Player rule as well as they would have liked to. If Williamson had been available to bat, Titans would likely have used him as their anchor and would have probably brought in Abhinav Manohar as their Impact Player down the order.

B Sai Sudharsan, who ended up replacing Williamson as the Impact Player, started brightly at No. 3, but a legcutter from Hangargekar cut his innings short at 22 off 17 balls.

Earlier, Tushar Deshpande became the first Impact Player in the IPL when he came in for Ambati Rayudu during Super Kings' defence. Deshpande found some swing in the early exchanges and then had Gill holing out for 63, but was left with only seven to defend in the final over. Tewatia finished it off with four balls to spare.

Gaikwad special

Before the start of IPL 2023, Gaikwad had not played competitive cricket for two months and had joined the CSK camp in Chepauk late after undergoing rehab at the National Cricket Academy (NCA) in Bengaluru. He showed no signs of rust and quickly set to work with a brace of punched fours off Hardik Pandya.

Devon Conway was bowled through the gate by Mohammed Shami for 1, but Gaikwad went on to play a range of sparkling shots, particularly against the seamers. Josh Little, the first Ireland player to feature in the IPL, was swatted over square leg for six while Joseph was hooked over the midwicket boundary for six more. Gaikwad charged to a half-century off just 23 balls, and when it seemed like a century was almost inevitable, Joseph had him splicing a full toss to long-on.

Ruturaj Gaikwad's 92 ended in vain • BCCI

Dube dawdles

When Dube came out to bat at No.6, Super Kings were well placed at 121 for 4 in the 13th over. Joseph and Hardik kept peppering Dube's body with short balls and he just couldn't get the pull away. According to ESPNcricinfo's logs, 13 of the 17 balls he faced were short or short-of-good-length deliveries and he could manage only one boundary off them. His go-slow sent Super Kings' innings spiralling out of control.

After conceding 18 runs in his first over, Joseph hit back to give up only 15 from his next three while taking out Gaikwad and Ravindra Jadeja.

Gill and Hangargekar sparkle

Gill matched Gaikwad shot for shot. It is often fiendishly difficult to step out and hit Mitchell Santner and Jadeja for boundaries, but Gill made it look ridiculously easy. He also targeted Deshpande, taking him for 23 off 11 balls before ultimately falling to him.

After bowling an over in the powerplay, Hangargekar also fronted up to bowl at the death and tricked Vijay Shankar (27 off 21) with a slower ball in the 18th over. His yorkers and cutters even had Super Kings' former death-overs specialist and current bowling coach Dwayne Bravo applauding from the dugout. When Hangargekar finished his shift with 4-0-36-3, Titans needed 23 off the last two overs. Rashid and Tewatia sealed victory for Titans, who made it 3-0 against Super Kings.

Match 2

Punjab Kings 191 for 5 (Rajapaksa 50, S Dhawan 40, Southee 2-54) beat Kolkata Knight Riders 146 for 7 (Russell 35, Arshdeep 3-19) by seven runs (DLS method)

For most of the contest, Kolkata Knight Riders were behind the run of play against Punjab Kings.

Chasing 192, they were 80 for 5, with victory looking like a bleak possibility. That's when Andre Russell and Venkatesh Iyer stitched together a partnership that appeared to take them ahead in the match for the first time. Russell's six and four off Sam Curran brought the equation down to 62 needed from 32 with the balance of power shifting. It also brought Knight Riders closer to the DLS target with rain hovering around Mohali.

But Russell fell next ball to Curran. Venkatesh perished in the next over. And the DLS ballooned beyond reach. Despite Shardul Thakur and Sunil Narine scoring 15 off five balls between them, Kings held on to stay ahead, and when rain finally stopped play, the DLS table showed the hosts were seven ahead, just enough to pocket two points in their season opener.

Knight Riders were behind the DLS target because of their loss of wickets up top. Arshdeep Singh was the wrecker-in-chief with the new ball, helping reduce Knight Riders to 29 for 3. He also dismissed Venkatesh later to finish with 3 for 19 in three overs.

Kings were excellent with the bat as well, especially Bhanuka Rajapaksa who made a 32-ball 50. His knock lifted Kings to 100 for 1 in ten overs, but they failed to get a boost at the death, finishing only on 191 for 5. At the time, it looked like a score that was just about par on a batting-friendly surface. In the end, it was enough.

Impact Player's impact

Rajapaksa was replaced by Rishi Dhawan, the bowling allrounder, for the second innings but the Sri Lankan had done the damage by then. He picked up from where opener Prabhsimran Singh left off in the afternoon. Rajapaksa was especially brutal against spin. He used his feet to attack both pacers and spinners, and overshadowed his captain Shikhar Dhawan who struggled to find much strike.

When Rajapaksa was out in the 11th over, he held up his end of the bargain for the Kings to post a big total. His replacement, Rishi, conceded 15 in the only over he bowled.

For Knight Riders, it was Varun Chakravarthy who was swapped out after the first innings. Varun bowled smartly to finish with 1 for 26 in four overs, but it was a given that Venkatesh or N Jagadeesan would replace him. When the Knight Riders were 17 for 2 in two overs, they opted for Venkatesh. He made 34 in 28 balls.

Bhanuka Rajapaksa scored a 30-ball half-century•PTI

Inexperienced Knight Riders crumble

Knight Riders' batting always gave the impression that they would either impress magnificently or crash and burn. More so with their regular captain Shreyas Iyer also missing. They went with one of their most inexperienced top-six units, and both Mandeep Singh and Anukul Roy struggled against Arshdeep's accurate short-pitch bowling that was aimed at their necks.

Rahmanullah Gurbaz sparkled with three fours and a six to race to 22 off 16, but when he fell as the third wicket, the rest of the chase was an uphill battle. Nitish Rana made 24 in 17 and Rinku Singh was out cheaply too, leaving old hands Venkatesh and Russell to do the repair job.

Eventually, it was Curran who brought the breakthrough with a short ball that had Russell pulling to midwicket. Narine and Shardul gave Knight Riders a brief glimmer of hope, but that was about it.

A solid Punjab Kings performance

Kings were inserted in at the toss, and Prabhsimran's 12-ball 23 was the perfect start for them. Even though Shikhar was starved for strike, it didn't impact Kings' scoring rate because of Rajapaksa's assault, especially on Narine. In all, Rajapaksa muscled five fours and two sixes to reach his half-century in 30 balls.

After his dismissal, Jitesh Sharma took over, smacking 21 in 11. Even when Varun bowled Shikhar for 40 to make it 143 for 3 in 14.3 overs, Kings aimed for 200-plus. But a couple of quiet overs from Varun restricted their progress. Raza, Curran and Shahrukh Khan put together small cameos to score 53 in 37 balls between them at the death, and even if that left Kings a little disappointed, Arshdeep's new-ball spell in the second innings ensured their victory.

Match 3

Lucknow Super Giants 193 (Mayers 73, Pooran 36, Khaleel 2-30) beat Delhi Capitals 143 for 9 (Warner 56, Wood 5-14) by 50 runs

An explosive 38-ball 73 from Kyle Mayers on IPL debut and a blistering spell of fast bowling from Mark Wood, who was featuring in only his second IPL game, razed Delhi Capitals in Lucknow.

Mayers might not have even played this game for Lucknow Super Giants had Quinton de Kock been available for the franchise. He was dropped on 14 by Khaleel Ahmed and in the powerplay, he managed only a run-a-ball 17. The left-handed batter then lined up Capitals' left-arm spinners Axar Patel and Kuldeep Yadav to finish with almost two runs a ball; Super Giants finished with an above-par 193 for 6 on a challenging pitch.

Wood then took the pitch out of the equation and knocked over Prithvi Shaw and Mitchell Marsh with 147kph thunderbolts. He went on to become the second England player after Dimitri Mascarenhas to bag a five-wicket haul in the IPL. Though Capitals' new captain David Warner made a half-century, he couldn't keep in touch with the mounting asking rate. Capitals eventually fell short of their target by 51 runs.

Impact Players: Aman Khan and K Gowtham

After Khaleel finished his four overs with the ball, Capitals replaced him with Aman Khan. Aman, who is arguably a better fielder than Khaleel, patrolled the boundary in the last over of Super Giants' innings. Then, when he came out to bat at No.7 for Capitals, their chase had already spiralled out of control.

With just one ball left in their innings, Super Giants roped in allrounder K Gowtham as an Impact Player in place of Ayush Badoni, who had just holed out for 18 off seven balls. Gowtham launched his first ball - and the final ball of the innings - for six and then gave up just 23 runs in his four overs. Warner, in particular, struggled to get Gowtham away, managing only seven off eight balls from him.

Kyle Mayers brought up a 28-ball half-century •BCCI

Mayers messes with Kuldeep and Axar

The Ekana pitch was a strange one. The green patch offered some extra bounce while the drier areas assisted turn. At the post-match presentation, Warner felt that they were playing on two different surfaces from either end. Mayers didn't take too many risks in the powerplay, where Super Giants crawled to 30 for 1.

But then he went on a boundary-hitting spree against Kuldeep and Axar. All up, he smashed them for 42 off 17 balls. It needed a ripper from Axar to bowl Mayers in the 12th over. Mayers' early success in the IPL will leave Super Giants' management with a happy headache once de Kock links up with the side after the final ODI against Netherlands, which is on April 2.

Pooran, Badoni provide finishing kick

Nicholas Pooran, for whom Super Giants had shelled out INR 16 crore (USD 1.95 million approx.) at the auction, also made a good impression, hitting 36 off 21 balls. Pooran cracked his fourth ball for six and went onto hit two more sixes. Twenty-three-year-old Ayush Badoni, who was Super Giants' finisher last season, pitched in with 18 off seven balls as Super Giants posted a huge total.

Wood cranks it up

Wood then took centre stage as he harried Capitals with high pace and trampoline bounce. After softening Prithvi Shaw with the bouncer, Wood went fuller and stormed through his defences with a seemingly unplayable inducker. He went even fuller to Marsh next ball and bowled him in similar fashion by getting the ball to zip back in off the seam. Wood missed the hat-trick, but in his next over, he banged one in at Sarfaraz Khan's throat and had him ramping a catch to deep fine leg when he was aiming to clear deep third. Wood returned to decimate the lower order too and marked his return to the IPL after five years with a Player-of-the-Match display.

Match 4

Rajasthan Royals 203 for 5 (Samson 55, Buttler 54, Jaiswal 54) beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 131 for 8 (Samad 32, Chahal 4-17, Boult 2-21) by 72 runs

Rajasthan Royals dominated the first half of their batting innings, racing to 122 for 1 in ten overs. And then they owned the first half of their bowling innings too, reducing Sunrisers Hyderabad to 52 for 6 in 11 overs.

The two periods of play proved decisive and led last season's runners-up to a 72-run victory to kickstart their 2023 campaign.

It was all Royals from the first over of the game. Their top three of Jos Buttler, Yashasvi Jaiswal and Sanju Samson thumped half-centuries to give their team a record-breaking start: Royals posted their highest powerplay score (85) and also their fastest hundred in the IPL (in 7.4 overs). Even though their middle and lower order didn't fire, the brutal hitting at the top ensured that the Royals posted the first 200-plus score of the season.

The target of 204 was daunting against a strong Royals attack, and Trent Boult killed any hope of a successful chase by beginning with a double-wicket maiden. Yuzvendra Chahal then ran through the Sunrisers with a four-wicket haul. The margin of defeat was a blow to the Sunrisers' net run rate, eerily similar to how their 2022 season began.

Buttler begins like a boss

Jaiswal raced to 24 off 11 balls before Buttler raised his tempo even more, smacking Washington Sundar for successive sixes over midwicket and T Natarajan for four fours in five balls. Buttler then hit three fours in four balls off Afghanistan's Fazalhaq Farooqi to bring up his fifty off 20 balls.

By the time Buttler fell, Royals were 85 for 1 in 5.5 overs. Jaiswal then picked up the pace while Samson settled in; and Samson kept the momentum going when Jaiswal was dismissed for 54. He looked set for a huge score but was superbly caught by Abhishek Sharma on the edge of the long-on boundary for 55.

Adil Rashid's tidy spell in the middle overs, combined with improved second spells from Natarajan and Farooqi reduced the flow of runs. At one stage it seemed like Royals might fall just short of 200, but a late cameo from Shimron Hetmyer gave them 203.

Jos Buttler slammed a fifty off 20 balls against Sunrisers Hyderabad • BCCI

Sunrisers sink fast in the chase

After Abhishek and Rahul Tripathi were out for ducks in Boult's opening over, Harry Brook and Mayank Agarwal had the gargantuan task of repairing the innings while faced with a rising asking rate. It didn't happen. Brook was bowled by Chahal googly, out for a 21-ball 13 in his maiden IPL innings.

Jason Holder got Washington out cheaply with a short ball; Glenn Phillips hit R Ashwin straight to cover; and Chahal returned to cut short Agarwal's innings. Chahal then had fellow legspinner Rashid stumped, and Bhuvneshwar playing all around a googly to have

Sunrisers at 95 for 8. Abdul Samad's unbeaten 32 helped them limp past 100, and they eventually finished with 131 for 8.

Impact Players: Samad and Saini

Sunrisers' Impact Player Samad had a better day out, compared to the Royals' Impact Player Navdeep Saini. Samad walked in when Sunrisers were 48 for 5 as a replacement for Farooqi, and held one end up even as wickets kept falling. He reined in his shot-making instincts for the most part, looking to last till the end. He did that successfully, finishing on an unbeaten 32.

Saini entered the game as Jaiswal's replacement midway through the Sunrisers chase and had a tough outing. He bowled only three dots in his two-over spell, and conceded 34 at an economy of 17.

Match 5

Royal Challengers Bangalore 172 for 2 (Kohli 82*, du Plessis 73) beat Mumbai Indians 171 for 7 (Varma 84*, Wadhera 21, Karn 2-32) by eight wickets

Virat Kohli and Faf du Plessis hit scintillating half-centuries as Royal Challengers Bangalore marked their homecoming with a dominating eight-wicket win over Mumbai Indians.

The win was set up by Royal Challengers' bowlers. After inserting Mumbai in, du Plessis used seven of them; except Glenn Maxwell who bowled just one over, everyone else picked up at least one wicket.

That Mumbai could post 171 for 7 in itself was an achievement. After 15 overs, they were 102 for 5 but Tilak Varma's magnificent 84 not out off 46 balls gave them something to fight with.

Du Plessis and Kohli, though, showed how much under par Mumbai were. The pair added 148 in 14.5 overs for the opening stand, du Plessis hitting a 43-ball 73 and Kohli an unbeaten 82 off 49. Between them, they hit 11 fours and as many sixes. When Kohli hit the winning six, 22 balls were still left in the game.

Impact Player - Behrendorff in for Suryakumar

Mumbai, who had started the game with three overseas players, brought in Jason Behrendorff in the second innings. He replaced Suryakumar Yadav, but it made little difference as Behrendorff went for 37 in three wicketless overs. Royal Challengers were in such a comfortable position throughout that they didn't even use an Impact Player.

A powerless powerplay

M Chinnaswamy Stadium is infamous for being the bowlers' graveyard. However, that wasn't the case in the first innings, with the ball coming slightly slower off the surface. Mohammed Siraj bowled three overs in the powerplay for just five runs and Ishan

Kishan's wicket. Kishan had hit two fours off Reece Topley in the second over but Siraj created the pressure with dot balls. When Kishan tried to break away, he ended up miscuing one to deep third.

Batting at No. 3, Cameron Green lasted only four balls and was castled by a Topley yorker. Siraj could have had Rohit Sharma too in the next over. After bowling three dots in a row to Rohit, Siraj went for a bouncer. Rohit countered it with a pull, only to top-edge it straight up. But Siraj couldn't hear Dinesh Karthik's call - blame it on the deafening noise by the spectators - and ended up colliding with the wicketkeeper, and the chance went down. It didn't prove costly, though, as Akash Deep had Rohit caught behind three balls later. Rohit made 1 off ten balls; Mumbai ended the powerplay on 29 for 3.

Tilak Varma raises his bat after reaching a well-deserved half-century•BCCI

Varma plays a lone hand

Coming in at 19 for 3, Varma opened his account with a second-ball six. Suryakumar's wicket in the ninth over left Mumbai at 48 for 4 but Varma kept playing his shots. He hit Maxwell for a six and four off successive balls before scooping Deep four a boundary in the next over.

He found some support from debutant Nehal Wadhera who hit Karn Sharma for back-to-back sixes, the second one going landing on the roof over long-on. When he tried it for the third time, he holed out. In his next over, Karn dealt a much bigger blow by bowling Tim David.

Varma appeared immune to all that and brought up his fifty in 32 balls. His knock had steered Mumbai to 133 for 7 after 18 overs. Then, Siraj lost his radar and sent down five off-side wides - four of them in a row. To make it worse, Varma picked up two fours as well in the over.

Harshal Patel had conceded only 21 from his first three overs but he too bore the brunt now, going for 22 in the last over of the innings. Arshad Khan, the other debutant on the night, smashed the second ball of the over for a six. Varma followed it with a pulled four before wrapping up the innings with a helicoptered six.

Faf du Plessis and Virat Kohli started strongly for Royal Challengers Bangalore•BCCI

The du Plessis-Kohli show

Mumbai's left-arm seamers Behrendorff and Arshad found swing with the new ball, but du Plessis defused that threat by using his feet. He went down the track three times in Behrendorff's second over, hitting one four and two successive sixes.

Jofra Archer failed to latch on to a tough return catch from Kohli off his first ball for Mumbai. On the next, Kohli steered him for four, and then went down the track to launch a slower one over long-off.

Du Plessis too enjoyed his luck when Kishan dropped him off Piyush Chawla in the fifth over, and took the side to 53 for no loss at the end of the powerplay. A couple of overs later, he welcomed Green into the attack with two fours and a six.

Du Plessis brought up his fifty - off 29 balls - with a six off Hrithik Shokeen and celebrated it with another six on the spinner's next ball. Kohli, despite hitting some eye-catching shots, was playing second fiddle to du Plessis. He took 38 balls for his half-century but by the time du Plessis got out, he had almost caught up with him.

Karthik was promoted to No. 3. He fetched a three-ball duck but Maxwell smashed two sixes in three balls to take Royal Challengers to the brink of victory.

Match 6

Gaikwad tees off, Conway follows

Gaikwad began the season with a 50-ball 92 in Ahmedabad, and his follow-up was an equally blistering knock high on aesthetic value. This half-century came off 25 balls, as Gaikwad announced himself in his very first outing at Chepauk.

The highlight was the three sixes he hit in K Gowtham's first over, the fifth of the innings. This included a straight hit off the backfoot and an inside-out six over extra cover.

Conway wasn't far behind. He began with crunching off-drives off Avesh Khan and Mark Wood to get into full rhythm, and then unleashed a ferocious slog-sweep off Krunal Pandya. The pair brought up a century opening stand in eight overs with that hit.

Bishnoi makes a grand entry

Ravi Bishnoi had Super Giants heaving a sigh of relief when he struck with his first delivery in the 10th over. Gaikwad was deceived in the air and off the pitch as his slog landed in a backpedalling short third's hand. One brought two when Wood had Conway with a short ball that he miscued to deep square, where Krunal Pandya's athleticism made the catch possible.

Super Kings promoted Shivam Dube to No. 3, ahead of Moeen Ali and Ben Stokes, and he pottered to 5 off 10 before picking up the scoring. He hit Bishnoi for back-to-back sixes in the 14th over, before falling in the same over to a wrong'un while attempting a slog to the short leg-side boundary. Bishnoi would complete a key spell by picking up Moeen in his next over to finish with 3 for 28 off his four overs.

The Dhoni finish

Only twice in his 15-year IPL career has Dhoni hit the first ball of his innings for six; Super Giants have borne the brunt both times. Having come in with six balls left, he slashed Wood over third man for his first six. Then, in a shot somewhat reminiscent of Sachin Tendulkar's pull off Andrew Caddick at Durban at the 2003 World Cup, he got into position and swatted

a pull that sailed over deep square leg. He now had the crowd expecting another, but that wasn't to be. When he sliced a catch to deep point, the party was over, but he had helped Super Kings blast their way to 217 for 7.

ESPNcricinfo Ltd

Moeen slices through LSG after Mayers' blast

Mayers has a touch of Chris Gayle to him. His reach, his ability to pick lengths early and swing through the line brought him massive returns as he went after Super Kings' erratic pacers. Chahar found no swing and Deshpande struggled for accuracy. Super Giants rushed to 73 for 0 in the first five overs. But Super Kings stormed back with three quick wickets from overs six to eight.

Mayers, who brought up a 21-ball half-century, and Rahul holed out to deep midwicket, while Deepak Hooda heaved one to long-on. Moeen and Santner were right in the game and Dhoni was able to exercise the kind of control he loves. Krunal Pandya and Marcus Stoinis continued to attack, but the enormity of the task at hand meant they had to keep taking their chances which eventually led to their downfall.

Deshpande redeems himself

A left-arm spinner to a left-hander is a match-up not quite up Dhoni's alley. But because the pacers had all proved expensive, and Moeen and Santner had bowled out, Dhoni had no option but to go to Ravindra Jadeja in the 15th over. It didn't help that Pooran was in sensational form.

After flat-batting Jadeja for a six over extra-cover, he followed up by reverse-sweeping a dart for a 97-metre six over the point boundary. It brought Super Giants' equation down to 68 off 30. Deshpande, who was then brought on for his second over, delivered a telling blow, getting Pooran caught at long-off in an over that went for just six runs.

That, right there, was the game for the Super Kings.

Match 7

Gujarat Titans 163 for 4 (Sudharsan 62*, Nortje 2-39) beat Delhi Capitals 162 for 8 (Warner 37, Rashid 3-31, Shami 3-41, Joseph 2-29) by six wickets

Three-wicket hauls from Mohammed Shami and Rashid Khan, backed up a measured unbeaten half-century from B Sai Sudharsan gave the defending champions Gujarat Titans their second consecutive win at the start of the 2023 season. Delhi Capitals suffered their second straight loss, in their first home game this year.

After Shami, Alzarri Joseph and Rashid restricted Capitals to 162 for 8, Anrich Nortje's pace had Titans in trouble at 54 for 3 in the sixth over. Sudharsan and Vijay Shankar, who was subbed in as Gujarat's Impact Player for Josh Little, forged a 53-run stand to take Titans

closer. David Miller, who had arrived in Delhi from Johannesburg only the previous day, provided the finishing touches as Titans wrapped up the win with 11 balls to spare.

Shami struggles and then hurts Capitals

The Delhi pitch was lively from the outset and Shami was unable to control his swing, conceding ten runs through wides in his first two overs during the powerplay. He also bowled several superb deliveries, one of which beat David Warner and grazed the off stump but did not dislodge the bail. Shami got Prithvi Shaw to spoon a well-directed short ball to mid-on and had Mitchell Marsh chopping a back of a length ball on to his stumps. Though Capitals managed to score 52 for 2 in the powerplay, none of their batters looked confident.

Sai Sudharsan is filling the gap left by Kane Williamson at No. 3 for Gujarat Titans•BCCI

Joseph and Rashid contain Capitals

Joseph also made life miserable for the Capitals. His first over cost 11 runs but his second was memorable. He first ended Warner's difficult stay, inducing a thick inside-edge on to the stumps. The next ball was a snorter to Rilee Rossouw, who fended in the air towards point, where Rahul Tewatia dived forward to take a sharp catch. Joseph was quick, mean, and accurate. Sarfaraz Khan and Abishek Porel were both struck on the helmet by his ferocious bouncers, as Joseph kept hitting speeds in excess of 145 kilometres per hour.

With pace causing Capitals plenty of problems, legspinner Rashid Khan was brought into the attack only in the 13th over and he had immediate impact. Rashid had Porel playing all around a sharp legbreak second ball, and he dismissed Sarfaraz and Aman Khan in the 17th and 19th overs. Only Axar Patel looked comfortable for Capitals, and his 36 off 22 balls helped them reach 162.

The Sudharsan-Vijay Delhi connection

Heading into this game, Tamil Nadu team-mates Sudharsan and Vijay had strung together two fifty-run stands in four innings, and coincidentally both of those partnerships had come at the Aurn Jaitley Stadium during the 2021 Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy. Now, batting for Titans, the pair produced another half-century stand in Delhi after beginning their stand in a difficult situation. Nortje had bowled the openers Wriddhiman Saha and Shubman Gill, and Khaleel Ahmed had Hardik Pandya caught behind. With the asking rate under control, Sudharsan and Shankar built the chase steadily, taking no unnecessary risks and rotating strike while scoring the occasional boundary in between.

Mohammed Shami gave the Titans two early wickets•Associated Press

Sudharsan keeps his head; Miller does what he does best

Sudharsan was one of the finds of the tournament last year and comes into this IPL on the back of a terrific domestic season. Though Nortje cranking up the pace and Kuldeep Yadav getting the odd one to rip, he never seemed out of depth. Sudharsan reached his fifty off 44

balls and remained unbeaten at the finish. Miller, on the other hand, found his bearings from the start, cracking Mukesh Kumar for 20 runs in the 16th over to decide the game. Miller was Titans' mainstay last year with his finishing abilities, and he started this season by having a similar impact.

Impact Players: Khaleel Ahmed and Vijay Shankar

Vijay had a stronger impact on the game than his Delhi counterpart. Khaleel entered the game at the start of the second innings, replacing Sarfaraz Khan, and while he did dismiss Hardik, he went for 38 runs in his four overs. Vijay managed a 23-ball 29 and his partnership with Sudharsan was one that turned the game for the Titans.

Match 8

Punjab Kings 197 for 4 (Dhawan 86*, Prabhsimran 60) beat Rajasthan Royals 192 for 7 (Samson 42, Ellis 4-30) by five runs

Punjab Kings made it two wins from two - and two defences under lights - as they held off a late-innings rampage from Rajasthan Royals to ensure Guwahati's IPL debut ended in defeat for the home side. Kings rode on half-centuries from Prabhsimran Singh and Shikhar Dhawan and, although they fell short of passing 200, Nathan Ellis' four-wicket haul was vital in hobbling Royals in the chase.

Dhawan, who became the third batter after David Warner and Virat Kohli to record 50 scores of 50-plus in the IPL, anchored Kings to what was perhaps only a par score at the compact Barsapara Stadium with an unbeaten 86 off 56. Only 45 runs came off the last five overs, with economical spells from Jason Holder and R Ashwin pivotal in preventing the game from running away after Prabhsimran had helped fire Kings to 63 for 0 in the powerplay.

Royal then shipped wickets at regular intervals, despite some crisp hitting from Sanju Samson. They seemed out of contention at 129 for 6 at the end of the 16th over, only for Shimron Hetmyer and Dhruv Jurel, Royals' Impact Sub, to summon a boundary-hitting spree that reduced the requirement to 16 off the final over, bowled by Sam Curran. But the IPL's record overseas signing held his nerve at the end of an otherwise indifferent performance to hand Royals a first defeat of the 2023 edition.

Prabhsimran comes out swinging

As he had in Kings' opening victory over Kolkata Knight Riders, Prabhsimran set the early tempo after his side were inserted. He clubbed his third ball, from Trent Boult, over mid-off and then spanked his first in KM Asif's second over into the stand at deep backward square leg. In the next from Asif, Prabhsimran helped himself to 18 more - three crashing fours and a six - before hitting Ashwin's second and third balls for boundaries as well.

He was dropped by Devdutt Padikkal from the final ball of the powerplay, a sizzling drive bursting through the fielder's grasp at cover as he threw the hands up, but had already

made 44 by that point. A maiden IPL half-century followed in the eighth over, from just 28 balls, and there was time for one more belligerent mow into the sightscreen off Boult before a miscue looking to take Holder over the leg side was athletically taken by Jos Buttler sprinting in from long-off.

2:30

Manjrekar impressed with Prabhsimran's evolution

Dhawan gets it done

Despite playing second fiddle to Prabhsimran during their opening stand, Dhawan went through the gears with aplomb through the second half of the innings. From 30 off 30 with three boundaries, he motored through to a 36-ball fifty - he took particular toll on Yuzvendra Chahal, who was dispatched for 6-1-4-4-2-4 on the way to a head-to-head analysis of 33 from 14 balls against the Kings captain.

Dhawan's charge enabled Kings to ransack 57 runs in a four-over span, having been briefly checked by the dismissal of Prabhsimran and a blow to Bhanuka Rajapaksa's forearm - sustained at the non-striker's end off a Dhawan drive - that forced him to retire hurt but, as Rajapaksa confirmed on Twitter later, was not serious*. Chahal removed Jitesh Sharma after a 66-run stand, and Ashwin then pinged the top of Sikandar Raza's off stump, but Dhawan revved the engine again, an audacious reverse-flick off Jason Holder sailing for six over deep backward point.

Asif, who leaked 20 from 11 balls to Dhawan, was ramped for six more in the 19th over and a Dhawan century was not out of the question. But he couldn't get on strike for the final over, Holder conceding just seven runs to keep Kings below 200.

Arshdeep strikes, Samson counters

With Buttler needing stitches on his fingers after taking a low catch from the last over of the Kings innings, Royals opted to send out Ashwin to open the batting alongside Yashasvi Jaiswal. An action-packed powerplay then began with Jaiswal nonchalantly swatting the first ball of the chase, bowled by Curran, into the crowd at deep square leg.

Jaiswal struck Arshdeep's first delivery to the rope as well, but fell in the same over when he flubbed a drive to cover. Buttler by this point was fit to walk out, and the Ashwin gambit ended in failure when he mistimed a pull to go without scoring in Arshdeep's second over. Kings had already seen Buttler survive a chance by that point, with Harpreet Brar putting down a running catch in the deep off Curran.

3:01

Are Royals wasting Hetmyer down the order?

Samson looked to put the pressure back on straight away, smoking Arshdeep straight back down the ground from his second ball. He took Brar and Ellis for back-to-back fours in consecutive overs as Royals breezed past 50 from 31 balls - but when Buttler diverted a caught-and-bowled chance back to Ellis off his pads, Royals were 57 for 3 and wobbling.

Ellis mops up

Ellis only played twice for Kings in 2022 but has made himself a first-choice overseas pick in the 12 months since, keeping Kagiso Rabada out of the XI. He added Samson to his bag just past the midway point of the innings and was on a hat-trick when he had Riyan Parag, the local boy whose volley of boundaries brought the crowd back to life, taken at long-off a few overs later. Hetmyer survived but Padikkal was bowled neck and crop for a limp 21 off 26 to finish the over. Ellis' fourth went for 16 but figures of 4 for 30 were the difference in what became a tight chase.

Impact player: Dhruv Jurel and Rishi Dhawan

Kings looked like becoming the second team, after Royal Challengers Bangalore, not to introduce an impact sub; they eventually brought on Rishi Dhawan for Prabhsimran after 15 overs of their defence, but he was not used with the ball as his opposite number threatened to have a match-turning impact. Jurel had initially trotted on at the end of the 16th over in Kings innings, after Chahal had bowled his allocation. Batting at No. 8, the 22-year-old showed both power and a cool temperament to thump 32 from 15 in only his fourth T20 innings, as Royals' seventh-wicket pair took the game to the wire.

Match 9

Kolkata Knight Riders 204 for 7 (Thakur 68, Gurbaz 57, Willey 2-16) beat Royal Challengers Bangalore 123 (du Plessis 23, Varun 4-15, Suyash 3-30) by 81 runs

Eleven-and-a-half overs into Kolkata Knight Riders' return to Eden Gardens, it seemed they were looking at a long, painful IPL ahead. Having lost the first match, they were 89 for 5. Andre Russell had got out for a golden duck. Shardul Thakur nearly became Karn Sharma's hat-trick victim, but then fashioned one of the remarkable IPL turnarounds.

Thakur's 68 off 29 - second-highest score for a No. 7 in the IPL - took KKR to 204 - the highest total for a team five down for less than 100. It was still probably just a par score with small boundaries and a quick outfield. It looked so when Faf du Plessis and Virat Kohli gave Royal Challengers Bangalore a flying start, but the two mystery spinners, Sunil Narine and Varun Chakravarthy, ran through their batting to give them a reality check in an IPL they start as one of the favourites.

Willey slots right in

At some point in the lead-up to the match, Royal Challengers learnt that Reece Topley would be missing the whole IPL after he injured himself during the first match. Minutes in, David Willey showed he could be the perfect replacement. He cleaned up Venkatesh Iyer with

seam movement in, and then squared Mandeep Singh up with a wobble-seam delivery to kiss the off stump. The latter put him on a hat-trick. Willey's figures of 3-1-9-0 in the powerplay were offset by the profligate Mohammed Siraj and Akash Deep, who leaked 38 from the other end.

Gurbaz stopped short by Karn

Even as the wickets fell and the fans questioned Knight Riders' work at the auction table, one acquisition, Rahmanullah Gurbaz, continued to show promise. His execution of aggressive intent took him to his first IPL fifty, off 38 balls despite losing four leg-glanced runs to a wrong leg-bye call. The first non-Gurbaz boundary came in the 11th over, but he had taken them to 79 for 3 in those ten overs. A good total was still on.

Rahmanullah Gurbaz steered Knight Riders almost single-handedly in the first ten overs•BCCI

In the 12th over, Gurbaz middled a reverse sweep off Karn Sharma but found short third to perfection. Not for the first time, Knight Riders were down to Andre Russell or bust. Bust it appeared to be as Russell tried to hit the first ball for a six, and found long-off.

Thakur takes over

The hat-trick ball that Thakur faced was the farthest from an indicator of things to come. Big back lift, looking to drive a legbreak into the covers, inside-edging the wrong'un. The only sign of things to come was that the edge went all the way for four.

Thakur's next boundary was two balls later, a picture-perfect leg glance off Deep, aided by the small boundary and the quick outfield. Then he drove Deep over extra cover. In the same over, he got a free hit, which he deposited over wide long-on.

What followed was what you expect from an innings of 68 off 29. A lot of powerful shots that he kept nailing, and three more mis-hits that fell bang between the infield and the boundary riders. The strikes into the leg side were so crisply hit they managed to avoid as many as four boundary riders.

Rinku Singh, at the other end, kept turning the strike over before joining in the fireworks in the last two overs. From 23 off 25 he went on to get 46 off 33. The turnaround began when he scooped a high full toss from Siraj for a six.

Siraj, in particular, and others, in general, were ordinary at the death. It was indeed a day when everything Thakur did was coming off, but Siraj, for example, bowled the last two overs with mid-off up and got hit over the fielder three times. None of them was a manufactured shot. Royal Challengers conceded 23 runs in extras.

Varun Chakravarthy picked up 4 for 15•BCCI

The chase nosedives

Royal Challengers didn't go into panic mode. Du Plessis and Kohli even gave themselves a sighter for two overs before laying into pace. The fourth over, bowled by Tim Southee, went for 23.

It looked like it was game on when Narine was introduced in the fifth over. Coming off a rare match in which he went at ten an over, Narine immediately settled into the perfect line and length. Five balls in, he had Kohli bowled through the gate. In the next over, Varun had du Plessis bowled as the carrom ball didn't turn and took the inside edge.

Royal Challengers tried funky things - sending Michael Bracewell at No. 3 and Harshal Patel at No. 4 - but the spinners were just too good. There was an assortment of deliveries, but almost all of them were hitting the stumps. Varun bowled Harshal and Glenn Maxwell, Narine had Shahbaz Ahmed caught.

Thakur came in to take a wicket third ball, and the debutant legspinner Suyash Sharma, who bowled predominantly wrong'uns, some seam-up deliveries, and the odd legbreak - ended up with three late wickets.

When Varun came back and took his fourth wicket to end the match, Knight Riders had taken nine wickets through spin, the most in an IPL match.

Match 10

Lucknow Super Giants 127 for 5 (Rahul 35, Krunal 34, Rashid 2-23) beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 121 for 8 (Tripathi 34, Anmolpreet 31, Krunal 3-18, Mishra 2-23) by five wickets

On a slow, low and dying black-soil surface at the Ekana Cricket Stadium, Lucknow Super Giants' spinners starved Sunrisers Hyderabad of runs to set up a five-wicket win.

After winning the toss, Aiden Markram opted to bat but his side could post only 121 for 8. Super Giants were without Mark Wood (flu) and Avesh Khan (injured) but Krunal Pandya, Ravi Bishnoi and Amit Mishra ensured their absence wasn't felt. The trio picked up 6 for 57 in their combined 12 overs, with Krunal inflicting the most damage with the wickets of Mayank Agarwal, Anmolpreet Singh and Markram.

KL Rahul and Kyle Mayers kicked off the chase by adding 35 in 4.3 overs. Mayers and Deepak Hooda fell in back-to-back overs but Krunal hit a 23-ball 34 to kill the game. When Nicholas Pooran hit the winning six, Super Giants still had four overs left.

KL Rahul top-scored for Super Giants with 35•BCCI

Impact Player strategy

Sunrisers started with three overseas players - Markram, Harry Brook and Adil Rashid - giving themselves the option to use either Heinrich Klaasen in case of a collapse, or one of Marco Jansen or Fazalhaq Farooqi to beef up their bowling in the second half. At 55 for 4 after nine overs, it looked like they would have to bring in Klaasen. He was padded up in the

dugout but Sunrisers didn't lose another wicket until the 18th over. Eventually, Farooqi replaced Rahul Tripathi at the start of the chase.

Super Giants followed a more straightforward route, swapping Mishra with Ayush Badoni after the 19th over of the first innings.

Krunal's three-for dents Sunrisers

Just after two overs of seam, it was clear that this pitch was tailor-made for spinners. Rahul duly brought Krunal on in the third over, and the left-arm spinner had Mayank Agarwal chipping one to extra-cover. Anmolpreet Singh and Rahul Tripathi took some time to get used to the slowness of the surface, and then hit four fours in eight balls to take the side to 43 for 1 at the end of the powerplay.

Krunal, though, dragged them back by dismissing Anmolpreet and Markram off successive balls. Anmolpreet was trapped lbw by a quicker one and Markram done in by turn. Playing his first game of the season, Markram looked to drive a full ball only to get beaten and have his off stump uprooted.

In the next over, the ninth of the innings, Bishnoi set Brook up nicely. After bowling two googlies, he anticipated Brook's advance down the track and slipped in a wide legbreak. Brook did exactly what the bowler anticipated, ended up nowhere near the pitch of the ball, and was stumped by some distance.

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Sunrisers struggle to break away

While Tripathi and Washington Sundar ensured Sunrisers didn't lose another wicket for the next seven overs, the scoreboard moved at a glacial pace - just two boundaries came from overs 7 to 16. Tripathi tried to ramp Yash Thakur in the 18th over but failed to clear Mishra, who dived full-length to his left at short third to take the catch. Mishra picked up two himself in the next over, tossing the ball up to Washington and Rashid and having them caught down the ground. Only Abdul Samad's unbeaten 21 off 10, which included two sixes off Jaydev Unadkat in the 20th over, took Sunrisers past a run a ball.

Rahul, Krunal boss the chase

With Quinton de Kock available, there was some intrigue over whether he or Mayers would open the innings alongside Rahul. But Super Giants stuck with the same batting line-up, leaving de Kock out to the surprise of many. And even if Mayers couldn't repeat his heroics of the previous two games, he and Rahul gave the side a breezy start.

Farooqi had Mayers pulling one straight to deep square leg in the fifth over, and from the other end, Bhuvneshwar Kumar took a low, one-handed return catch to his left to send Hooda back. But Super Giants had the advantage of knowing their target.

Krunal joined Rahul at the end of the powerplay, and without taking much risk, the pair picked up a boundary in each of the next five overs. Krunal was the aggressor during the third-wicket stand of 55 in 6.2 overs, scoring at a strike rate of 147.82. Super Giants reached 100 in the 13th over before Krunal nicked Umran Malik behind. Rashid then had Rahul and Romario Shepherd lbw off successive deliveries, but the result was a formality by then.

Match 11

Rajasthan Royals 199 for 4 (Buttler 79, Jaiswal 60, Mukesh 2-36) beat Delhi Capitals 142 for 9 (Warner 65, Chahal 3-27, Boult 3-29) by 57 runs

The first over of each innings pretty much set the tone for the result. Yashasvi Jaiswal carted Khaleel Ahmed for five fours to start Rajasthan Royals' innings after they were sent in by Delhi Capitals; and when the chase started, Trent Boult expanded his collection of lethal first overs by dismissing Impact Sub Prithvi Shaw and No. 3 Manish Pandey off back-to-back balls.

Capitals were 0 for 2 after one over; Royals were 20 for 0. That was how massive the difference between the two sides was in Guwahati. Royals' winning margin of 57 runs was justified, as Capitals suffered a hat-trick of defeats to start their season.

Jos Buttler, Yashasvi Jaiswal bash away

Royals headed into this match with the highest run rate in the powerplay among all sides to have batted for at least 12 overs during that phase this season. That figure stood at 11.83, and they furthered their reputation by hammering 68 in the first six overs against Capitals. The assault was led by Jaiswal, who was on 41 from 21 balls by the end of the first six; Buttler, at the other end, was on 24 from 15. And that was down to 14 fours smashed until then - 56 runs out of 68.

After Jaiswal had targeted Khaleel in the first over - boundaries flowed over midwicket, through deep third, to deep extra cover, over long-on and above short third - Buttler went after Anrich Nortje. Three boundaries were hit in the second over, with the third one the most effortless yet most impressive: it looked as soft as a pat on the back, pushed wide of mid-off with superb timing and placement.

As if that was not enough, Nortje had more to suffer: off the last ball of the fourth over, he turned around from mid-on and sprinted a good 25 yards, attempting to catch a mis-hit from Buttler over his right shoulder. But he ended up juggling, and the ball popped out of his hands. Buttler was on 18 at that stage; he finished with 79.

Just after that, Jaiswal reverse swept, cut and swept Axar Patel for three fours in the fifth over. He finished with 60, as the opening stand of 98 ended in the ninth over.

Yashasvi Jaiswal celebrates his 25-ball half-century • BCCI

Impact Player strategy

Capitals substituted Khaleel with Shaw to start their chase of 200. But Shaw lasted all of three deliveries. He went flicking across the line as Boult pitched one full on fourth stump; Shaw ended up getting an outside edge. Sanju Samson, behind the stumps, flung himself to his right to grab it one-handed and give Capitals a rude shock.

Royals in turn opted to bring in M Ashwin for Buttler when Capitals were 42 for 3 after seven overs. However, his services turned out to be a mere formality: he was brought on only when Capitals needed an unrealistic 82 from the last four overs, and he almost had David Warner straightaway. The batter swatted straight to extra cover, where Jaiswal was stationed, but he was found to be standing a few yards beyond the circle when the ball was delivered, resulting in a fielding-restriction violation. It was thus called a no-ball, and Ashwin's only over went for 11.

Trent Boult lets it rip - again

Boult had started the season with 2 for 21 against Sunrisers Hyderabad. Both of those wickets came in the first over. Tonight, for the fourth time in his IPL career, Boult nabbed two wickets in his team's opening over.

Although the credit for the first wicket might equally go to Samson, the ball had landed on a perfect line and an enticing length: Boult pitched it on the fuller side on middle and off, angling it slightly across to have Shaw edging behind.

David Warner struck a half-century but couldn't quite get going•BCCI

Next ball, he got one to angle into the comeback man Pandey, who was undone by the fuller ball darting in. It took Warner a bit of convincing to get Pandey to review; the latter he knew where the ball was heading. Replays confirmed it would have smacked into leg stump. That over finished a double-wicket maiden, and Boult's first spell read 2-1-9-2, before he ended the day with 3 for 29.

Warner's consolation fifty

Warner limped to 65 from 55 balls, as only two others entered double figures in Capitals' chase. His stand of 64 for the fourth wicket with Lalit Yadav gave them a flicker of hope, but it was too little for them to rebuild from 36 for 3 in the sixth over. A third defeat in a row duly followed, leaving Capitals with some thinking to do.

Match 12

Chennai Super Kings 159 for 3 (Rahane 61, Gaikwad 40*, Kartikeya 1-24) beat Mumbai Indians 157 for 8 (Kishan 32, Jadeja 3-20, Santner 2-28, Deshpande 2-31) by seven wickets

Chennai Super Kings lost their premier seamer Deepak Chahar to injury after he had bowled just one over. They were already without the match-winner from their last game, Moeen Ali (illness), and Ben Stokes (injured), but Ravindra Jadeja and Mitchell Santner combined to

carve up Mumbai Indians' middle order on a Wankhede pitch that offered some grip and turn.

Mumbai boy Tushar Deshpande also pitched in with the wickets of Rohit Sharma and Tim David as Super Kings limited Mumbai to 157 for 8. Ajinkya Rahane, another Mumbai boy, dashed out of the blocks for Super Kings, hitting a 19-ball half-century to set up their chase. His 27-ball 61 on Super Kings debut allowed Rituraj Gaikwad and rest of the batters breathing room after Devon Conway had fallen for a duck.

In the absence of Jasprit Bumrah, who has been sidelined from the entire tournament with a back injury, and Jofra Archer, who sat out of this game as a precautionary measure, Mumbai's attack lacked experience and penetration.

Ajinkya Rahane hit three sixes while scoring 61 off 27 balls•BCCI

Rohit, Kishan start strongly for Mumbai

As Santner suggested during the mid-innings chat, the ball slid onto the bat nicely in the early exchanges before the pitch slowed down. Rohit charged out of the crease third ball and pumped Chahar over extra-cover before backing away and carving Deshpande over point for four in the next over.

Sisanda Magala had a tough initiation to the IPL as Ishan Kishan took him for three fours in his first over, the third of the innings, which cost 14 runs overall. Magala, a death-bowling specialist from South Africa, was operating early in the powerplay because Chahar had left the field, clutching his hamstring, after bowling the first over.

But Deshpande stepped up, drawing movement off the surface to beat Rohit's outside edge and hit the top of middle and off with a beauty. Kishan then smashed Magala for two more fours, helping Mumbai end the powerplay at 61 for 1.

Left-arm spin is right for CSK

In Super Kings' previous game at Chepauk against Lucknow Super Giants, Jadeja bowled just one over as MS Dhoni kept him away from first Kyle Mayers and then Nicholas Pooran. On Saturday, Dhoni brought Jadeja into the attack immediately after the powerplay and the allrounder responded by having Kishan hole out for 32 off 21 balls.

Jadeja kept bowling into the Wankhede pitch and came away with the wickets of Tilak Varma (22) and Cameron Green (12) as well.

Ravindra Jadeja and Mitchell Santner finished with combined figures of 8-0-48-5•Associated Press

Santner might not have played this game had Stokes or Moeen been available for selection, but he proved his worth once again. In stark contrast to Jadeja, Santner tossed the ball up at

a much slower pace and dismissed both Suryakumar Yadav (1) and the left-handed Arshad Khan, who had been promoted to No.6 to counter him and Jadeja.

Tim David, who was pushed down to No.7, went 6, 4, 6 against Deshpande before the seamer struck back to have him dragging an offcutter to deep midwicket. After taking a pasting in the powerplay, Magala unleashed his yorkers and slower variations at the death to finish with 4-0-37-1.

Rahane slots into Uthappa role

After Conway fell in familiar fashion, chopping on in the first over, Rahane went on an unfamiliar boundary-hitting spree in the powerplay He crashed Arshad for 6, 4, 4, 4, 4 in the fourth over, and by the end of the powerplay he had zoomed to his half-century, setting Super Kings up for a net-run-rate-boosting victory.

Before Robin Uthappa retired from international and Indian cricket last September, he used to be the enforcer in the powerplay and middle overs for Super Kings. Rahane slotted into this role straightaway, affording Gaikwad space to go at a run a ball or thereabouts.

Mumbai brought in left-arm spinner Kumar Kartikeya as their Impact Player, but Super Kings messed with their plans by promoting their spin-hitter Shivam Dube to No. 4. Kartikeya eventually bowled Dube for 28 off 26 balls, but the game was all but up by then. Rayudu, who replaced Chahar as Super Kings' Impact Player, and Gaikwad completed the formalities with seven wickets and almost two overs to spare.

Super Kings notched up their second successive victory and will be bolstered further by the arrival of Maheesh Theekshana and Matheesha Pathirana ahead of their home game against Rajasthan Royals on April 12. On the other hand, Mumbai slipped to their second successive loss and are still searching for their first points this season.

Match 13

Rinku Singh goes 6, 6, 6, 6, 6 off last five balls to script miracle win for Knight Riders

The last over started with 29 needed. Then it was 28 from five balls. Then followed carnage, and an unlikely Knight Riders win

Hemant Brar

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Rinku Singh rushes into the arms of his team-mates after pulling off a miracle • BCCI

Kolkata Knight Riders 207 for 7 (Venkatesh 83, Rinku 48*, Rana 45, Rashid 3-37, Joseph 2-28) beat Gujarat Titans 204 for 4 (Vijay 63*, Sai Sudharsan 53, Narine 3-33) by three wickets

This is what they mean when they say truth is stranger than fiction.

Chasing 205, Kolkata Knight Riders' Impact Player Venkatesh Iyer and their captain Nitish Rana had kept them in the game by adding 100 runs in 9.1 overs. Alzarri Joseph dismissed both, and then Rashid Khan picked up a hat-trick to kill the contest. At least that's how it appeared.

But, just then, Rinku Singh rose to the occasion. When Knight Riders needed 39 off eight balls, Rinku was on 8 off 14. He hit the last two balls of the 19th over, bowled by Josh Little, for a six and four.

With 29 required from the last over, ESPNcricinfo's Forecaster gave Knight Riders a 1.29% chance of winning. After all, no team had chased down that many in the 20th over of a T20 game. The previous best was 23, by Sydney Sixers against Sydney Thunder in 2015, and Rising Pune Supergiants against then Kings XI Punjab in 2016.

Umesh Yadav took a single off Yash Dayal's first ball, and then Rinku went 6, 6, 6, 6, 6 to script a win that will be talked about for a long, long time.

Knight Riders' opening woes

In Rahmanullah Gurbaz and N Jagadeesan, Knight Riders had their third opening pair of the season in as many games. In fact, since the start of IPL 2022, they have used nine different opening pairs in 17 matches - Delhi Capitals are second with five, also in 17 games - and have had starts of 30 or better only twice. It was no different on Sunday. Mohammed Shami and Little, who came in as an impact substitute for B Sai Sudharsan, removed Gurbaz and Jagadeesan inside four overs with just 28 on the board.

2:01

Dasgupta: Only thing similar to Rinku was Brathwaite

Venkatesh Iyer, Nitish Rana threaten to take the game away

Knight Riders finished the powerplay on 43 for 2. The field restrictions were lifted, but Iyer and Rana didn't have a problem in sending the ball to the boundary, or over it. Iyer hit Dayal for a four and six in the seventh over. In the next, Rana smashed Joseph for two sixes.

Rashid's first two overs went for 23. Sandwiched between them was a 17-run Dayal over. With 77 needed from seven overs, Knight Riders were well and truly alive, before Joseph's double-strike to remove both set batters tilted the game towards Titans.

Rinku trumps Rashid's hat-trick

Rashid had conceded 34 in his first three overs, but he almost won the game for his side with his final over. Knight Riders needed 50 from four overs with Andre Russell in the middle. It looked like Rashid had kept his one over only for Russell - he had dismissed him four times in 38 balls before this game. And with his first ball, he had Russell caught behind off an inside edge that bobbed up off the pad. Narine hit the next to deep midwicket,

and Shardul Thakur was lbw off the third to give Rashid his record fourth hat-trick in T20 cricket. All three wickets came from googlies.

ESPNcricinfo Ltd

Rashid seemed to have sealed the game. Except Rinku had other ideas. With 28 needed from five balls, Dayal lost control. The next three balls were full tosses, and Rinku dispatched them over long-off, over deep-backward square leg, and again over long-off.

After a chat with Rashid and David Miller, Dayal bowled a back-of the-hand slower one into the pitch only for Rinku to clear long-on. With four needed from the last ball, another meeting was called, with Shubman Gill too joining in this time. Dayal bowled the last one short and outside off and Rinku hit it over his head. Even before the ball had cleared the boundary, Rinku took off in celebration, running towards his team-mates, who had rushed on to the field to embrace him.

Shubman Gill gives Titans strong powerplay

The day started with Rashid, standing in for the unwell Hardik Pandya, opting to bat after winning the toss. After a slow start, Wriddhiman Saha was looking to accelerate. He had hit a boundary in each of the previous three overs, but Sunil Narine neutralised that threat. Saha tried to slog-sweep, only to top-edge it towards deep midwicket where Jagadeesan, running backwards, took an excellent catch.

That left Titans 38 for 1 after five overs. Varun Chakravarthy, though, bowled a touch too full and Gill caressed him for back-to-back fours through extra cover. Varun's over also included five wides, which helped Titans finish the powerplay at 54 for 1.

Venkatesh Iyer scored 83 off 40 balls after walking out as the impact sub•AFP/Getty Images

Sai Sudharsan's fifty keeps Titans afloat

Gill and Sai Sudharsan took Titans to 100 in the 12th over, but Narine didn't let Gill convert his start into a big score, having him miscue one to long-on for a 31-ball 39. Titans sent in Abhinav Manohar at No. 4 to provide some impetus. He hit Umesh for three successive fours before Suyash Sharma cut short his innings, breaching his defence with a googly.

Titans seemed to be eyeing 180, and Sai Sudharsan kept them on course for that. Apart from hitting a six each off Narine and Varun, he also ran four twos and a three, and brought up his fifty in 34 balls. It was his second successive fifty, having scored an unbeaten 62 off 48 balls against Capitals. But, looking for quick runs, he holed out to long-off off Narine in the 18th over.

Vijay Shankar has a party

Titans were 159 for 4 after 18 overs. Vijay Shankar had his eye in by then and had moved to 22 off 13. Then he brought out his biggest hit, smashing two fours and two sixes off Lockie

Ferguson before launching three successive sixes off Shardul Thakur. The last two overs of Titans' innings produced 45 runs; 41 of those came from Vijay's bat. In all, Vijay scored 63 not out off 24 balls, hitting four fours and five sixes along the way, to haul Titans past 200. It was not enough on the night.

Match 14

Sunrisers Hyderabad 145 for 2 (Tripathi 74*, Markram 37*, Arshdeep 1-20) beat Punjab Kings 143 for 9 (Dhawan 99*, Markande 4-15, Jansen 2-16) by eight wickets

Shikhar Dhawan watched nine wickets tumble around him, but he stood out amid the rubble, his unbeaten 99 taking Punjab Kings to a respectable 143 for 9. That total looked even more respectable when Sunrisers lost their openers Harry Brook and Mayank Agarwal early with the slower balls gripping the Hyderabad surface.

But Rahul Tripathi rose above the conditions to score a sprightly half-century and give Sunrisers their first victory of the season. He contributed 63 in an unbroken 100-run stand off 52 balls with his captain Aiden Markram to help ice the chase and hand Kings their first defeat of the season.

Bhuvneshwar, Jansen go bang, bang, bang

On Friday, Sunrisers' seamers were neutralised on a black-soil turner. Two days later, Bhuvneshwar and co. were on the money from the get-go on a pace-friendly red-soil Hyderabad track. Bhuvneshwar struck first ball to trap Prabhsimran Singh lbw for a duck.

Much like Bhuvneshwar, Jansen, picked ahead of legspinner Adil Rashid, exploited the early swing on offer. The left-arm seamer struck with his second legal ball to pin IPL debutant Matt Short lbw for 1. He won another lbw appeal from umpire Bruce Oxenford next ball, but Jitesh Sharma overturned the on-field decision on review. Jitesh managed four before Jansen had him chipping a drive to mid-off in his next over. T Natarajan also found swing in the powerplay as Sunrisers' seam attack thrived at home.

Dhawan or nothing for PBKS

Once the early movement disappeared for the seamers, Dhawan took some trips down the pitch and hit them over the top. However, at the other end, legspinner Mayank Markande, who was playing his first game for Sunrisers, tore through the middle and lower order with his stock ball and the wrong'un. The innings was going so badly pear shaped that Kings had to Impact Sub a batter for a batter, bringing Sikandar Raza in for the already dismissed Prabhsimran, but it didn't really help matters. Together the two players contributed 5 runs off 7 balls

Markande, meanwhile, came away with figures of 4 for 15 in his four overs. Dhawan quietly played him out, but laid into Natarajan and Umran Malik, taking 61 off 31 balls from them. He reached his fifty off 42 balls by launching Natarajan over midwicket for six and then went 6,4,6 against Malik in the 18th over. Dhawan was dropped three times along the way,

but he carried on until the end of the innings. He contributed 52 in an unbroken 55-run partnership for a last wicket with debutant Mohit Rathee - an IPL record.

Dhawan's 69.2 was the second-highest percentage of runs scored in a completed IPL innings that went 20 overs or ended with a team all out. It was second only to Brendon McCullum in the first match of the IPL, where he shellacked 158 out of KKR's total of 222 (71.2%).

2:49

Moody: 'Tripathi showed that he is of high value'

Tripathi, Markram see SRH home

Sunrisers decided to shake up their batting line-up by pairing up Agarwal with Brook at the top. Brook seemed comfortable with pace on the ball, but when Arshdeep Singh cut it down to 117kph and bowled a knuckle ball, he was bowled through the gate for 13 off 14. Then, when Agarwal dared to sweep Rahul Chahar off the stumps, he spliced a catch to long-on, leaving Sunrisers at 45 for 2 in the ninth over.

Tripathi and Markram then got together to settle the innings. When Chahar darted it quicker and flatter outside off, Tripathi used the pace to glide the ball behind point. When Chahar slowed his pace down and tossed up his legbreaks, Tripathi stretched out to either drive him inside out over extra cover or sweep him over midwicket. He treated Rathee with even more disdain, smashing him for two sixes and two fours in eight balls.

Tripathi's high intent and execution allowed Markram to sit back and tap the ball into the gaps. Fittingly, it was Tripathi who finished the game for Sunrisers with eight wickets and almost three overs to spare.

Match 15

Lucknow Super Giants 213 for 9 (Stoinis 65, Pooran 62, Siraj 3-22) beat Royal Challengers Bangalore 212 for 2 (du Plessis 79*, Kohli 61, Maxwell 59, Mishra 1-18) by one wicket

It was a rolling ride where the teasing tickle in the stomach never seemed to stop, as the coaster went up and down, left and right, threatening to crash into a pool one moment before soaring high into the clouds the next. That's what the game felt like.

Lucknow Super Giants needed four to win from the remaining five balls with three wickets in hand. Then Mark Wood got bowled. Few balls later, a tumbling Faf du Plessis almost fumbled a catch, but eventually took it.

That made it 1 off 1, with one wicket in hand. Harshal Patel, the bowler, then attempted to run the non-striker out backing up, but missed.

Still 1 off 1. Dinesh Karthik then juggles and fails to grab the last ball behind the stumps, enough for the last two Super Giants batters to sneak a bye.

Game over. The Royal Challengers Bangalore and their fans were left with broke hearts. The Super Giants claimed a humdinger.

Highest win contribution % for Lucknow Super Giants vs Royal Challengers Bangalore•ESPNcricinfo Ltd

Stoinis starts the party

Marcus Stoinis came out at 23 for 3 after four overs. Not managing to score from his three balls, Stoinis swung across the line. Mohammed Siraj, placed at mid-on, ran back towards midwicket and dropped a difficult catch.

After seven overs, Super Giants' required rate had crossed 13, but Stoinis welcomed Harshal with 6, 4, 4. Next over, Karn Sharma was given the same treatment. In the over after that, Shahbaz Ahmed was creamed for two sixes. The first of that brought up his fifty off 25 balls. Karn got his revenge in the 11th over when Stoinis departed for 65 from 30 deliveries. But only if Royal Challengers knew what was to follow.

Pooran pings sixes at will

Nicholas Pooran arrived when Super Giants needed another 114 from 56 balls in pursuit of 213. The second ball he faced was dispatched over long-on. He was on 10 off five deliveries at one stage. He ended with 62 from 19. Seven of those balls were hit for sixes, and four of them for fours. Carefree, unstoppable T20 batting, with the swag, muscle and calmness of Sir Viv.

Pooran's fifty came up off 15 deliveries. Balls flew over long-on, square leg, extra cover and fine leg. Fielders' jaws dropped and the bowlers' spirits were crushed as Pooran was merciless. When he was finally dismissed, he left Super Giants needing only 24 from 18.

Glenn Maxwell and Faf du Plessis put on a 115-run stand in quick time•Associated Press

Impact Player Strategy

Introduced in the 12th over, Amit Mishra carried forward the mania from Lucknow to Bangalore, and struck third ball to dismiss Virat Kohli. Two overs later, Glenn Maxwell smashed him for 4, 6 off successive deliveries as Mishra ended at 2 for 18. Despite being brought on quite late, he was subbed by Ayush Badoni. Badoni, to his part, played the ice to Pooran's fire, guiding Super Giants with a composed 30 in 24 deliveries, before hitting his stumps with the bat in a follow through after scooping the ball for six, a-la Roy Fredericks from the 1975 World Cup final.

RCB penalised for slow over-rate

Royal Challengers were fined for maintaining a slow over-rate during the game. Since it was their first offence of the season, only captain du Plessis was fined Rs 12 lakh.

Avesh Khan, the Super Giants quick, was reprimanded for a Level 1 offence [2.2 of IPL's Code of Conduct].

Royal Challengers replaced Anuj Rawat, who didn't get to bat, with legspinner Karn at the start of their defence. Karn ended up conceding 48 in three overs, the most expensive economy for any Royal Challengers bowler (min. three overs) ever.

du Plessis, Maxwell and Kohli's fifties in vain

Royal Challengers' innings was of three parts: 56 runs in the powerplay, 48 in the next seven, and 108 from the final seven. The start was down to an attacking Kohli, who ended the first six overs on 42, with four fours and three sixes. But his last 19 runs took as many deliveries to come, with the Super Giants' spinner Krunal Pandya and Ravi Bishnoi applying the brakes.

Carnage was to follow. In what turned to be a six-fest, du Plessis and Glenn Maxwell smacked 11 sixes until the end of the innings. Du Plessis finished on 79, while Maxwell smashed 59 at double the pace. Royal Challengers soared to 212. In the end, it was all for nothing.

Match 16

Mumbai Indians 173 for 4 (Rohit 65, Tilak 41, Mukesh 2-30) beat Delhi Capitals 172 (Axar 54, Warner 51, Chawla 3-22, Behrendorff 3-23) by six wickets

Mumbai Indians held their nerve with the last ball of a scrappy, tension-fuelled basement battle against Delhi Capitals to claw themselves off the bottom of the IPL standings with their first win in three attempts this season, and condemn their opponents to a fourth consecutive loss in a season that is no closer to offering up any answers to their numerous issues.

Piyush Chawla rolled back the years, and ripped his googlies, to serve up game-shaping figures of 3 for 22 either side of a pair of chalk-and-cheese fifties from David Warner and Axar Patel, but despite a timely half-century from Rohit Sharma and 41 from 29 from Tilak Varma, Mumbai were forced to scramble over the line, into the teeth of a magnificent final over from a pumped-up Anrich Nortje.

With just five runs to defend against Cameron Green and the impact sub, Tim David, Nortje nailed his yorkers to perfection, and was let down only by his fielders - first by a bad drop from Mukesh Kumar at midwicket to reprieve David and then, with two runs needed from his final ball, a poor loopy shy from Warner at mid-off that allowed David to dive home for the second run and so avoid the Super Over.

In truth, it was a contest in which Mumbai had bossed the key moments - first through Chawla's mid-innings incisions, then with the scalping of five wickets in the final ten balls of Delhi's innings that had kept their target to a gettable 173. The early exchanges of the run-chase had fallen in the visitors' favour too, with Rohit's 65 from 45 including a 29-ball fifty

that provided the impetus for a 68-run powerplay. But after Mumbai failed to kill the chase when the going was still good, Nortje - armed with two death overs and aiming fast, full and furious throughout - so nearly saved the day.

ESPNcricinfo Ltd

Chawla shows he's still got it

At the age of 34, and more than a decade after his last appearance for India, Chawla may be a touch more weather-beaten these days, but his googly has lost none of the startling impact it first made more than half a lifetime ago in 2005 when, aged 15, he bowled Sachin Tendulkar in a Challenger Trophy fixture. Two of his three wickets today were pitch-perfect wrong'unns to Rovman Powell and Lalit Yadav respectively, to rip the heart out of a Delhi batting line-up that, Axar's cameo aside, was never allowed to emerge from second gear.

In an unbroken spell from the seventh to the 13th overs, Chawla returned the exceptional figures of 3 for 22, with only a brace of Warner boundaries disrupting his otherwise complete hold over Capitals' batters. After a threatening Manish Pandey skipped to the pitch but was beaten in flight to scuff a legbreak to long-off, Powell and Lalit were confounded in consecutive overs by a pair of leg-stump-seeking googlies, the former thumping the pad, the latter plucking the stump clean out.

The only real blot in Chawla's copybook was a bad miss at mid-off as Warner, then on 37, clattered a drive clean through his grasp. He left the field soon after his spell, apparently nursing a sore finger for his efforts, although compared to the hapless Suryakumar Yadav's spill on the boundary's edge off Axar, it was a fairly routine miss. Poor Suryakumar, desperate for a break amid a terrible run with the bat, wore a full-blooded slog on the forehead as it burst through his fingers, and left the field with suspected concussion. Though he did eventually appear at No. 4 in Mumbai's chase, he soon wished he hadn't, as a first-ball flick off the hip to fine leg completed his fourth golden duck in his last six innings.

Axar Patel raced to a 22-ball half-century • BCCI

A pair of contrasting fifties

Axar and Warner fell within three balls of one another, in the midst of a four-wicket 19th over from Jason Behrendorff that also featured ducks for Kuldeep Yadav and Abishek Porel, but there their tales converged. Axar departed with 54 from 25 balls at a strike-rate of 216; Warner with 51 from 47, at almost exactly half his team-mate's tempo (108.51).

It was Warner's third half-century of Capitals' campaign, but all three have come from more than 40 balls - 43 on this occasion - and his lack of celebration was tell-tale evidence of another stodgy display.

On the one hand, at least he was there, providing some grit to the oyster that his middle-order team-mates - the debutant Yash Dhull included - could not muster. On the other hand,

the carefree fluency of Axar told a different tale, of an innings in which too many scoring opportunities had been squandered.

Axar is in the midst of a startling coming-of-age as a batter of some repute and his maiden IPL fifty was a knock of high pedigree - four fours, five sixes, each of them launched down the ground including a Riley Meredith slot-ball that brought up his fifty from 22 balls. For five consecutive overs from the start of the 14th to the end of the 17th, he was Capitals' solitary source of momentum, with Warner contributing a mere five from nine at the other end.

Rohit Sharma brought up his fifty in 29 balls•BCCI

The Hitman cometh

Despite Warner's struggles to push his tempo, 41% of respondents to a mid-broadcast poll said they would still prefer him over Rohit at the top of their IPL order, which perhaps says much about the criticisms the latter has endured since India's disappointing T20 World Cup. But those doubts dissolved in the midst of an enervating powerplay onslaught, as Rohit romped towards a 29-ball fifty that offered the sort of proactive backbone that Capitals' own innings had lacked.

Rohit set the tone for Mumbai's chase in Mukesh's opening over, with a clip for four off the pads followed by a violent slap for six over deep midwicket. When Nortje also strayed into his slot two overs later, he too was launched emphatically into the stands, as Mumbai's openers cantered along at more than 11 an over in the powerplay.

At the other end, Ishan Kishan started like the clappers against the quicks as well, with three fours in his first four balls from the left-arm seam of Mustafizur Rahman. But, much as Chawla had derailed Delhi's intentions, so Kishan was less sure-footed against the spinners - after making 28 from his first 15 balls, he managed just three runs from his next 10 before Rohit - cold-blooded at both ends of the pitch - effectively retired him out with a call for a non-existent run to point.

Mumbai fall over the line

By this stage, perhaps Capitals' likeliest matchwinner hadn't yet made his bow. Kuldeep's left-arm wristspin duly made its entry in the ninth over, but with Tilak's rubbery wrists and feet producing a brace of sixes in his only two overs, he was denied the chance to emulate Chawla's impact. And when Tilak responded to a fallow run of 11 runs in three overs by smoking Mukesh for a four and two sixes in his first three balls, the contest seemed cooked with 34 needed from the last 27.

Mukesh, however, was not yet done. Tilak's next shot in anger picked out Pandey at deep midwicket, and when Suryakumar's miserable match ended one ball later, all eyes were suddenly back on Rohit. A cathartic four through midwicket eased the pressure a touch, but when Mustafizur fired in a wide yorker, Rohit could only toe-end an attempted steer

through to the keeper. Suddenly Mumbai had two men yet to face, and an angsty finale to negotiate. Despite Nortje's unstinting efforts, Green and David did just enough - the killer blows landing within the final three balls of an otherwise fine effort from Mustafizur, as each man picked off a six that left Nortje with just too little to defend.

Match 17

Rajasthan Royals 175 for 8 (Buttler 52, Padikkal 38, Jadeja 2-21, Deshpande 2-37, Akash 2-40) beat Chennai Super Kings 172 for 6 (Conway 50, Dhoni 32*, Ashwin 2-25, Chahal 2-27) by three runs

It was set up perfectly. The whistles at Chepauk were getting louder with each moment as MS Dhoni took strike with 21 needed off six balls. Two wides later, Sandeep Sharma nailed a yorker, before erring in length and seeing Dhoni wallop back-to-back leg-side sixes.

Dhoni was leading Chennai Super Kings for the 200th time in the IPL and he had the chance to script another fairytale, and the perfect finish loomed even after Sandeep went around the wicket and pulled things back, bringing the equation down to five needed off the last ball. This was still Dhoni territory, but Sandeep nailed another perfect yorker from around the stumps and Rajasthan Royals eked out a three-run win to go top of the table after four games.

Samson fined for slow over rate

Rajasthan Royals captain Sanju Samson has been fined INR 12 lakh (USD 14,000 approx.) for his team's slow over rate against Chennai Super Kings. It was his team's first over-rate offence this season, a post-match IPL statement said.

No in-game fielding-restriction penalty was imposed on Royals during the match.

Super Kings needed an improbable 54 off 18 balls with Ravindra Jadeja and Dhoni still new to the crease. Dhoni began the assault with a four and a six in Adam Zampa's last over before Jadeja took over in a 19-run penultimate over bowled by Jason Holder, hitting him for a four and two sixes.

Sandeep, however, just about kept his calm and Royals became the first side to defend a sub-190 total this season.

MS Dhoni rolled back the years but Super Kings fell just short in the end •BCCI

Ashwin, Chahal, Zampa storm CSK's spin fortress

Chasing 176, Super Kings lost the prolific Ruturaj Gaikwad in the third over. But Devon Conway and Ajinkya Rahane added 68 in 43 balls to keep the chase on track. Rahane, who had scored a blazing half-century against Mumbai Indians in his last outing, was quick off

the blocks again, pulling Jason Holder through midwicket and slinking down the track to deposit R Ashwin over the long-off boundary while rushing to a 19-ball 31.

In Ashwin, Yuzvendra Chahal and Impact Player Adam Zampa, however, Royals had a spin attack made for Chepauk conditions, and they extracted plenty of purchase even with dew starting to kick in. Ashwin's dismissal of Rahane turned the tide for Royals. From 78 for 1 in the 10th over, Super Kings slumped to 122 for 6 at the end of the 17th.

Zampa conceded 14 in the 18th over, when Dhoni went after him, but even including that, Royals' spinners conceded just 95 in 12 overs while taking five wickets, while their Super Kings counterparts went for 84 in 10 while taking three.

Buttler and Padikkal set the tone

Yashasvi Jaiswal has been in red-hot form for Royals this season, and he threatened to go on another boundary spree in the powerplay when he hit two fours off the left-arm quick Akash Singh in the first over, after Super Kings elected to bowl. But Tushar Deshpande, Super Kings' go-to bowler in Deepak Chahar's absence, prised Jaiswal out in the next over. Royals kept the left-right combination going by promoting Devdutt Padikkal, who sat out the match against Delhi Capitals, to No. 3.

Padikkal and Jos Buttler went after Maheesh Theekshana - who was playing his first game of the season - hitting him for four fours and a six in his first two overs, both inside the powerplay. That got them into groove for a 77-run second-wicket partnership off just 41 balls, which took Royals to a formidable 88 for 1 in the ninth over.

R Ashwin made an impact with bat and ball • Associated Press

Bowlers keep CSK in the game

Jadeja helped Super Kings claw back with the wickets of Padikkal and Sanju Samson in the space of three balls, and Royals responded with the now familiar tactic of promoting Ashwin up the order. The scoring rate dipped for a while, with Royals failing to find the boundary in five successive overs, before Ashwin broke the drought with a slashed four off Theekshana in the 14th. He then swatted Akash for successive sixes in the 15th, before falling later in the over for a 22-ball 30.

Buttler, who had been 34 off 17 at the time he lost Padikkal, didn't hit another boundary, and eventually fell for a 52 off 36 balls. In the process he also crossed 3000 runs in the IPL, becoming the third-quickest to the mark in terms of innings taken.

The ostensible intent behind the Ashwin promotion was to delay Shimron Hetmyer's entry, and he came in at roughly his preferred time, with five overs remaining. He did his bit at the finish, smacking an unbeaten 30 off 18, but there was little support from the other end during his time in the middle, as Royals only managed 40 in their last five overs.

Having at one stage seemed on course for 200, they finished on 175 for 8, with Deshpande dismissing Holder and Zampa in the last over .

Impact Player Strategy

Royals brought in Zampa as their Impact Player: he walked out to bat at No. 10 to face the last ball of their innings, replacing Buttler. The finger injury Buttler picked up earlier in the competition could have played a part in his removal. Super Kings, meanwhile, yanked off Sisanda Magala, whose two overs went for 14, after he injured a finger in his right hand while taking the catch to dismiss Ashwin. Super Kings subbed in Ambati Rayudu, who batted at No. 6 and lasted just two balls.

Match 18

Gujarat Titans 154 for 4 (Gill 67, Saha 30, Brar 1-20) beat Punjab Kings 153 for 8 (Short 36, Jitesh 25, Mohit 2-18) by six wickets

Another day, another last-over thriller. This one, though, wasn't as topsy-turvy as a few of the earlier games in IPL 2023. But, it still required the ice man Rahul Tewatia's services. With four needed off the last two balls, Tewatia calmly scooped Sam Curran, who was bowling really well, over fine leg and ensured Gujarat Titans beat Punjab Kings by six wickets.

For the longest time, the chase seemed a straightforward one. Having restricted Kings to 153 for 8 with an all-round show from the bowlers on a decent Mohali surface, Titans were cruising, led by a classy 49-ball 67 from Shubman Gill.

Hardik fined for Titans' slow over-rate

Gujarat Titans captain Hardik Pandya has been fined after his team maintained a slow over-rate during the match against Punjab Kings in Mohali. As it was Titans' first offence of the season, Hardik was fined INR 12 lakh under the IPL's Code of Conduct relating to minimum over-rate offences.

But with 13 needed off 12, Arshdeep Singh bowled a nerveless penultimate over going for just six. Curran then cleaned up Gill second ball of the final one before bowling an inch-perfect yorker which almost resulted in David Miller's run-out. Through it all though, Tewatia just held his cool, like he normally does, and came out a winner.

Kings' batting plans go awry

After Kings were sent in to bat, Prabhsimran Singh bagged his second successive duck, meekly clipping an innocuous Mohamad Shami back-of-a-length ball to short midwicket. Shikhar Dhawan, the star of Kings' batting unit, then skied Josh Little to mid-on, falling for 8. Matthew Short, however, looked impressive from the start. He got going with two crisp fours. Kings raced to 52 for 2 in the powerplay, but once Short fell to a Rashid Khan googly, the innings unravelled.

Bhanuka Rajapaksa managed 20 off 26 balls, Jitesh Sharma 25 off 23, while Curran scored a run-a-ball 22. The dot balls hurt Kings the most. Even in the powerplay where they went big, there were 20 balls which the batters failed to score off, while in the middle overs - 7 to 16 - there were 28 dot balls. In contrast, Titans faced only 12 dot balls in the first six overs and 18 dots in the middle phase.

Shahrukh Khan, coming in at No. 7, smashed a 9-ball 22 to get Kings over the 150-mark, but it was never going to be enough.

Rahul Tewatia paddles for the win•BCCI

Mohit turns back the clock

It hasn't been the smoothest of sails for Mohit Sharma. He started quite well in the IPL and was the purple cap winner in 2014, even making it to the national side. But his fortunes dipped soon after. Before this game, Mohit last played in the IPL in 2020 - a solitary game for Delhi Capitals. He was a net bowler for Titans last year, his work prompting the franchise to bid for him in 2023. And he repaid the faith with a sterling debut. Mohit bowled overs 11, 13, 15 and 19, conceded 18 runs and picked up two key wickets. The variations were back, and most importantly his control over them, something that had been missing over the last few years.

Gill lights up the chase

Titans' chase got off to a perfect start courtesy Gill and Wriddhiman Saha. Gill was up and away with a lovely cover drive off Arshdeep before clipping Kagiso Rabada through mid-on. Saha got his boundary counter running with a stylish cover drive off Rabada before he laid into Arshdeep, creaming him for four fours in the third over as Titans raced to 36 for 0 after three overs. While Rabada did claim Saha's wicket - his 100th in the IPL - Titans scored 56 runs in the powerplay. Kings needed to be better with the new ball, especially given they were defending only 153.

Sai Sudharsan and Gill then added 41 runs for the second wicket off 40 balls, with both players concentrating more on singles than boundaries. Hardik Pandya came and went before a lofted four over extra cover helped Gill reach his second fifty of this IPL. The opener continued to go hard, an 81 metre six off Rabada standing out. He added a 42-run stand with Miller off 30 balls, but his dismissal in the final over threw the game open... at least until Tewatia slammed it shut.

Impact Player Strategy

Titans did not use their impact player, while Kings brought in Rahul Chahar in place of Rajapaksa at the end of their first innings. Chahar failed to make much of an impact, going for 24 runs in his three overs and failing to pick a wicket.

Match 19

Sunrisers Hyderabad 228 for 4 (Brook 100*, Markram 50, Abhishek 32, Russell 3-22) beat Kolkata Knight Riders 205 for 7 (Rana 75, Rinku 58*, Jagadeesan 36, Markande 2-27, Jansen 2-37) by 23 runs

Harry Brook put behind a string of low scores with an unbeaten 55-ball 100 that included imperious hitting against pace and calculated strike rotation against spin. Aiden Markram was equally destructive, scoring 50 off 26 balls, as Sunrisers Hyderabad posted 228 for 4, the highest total of IPL 2023 so far.

In response, Kolkata Knight Riders were 96 for 5 in the 11th over and in need of a miracle for the third game in a row. Nitish Rana's 41-ball 75 kept their hopes alive, and with 58 required from the last three overs, they had Rinku Singh and Shardul Thakur - their miracle-makers from the previous two games - in the middle. Rinku fought hard with an unbeaten 58 off 31 but this time, it wasn't to be.

Brook shows his class

Coming into this game, Brook had 29 runs in three innings at a strike rate of 74.35. But one felt it was only a matter of time before he stepped up. On Friday, he started by hitting the first ball of the innings, bowled by Umesh Yadav, through the covers for four. He picked up two more fours in the over, pulling and scooping the bowler with little fuss.

Against Lockie Ferguson, he exposed his stumps and dispatched a slow full toss to the cover boundary. He used the same strategy in Umesh's next over with even better returns - two back-to-back sixes. Thanks to Brook, Sunrisers raced to 43 for no loss in three overs.

Russell's double-strike

Andre Russell hadn't bowled this season so far, but it took him just one ball to make an impact. While Brook seemed unstoppable, Mayank Agarwal was struggling. Russell ended his agony by having him caught at short third for 9 off 13 balls. Rahul Tripathi hit a couple of fours but ended up top-edging a pull on the last ball of the over, giving Russell his second wicket.

Aiden Markram took out his big strokes when Harry Brook slowed down • Associated Press

Markram takes over

In their spinners, Knight Riders found a way to keep Brook quiet. In the first six overs of the innings, Brook had smashed five fours and two sixes. In the next eight - seven of which were bowled by the spinners - he didn't find a single boundary, and instead focused on rotating the strike.

That, though, didn't mean Knight Riders could breathe easy. Markram took the baton and ransacked 42 off 22 balls against the spinners. He was severe on Suyash Sharma, in particular, taking him for two sixes and a four in the 12th over of the innings. In the next over, he hit successive balls from Varun Chakravarthy for a four and a six, the second shot

bringing up his half-century off 25 balls. He tried to go big on the next ball as well but holed out at deep midwicket.

Brook brings up his hundred

In the 15th over, Knight Riders re-introduced seam in the form of Ferguson. And Brook was back hitting boundaries, sending the bowler for four fours and a six in a 23-run over. Abhishek Sharma, meanwhile, took over Markram's role and looted 32 off 16 against spin. He didn't even spare Sunil Narine, hitting him for a four and a six in the 17th over. Those were the only two boundaries Narine conceded in his 4-0-28-0. Abhishek faced just one ball of pace, and was out on that.

Brook kept picking up the occasional boundary, and moved to 95 off 52 with one over left. He was tiring by then but found just enough energy to hobble a couple of twos and a single to bring up his hundred.

1:59

Did KKR get their plan for Narine's overs wrong?

Knight Riders start poorly

Bhuvneshwar Kumar dealt Knight Riders an early blow when Rahmanullah Gurbaz sliced the third ball of the chase to deep third. In the fourth over, Marco Jansen dented them further by removing Venkatesh Iyer and Narine off successive deliveries. Iyer, who came in as Impact Player for Suyash, hit a couple of boundaries before miscuing one to Markram at mid-on. Narine was cramped for room and was also taken at mid-on, leaving Knight Riders 20 for 3.

Nitish Rana's counter-attack

It looked like Knight Riders would surrender without a fight, but their captain Rana resuscitated the chase. In the sixth over, he hit Umran Malik for 4, 6, 4, 4, 4, 6. Not every shot came off the middle of the bat, but the 28-run over helped Knight Riders end the powerplay on a solid 62 for 3.

N Jagadeesan gave Rana good support with his 36 off 21 before Mayank Markande had him caught at deep midwicket. Russell, who had walked off twice during the first innings with cramps, didn't last long either, holing out in the legspinner's next over.

At that stage, Knight Riders needed 133 in 9.5 overs. Rana and Rinku kept the fight on, adding 69 in 6.2 overs for the sixth wicket. The pair was also helped by some lapses in the field - both Rana and Rinku were dropped once each, and later, Thakur was dropped twice.

With 70 needed from 23 balls, Rana got two full tosses in a row from T Natarajan. He smashed the first one for a six but ended up hitting the second to sweeper cover, where Washington Sundar held on to the chance.

Rinku hit three fours off Natarajan in the 19th over to reduce the equation to 32 needed off six, but as Rana himself said after the game, miracles don't happen every game.

Match 20

Royal Challengers Bangalore 174 for 6 (Kohli 50, Marsh 2-18, Kuldeep 2-23) beat Delhi Capitals 151 for 9 (Pandey 50, Vyshak 3-20, Siraj 2-23) by 23 runs

Royal Challengers Bangalore spent a large part of this game under the pump. Frustratingly, every time they thought they got ahead, like when Virat Kohli reached a 33-ball fifty, or when Glenn Maxwell was pummelling the spinners on a spin-friendly pitch, a wicket would fall to douse the momentum. Winning a game like this - a game where their crowd spent the first innings largely silent - will do wonders for their campaign because they clawed their way back. And because their star turns came with the ball.

Mohammed Siraj (4-0-23-2) was phenomenal in conditions that should have cancelled him. Their debutant Vijaykumar Vyshak was the most successful bowler on the night, with three wickets including that of an IPL legend, David Warner. Their fielding was electric, a direct hit run-out from Anuj Rawat setting the tone for the fightback. The only Delhi Capitals batters who managed to resist were Manish Pandey (50 off 38) and Axar Patel (21 off 14).

Towards the end of the game, it became clear that the pitch had got better for batting under lights. This is the reason why Capitals, having won the toss, chose to bowl in the first place. But their calamitous start to a chase of 175 - 2 for 3 in three overs and then 30 for 4 with Warner dismissed - just didn't allow them to take advantage.

Virat Kohli celebrates his third half-century of the season • Associated Press

Spin > Pace

A slow pitch and the spinners targeting the stumps together meant it was hard for RCB to hit them off the 30-yard circle. Axar and Lalit Yadav bowled three overs in the powerplay for eight dots and just 16 runs.

When there's no pace coming on to the bat, and you also don't have room to free the arms, it's really hard to get power into your shots. That's why Faf du Plessis felt compelled to go extra hard on the quicks and lost his wicket in the fifth over to Mitchell Marsh.

RCB hit seven boundaries in the first six overs. Only one of them came off spin. Even for the rest, they often had to charge out of their crease - creating pace for themselves - to get the most bang for their buck.

Kohli on song

A 33-ball fifty on this pitch was an excellent effort, but also typical Kohli. He knew that 1) this wasn't a 200 pitch so he could bat at his own pace, and 2) the team would almost

certainly benefit if he dropped anchor and played out the whole innings. And 3) he is a monster at the death, striking as well as Andre Russell or MS Dhoni in the last four overs.

Things were going smoothly enough. He had just played not one but two shots of the match. A stand-still and bottom-hand drill down the ground turning an almost yorker from Mustafizur Rahman into a boundary. And then another stand-perfectly-still and bottom-hand whip to a back of a length ball on his hips for six. The wristwork on that shot to get it so far was just incredible.

But then came Lalit Yadav with a massive full toss. It had to be put away. It was begging to be put away. And Kohli went for it, the only mistake he made was dragging it to the leg side, towards the 70-metre part of the ground. He was caught right on the edge of the rope. If he had gone straight, to the 60-metre boundary, it would've been six.

2:37

Bishop: Brave call to bring on Kuldeep against Maxwell paid off

Maxwell's little gem

Prior to this game, among batters with at least 500 runs against spin, Maxwell had the highest strike rate (164) and the best balls-per-boundary ratio (4.6) in the IPL. He lived up to that billing, smashing 20 runs off eight balls against the slower bowlers, and that contribution proved crucial. RCB fell from 117 for 2 to 132 for 6. But they still reached 174 because their spin hitter produced a cameo that allowed their unheralded Indian batters to just play out the overs. The impact sub, Rawat, made only 15 off 26 despite coming in as late as the last five overs and yet it didn't matter.

Capitals collapse

They were 3 for 2 in the third over. They took 23 balls to hit the first boundary.

The first innings was all about fast bowlers being dispatched. Mustafizur, for example, gave up one-third of the total boundaries that RCB hit (7 of 21). They were the ones providing release to under-pressure batters.

But RCB's new-ball attack decided to change all that. Siraj found ways to use even these conditions to his advantage, hitting the deck hard, at high pace and generating movement with his wobble seam variation.

Capitals were suddenly under siege against the very type of bowling they thought they'd hit around the park. Yash Dhull certainly thought that when he tried to hit Siraj on the up and over the top, but the problem was, even though it was a full ball, and had very little distance to travel after pitching, it still seamed in to beat the inside edge and trap him plumb lbw. That wasn't so much a wicket as an exhibition of the gulf in class between bowler and batter.

ESPNcricinfo Ltd

The end

Vyshak on IPL debut had a great game. RCB's batters had told their bowlers that digging balls into the wicket was causing problems and he did that all night long.

Take his first wicket. It was a slower ball banged into the surface. That length makes you pull on instinct. You know you need to delay their shots on this slow pitch. But that length just over-rides everything. Warner was into the pull too early. Toe end of the bat. Caught at midwicket.

That at least was the conditions working against them. Prithvi Shaw, Capitals' impact sub, which means he didn't field at all, started by refusing a two that was on, then got run out showing zero urgency to get to the crease. Rawat produced a moment of magic at short extra cover, diving to his right, picking the ball up one-handed and nailing a throw with only one stump to look at. But Shaw just didn't budget for the fact that his shot could be stopped. He was lazy getting into the run, then didn't even try to dive when it was clear he was in trouble. His IPL reads 12, 7, 0, 15, 0.

That wicket set the tone as Capitals crumbled to their fifth loss in five games this season.

Match 21

Punjab Kings 161 for 8 (Raza 57, Short 34) beat Lucknow Super Giants 159 for 8 (Rahul 74, Curran 3-31) by two wickets

Sikandar Raza's maiden IPL gig at the age of 36 was reward for his compelling performances with bat and ball at the T20 World Cup last year. But three games into this season, his rich form seemed to elude him.

The delayed arrival of Liam Livingstone and a subsequent niggle meant that Raza had a fourth chance to impress. And he didn't miss a beat, at least for the most part.

Needing to turnaround Punjab Kings' chase of 160 from a precarious 45 for 3 on a sluggish surface in Lucknow, Raza held the middle order together for much of the innings. But when he picked out Marcus Stoinis at deep backward square leg on 57, with Kings needing 21 off 13 balls, there was another twist.

But Shahrukh Khan wasn't giving up.

At one end, he had to contend with Mark Wood's ferocious pace and hard lengths. At the other, there was Ravi Bishnoi's wrong'uns. Another tightrope of a finish loomed, and Shahrukh held on to finish unbeaten on 23 off 10 balls to seal victory with three balls to spare.

For Kings, the victory was particularly heartening because they were without their regular captain Shikhar Dhawan, who missed the game with a shoulder niggle. There was also the

matter of trying to arrest a slide of two consecutive defeats, which they did to rise to No. 4 in the points table.

Lucknow Super Giants will look back on the last five overs of their batting innings, where they lost 4 for 48 after KL Rahul had played anchor once again with 74 off 56 balls.

Sikandar Raza took his chance in Liam Livingstone's absence•BCCI

Kyle Mayers gives LSG a start

On a surface that had a smattering of grass amid barren patches, the ball was doing all sorts of things. Offspinner Matt Short got it to turn, Arshdeep Singh was able to zip it through, and Kagiso Rabada rapped Rahul with a lifter from a length.

Kyle Mayers wasn't too fussed and threw his bat at anything in his zone. If the ball was drifting onto his pads, he swung hard. If there was room, he fearlessly lofted through the line. If it was bowled into the pitch, he flat batted it. But his daredevilry didn't last long as he picked out deep square leg when he could have hit Harpreet Brar's half-tracker wherever he liked on the leg side. Kings had broken LSG's flourishing half-century opening stand in the eighth over.

Rahul drops anchor

In the next over, Raza had Deepak Hooda lbw with a skiddy delivery, but Rahul fed off Krunal Pandya to keep the innings ticking in third gear. His knock had its moments - like the outrageous loft to the cover boundary off Kagiso Rabada - but his mellowed-down tempo during his half-century meant that LSG were always searching for acceleration.

Captain Curran delivers at the death

LSG lost their way when Kagiso Rabada struck twice in the 15th over. He first had Krunal caught at deep midwicket and then, after a failed caught-behind appeal that was called wide down the leg side, he had Nicholas Pooran out first ball, pulling to deep midwicket.

Sam Curran, who was leading the Kings in Dhawan's absence, then picked up the huge wicket of Marcus Stoinis, convinced the batter had gloved a glance to the keeper and successfully overturning the on-field decision. Curran bowled his cutters into the pitch effectively and picked up two more wickets in the final over to finish with figures of 3 for 31.

KL Rahul put in a full-stretched dive to remove Jitesh Sharma•Associated Press

Yudhvir's dream start

Yudhvir Singh made a special debut for LSG. In his first over, he dismissed fellow debutant Atharva Taide, and then flattened Prabhsimran Singh's off stump with a rocket of a nipbacker in his second over. Matt Short, however, put Punjab's chase back on track with a counterattack.

He found support in Harpreet Singh, who was playing his first IPL game in nearly 11 years. Harpreet played the anchor's role until it got to a point where he had to attack. And after a few missed attempts, he picked out deep square for a run-a-ball 22. At 75 for 4, Kings weren't out of trouble yet.

Raza to the rescue

After playing himself in and scoring his first 20 at nearly a run a ball, Raza went after Krunal, taking 17 off the 13th over to reduce the equation to 61 off 42 balls.

Rahul held back his legspinner Ravi Bishnoi until the 15th over, which meant that he would not be able to complete his full quota of four overs. He struck with his third ball to dismiss Sam Curran. Now, it was down to Raza, and he brought up his maiden IPL half-century off 34 balls. But there was another twist when Rahul pulled off a diving catch to his left at mid-off to dismiss Jitesh Sharma, and Raza also picked out Stoinis at deep backward square leg soon after.

Shahrukh takes on Wood

With 38 runs needed off 25 balls, Shahrukh smashed his first delivery - off Wood no less - over the long-on boundary. And then, with 18 to get off 11, he went hard at Wood again. This time the top edge flew off the attempted pull and cleared the boundary behind the wicketkeeper. At the start of the final over, Punjab needed only seven runs, and Shahrukh muscled Bishnoi to the wide long-off boundary to spark off celebrations in his dugout.

Match 22

Mumbai Indians 186 for 5 (Kishan 58, Suryakumar 43, Suyash 2-27) beat Kolkata Knight Riders 185 for 6 (Venkatesh 104, Shokeen 2-34) by five wickets

On a special day for the Mumbai Indians franchise, their home fans were treated to a commanding victory over Kolkata Knight Riders, with contributions from Ishan Kishan, Suryakumar Yadav, Piyush Chawla and Hrithik Shokeen.

The all-round effort from the Mumbai team overshadowed Venkatesh Iyer's 51-ball 104 that had single-handedly lifted the Knight Riders to 185. Iyer broke Knight Riders' jinx of no IPL centuries since Brendon McCullum's 158* from 15 years ago, but the other batters were not fluent.

That meant Knight Riders finished below par and Kishan's powerplay dominance (58 off 25) made it even worse for them. Suryakumar, the stand-in captain, then showed glimpses of his best (43 off 25) with solid contributions from Tilak Varma and Tim David to polish off the win.

There was also a debut for Arjun Tendulkar, the son of Indian batting legend Sachin Tendulkar. He bowled two new-ball overs that showed promise for the future.

Venkatesh ends KKR's century curse

Sometimes intent matters more than timing. Or so it seemed in Venkatesh's case. Walking in after N Jagadeesan fell for a duck early, he hit Tendulkar and Cameron Green for sixes to race away to 19 in 8 balls.

He often charged out of his crase, using his reach to convert length balls into fuller deliveries, and even if he wasn't timing it, he was clearing the boundaries. He also survived some inside-edges that whizzed past the stumps for four, including the ball that got him to fifty in 23 deliveries.

Sometimes Venkatesh looked a million dollars. Like when he pulled both Riley Meredith and debutant Duan Jansen - Marco's twin - for sixes in the 11th and 12th overs. At other times, Venkatesh rode his luck with his footwork getting him in awkward positions.

Another six off Meredith in the 14th over took Venkatesh to 94, but he wouldn't reach his century till his 17th, with Mumbai's bowlers squeezing him and Shardul Thakur with three tight overs. When he got there, he presented a wide grin and acknowledged the crowd.

He couldn't stay till the end though. In the 18th over, an attempted reverse scoop off Meredith resulted in an easy catch on 104 for short third.

Chawla leads Mumbai's bowling effort

Suryakumar chose to bowl at the toss. Tendulkar took the new ball and got it to swing early. He bowled six dots and finished 0-17 in two overs. Green kept tight lines and Shokeen's offbreaks to two left-handers kept one end quiet.

Trying to increase his strike-rate, Rahmanullah Gurbaz was caught at short third off Chawla. Then things got heated when Nitish Rana was dismissed by his state team-mate Shokeen. Shokeen went on to remove Shardul Thakur, slog sweeping to the deep and Rinku Singh couldn't repeat his recent heroics either, making only 18.

It was Venkatesh's hitting - a total outlier in the Knight Riders innings - that had kept them on course for a 200+ score, but Shokeen, Chawla and Jansen bowled three tidy overs between 15 and 17 to take some momentum out from the batting innings. Russell faced only 11 balls after walking in at No. 7 and hit 21 unbeaten runs to set Mumbai 186 to win.

Ishan's burst and Rohit's 'Impact'

Rohit, who didn't start the game due to a 'stomach bug', walked in as opener after Mumbai activated their Impact Player. He was very nearly caught-and-bowled by Umesh Yadav off his first ball. For most of the powerplay, he was spectator to Kishan's thrashing of Knight Riders' bowlers before falling for 20.

Kishan punished Shardul for 4, 4, 6 through the off side in the second over. He then showed his leg-side play with a four and six off Umesh in the third. When Narine came in to bowl the

chase's fourth over, he was hit for 22 with Kishan going 6, dot, 6, 4 through slogs. He got his fifty in 21 balls.

Kishan then smashed Varun Chakravathy for six to move to 58, but when he tried to repeat it, he was bowled.

But the openers had done their job. According to ESPNcricinfo's forecaster, Mumbai were 30% favourites to win the game at the start of the chase. By the time Kishan and Rohit were gone, Mumbai were 87 for 2 in 7.3 overs - now 70% favourites.

Tilak, SKY bring it home

The blazing start gave both batters the liberty to start cautiously but the big hits came out soon enough, with Suryakumar punishing wide deliveries with cuts for four and Tilak slog sweeping Narine at the start of his second spell for six over square leg.

Otherwise, they were cautious against spin through the middle overs with Rana being forced to use his best bowlers early. When Lockie Ferguson took the ball, Suryakumar brought out some vintage shots, picking up a full ball for six over fine leg and repeating it next ball over midwicket. Tilak and Suryakumar then picked off Russell for 17 in one over.

Their partnership of 60 in 6.2 overs deflated Knight Riders, and after they were dismissed, David made a dash for the finish. His 24 in 13 balls sealed the deal with 14 balls to spare and gave Mumbai a net-run rate boost.

Nitish, Shokeen fined after altercation

Nitish Rana and Hrithik Shokeen, who are team-mates for Delhi at state level, were both fined for breaching the IPL's Code of Conduct after exchanging words following the former's dismissal. Nitish charged down the pitch to Shokeen, lofting him to long-on, and Shokeen appeared to give him a send-off after substitute fielder Ramandeep Singh took the catch.

Nitish responded angrily and was escorted away from Shokeen by Suryakumar and Chawla. Nitish was fined 25% of his match fee under Article 2.21 of the Code of Conduct, which covers "all types of conduct that bring the game into disrepute".

Shokeen was fined 10% of his match fee under Article 2.5, which covers the use of "language, actions or gestures which disparage or which could provoke an aggressive reaction from a batter upon his/her dismissal".

Suryakumar was also fined INR 12 lakh (USD 14,000 approx.) for Mumbai's slow over-rate.

Match 23

Rajasthan Royals 179 for 7 (Samson 60, Hetmyer 56*, Shami 3-25, Rashid 2-46)
beat Gujarat Titans 177 for 7 (Miller 46, Gill 45, Sandeep 2-25) by three wickets

Rajasthan Royals had almost reached a point of no-return.

Their chase of 178 was going nowhere at 66 for 4. They needed a further 112 more off 48 balls. Twelve of those were to be bowled by Rashid Khan.

You sensed this was perhaps a task too steep, even for someone as pedigreed as Sanju Samson and Shimron Hetmyer. But as Rinku Singh showed the other night at this very ground, it ain't over till it's over.

Samson went 6,6,6 in Rashid's third over that went for 20 runs, Hetmyer took the attack at the other end to his West Indies team-mate Alzarri Joseph. Within no time, momentum had swung the Royals way to such an extent that not even Samson's dismissal at that juncture seemed a bother.

Hetmyer stood tall to bring up his half-century off 25 balls, Dhruv Jurel contributed a cameo knock of 17 that was worth a lot more and R Ashwin came in to smack a six and a four in the penultimate over. All of this brought them within a couple of blows of victory.

With five needed off five, Hetmyer sealed a win that seemed improbable at one stage, by biffing Noor Ahmad for six as Royals had comeback from nowhere to pull off a heist that took them to the top of the IPL 2023 leaderboard five games in.

For Gujarat Titans, this was yet another heartbreak, eerily similar to the one they endured against Kolkata Knight Riders last week.

Titans' chaotic start

Wriddhiman Saha and B Sai Sudharsan were gone inside the powerplay as Titans limped to 42 for 2; the first time they didn't cross 50 in the first six overs this season.

Saha was out to a hoick that had three people going for it, only for a fourth, Trent Boult, take the rebound that followed a collision between Samson and Hetmyer. Sudharsan was run-out at the striker's end by a yard, after he coiled himself at the bowler's end; those precious seconds costing him the distance to make the ground.

Shubman Gill and Hardik Pandya put on 59 off 33 balls•Associated Press

Hardik-Gill get going

The pair set about rebuilding the innings, and one of the ways they went about it was to try and attack the spinners. Ashwin was hit for 27 in his first two; Gill used his feet to score against him, while Hardik took down Adam Zampa. The pair added 59 in just 33 balls before Yuzvendra Chahal deceived Hardik in flight to have him caught for a 19-ball 28.

Titans' slowdown

The next 30 deliveries following Hardik's dismissal went for just 31 runs as Royals brought their spinners into play superbly. Titans owed much of their momentum in the end to Abhinav Manohar and

Manohar made 27 off 13 in a game he may have not played had Vijay Shankar been fit. Miller did Miller things - taking the innings deep before unleashing some ferocious hits to make 46. Titans suddenly had 177 for 7, more than they looked like getting at one stage but perhaps less than what they would've liked anyway.

Royals rocked early

Yashasvi Jaiswal was snuffed out in the slips, and Jos Buttler was clean bowled - only his second duck in the IPL - trying to scoop Mohammed Shami. At 4 for 2 in three overs, they needed some semblance of normalcy which Devdutt Padikkal and Samson provided, until Rashid entered and made a splash.

In his first over, he had charging Padikkal slice a wrong'un to short third man. In his second over, the 11th, he had Riyan Parag flay one straight down long-off's throat.

Samson goes 6,6,6

With Royals needing 112 off 48, ESPNcricinfo win probability had Royals at 2.01%. But Samson unleashed some big hits in Rashid's third over. He got to the pitch to belt the first two down the ground and quickly transferred weight back to pull as soon as Rashid dropped short in trying to mix his lengths.

It's at this point that Titans introduced Noor Ahmad, the Afghanistan left-arm spinner, for his bag of tricks in place of Gill as the Impact Sub. After being hit for a six and four, he had Samson pick out long-off.

Hetmyer sees Royals home

Hetmyer was the perfect foil at the other end, feeding off Samson's energy with takedowns off his own, more so Joseph. There was a moment when Royals could've had Hetmyer, but for Shami who stumbled a few yards in at third man for a catch that may have been straight down his throat had he stayed on the ropes. Royals needed 62 off 29 then. It's a moment they could look back and wonder what could've been.

Dhruv Jurel, coming in at the fall of Samson's wicket, didn't take time settling in. His impeccable six-hitting and gamesmarts of using pace to good effect to play behind the wicket helped Royals quickly bring the deficit down.

Titans may have yet sniffed a chance when Jurel went for a 10-ball 17, but Ashwin wielded the long handle off his first two deliveries to bring the target down to single digits. From there on, Hetmyer wasn't going to let this slip away as Royals pulled off a comeback win.

Match 24

Chennai Super Kings 226 for 6 (Conway 83, Dube 52, Siraj 1-30) beat Royal Challengers Bangalore 218 for 8 (Maxwell, 76, du Plessis 62, Deshpande 3-45, Pathirana 2-42) by eight runs

In February earlier this year Faf du Plessis was back in yellow, leading Jo'burg Super Kings to the inaugural SA20 semi-finals along with coach Stephen Fleming. Two months on in the IPL, du Plessis, in red and gold, launched an audacious assault with Glenn Maxwell as Royal Challengers Bangalore threatened to mow down 227 against Fleming and MS Dhoni's Chennai Super Kings at the Chinnaswamy Stadium.

Kohli fined 10% of his match fee

Virat Kohli was fined for breaching the IPL Code of Conduct during RCB's fixture against CSK on Monday. "Kohli admitted to the Level 1 offence under Article 2.2 of the Code of Conduct," said an IPL release. The statement did not go into details about the incident. "For Level 1 breaches of the Code of Conduct, the Match Referee's decision is final and binding," the release further added.

After Super Kings had posted 226 for 6 on the back of Devon Conway's 45-ball 83 and Shivam Dube's 27-ball 52, they struck early through their Impact Player Akash Singh to dismiss Virat Kohli for 6 in the first over. Mahipal Lomror then fell to Tushar Deshpande in the next over, but du Plessis and Maxwell then tore into Super Kings' inexperienced seamers to power them to 75 for 2 in the powerplay.

Royal Challengers doubled that score by the 14th over, with du Plessis - bruised rib and all - riding his luck to push them even further ahead. Du Plessis had been dropped on 0, by Dhoni behind the stumps, and then on 52 by Maheesh Theekshana off his own bowling. Super Kings dropped two more catches in a lax fielding effort, but late wickets and nifty variations from the Sri Lankan pair of Theekshana and Matheesha Pathirana saved the day for them.

Theekshana had got rid of Maxwell for 76 off 36 balls with a fizzing 104kph carrom ball in a boundary-less over. Pathirana, who had been taken for 26 off ten balls from Maxwell, had Shahbaz Ahmed holing out in an 18th over that cost just four runs to go with that wicket.

Royal Challengers' Impact Player Suyash Prabhudessai then heaved Deshpande for six in the 19th over, but Pathirana successfully defended 18 off the final over with his slinging, on-pace yorkers and slower cutters. He had Prabhudessai caught at deep midwicket last ball with his bowling coach Dwayne Bravo applauding him from the dugout.

Conway, Rahane turn up the tempo

Mohammed Siraj excelled in the powerplay once again, giving up just six runs in his two overs while claiming the wicket of Ruturaj Gaikwad for 3. Conway and Ajinkya Rahane, too, had started slowly, but they turned up the tempo in the fifth over, bowled by rookie seamer

Vyshak Vijaykumar. Conway manufactured a scooped four while Rahane hit the roof of the Chinnaswamy Stadium with a 91-metre six.

Rahane then cracked Wayne Parnell for 4,6,4 in the last over of the powerplay, taking Super Kings up to 53 for 1 in six overs. He tried to keep up the attacking intent against Wanindu Hasaranga, but the wristspinner bested him with a wrong'un.

3:07

Jaffer: Feeling secure at CSK has probably helped Rahane

Dube dazzles

Hasaranga bowled only two overs and didn't return after dismissing Rahane because Super Kings had promoted their left-handed spin-hitter Dube to No.4 once again. Royal Challengers matched Dube up with Maxwell, but he got going by launching his own six into the roof of the ground.

Conway brought up back-to-back half-centuries and looked good for a maiden IPL hundred, but Harshal Patel eventually cleaned him up for 83 with a dipping yorker. With Royal Challengers not having an out-and-out fast bowler in their ranks, Dube continued to find or clear the boundary. He charged to a 25-ball fifty before Parnell had him holing out in the 17th over.

The drama at the death

Despite the loss of Ambati Rayudu in the next over, Super Kings seemed on track for a total of 230. Siraj, however, nailed his wide yorkers in the 19th over that cost ten runs.

Harshal started the final over, which was closed out by stand-in captain Maxwell; du Plessis was off the field during that time because of a side strain.

After Harshal bowled two beamers, he had to be taken out of the attack. Maxwell brought himself into the attack, ahead of Hasaranga, and conceded nine runs, including a wide, for the wicket of Ravindra Jadeja off the last four balls.

Faf du Plessis and Glenn Maxwell controlled the chase after the early wickets•Associated Press

The du Plessis-Maxwell show

Royal Challengers were two down in two overs, but they still flew out of the blocks, thanks to du Plessis and Maxwell. They played to their strengths, with du Plessis taking down pace and Maxwell spin. Du Plessis was responsible for 45 of the 75 runs Royal Challengers had scored in the powerplay.

Maxwell then took centre stage, lining up both Jadeja and Theekshana. Maxwell didn't spare Pathirana either after the powerplay, shanking him for a 94-metre six over square leg.

The pair took their team to 141 off 2 in 12 overs. Eighty-six from eight overs is a manageable ask at the Chinnaswamy, but Theekshana had Maxwell skying behind to set the scene for Super Kings' comeback.

Pathirana steps up

Dinesh Karthik then played out the spinners and took the game deep with his 14-ball 28. By the time Karthik was out, Royal Challengers needed 35 off 18 balls. Pathirana would bowl two of those.

Super Kings had opted against rushing Pathirana back into action because he had just recovered from Covid-19. But with Sisanda Magala also joining their injury list, they threw Pathirana into the mix on an easy-paced Chinnaswamy track. After taking a pasting in the early exchanges, he showed excellent control with his variations, showing why Super Kings were interested in signing him up even before he had played the Lanka Premier League in Sri Lanka.

In an IPL game where a record-equalling 33 sixes were hit, Pathirana held his nerve to drag Super Kings back into the top half of the standings.

Match 25

Mumbai Indians 192 for 5 (Green 64*, Kishan 38, Tilak Varma 37, Jansen 2-43)
beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 178 (Agarwal 48, Klaasen 36, Meredith 2-33, Behrendorff 2-37, Chawla 2-43) by 14 runs

Two days after their top order made short work of a 186-run target against Kolkata Knight Riders, Mumbai Indians' middle order muscled an above-par total of 192 on a sluggish pitch against Sunrisers Hyderabad to set up their third straight win and take them two places up to the sixth spot on the points table. It was also the second day in a row in the IPL where a team defended a total successfully.

Mumbai will also gain confidence from the fact that their bowlers reduced Sunrisers to 127 for 5 in the 14th over without the help of Jasprit Bumrah and Jofra Archer, their main quick bowlers, and were largely ahead in the game. Heinrich Klaasen, Marco Jansen and Washington Sundar pulled out some big hits but couldn't finish the job. The last over started with 20 required, and Arjun Tendulkar had the ball. It was a sequence of wide yorkers, which resulted in two wickets and just five runs scored.

The prime architects of Mumbai's win were Cameron Green and Tilak Varma, who put on a stand of 56 in 28 balls and helped them score 83 off the last six overs before Green sent down some tight overs to finish with 1 for 29, including the big wicket of Aiden Markram.

Rohit lights up the powerplay

After opting to bowl, Sunrisers brought on Washington in the third over for the match-up against Rohit Sharma: 25 runs off 26 balls with three dismissals before this game. But Rohit

turned it around by taking on the bigger leg-side boundary, which had the two fielders out. He hit two fours behind square, and then one through cover-point to hit the pedal.

Rohit continued to attack with his array of shots; he smoked T Natarajan over mid-on and ramped him for four more. It didn't last long. Natarajan sent a slow cutter on the pads and Rohit got a leading edge to mid-off to leave for 28 off 18.

But Ishan Kishan then took over and took Mumbai to 53 for 1 at the end of the powerplay.

Caught Markram bowled Jansen

Jansen had already bowled two good overs in the powerplay - making him one of the best in this IPL with an economy rate of 5.57 - and he returned for the 12th over to strike twice. He first banged the ball short - not to forget the height he delivers from - to make Kishan miscue the ball to mid-off, where Markram completed an excellent catch.

Four balls later, Markram was at it again when Suryakumar Yadav chipped a slow cutter down the ground; Markram ran across, put in the dive, and got up with the ball in his hand. It was a case of leading by example after Markram had said at the toss that his team had to field better, having dropped 11 catches earlier in the tournament, according to ESPNcricinfo's data.

2:35

Moody: Tilak Varma has big career ahead of him

Tilak and Green take off

Mumbai could have easily slipped or slowed down after that, but their search for boundaries every over paid off when Tilak Varma and Green took on their best bowler of the day to start the onslaught.

Green used his tall frame to unleash big swings combined with brute force, while Tilak Varma displayed more of his clean hitting and supple wrists against the spinners. The two batters collected 21 and 14 runs off the 15th and 16th overs respectively, with three fours and as many sixes to lift the run rate from 7.78 to nine an over.

It took Bhuvneshwar Kumar's experience in the 17th and 19th overs to keep Mumbai under 200. He took the pace off with his cutters and knuckle balls to concede just 14 runs in those two overs.

Natarajan, meanwhile, missed his yorkers and Green dispatched him for three consecutive fours followed by a six over long-off that also took him past his first IPL fifty, off 33 balls. In the last over, Tim David manipulated the field to put away two more Natarajan full tosses to collect 14 more useful runs.

Highest win% contribution for Mumbai Indians' players against Sunrisers Hyderabad•ESPNcricinfo Ltd

Behrendorff makes early inroads

After missing the previous game because of an illness, Jason Behrendorff returned to deliver two big and early bowls to Sunrisers. His short ball drew a top edge from Harry Brook before a delivery outside off took Rahul Tripathi's outside edge to Kishan.

The onus was largely on Markram now to chaperone them to the end overs as Mayank Agarwal wasn't scoring as quickly and the asking rate was creeping up.

Markram started attacking with his strong suit - hitting a six off a spinner - but holed out to deep midwicket off Green while attempting a big hit. Three balls later, Abhishek Sharma found long-off off Piyush Chawla and Sunrisers were four down with the asking rate nearly touching 12.

Shades of a fightback

With runs not coming easily and the lack of dew helping the bowlers, Sunrisers were already behind the curve. They got a big boost when Heinrich Klaasen blasted Chawla with two mighty pulls and two reverse sweeps for 4, 6, 6 and 4, but he then handed a catch to long-on in the same over, but after reducing the equation to 66 from 36.

It was within reach at that point, but Meredith soon accounted for Agarwal in a frugal over and Jansen, after a couple of boundaries, handed David his fourth catch of the match. David wasn't quite done - after Washington raised Sunrisers' hopes again, his lazy running gave David an opportunity, and the direct hit from mid-off ended Washington's stay.

Match 26

Lucknow Super Giants 154 for 7 (Mayers 51, Rahul 39, Ashwin 2-23) beat Rajasthan Royals 144 for 6 (Jaiswal 44, Buttler 40, Avesh 3-25, Stoinis 2-28) by 10 runs

On a slow Sawai Mansingh Stadium pitch, Lucknow Super Giants spoiled Rajasthan Royals' homecoming in a game of middling totals by defending 154, the lowest total successfully defended this IPL.

Playing in Jaipur after almost four years, Royals restricted Super Giants to 154 for 7. In response, they were 89 for 1 after 12 overs, needing 66 from the remaining eight. But Marcus Stoinis and Avesh Khan used the slowness of the surface to their advantage by banging the ball in the middle of the pitch to make run-scoring difficult.

Rahul fined for Super Giants' slow over-rate

Lucknow Super Giants captain KL Rahul was fined INR 12 lakh for his team's slow over-rate. It was Super Giants' first offence of the season. They also faced the on-field penalty and had to bowl the 20th over with just four fielders outside the 30-yard circle.

As the asking rate mounted, so did the pressure on the Royals batters. With 48 required from four overs, Ravi Bishnoi conceded just six in the 17th. In the next over, Devdutt

Padikkal picked up three fours off Stoinis to keep Royals in the contest but Naveen-ul-Haq bowled an excellent 19th over, giving away just ten and leaving 18 to defend for Avesh.

Riyan Parag started the final over with a four, followed by a leg-bye, before Avesh dismissed Padikkal and Dhruv Jurel on successive deliveries to seal the result.

LSG's scratchy start

The recent record in Jaipur was in favour of the chasing sides, and Sanju Samson duly opted to bowl. Even though Trent Boult couldn't pick up a wicket in the first over this time, he started with a maiden to KL Rahul. With just 14 runs on the board after three overs, Rahul walked at Sandeep Sharma and punched him uppishly towards extra cover, where Yashasvi Jaiswal put down a straightforward chance. Later in the over, Rahul got another life when he pushed one to the right of Jaiswal and took off. Jaiswal intercepted with a dive but missed a direct hit, and Rahul would have been out by a yard.

In the next over, Rahul had a third life: he miscued Boult, but Jason Holder, having settled under it after running back from mid-off, failed to hold on. With Kyle Mayers also struggling to score freely, Super Giants finished the powerplay on 37 for 0 - the lowest wicketless powerplay total this season by a distance.

A flicker from Rahul and Mayers, but nothing more

It was only after the powerplay that Rahul and Mayers really tried to increase the tempo. They were successful too for a while. Mayers launched Holder for a six in the eighth over and Rahul finished it with a four. In the next over, Yuzvendra Chahal was in the firing line. Mayers started by hitting a six and four off successive balls before Rahul slog-swept the legspinner for another six.

3:27

Were Rajasthan Royals left surprised by the slowness of their 'home' ground?

With Super Giants 74 for no loss after nine overs, the platform was set. However, the next nine overs brought them just 55 runs with the loss of four wickets. Rahul was the first to depart, chipping Holder to long-on for 39 off 32. The experiment to send Ayush Badoni at No. 3 didn't work either; the batter deflected a scoop off Boult onto his leg stump in the next over.

In the 13th over, Mayers struck back-to-back fours off Chahal, and brought up his half-century off 40 balls. But R Ashwin's double-strike from the other end to remove Deepak Hooda and Mayers kept the lid on the scoring rate. And despite Nicholas Pooran hitting Holder for two fours and a six in a 17-run 19th over, Super Giants just crossed 150.

Jaiswal keeps Royals afloat

Royals started their chase slowly and were 23 for 0 after four overs despite Yuvraj Singh leaking 16 in the second. By the end of the powerplay, though, they had more than doubled their score. A misfield by Mayers gifted Jaiswal a boundary on the first ball of the fifth over, bowled by Yuvraj. Three balls later, Buttler - on 5 off 14 until then - smashed a 112-metre six.

In the last over of the powerplay, Jaiswal and Buttler hit Avesh for three fours, the second of those a slash from Jaiswal that burst through Naveen's hands at short third.

Still, Buttler was going slower than a run a ball, and it was Jaiswal who kept Royals afloat. The two added 87 in 11.3 overs; Buttler's contribution in that was only 35 off 35.

ESPNcricinfo Ltd

Stoinis and Avesh turn it around

Royals were moving towards their target with little fuss when Stoinis ended the opening stand with Jaiswal's wicket, who steered one low to Avesh at short third. The next two overs brought two more wickets; Samson was run-out and Buttler holed out to deep midwicket off Stoinis for 40 off 41.

With 56 needed from six overs, and Padikkal and Shimron Hetmyer in the middle, Royals were still the favourites. Naveen leaked just five in the 15th, resulting in the required rate going past ten for the first time in the chase. Hetmyer tried to take on Avesh but was caught at long-on, only for 2. That turned the game in Super Giants' favour, and from there on, they didn't give Royals any chance.

Match 27

Royal Challengers Bangalore 174 for 4 (Du Plessis 84, Kohli 59, Brar 2-31) beat Punjab Kings 150 (Prabhsimran 46, Jitesh 41, Siraj 4-21) by 24 runs

Faf du Plessis revealed that he wouldn't have played this game had the Impact Player rule not been in place. His bruised rib was causing too many problems. But the new rules gave him the chance to affect the game with just his batting and that's what he did. Handing over the captaincy to Virat Kohli so he could play as a substitute, he hit 84 off 56 balls on a sluggish Mohali pitch to haul Royal Challengers Bangalore to 174 for 4, despite a late slowdown. Then he just rested in the dugout and watched Mohammed Siraj excel in both the powerplay and death to help them defend that total.

Royal Challengers had managed only 37 for 4 in their last four overs after being on 137 for 0 in 16 overs. However, they dominated the powerplay - both with bat and then ball - to hold off Punjab Kings and give their campaign a leg-up after a narrow defeat against Chennai Super Kings at home.

The opening salvo

After a sedate start - du Plessis was on 3 off 7 balls at one point - he manufactured swinging room against left-arm fingerspinner Harpreet Brar and launched him over his head for six. Two balls later, he created more room and bludgeoned him over midwicket for six more. Kohli had also started strongly, driving Brar and then pulling the seamers for fours, as Royal Challengers ran away to 59 for 0 in the powerplay. Du Plessis batted with similar high intent even beyond the powerplay and went onto bring up his half-century off 31 balls.

The slowdown

Kohli, though, slowed down after the powerplay especially against legspinner Rahul Chahar and the slower variations of Sam Curran. After being on 29 off 19 balls at the end of the powerplay, he managed only 30 off his next 28 balls.

His innings ended - and Kings finally broke through - when he spliced a sweep off Brar, with wicketkeeper Jitesh Sharma completing a stunning one-handed catch. Brar then had Glenn Maxwell holing out for a duck next ball and then Nathan Ellis, picked ahead of Kagiso Rabada, tricked du Plessis with a slower variation to shut down Royal Challengers at the death.

They were 91 for 0 in ten overs and later 137 for 0 in 16 overs but ended up with what seemed like a sub-par total at that stage. In the end, it would prove to be 24 too many for Kings.

Siraj bosses the powerplay and death

Royal Challengers quickly regained lost ground when Siraj struck twice in the powerplay to trap both Atharva Taide (4) and the returning Liam Livingstone (2). With those two wickets, Siraj took his powerplay tally this season up to six. No other bowler has more wickets during this phase in IPL 2023.

After finding late inswing in the early exchanges, Siraj returned in the death to wrap up Kings' chase. Jitesh's late blows had given Kings a sliver of hope, narrowing the equation to 30 off 18 balls, but Siraj knocked over Brar and Ellis in an 18th over that cost only four runs. Siraj was also at it in the field, effecting a direct hit from mid-off to catch Harpreet Bhatia short at the non-striker's end.

Jitesh, Prabhsimran flicker for Kings

That Kings got this close to the target from being 43 for 4 in the powerplay was down to contributions from their Impact Player Prabhsimran Singh and finisher Jitesh. Even as five wickets fell around him, Prabhsimran went after the RCB attack. He was particularly severe on Wanindu Hasaranga, taking him for 18 off eight balls. But when he fell four short of a half-century, the chase slipped further away from Kings' reach.

Jitesh briefly kept Kings in the chase with his own counterattack, but Siraj and Harshal Patel eventually dismissed them for 150 and dragged RCB up to fifth on the standings.

Match 28

Delhi Capitals 128 for 6 (Warner 57, Pandey 21, Varun 2-16, Rana 2-17, A Roy 2-19) beat Kolkata Knight Riders 127 (J Roy 43, Russell 38*, Axar 2-13, Kuldeep 2-15) by four wickets

Delhi Capitals finally earned their first win of IPL 2023, breaking a five-game losing streak, but it did not come easy. Despite chasing only 128 after their best bowling performance of the season, their batters struggled with Kolkata Knight Riders overloading on spin bowling. If it wasn't for David Warner's fourth fifty of the season and Axar Patel staying on till the end, it could very well have been 0-6 for the hosts.

Even though their batting brought life late into the contest, it was the Capitals bowlers in the first innings who set up the win. Ishant Sharma - playing his first IPL game since May 2021 - took 2 for 19 in four overs, while Anrich Nortje (2 for 20) made batting difficult with his extra pace. Kuldeep Yadav and Axar ran through the middle order by sharing four wickets, while Mukesh Kumar impressed with his new-ball and yorker skills.

They ensured Knight Riders' batters struggled to put in a cohesive performance yet again. Knight Riders made four changes to their playing XI but except for Jason Roy's 43, their batting lacked direction. While their spinners dug deep, the target was too low in the end. They have now lost four games out of six, three on the trot.

Ishant, Nortje, Mukesh sizzle up top

The three pacers took a wicket each in the powerplay. Litton Das, playing his first IPL game, was the first to go trying to pull Mukesh from outside off, and then Venkatesh Iyer fell from the high of a century to the low of a duck when he was caught at slip off a Nortje snorter that was going across the batter.

But the best bowler in the powerplay was Ishant, bowling metronomic lines at a high pace to keep the batters in check. His persistence earned him Nitish Rana's wicket when he failed to clear mid-on in the sixth over.

Ishant Sharma finished with figures of 2 for 19 • Associated Press

It was a familiar sight for the Knight Riders with another top-order collapse. When Mandeep Singh and Rinku Singh were out to Axar, trying to take the bowler on, the score looked even worse at 64 for 5.

Jason, though, battled on. He wasn't timing it perfectly despite initially looking fluent, and looked to hold one end up. He saw Sunil Narine holing out next before Andre Russell joined him. They picked up singles for two overs before a 15-run Mitchell Marsh over gave Knight Riders some hope of a strong finish. Ishant, meanwhile, left the field with figures of 4-0-19-2 as Capitals brought in Prithvi Shaw as their Impact Player.

Kuldeep triggers lower-order clean-up

But Jason perished for 43 in the 15th over to Kuldeep. After failing to clear square leg, he looked annoyed at himself for falling that way. Kuldeep looked delighted in equal measure, getting a wicket against his former side.

Next ball, Kuldeep dented Knight Riders further when he had the incoming Impact Player Anukul Roy lbw. That left Knight Riders at 93 for 8, which soon became 96 for 9 with Nortje dismissing Umesh Yadav.

Russell farmed the strike thereafter. He tried to deal only in boundaries but his success rate was low. Mukesh delivered yorker after yorker to frustrate Russell in his penultimate over and Nortje did more of the same. Kuldeep also upped his pace to restrain the big hitter.

The final over started with Knight Riders at 108 for 9, but Mukesh struggled to nail his yorkers. Russell smacked him for a hat-trick of sixes to give Capitals 128 to chase.

David Warner brought up his fourth half-century in six games • Associated Press

Warner stands tall again

As it has been all season, Warner stood at one end while wickets tumbled from the other. Shaw made only 13 while Mitchell Marsh and Phil Salt fell for single digits. That gave Knight Riders a glimmer of hope.

But Warner motored along to get his fourth fifty in six games this season, this one his quickest in 33 balls. The small target allowed him to keep playing his shots, and he had hit 11 fours by the time he raised his bat for the half-century.

He was especially brutal against Narine, hitting him for four fours in one over, while otherwise being more expressive against the seamers. After Salt was the third man gone, Manish Pandey offered an experienced hand alongside Warner and brought the equation to 35 in 42.

Capitals conquer their nerves

However, the equation soon became 35 off 36 when Varun dismissed Warner for 57 and eked out a maiden. Pandey then tried to hit out, but he became Anukul's second victim when he failed to clear long-on. The atmosphere turned even more nervy when Rana rattled Aman Khan's stumps next.

But with 15 needed off 18, Capitals remained favourites with four wickets still in the hut. Varun bowled a dream 18th over where Axar just about survived an lbw call and Lalit Yadav escaped a stumping, but the two batters ensured they did not give their wicket away. Rana's tidy 19th brought the equation to seven off the final over.

Rana would have preferred using spin for the 20th over too, but having exhausted all 16 overs of spin available, he turned to the pacer Kulwant Khejroliya. Axar comfortably negated his challenge to finish the game with four balls to spare.

Match 29

Chennai Super Kings 138 for 3 (Conway 77*, Gaikwad 35, Markande 2-23) beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 134 for 7 (Abhishek 34, Jadeja 3-22, Akash 1-17) by seven wickets

Devon Conway's third half-century in a row helped Chennai Super Kings chip away at the target of 135 against Sunrisers Hyderabad on a slow, gripping pitch at the MA Chidambaram Stadium. Earlier, Ravindra Jadeja grabbed three wickets - and combined with Maheesh Theekshana to bowl eight overs for only 4 for 49 - to stem Sunrisers' momentum after a bright start.

The visitors had three spinners in their side, including the left-arm spin of Impact Sub Mayank Dagar. But even as Dagar, Washington Sundar and Mayank Markande were economical, and even got two wickets, they didn't particularly cause any trouble to the opposition batters. Thus, as a result of the seven-wicket win, Super Kings stay third on the points table, but only on net run rate, level on points with Royals and Super Giants.

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Stolen bats of Delhi Capitals players found, says Warner

Jadeja turns it CSK's way

Jadeja was introduced in the eighth over after Harry Brook had helped Sunrisers to 34 from the first four overs, and then Theekshana and Moeen went for ten each. His first over went for seven, and next over, Moeen went for eight; Sunrisers were 70 for 1 after nine overs.

Then came the time-out, and the match changed tracks; the track itself seemed to have become rugged. Some deliveries turned, some didn't. A few held on to the pitch, while some others came on higher than anticipated. Second ball after the break, Jadeja got one to bounce nicely at Abhishek Sharma, with the batter playing for the turn. But he pulled and found long-on as the ball just went on straight after pitching. An innings of 34, which had sparkled briefly, came to an end.

Then, second ball of the 12th over, Jadeja bowled full and outside off to Rahul Tripathi, who tried to fetch it for a slog sweep but top-edged to short fine leg. On that occasion, the ball seemed to have stopped before coming on, as Tripathi fell for a run-a-ball 21. And if that was not enough, Mayank Agarwal - demoted to No. 6 - lost patience and skipped out to Jadeja in the 14th over. MS Dhoni had him stumped, and Sunrisers' slide from 71 for 1 to 95 for 5 turned out to be match defining.

Devon Conway and Ruturaj Gaikwad added 87 for the first wicket•BCCI

Conway motors along

Conway found the boundary three times off the first ten balls he faced, lofting, flaying and punching away at the ball. Yet, he was on 18 off 19 deliveries when Super Kings were at 37 without loss after five overs. That is when Marco Jansen got some treatment: Ruturaj Gaikwad took a single to start the sixth over, and Conway went 4, 4, 6, 4, 4.

All of those shots had variety: it started with the ramp; then came the scoop; a lucky, top-edged pull followed, and a deft touch past the wicketkeeper later, Conway ended the over by bisecting the short third and the point fielders. It took all of that for Sunrisers to introduce spin, but it was a bit too late. Conway raised his fifty from 33 balls in the tenth over, and ended unbeaten on 77, including 12 fours and a six.

Sunrisers' experiment backfires

Sunrisers had started the season with Abhishek and Mayank Agarwal as openers, with Brook in the middle order; next match, there was no Abhishek. Then they realised Brook and Agarwal can open together, and one game later, Abhishek returned, but in the middle order. They stuck with that one more time, before pushing Abhishek back and Agarwal down to No. 6 against Super Kings. Alas, it didn't work. Agarwal departed for his third single-digit score in six innings, though Sunrisers would take heart from Abhishek's effort at the top. But time is running out for Sunrisers, who find themselves ninth just one game away from the halfway stage. Batting first, two out of three times they have been restricted below 135, and they haven't always been competitive while chasing either. Something must click. Soon.

Match 30

Gujarat Titans 135 for 6 (Hardik 66, Saha 47, Krunal 2-16, Stoinis 2-20) beat Lucknow Super Giants 128 for 7 (Rahul 68, Noor 2-18, Mohit 2-17) by seven runs

A game that was very much in Lucknow Super Giants' hands was snatched from them by the combined efforts of Noor Ahmad, Mohit Sharma and Mohammed Shami. The Gujarat Titans bowlers turned the tables on the hosts, when they needed a comfortable 31 to win from 36 balls with as many as nine wickets left and a well-set KL Rahul in the middle.

The turnaround started with Noor Ahmad picking up two wickets for one run over nine balls, which put the pressure back on Super Giants as the equation reached 23 off 18. Mohit then sent down a flurry of accurate yorkers and slower balls for six singles, Shami bowled a tight 19th over for five runs, and when 12 were needed off six, Mohit pretty much shut the game out with the wickets of Rahul and Marcus Stoinis on the second and third balls of the last over. When 10 were needed off three, Ayush Badoni and Deepak Hooda were run out while attempting risky second runs and a dot ball sealed the win for Titans.

Titans are on eight points now, like the three teams above them on the IPL points table, and extended their unbeaten record against Super Giants to 3-0.

More questions on Rahul?

When Rahul raced to 30 off 19 and led his team to 53 for 0 in the powerplay with Kyle Mayers, it looked like the LSG captain was ready to take the bowlers on on a slow and sluggish pitch. He and Mayers finished the boundary-laden powerplay on such a good score that the asking rate had come down to under six an over.

Rahul brought up his fifty off 38 balls, stitched a fifty stand with both Mayers and No. 3 Krunal Pandya, and looked all set to see his side through when they needed 31 from the last six overs.

But the Titans bowlers dried up the boundaries after the 13th over, and took advantage of Super Giants' slow down to eventually emerge victorious. Noor's second spell started the slide with wickets in consecutive overs when Krunal was stumped while going for a big shot and Nicholas Pooran was caught off the leading edge by Hardik Pandya while attempted a big sweep. When it came down to the last three overs, Rahul just couldn't put away Shami and Mohit's accurate deliveries and holed out before Stoinis did the same in the last over.

Gujarat Titans' slowest powerplay of IPL 2023

There were early indications that the black soil pitch in Lucknow was going to help spinners a lot more than the quicks. They bowled three of the first six overs of the game and Krunal even found success when Shubman Gill came down to attack but handed an easy catch to long-off after the turning ball took a leading edge. Seeing the lack of pace on the pitch and knowing they needed someone senior to guide the innings, Hardik Pandya promoted himself to No. 3. Meanwhile, Wriddhiman Saha went all out attack and raced to 34 off 24 to push the score to 40 for 1, which was still Titans' lowest in the powerplay this IPL.

LSG's spinners shows up. Kind of

Saha kept the tempo up by making room and coming down the pitch often, but he became Krunal's second victim when he failed to clear long-on and fell for 47 off 37. By then, however, Saha and Hardik had bashed Ravi Bishnoi, Super Giants' best bowler this season, out of the attack. His first two overs went for 25 runs.

Super Giants turned to the experience of Amit Mishra, who sent down slow and loopy deliveries which made scoring even tougher. Abhinav Manohar took him on by targeting the long cover boundary where Naveen-ul-Haq took a stunning diving catch and Titans had lost wickets in successive overs to be 77 for 3 in the 12th over.

Quiet death overs despite Hardik's fifty

Hardik had struck the only six of the innings when David Miller joined him at 92 for 4 in the 15th over, and Titans were in desperate need of runs. Bishnoi and Avesh Khan slowed them

down further with tight lines and taking the pace off, and curiously they subbed out Mishra when he had two overs left. It meant Hardik faced Bishnoi in the 18th over and the Titans captain pulled him for 4, 6 and 6 in a 19-run over that ended a 27-ball boundary drought. The first of those sixes also took Hardik to his first fifty - off 44 balls - of the season to lift Titans almost single-handedly in the end.

Even without Mishra, Super Giants emerged the better side in the last two overs as Naveen and Stoinis took all the pace off the ball, dismissed Hardik in the last over and kept Miller quiet to just 6 off 12 balls, which, thankfully for them, didn't prove costly in the end.

Match 31

Punjab Kings 214 for 8 (Curran 55, Bhatia 41, Chawla 2-15) beat Mumbai Indians 210 for 6 (Green 67, Suryakumar 57, Arshdeep 4-29) by 13 runs

Punjab Kings' innings was going nowhere. After 14 overs, they were 105 for 4 with Harpreet Singh Bhatia batting on 15 off 16 and Sam Curran on 8 off 12. But in the next six overs, they ransacked 109. Bhatia ended with 41 off 28, Curran 55 off 29, and Jitesh Sharma 25 off just seven. That lifted Kings to a formidable 214 for 8.

In response, Mumbai Indians were always in the contest, thanks to Rohit Sharma's 27-ball 44 and Cameron Green's 43-ball 67. Suryakumar Yadav then threatened to snatch the game from Kings with his blazing half-century. That's when Arshdeep Singh rose to the occasion. He dismissed Suryakumar in the 18th over, and then with 16 required from six balls, he conceded just two while breaking the middle stumps of Tilak Varma and Nehal Wadhwa with back-to-back deliveries.

The 13-run win took Kings to fifth position with eight points from seven games. In fact, the top five teams all have eight points each, only the net run rate separating them.

Rohit and Green keep Mumbai on track

Before his heroics at the death, Arshdeep dealt Mumbai an early blow by sending back Ishan Kishan in the second over of the chase. Rohit and Green didn't let that deter them and kept finding boundaries at regular intervals. They hit five fours and three sixes in the powerplay to take Mumbai to 54 for 1 after six overs. The pair added 76 off 50 balls before Rohit spooned a return catch to Liam Livingstone in the tenth over.

Green and Suryakumar press on further

With Mumbai needing 127 in the last ten overs, Suryakumar didn't waste any time. He swept his third ball for a four before hitting Livingstone for a hat-trick of fours. It was a typical Suryakumar innings - he hit a 26-ball 57, with 33 of those runs coming behind square on the leg side.

At the other end, Green too switched into the next gear. In the 15th over, he hit Rahul Chahar for a six and four, bringing up his half-century in the process and reducing the equation to 66 needed from 30 balls.

It was even Stevens when the last over started, but Arshdeep Singh made sure the result went his team's way • BCCI

Ellis and Arshdeep show their skills

Green started the 16th over by hitting Nathan Ellis, Kings' Impact Player, for a four and six. But Ellis had him miscuing a back-of-the-hand slower one, and Curran settled under it near extra cover.

Despite that, Mumbai were very much in the contest. In fact, Suryakumar's six and four off Curran in the 17th over put Mumbai ahead. With 40 needed from the last three overs, Tim David hit Arshdeep's first ball - a full toss - for a six but the bowler conceded only three off the remaining five balls. One of those balls also took out Suryakumar. It was a low full toss that the batter flicked towards midwicket, where Atharva Taide leapt to his left to pluck the ball.

David still threatened to pull it off for Mumbai. In the penultimate over, he hit an Ellis full toss for a 114-metre six but apart from that, he struggled to middle the ball. In the final over, he took a single on Arshdeep's first ball, and then spent the rest of the over at the non-striker's end watching a death-bowling masterclass.

Prabhsimran, Taide revive the powerplay

Earlier, Kings had a quiet start after being sent in. Matthew Short tried to take on Green in the third over, flicking him over square leg for four. He eyed another boundary on the next ball, but his attempted pull failed to clear Piyush Chawla at short midwicket.

After three overs, Kings were 20 for 1. The next three, however, produced 38. Jason Behrendorff bowled a couple of short balls in the fourth, and Prabhsimran Singh duly dispatched them over the short square-leg boundary. From the other end, Taide ramped Jofra Archer for his first six.

Rohit introduced Chawla in the sixth over, and the two batters picked up a boundary each off him as well to lift Kings to 58 for 1 by the end of the powerplay.

Tendulkar, Chawla drag Kings back

It was a bit of a surprise when Arjun Tendulkar, who swung the new ball, was taken off after just one over. When he came back for his second, in the seventh of the innings, he had Prabhsimran lbw with an excellent yorker, the ball sneaking underneath the bat to hit the back shoe.

Chawla hurt Kings further with his double-strike in the tenth over. First, seeing Livingstone come down the track, he slipped one down the leg side to have him stumped. Three balls later, he beat Taide on the sweep. The ball hit the pad and went on to disturb the stumps. That left Kings 83 for 4 after ten overs.

The calm, followed by the carnage

Bhatia and Curran consolidated for a while, scoring only 22 from the next four overs. But then came the acceleration, and how. Hrithik Shokeen's 13-run over, the 15th of the innings, was a bad omen for Mumbai. But instead of bringing back Chawla, who had figures of 2 for 15 from three overs, Rohit went ahead with Tendulkar. Curran and Bhatia smashed him for four fours and two sixes, taking 31 from the over that also featured a wide and beamer.

Two overs later, Green came in for the punishment. Curran started it with two successive sixes. After a single on the third, Green dismissed Bhatia, but Jitesh launched him for two more maximums to make it 25 from the over.

Curran brought up his fifty, off 26 balls, with a four off Archer before getting out in the same over. Jitesh wasn't done yet, though. He hit two more sixes in the final over, bowled by Behrendorff, to take Kings to what proved to be just the winning total.

Match 32

Royal Challengers Bangalore 189 for 9 (Maxwell 77, du Plessis 62, Boult 2-41, Sandeep 2-49) beat Rajasthan Royals 182 for 6 (Padikkal 52, Jaiswal 47, Jurel 34*, Harshal 3-32) by seven runs

Royal Challengers Bangalore overcame a 50-for-7 collapse at the end of their innings and defended a total for the third time in IPL 2023 to go level on points with table leaders Rajasthan Royals and Lucknow Super Giants.

It was a weird match with arhythmic twists and turns. However, the centrepiece of RCB's win was a lightning 127-run partnership between Glenn Maxwell and Faf du Plessis in just 11.1 overs after they came together at 12 for 2, which perhaps made the pitch look easier than it was.

The pitch itself was an enigma. RCB were in doubt that it was a dry pitch that would slow down and wanted to bat first, and Royals wanted to chase. Even though they were bowling first, Royals didn't name a single batter in their substitutes' list, and continued to not use Jason Holder's batting. RCB continued to benefit from the Impact Player rule as they managed to play two players who wouldn't have featured but for the rule: du Plessis with his rib issue, and Harshal Patel with a finger injury that made batting difficult for him. Eventually both made crucial contributions.

Boult strikes like lightning

With five first-over wickets to his name this season already, Trent Boult's starts have become unmissable. This one was as good as any: full inswinger, past Virat Kohli's inside edge, plumb lbw first ball. With the first ball of his second over, Boult had Shahbaz Ahmed caught at short midwicket. Some even joked that RCB's last batting pair was at the wicket when Maxwell walked out.

Glenn Maxwell and Faf du Plessis added 127 in just 11.1 overs • Associated Press

Maxwell, du Plessis put on a show

If it was the last pair, they were not going to hold back. Maxwell square-drove the first ball he faced for four, and repeated the same shot for the same result in the same over. Du Plessis got stuck into Sandeep Sharma, hitting two sixes and a four in the fourth over. Maxwell kept manipulating the field, and lofted R Ashwin for a six to make it 62 for 2 at the end of the powerplay.

Unlike the typical RCB innings, there was no slowdown immediately after the powerplay. Maxwell reverse-swept Yuzvendra Chahal in his first over for a six, and two overs later he and du Plessis took 16 off a Jason Holder over.

Royal Challengers Bangalore fined for slow over rate

Royal Challengers Bangalore have been fined after they maintained a slow over rate in the game against Rajasthan Royals. As it was the team's second offence of the season, Virat Kohli, the stand-in captain for the match, has been fined Rs 24 lakh while all other members of the playing XI, including the Impact Substitute, have been fined either Rs 6 lakh or 25% of their match fee, depending on whichever is lesser. The team also had to face the on-field penalty and could field only four fielders outside the 30-yard circle in the 20th over

While du Plessis kept going down the ground, Maxwell mixed both straight hits and innovative ones behind square.

The collapse

Neither of the batters looked like getting out even when going at such high strike-rate, and eventually it had to be a run-out to send du Plessis back. A slight slowdown ensued, and Maxwell found backward point with a reverse-sweep to the last ball of R Ashwin's quota.

With both danger men gone, Royals snuck back into the match. The wily Chahal bowled the 17th and the 19th overs for just 11 runs and the wicket of Mahipal Lomror. Suddenly the pitch began to look like aiding slower balls again, and RCB huffed and puffed to 189.

Jaiswal, Padikkal fuel the chase

After an incutter from Mohammed Siraj bowled Jos Buttler for his second duck this IPL, Padikkal and Jaiswal set the chase up beautifully. Like Chahal and Shivam Dube before him, Jaiswal, too, made a big contribution against the team that had released him, RCB. Padikkal

and Jaiswal managed to hit at least one boundary an over from overs 2 through 10. It left Royals needing 98 off the last 10. In the over after that, Padikkal brought up his fifty.

Harshal Patel took the key wicket of Sanju Samson•BCCI

The Hasaranga-Willey slowdown

If it was the death overs during which the RCB slide began, Wanindu Hasaranga and David Willey started it around the 11th over for Royals. Hasaranga conceded just five in the 11th. Three more deliveries went without a boundary in the 12th, and Padikkal became the first one to hole out, off Willey.

Sanju Samson was watchful against Hasaranga, who enjoys a great match-up against him, in the 13th. Jaiswal, who tends to struggle once the field spreads, holed out off Harshal in the 14th having scored seven off the last 10 balls he faced.

The endgame

The equation was still within touch especially with Samson and Shimron Hetmyer still there. Samson managed to get the better of Hasaranga in the 15th but just like Maxwell's dismissal earlier in the day, a well-timed late cut found short third in the 16th.

Royals needed 65 off 28 then, which is not unheard of, but Hetmyer got stuck, failing to connect cleanly with even a single shot. Mohammed Siraj later said the ball was reversing in the end, which might explain Hetmyer failing to hit even one of the nine balls he faced cleanly.

It was Dhruv Jorel who kept RR alive with 34 off 16, but he didn't assume the leadership role in the partnership with Ashwin. Off the last ball of the 19th over, he took a suicidal second, which handed the strike over to Ashwin for the last over.

Ashwin got lucky with two boundaries in the last over, but with 10 required off the last three, he too holed out to a slower ball. RR still didn't send out Holder, who has faced only two balls in this IPL, and there was too much left for debutant Abdul Basith to do.

Match 33

Chennai Super Kings 235 for 4 (Rahane 71, Conway 56, Dube 50, Khejroliya 2-44)
beat Kolkata Knight Riders 186 for 8 (Roy 61, Rinku 53, Theekshana 2-32, Deshpande 2-44)
by 49 runs

For a while, the IPL record for most sixes in an innings (21), which was coincidentally set on this day in 2013, was in danger of being toppled. Chennai Super Kings fell just three short of that mark, but muscled a record first-innings score at Eden Gardens courtesy swashbuckling knocks from Ajinkya Rahane, Shivam Dube and Devon Conway.

Kolkata Knight Riders lost two wickets inside the first three overs and merely played catch up for much of their chase. They eventually stumbled to their fourth successive loss. This

meant MS Dhoni's men are now top of the leaderboard with five wins in seven matches, two clear of a logjam that has five teams on eight points apiece.

CSK set the pace

Leading the six-hitting spree was Rahane, who smashed five of them in a 29-ball 71 to take Super Kings through the gears in the middle order, along with Dube.

The raw numbers from their partnership read like this: 85 runs, 32 balls, four fours, eight sixes. This came on the back of another stellar knock from Conway, who hit a fourth straight half-century to set the innings up with Ruturaj Gaikwad.

Their 73-run opening stand in just 7.3 overs was another fine exhibition of timing, power, wrist work and plenty of muscle. KKR's bowlers went with length into the pitch up front when they discovered there wasn't much swing, but it backfired as Conway was superb at picking lengths and hitting them square on both sides.

Suyash's strike offset by sustained aggression

All the elements that make for compelling viewing when a legspinner is on were at play in Suyash Sharma's first over - drift from wide of the crease, flight, rip and turn to beat the inside edge. Gaikwad was stunned. But the relief was quickly offset with Conway skipping down to launch Sunil Narine for a massive six down the ground.

The 100 was up in the 11th over and CSK seemed bullish. Conway eventually perished when he couldn't quite get the elevation off Varun Chakravarthy, but Dube got into the act with two massive hits in the same over. The first of those was a 100-metre hit to deep midwicket when Varun attempted a carrom ball into the pitch. Then, when Varun went full, he was tonked down the ground, over the sight screen.

Ajinkya Rahane and Shivam Dube put on 85 from just 32 balls•BCCI

Rahane takes the attack to Umesh

In the very next over, the 14th, Rahane made it three sixes in a row for CSK when he played a stunning pick-up shot, using Umesh Yadav's pace and letting his wrists take over. It was instinct-driven batting out of the top drawer, free of any shackles that might have been holding him back in previous seasons. He seemed to feed off this role clarity. He was an anchor no more; he was instead unlocking his destroyer avatar.

The over would fetch another six that would be hoisted over fine leg and one of the most gorgeous extra cover drives you could see - feet to the pitch, leaning into the stroke and lacing the ball through the off side.

That was the start of a fascinating passage as Rahane and Dube - another batter who seems empowered to play the game he has long threatened to - had fun and made the bowling

attack look pedestrian. Rahane got to his fifty off 24 balls, Dube off 20. The last five overs went for 75 as KKR went into the break a deflated lot.

KKR stumble early

Narine saw his off stump cartwheel in the first over of the chase and N Jagadeesan was out to Ravindra Jadeja's athleticism in the second. Venkatesh Iyer and Nitish Rana then swung hard and connected from time to time, before Moeen Ali and Jadeja struck in consecutive overs. Venkatesh was out lbw sweeping a full ball, Rana dragging a slog sweep to Gaikwad at deep midwicket.

Roy's blitzkrieg

Jason Roy came in at this point, and hardly took time to settle in, going 6, 6, 6 off his second, third and fourth balls - all off Moeen. The first two were powerful slogs to the leg side, and when Moeen fired one full in trying to correct his line, he was reverse-swept behind point. Roy was in the mood to mow the ball down and connected more often than he missed to race away to a 19-ball half-century. By then the equation had touched 109 off 36.

Sri Lankan flavour to finish

Roy continued to hit out. After taking Maheesh Theekshana for two fours to begin the 15th though, he was out off the third ball to a full delivery that dipped and slid underneath his powerful swing. Even after all that magic, KKR's win percentage was less than 1%.

Two overs later, when Theekshana's Sri Lanka team-mate Matheeshan Pathirana sent back Andre Russell, you got the sense that it was game over. And so it was, despite everything Rinku Singh did at the other end to make a half-century of his own.

Match 34

Delhi Capitals 144 for 9 (Pandey 34, Axar 34, Washington 3-28, Bhuvneshwar 2-11) beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 137 for 6 (Agarwal 49, Klaasen 31, Axar 2-21, Nortje 2-33) by seven runs

For a large part of the contest, Sunrisers Hyderabad seemed to have a hold on Delhi Capitals. Like when Washington Sundar picked up three wickets in an over. When Bhuvneshwar Kumar gave away almost nothing in his four overs. When Mayank Agarwal laid a solid platform for Sunrisers' chase of 145.

It came down to Sunrisers needing 13 off the last over, with Washington and Marco Jansen in the middle. But Mukesh Kumar exuded calmness as he nailed his yorkers and gave away only five runs, sealing a seven-run win for Capitals. It was the lowest total the Delhi franchise had successfully defended in the IPL.

Warner fined for maintaining slow over-rate

Delhi Capitals captain David Warner was fined after his team maintained a slow over-rate during their match against Sunrisers Hyderabad. As it was his team's first offence of the season under the IPL's Code of Conduct relating to minimum over-rate offences, Warner was fined INR 12 lakh.

Capitals' spinners Kuldeep Yadav and Axar Patel had combined figures of 8-0-43-3 to stifle Sunrisers in the chase. It was Capitals' second successive win, but despite that they stayed at the bottom of the standings, thanks to their net run rate of -0.961.

Washington, Klaasen take Sunrisers close

Capitals' spinners had done well to leave Sunrisers needing 51 off the last four overs. But Heinrich Klaasen displayed his power-hitting skills, taking on fellow South African Anrich Nortje. From being on 9 from 8 at the start of the 17th over, Klaasen raced to 31 off 18, launching Nortje for a six over deep midwicket and then hitting two fours off Mukesh in the 18th over. At the other end, Washington first ramped Nortje through deep third before playing a tumbling scoop off Mukesh. He then heaved Nortje through deep midwicket to get the equation down to 13 off 6. But Washington couldn't get the big hits away in the final over.

Sunrisers get stuck

After changing their opening combination once again, Sunrisers got off to a sedate start. Harry Brook struggled to get the measure of the surface and fell for seven off 14 balls trying to scoop Nortje. Agarwal started more positively, but Sunrisers managed only 36 for 1 in the powerplay.

Rahul Tripathi, brought in as the Impact Player for T Natarajan, tried everything he could - dashing down the track, getting inside the line to play the scoop, using the depth of the crease - but he couldn't put the ball away either. Agarwal, meanwhile, found the occasional boundary but the runs came at a premium. Their 38-run stand for the second wicket ended when Agarwal looked to hit out off Axar, against whom he doesn't have a favourable match-up. Off the 54 balls Agarwal has faced from Axar in the IPL, he has managed to score only 43. On Monday, he fell for 49 off 39 balls and that opened the floodgates. Tripathi was caught behind off Ishant Sharma in the next over, Kuldeep deceived Abhishek Sharma in the following over before Axar had Aiden Markram chopping on in the 15th over.

In the middle overs (7-16) Sunrisers could muster only 58 and lost four wickets. In the corresponding phase, Capitals had managed 64 for 3.

Washington's triple-strike

In 13.4 overs in IPL 2023 before Monday, Washington had gone wicketless. His first over against Sunrisers went for 13 with David Warner hitting a four and a six. Washington then stepped up in his next over, the eighth of the innings, putting the skids on Capitals.

Warner went for a slog-sweep and only found deep midwicket. A ball later, Washington had Sarfaraz Khan top-edging a sweep to deep backward square leg. And then, off the fifth ball of the over, Aman Khan fell top-edging an attempted slog across the line to covers. From 57 for 2, Capitals had slid to 62 for 5 in eight overs.

Capitals' batting wobbly again

Having benched Shaw, Phil Salt opened for Capitals but nibbled at an outswinging length ball from Bhuvneshwar on his first ball, the third of the match, to be caught behind for a blob. Warner hit his first six of the season but was not fluent. Sarfaraz Khan had one lofted extra cover drive for six to write home about. But barring Mitchell Marsh, Manish Pandey and Axar, Capitals' batting left a lot to be desired again.

Marsh got going with four fours off Jansen's first over. He first flicked a length ball over midwicket before tickling one down to fine leg. Jansen went wide and was duly thrashed through cover-point before being caressed through extra covers. But Natarajan managed to see the back of Marsh in the final over of the powerplay, getting one to swing into him off a length. It struck Marsh on the back pad and the umpire ruled the lbw appeal in the batter's favour but Sunrisers got their man via the DRS.

With Pandey and Axar joining hands in the eighth over, Capitals were in danger of falling way short on a surface that had enough in it for the spinners. But the duo added 69 together off 59 balls to give them a semblance of platform for the final flourish. Both scored 34 apiece with Pandey taking 27 balls and Axar taking 34 for his.

But Bhuvneshwar cleaned up Axar with a seaming ball that dipped on the batter to bowl him. Pandey was run-out in the following over as Sunrisers slid into the driver's seat. Capitals lost four wickets in the last 19 balls to finish at 144 for 9, a total that didn't seem enough at the halfway stage. But their bowlers ensured it was.

Match 35

Gujarat Titans 207 for 6 (Gill 56, Miller 46, Manohar 42, Chawla 2-34) beat Mumbai Indians 152 for 9 (Wadhera 40, Green 33, Noor 3-37, Rashid 2-27) by 55 runs

Batting fireworks from Gujarat Titans in the death overs and five wickets shared by Afghan spinners Rashid Khan and Noor Ahmad gave the hosts their second win in a row as they steamrolled Mumbai Indians for their second straight loss on a hot and humid evening in Ahmedabad. After defending the big score of 207 for 6 comfortably, Titans jumped to second place with 10 points, the same as table-toppers Chennai Super Kings.

Mumbai's death bowling came in the spotlight again with Jofra Archer sitting out with an illness, Arjun Tendulkar not bowling in that phase, and their quicks leaking 70 runs in the last four overs, after conceding 65 in the same phase against Punjab Kings in their last game.

After Shubman Gill's fifty and a boundary-laden partnership of 71 off just 35 balls between Abhinav Manohar and David Miller for the fifth wicket, Mumbai's batting firepower

fizzled against Afghanistan's spin duo as only one of their top six crossed 25 and they fell short by 55 runs after being reduced to 59 for 5 in the 11th over.

Gill lays the platform

Tendulkar kept it tight with his inswing early on that had Wriddhiman Saha caught down leg and along with Jason Behrendorff, he kept Titans to 33 for 1 after five overs. Gill then started his onslaught by milking Cameron Green for 17 in the last over of the powerplay, with a powerful pull, a scythe through off and a stunning lofted straight drive for six to power the run rate past eight.

Mumbai brought on Piyush Chawla immediately and Hardik Pandya holed out to long-off immediately for 13. But that didn't deter Gill's tempo. He drilled Chawla through the covers for four and smashed Kumar Kartikeya to the leg side next over to reach a 30-ball fifty and lead Titans to 84 for 2 at the halfway mark.

David Miller was in a marauding mood at the death•BCCI

The take off from Manohar and Miller (and Tewatia)

Gill and Vijay Shankar holed out to long-on against the spinners in successive overs, and at 103 for 4 after 13 overs, the innings could have tilted either ways.

Manohar bravely took on a miserly Chawla and tilted the pendulum in Titans' favour in such a way that Mumbai never recovered. With the field spread out, Chawla started the 15th over with two full deliveries and Manohar blasted both to the cover boundary. On the fifth ball, Manohar charged down and smoked a straight six which made it a 17-run over, the same runs Chawla had conceded in his first three.

There was no stopping Manohar and Miller after that. The duo hammered three batches of back-to-back sixes in the last three overs - with the help of Rahul Tewatia - and gave Mumbai's bowling lots to think about before their next game. Manohar used his brute force to slam Green for the first of those batches in the 18th over, Miller did it with his golf swings to end Meredith's last over, which also saw Manohar hole out to long-off for 42 off 21.

Tewatia swept his first ball for six before slamming two more off Behrendorff's slower ones in the last over on the leg side to finish on 20 off 5, and Miller's dismissal for 46 off 22 on the penultimate ball was hardly a consolation for Mumbai because by then Titans had crossed 200.

Shami's masterclass

The WTC final is still month and a half away, but Mohammed Shami was so accurate with his pace and swing early on that Mumbai and India captain Rohit Sharma might have something to smile about. Maybe not. Shami fired in one quick delivery after another outside Ishan Kishan's off stump and made him look like a deer caught in the headlights, which meant Mumbai never took off in the chase. Kishan poked, jabbed and prodded at

many such Shami deliveries to score eight off his 13 balls and crawled to 10 off 17 at the end of the powerplay.

From the other end, Hardik fired in deliveries around 140-145kmh with outswing and took Rohit's return catch off a leading edge for just 2, before also beating Green's swings many a times in the powerplay that saw Mumbai struggling on 29 for 1.

Nehal Wadhera impressed with his hard-hitting late in the order•AFP/Getty Images

The Rashid and Noor strangle

Titans unleashed the Afghan spinners together after the powerplay and Rashid struck immediately. He first had Kishan caught off a heave on the leg side to end a painful stay of 13 off 21, and three balls later trapped the Impact Player Tilak Varma for 2 with the help of a review. Green had by now collected two sixes and slammed a third off Noor in the ninth over even though the asking rate crossed 14.

Noor then landed a double blow himself by rattling Green's stumps in the 11th over and also had the big-hitting Tim David caught off a full toss for a two-ball duck. At 59 for 5 after 11, Mumbai hardly any chance of bouncing back.

Apart from a cameo from Suryakumar Yadav, Mumbai will be thrilled about unearthing another young batter, the 22-year-old Nehal Wadhera from Punjab. Wadhera manipulated the field to find gaps, hit big sixes down the ground and on the leg side, and impressed with his temperament under pressure even if the chase was virtually over when he batted. He and Suryakumar took down Noor for 15 runs in the 13th over and Wadhera finished with 40 off 21 studded with three sixes and as many fours even as Mumbai stumbled in another big chase.

Match 36

Kolkata Knight Riders 200 for 5 (Roy 56, Rana 48) beat Royal Challengers Bangalore 179 for 8 (Kohli 54, Varun 3-27) by 21 runs

It took Kolkata Knight Riders eight games to finally produce a cohesive team performance. They excelled with bat and ball, and were the better team in the field too, as they achieved only their third win of the season. It was the perfect way for them to start the second half of the league stage, beating Royal Challengers Bangalore for the second time in the season.

KKR's win was set up by their new opener Jason Roy, who laid the base for their total of 200 by smacking 56 off 29 balls. Nitish Rana pumped 48 off 21 to keep the momentum going through the middle overs, and Rinku Singh (18 off 10) and David Wiese (12 off 3) put on the finishing touches.

RCB's chase, though, was on while Virat Kohli was out there. He scored 54 off 37 to keep them on course. However, regular wickets from Suyash Sharma, Varun Chakravarthy and Andre Russell kept pegging them back, and RCB eventually ran out of gas and fell 21 short.

Suyash, Varun pull it back for KKR

Kohli and Faf du Plessis hammered 30 runs in two overs from Vaibhav Arora and Umesh Yadav to start the chase, forcing Rana to bring on spin in the third over. He chose to go to his least experienced spinner - Suyash Sharma - ahead of Sunil Narine and Varun, and was rewarded with du Plessis holing out to long on second ball.

While Kohli kept finding the boundary, he failed to find support in the powerplay with Shahbaz Ahmed falling lbw to Suyash, while Glenn Maxwell holed out off Varun. With RCB three down in the powerplay, Kohli and Mahipal Lomror stabilised the chase by running hard and taking on Sunil Narine.

Jason Roy gave KKR a fabulous start • Associated Press

Rana then went back to Varun, who had Lomror caught in the deep, and when Kohli was superbly caught on 54 by Venkatesh Iyer, diving to his left at deep midwicket in the 13th over, KKR were decidedly ahead in the contest. The dismissals of Wanindu Hasaranga and Dinesh Karthik in the space of four balls ensured RCB had no way back and Kohli, who was standing in as captain for du Plessis once again, said they had "gifted" the victory to KKR.

Rana makes RCB pay

Kohli's scathing post-game comments were largely because of RCB's fielding. They put down a tough caught-and-bowled chance off Roy, but it was the two reprieves that Rana received that really cost RCB. According to ESPNcricinfo's Luck Index the two drops, by Mohammed Siraj in the 13th over and Harshal Patel in the 15th, cost RCB a total of 29 runs.

Roy fined for breaching Code of Conduct

KKR opening batter Jason Roy has been fined 10 percent of his match fees for breaching the IPL Code of Conduct. It appeared that he hit the bails with his bat after he was dismissed by Vijaykumar Vyshak. He admitted to the Level 1 offence, where the Match Referee's decision is final.

The first chance came when Rana was on 5 off 5 deliveries and then second when he was on 19 off 12. He ended up scoring 48 off 21 balls. Rana's innings included three fours and four sixes and it allowed KKR to wrest the momentum after sluggish innings from N Jagadeesan and Venkatesh.

Roy sets Knight Riders up

It was Roy's innings, however, that set the tone for KKR's night. After struggling for runs from their opening partnership all season, KKR finally had a strong start and it was all Roy. He smashed four sixes in the fifth over from left-arm spinner Shahbaz Ahmed to power them to 66 for 0 in the powerplay.

So even though Vijaykumar Vyshak dismissed N Jagadeesan and Roy in the same over, KKR had a platform to build on, and this time Rana and the rest ensured that it was not wasted.

Match 37

Rajasthan Royals 202 for 5 (Jaiswal 77, Jurel 34, Deshpande 2-42) beat Chennai Super Kings 170 for 6 (Dube 52, Gaikwad 47, Zampa 3-22, Ashwin 2-35) by 32 runs

After losing their previous two games, Rajasthan Royals not only returned to winning ways but also the top of the IPL points table with a thumping 32-run win over Chennai Super Kings.

After Royals opted to bat, Yashasvi Jaiswal attacked his way to 77 off 43 balls. Super Kings did stage a brief comeback in the middle overs but late hitting from Dhruv Jurel (34 off 15) and Devdutt Padikkal (27* off 13) lifted Royals to 202 for 5, the first 200-plus total by an IPL team in Jaipur.

Matheesha Pathirana, despite nailing his yorkers at express pace, was unlucky to concede 48 in his four overs, as 28 of those runs came when batters were not in control of their shots.

Super Kings didn't get the start they were after. Adam Zampa and R Ashwin further stifled them while sharing five wickets. Shivam Dube was the only one to offer resistance but it was too little, too late.

Jaiswal leads the way for Royals

Even if it was an away game for Super Kings, they seemed to have more supporters in the stands than Royals had. It didn't have any effect on Jaiswal and Jos Buttler, though, as they gave Royals yet another flying start. Jaiswal kicked things off by hitting Akash Singh for two fours off the first two balls of the match, followed by one more in the over. He was even more severe in the seamer's next over, picking up three fours and a six. In between, Buttler hit Tushar Deshpande for two fours.

With seamers going for plenty, MS Dhoni turned to spin, and Maheesh Theekshana bowled a three-run over. Buttler, though, took the spinner for two fours - both times hitting length balls off the back foot over his head - in the sixth over to take Royals to 64 for no loss.

Ravindra Jadeja broke the opening stand with Buttler's wicket but Jaiswal kept marching on. Coming into this game, Jaiswal had scored 81 off 70 in the middle overs. Tonight, there was no slowdown; he smashed 37 off 22 after the field restrictions were lifted.

Yashasvi Jaiswal once again took a liking to the Chennai Super Kings bowling•Getty Images

Jurel and Padikkal pick up after a brief lull

Deshpande removed Sanju Samson and Jaiswal in the 14th over to briefly put the brakes on the scoring rate. From overs 14 to 17, Royals managed only 28 runs and lost three wickets along the way. It was starting to look like Super Kings might restrict them under 200 but

Jurel and Padikkal, who came in at No. 6, threw their bat around. They didn't always find the middle but the runs came thick and fast. Super Kings' sloppy fielding also helped Royals, and left Dhoni visibly angry on more than one occasion, as they ransacked 56 in the last four overs.

Zampa, Ashwin keep Super Kings on back foot

With Trent Boult picking up a niggler, Zampa got an opportunity. And the legspinner made an impact in his very first over. Bowling the last over of the powerplay, he had Devon Conway hitting one to mid-off.

Ruturaj Gaikwad was trying to make up for Super Kings' slow start. He had moved to 47 off 28 balls when he tried to attack Zampa only to be caught at long-on. R Ashwin dragged Super Kings further back in the next over, the 11th of the innings, by dismissing Ajinkya Rahane and Ambati Rayudu.

Dube, Moeen fight back

With 130 needed from nine overs, Dube and Moeen threatened a fightback. The pair hit four sixes and a four in the next three overs, reducing the equation to 90 needed from the last five. Samson once again turned to Zampa, and he didn't disappoint his captain. Dube launched him into the stands, and Moeen too picked up a boundary, but with his fifth ball of the over, Zampa had Moeen under-edging one to Samson.

Dube, however, kept the fight on. He hit Jason Holder for a six and two fours in the 17th over. In the next, Jadeja took Sandeep Sharma for two fours but scoring 46 in the last two overs was too much of an uphill task.

Match 38

Lucknow Super Giants 257 for 5 (Stoinis 72, Mayers 54, Pooran 45, Badoni 43, Rabada 2-52) beat Punjab Kings 201 (Taide 66, Thakur 4-37, Naveen 3-30, Bishnoi 2-41) by 56 runs

Marcus Stoinis: 72 off 40 balls. Kyle Mayers: 54 from 24. Nicholas Pooran: 45 off 19. Ayush Badoni: 43 from 24. Their contributions led Lucknow Super Giants to 257 for 5, the highest total this IPL season, and the second highest in the tournament's history.

Punjab Kings fought hard to get past 200 themselves, with Atharva Taide slamming a 36-ball 66, but they were never really in contention to reach an improbable target. Super Giants won by 56 runs in the end, and their net-run-rate boost lifted them from fourth to second on the points table.

LSG's hitting was awe-inspiring: their batters combined to hit 27 fours and 14 sixes, ensuring the statisticians had a busy night.

Marcus Stoinis goes one-handed • Associated Press

Mayers gets the party started

The entertainment began when Mayers clubbed Arshdeep Singh for four fours in the second over. Next over, he deposited a free hit from debutant Gurnoor Brar for six over midwicket. When PBKS introduced spin, Mayers went 6, 4, 6 off Sikandar Raza in the fifth over. He was dismissed with one ball left in the powerplay, but by then he'd already scored 54 - the most by a batter in the first six overs this season. LSG ended that phase at 72 for 2.

Unstoppable Stoinis

In seven previous innings this season, Stoinis had been dismissed for 21 or less five times, including a duck in his last game against Chennai Super Kings. But when he's got into his groove, LSG have prospered. He'd slammed 65 off 30 in a successful chase of 213 against Royal Challengers Bangalore, and here in Mohali Stoinis was similarly brutal.

It began with a free-hit off the second legal ball of the eighth over, which Stoinis flicked for six off Gurnoor. The next ball was driven for four, and Stoinis was away. In the tenth over, he guided Sam Curran for four behind point; and when the bowler tried a slower delivery, he put him away with a short-arm pull.

There was a life in the 13th over when Liam Livingstone's left foot tickled the rope while he caught Stoinis on the long-off boundary, off Rahul Chahar. Stoinis soon reached fifty from 31 balls, his innings of 72 eventually featuring five sixes.

Badoni and Pooran keep the fireworks going

The bowlers had no respite when Stoinis was off strike. Badoni put on 89 for the third wicket with Stoinis and struck three fours and three sixes while rushing along at a strike rate close to 180. His dismissal in the 14th over brought Pooran to the crease, and he immediately hit Liam Livingstone for three successive fours.

Pooran's 45 off 19 featured just a solitary six, a swivel-pull that sailed high over fine leg, but there were seven fours, most of them timed beautifully through gaps in the outfield, with a late squeeze behind point of Arshdeep standing out.

Atharva Taide attempts to ramp the ball • Associated Press

Taide fights, but PBKS fall well short

Sent in at No. 3 after Shikhar Dhawan departed in the first over, Taide kept ticking along as his partners came and went. Taide made 31 of the 47 runs PBKS scored in the first five overs, including five boundaries, including a leg-side hoick, a drive past mid-off, and a slap through point off one Avesh Khan over, and he followed up with a big six off Amit Mishra soon after the powerplay.

Taide got to his half-century from 26 deliveries to start the tenth over, but by then PBKS' required rate was already threatening to touch 16 an over. And when Taide departed after miscuing a slog-sweep off Ravi Bishnoi, PBKS needed a near-impossible 131 from seven overs, with six wickets in hand.

Livingstone, Curran and Jitesh Sharma kept the boundary count rising - there were 67 in all, eventually, the joint second-most in an IPL game - but the contest was done and dusted by then.

Match 39

Gujarat Titans 180 for 3 (Vijay 51*, Gill 49, Miller 32*) beat Kolkata Knight Riders 179 for 7 (Gurbaz 81, Russell 34, Shami 3-33, Noor 2-21, Little 2-25) by seven wickets

Rahmanullah Gurbaz, filling in for the injured Jason Roy, scored 81 off 39 against his former franchise Gujarat Titans, but Kolkata Knight Riders managed to score just 179, which Titans overhauled with 13 balls to spare despite a scare in the middle overs.

Gurbaz was sensational especially in his takedown of Rashid Khan, who went for 50 or more for only the second time in the IPL, but the only support he received was from Andre Russell, who scored 34 off 19 at the death. Josh Little tied them down in the middle overs, resulting in wickets, and Noor Ahmad registered the Afghan presence with 4-0-21-2, including the wicket of Gurbaz.

Shubman Gill, a former Knight Rider, set up the chase, and Vijay Shankar and David Miller finished it off in style after two quick wickets in the middle overs threatened to turn this into a thriller.

Shami with early strikes

The match started 45 minutes late because of a brief shower. That rumble of a thunderstorm at the time of the toss made Titans change their mind and chose to bowl. The pitch was spiced up, and Mohammed Shami found seam movement. He bowled through the powerplay to get the wickets of N Jagadeesan and the promoted and returning Shardul Thakur.

Gurbaz plays a different game

Even as the others struggled to hit boundaries, Gurbaz middled almost everything and kept hitting to where the fielders weren't. He began with a pick-up pull off Hardik Pandya, and followed it up with a wristy pick-up six.

The most awesome perhaps was the attack on compatriot Rashid, making room, picking his variations, and hitting him down the ground, for 30 off 11. The middle overs were unable to slow him down.

2:33

Moody: Little is getting better and better with experience

Little slows KKR down

With Rashid taken for plenty, it was Josh Little who pulled things back for Titans. He just extracted extra bounce from hard lengths to frustrate the batters. His first two overs - seventh and ninth - went for just 10. At the start of his third, Venkatesh Iyer felt obliged to play a low-percentage shot, and was out lbw. In the same over, Nitish Rana found backward point with a cut.

This is when the arrival of Rinku Singh, hero of the last match against Titans but under a run a ball against spin in the IPL, slowed Knight Riders further down. Eventually, Gurbaz fell to a Noor Ahmad full toss having got only 54 off 53 from the other end, including extras.

Only a late burst from Russell kept Knight Riders in the game, but he himself admitted in a sidelines interview that they were 20 short.

Gill launches the chase

The way the ball sounded like gun shots off Gill's bat, it looked like Knight Riders were way more than 20 short. He raced away to 35 off 20 in the powerplay without even trying to hit a six. Like Gurbaz, he dominated by scoring 44 of the first 70 runs.

KKR spinners refuse to go down

Not for the first time, the Knight Riders spinners dragged them back into the contest with some tight overs. Just as Hardik began to open up, he got a peach from Harshit Rana, filling in for the injured Umesh Yadav. Having taken 10 balls to go from 40 to 49, Gill tried to hit Sunil Narine for a six, but ended up giving him his first wicket in six matches.

A grandstand finish looked likely as Vijay and Miller absorbed some dots to make it 69 required off the last six.

Don't take it deep

The virtues of taking chases deep get spoken about often because the ones finished early don't have the drama attached. Miller and Vijay could have absorbed three more overs of spin and waited for some pace in the end, but they decided otherwise. Miller first took on Suyash Sharma and hit two sixes, which hurried the return of pace. Now Vijay got into the act, hitting a six off Russell before dismantling his Tamil Nadu team-mate Varun Chakravarthy with three sixes in the 17th over. Before you realised, he was bringing up his fifty in just 24 balls, and Titans were back on top of the table with six wins out of eight.

Match 40

Sunrisers Hyderabad 197 for 6 (Abhishek 67, Klaasen 53*, Marsh 4-27) beat Delhi Capitals 188 for 6 (Marsh 63, Salt 59, Markande 2-20) by 9 runs

In a game of high drama where both sides kept landing punches at each other with neither backing off, Sunrisers Hyderabad pipped Delhi Capitals to arrest a three-match losing streak on a low, slow pitch at the Arun Jaitley Stadium.

At one stage, Capitals were on track to gun down a 198-run target when Mitchell Marsh and Phil Salt put together 112 in just 11 overs after David Warner fell for a second-ball duck.

Then one wicket led to another, and before Delhi could realise, Sunrisers had clawed back courtesy the guile of Mayank Markande, who picked up 2 for 20. Sunrisers now have three wins in eight games to Capitals' two in eight, which keeps them rooted to the bottom of the points table.

Abhishek's powerplay salvo

Back to open the innings after a game in the middle order, Abhishek Sharma began positively, lofting Ishant Sharma for two successive boundaries in the opening over. Mayank Agarwal's dismissal to a short ball gave Ishant some joy in his second over, but Abhishek wasn't in a mood to slow down. He took Ishant for four boundaries in the seamer's third over, hitting 43 in Sunrisers' 62 for 2 after the first six.

The reverse scoop, Heinrich Klaasen way•BCCI

Capitals' comeback

The next four overs belonged to Capitals as they conceded just 21. Marsh left his mark on the game during this phase by taking pace off, the short boundaries notwithstanding, and allowing batters to force the pace on a surface where the ball was holding up. Two balls after he had Aiden Markram picking out deep midwicket, Harry Brook toe-ended a pull to the edge of the ring, Axar Patel the catcher on both occasions.

The Klaasen kick

After Abhishek raced to a 25-ball half-century, Heinrich Klaasen got into the game by taking apart Mukesh Kumar as the 11th over went for 24. Abhishek began it with two back-to-back fours and Klaasen finished it with a monstrous six down the ground off a legcutter. Axar, though, proved difficult to get away as he varied his pace and angles to finish with 1 for 29 from his four overs, the reward being the big wicket of Abhishek for a 36-ball 67. It could've been far more impressive if Klaasen hadn't belted him for two sixes to end his spell. A 53-run stand between Klaasen and Abdul Samad off 33 balls and some late runs from Akeal Hosein helped Sunrisers muscle 62 off the last five overs.

Mitchell Marsh and Phil Salt's 112-run stand had kept Capitals in the contest•BCCI

Warner falls but Marsh fires

Sunrisers couldn't have asked for a better start; Bhuvneshwar Kumar got Warner to chop on second ball of the chase. But Marsh and Salt raised the half-century of their partnership in just 29 balls by going after Hosein's left-arm darts. Sunrisers tried to get overs out of spin seemingly in a bid to negate dew, but Hosein was far too short and the batters helped themselves to a nice spread against the short square boundaries.

After five overs, ESPNcricinfo's forecaster pegged Capitals' chances of victory at 19.43%, but after seven, this figure had jumped to 45.68%. The reason for that partly was Marsh's take-off against Umran Malik. Malik kept bowling short and into the body for Marsh to get inside the line and simply help it to beat long leg twice for sixes in a 22-run over. Salt opened and closed that over with two bludgeoning fours of his own against the short ball. That put Sunrisers under the pump.

Markande leads spinners into it

Markande used the slowness of the pitch to string together dots before dismissing Salt with a return catch that he just managed to hold on to. It was a big wicket considering Salt's maiden half-century had set the tone for the chase. Then seven balls later, Manish Pandey ran down the track only for Abhishek to shorten his length and beat him in the air and off the pitch.

It was now all on Marsh to see Capitals home, but that wasn't to be as Hosein hit back superbly after the early onslaught by dismissing him. After being walloped out of the ground on the previous delivery, he bravely tossed it up for Marsh to go again, except this one gripped and turned and Marsh sliced it to Markram. That, right there, was the game for Sunrisers. Axar muscled a few towards the end, but the middle-order slowdown after the Salt-Marsh stand proved to be the difference.

Match 41

Punjab Kings 201 for 6 (Prabhsimran 42, Livingstone 40, Deshpande 3-49, Jadeja 2-32) beat Chennai Super Kings 200 for 4 (Conway 92*, Gaikwad 37) by four wickets

A last-ball thriller that ended with Sikandar Raza pulling Matheesha Pathirana for three quick runs stunned a Chepauk crowd that may have expected their team to return home with a win and get closer to the top of the table. Chennai Super Kings had almost everything going for them; Devon Conway walloped an unbeaten 92, MS Dhoni stretched their total to 200 with two sixes to end the innings, and they strangled Kings' chase through the middle overs, but lost despite largely being ahead through the final over thanks to Pathirana's accuracy.

With nine to win off the last over, Raza and Shahrukh Khan couldn't hit a single boundary against Pathirana's dipping deliveries. After a single, a leg bye, a dot ball and two twos off Pathirana's yorkers and slower balls, Kings needed three off the last ball. Raza shuffled across and pulled a short-of-length slower ball over square leg, landing it right in between deep fine leg and deep midwicket to secure three and seal victory with his arms aloft.

The two points took Kings to 10 points alongside three other teams, and to fifth place on the table, just behind Super Kings on net run rate.

Sikandar Raza celebrates after taking Kings to a tense win • BCCI

Livingstone turns tables at the right time

Super Kings were favourites when Liam Livingstone and Sam Curran struggled to score freely off Pathirana and Maheesh Theekshana. With 72 to win off 30, Livingstone got to face Tushar Deshpande and belted three sixes in four balls with four leg byes in between. Even though he fell off the fifth ball of the over, Kings still had Jitesh Sharma and Shahrukh to come, and the 24-run over brought their equation down to 48 off 24.

Curran and Jitesh slammed straight sixes off Ravindra Jadeja in the 17th, but Pathirana was going to bowl two of the last three overs. He removed Curran's off stump with a stunning, full delivery that swerved past his outside edge, and with 22 needed off 12, Kings went after Deshpande in the 19th to try and ensure they didn't leave too much for the last over. Jitesh lofted the first ball over cover for four and got out to a contentious decision two balls later when substitute fielder Shaik Rasheed caught him at the wide long-on boundary while almost touching the boundary cushions with his foot. With 15 required off eight, Raza edged his first ball for four to make it a 13-run over.

Even though Pathirana sent down an excellent last over, Raza manipulated the field perfectly to pick ones and twos and sealed the match with a hard-run three.

Boundaries rain in Kings' powerplay, but not beyond

Kings came out all guns blazing in a steep chase. Shikhar Dhawan danced down off the second ball and went on to smash 21 off nine balls in Akash Singh's first two overs. Prabhsimran Singh took on Theekshana's carrom ball at the other end in a 12-run fourth over, and Kings raced to 46 for no loss in four overs.

Dhawan sliced Deshpande to short third in the fifth over to fall for 28, but Prabhsimran kept his foot on the pedal with at least one boundary an over before being stumped off a 100kph Jadeja delivery in the ninth. It was then that Kings went through a slowdown, with Atharva Taide managing just 13 off 16 before falling to Jadeja in a three-run 11th over. Livingstone and Curran struggled to score freely off the Sri Lankan duo, scoring just 22 runs in overs 12 to 14, which pushed the asking rate beyond 12. But Livingstone soon broke the shackles against Deshpande, and Kings were back on track.

Devon Conway made 92 not out, his fifth half-century in his last six innings•BCCI

CSK make quick start on a slow pitch

The Kings bowlers had to bowl in the unforgiving Chennai heat, and they were made to sweat further by Ruturaj Gaikwad and Devon Conway. Gaikwad showed excellent timing whereas Conway took the aerial route more often, such as when he hit Curran for back-to-back boundaries down the ground in the sixth over, which went for 16. Super Kings, who have lost the fewest wickets in the powerplay this IPL, finished the phase on 57 for 0.

Conway smashes fifty, Dube promoted to take on spinners

Spinners were always going to be in focus at Chepauk. Rahul Chahar, Kings' lead spinner, was introduced in the powerplay and the openers hit a six each off him down the ground to

push the run rate towards nine. Conway also reeled off consecutive fours off Raza's flat offbreaks before the bowler unleashed a legbreak to have Gaikwad stumped for 37.

Super Kings promoted Dube to counter the spinners, and he also pulled Kagiso Rabada for six soon after Conway reverse-swept Raza to raise a 30-ball fifty.

Conway bosses the middle overs

At 121 for 1 after 13, Kings brought back Arshdeep Singh, who struck when Dube holed out to long-on while attempting his third six. Super Kings kept sending out left-hand batters - Moeen Ali came in next - and they kept attacking the spinners. Conway and Moeen lapped up Livingstone for a 16-run 15th over, and Conway hit two more fours with sweeps off Chahar, before Arshdeep and Rabada slowed things a little with 11 boundary-free balls in the 18th and 19th overs.

The Dhoni show

Once looking set for 200, Super Kings were 185 with an over to go. Two hundred looked even more distant when Jadeja fell off the first ball of the 20th and Dhoni managed just one off his first two balls. But once Dhoni got the strike back, he smoked two sixes to end the innings, an uppercut and a leg-side whack off a low full-toss from Curran. Conway stayed unbeaten on 92 off 52 with 16 fours and a six.

Match 42

Mumbai Indians 214 for 4 (Suryakumar 55, David 45*, Ashwin 2-27) beat Rajasthan Royals 212 for 7 (Jaiswal 124, Arshad 3-39) by six wickets

An IPL game to commemorate the past produced a glimpse of the future instead as Yashasvi Jaiswal hit the most amazing hundred for Rajasthan Royals against his hometown franchise Mumbai Indians. And for 35.4 overs it looked like he would end up on the winning side.

But a quirk of T20 cricket is that it can often be decided by the guy who doesn't spend a lot of time in the middle. Tim David faced only 14 balls but that was still enough to change the course of history. A 200-plus total was chased down for the first time in the IPL at the Wankhede Stadium, and the Australian was at the centre of it all, muscling three back-to-back sixes off three back-to-back full tosses from Jason Holder in the final over.

You gotta give it to the IPL. It knows how to throw a 1000th birthday party.

Jaisw-all the way

Over 999 matches, this tournament has become part of daily life in India. The main man from its 1000th might well assume similar status as his career blossoms. Twenty-one-year-old Jaiswal defied a slow pitch to amass 124 off 62 balls with 16 fours and eight sixes. Royals' next best contribution was 18 off 19.

His century became the top score by an uncapped Indian batter in the IPL and the one with the second-highest percentage (90.32) of runs in boundaries in all men's T20. It was incredible and here's a list of reasons why.

Yashasvi Jaiswal smashed 124 off 62 balls•BCCI

The range and quality of his shots. He launched a Jofra Archer short ball clean out of the Wankhede. He reverse-swept Piyush Chawla for a six over point. He scooped Riley Meredith over fine leg. He got to his fifty with a cover drive. And his hundred with a pull shot in front of square all along the ground.

Then there was the fact that all of them were cleanly hit on a surface that messed everyone else up. Rohit Sharma, perhaps the poster boy for timing in Indian cricket, was so badly deceived by a knuckle ball that 90% of his body was nowhere near the line of it. This pitch - and Sandeep Sharma - essentially duped him into ushering one onto his stumps.

And finally, most of Jaiswal's carnage happened at a time his team was in danger of losing the advantage. Royals were 72 for 0 in their first seven overs. Then they lost 3 for 31 in four overs. It was becoming painfully clear that the set batter had to both last the entire innings and also take care of the acceleration. That's a lot of responsibility. Especially given he was facing a once-in-a-generation bowler in Archer.

But Jaiswal barely batted an eyelid. He scored 72 of the 109 runs Royals scored in the last nine overs. That's a two-thirds split.

SKY high

R Ashwin came into this game having bowled 192 balls in this IPL. And he had only given away seven sixes. Suryakumar Yadav launched him for one the moment he walked out to bat. That's how good he is. He finds a way to render really good bowlers into really average ones.

Suryakumar Yadav started aggressively•BCCI

But as awesome as his shots sometimes are - in one over he scooped Jason Holder over the keeper for six and next ball, an attempted yorker from around the wicket, he whipped it straight-bat through midwicket - the thing that is really striking about Suryakumar is how much belief he has and how he is never shaken.

Not so long ago, he bagged three first-ball ducks on the trot, and yet he keeps playing the way he has always played. Epic high-risk cricket. And he had Wankhede believing. He had a crowd that roared for Sachin, that roared for Rohit, that roared for Bumrah, that roared for Malinga, roaring for him.

And suddenly Royals were worried.

A turning point

Sandeep was ignored by all ten teams at the auction. Royals only got him in when one of their first-choice quicks, Prasad Krishna, was ruled out with injury.

In his second match of the season, he became that rare bowler who can tell his grandkids that he bested MS Dhoni in the final over of a chase. In his seventh match, he took an absolute screamer to dismiss Suryakumar on 55 off 29.

Sandeep Sharma was mobbed after a stunning catch to dismiss Suryakumar Yadav • BCCI

Sandeep had to run back 19 metres from short fine leg. All the while looking up over his left shoulder. Even then, the ball seemed to be beating him. He had to dive, propel himself off the ground, and reach out with both hands. It was fingertip stuff. Mumbai needed 61 off 26.

David finishes it off

It was the 18th over. He was just 11 off 6. The asking rate was up in the nosebleeds, at 16.6. And yet David batted as if he was the one on top; like the scoreboard was telling a lie.

He hit Boult for a four to close out the 18th over. He welcomed Sandeep in the 19th with a six. Panic-stricken, the bowler conceded a wide and then missed his wide yorker, only by mere inches, but it was still enough for one of the most powerful players in the world to get under the ball and find the boundary.

The equation was now down to 17 off the last over and it was to be bowled by someone who is just not suited to the task. Holder is a new-ball weapon. He doesn't have a good enough yorker to do the job at the death. And to make matters worse, the dew had come in, making it hard to properly grip the ball.

Everything was set up for the grandstand finish and David provided it. A man who makes his name by snatching victory from the jaws of defeat went 6, 6, 6 prompting 27,000 people to go into delirium.

Match 43

Royal Challengers Bangalore 126 for 9 (du Plessis 44, Kohli 31, Naveen 3-30) beat Lucknow Super Giants 108 (Gowtham 23, Hazlewood 2-15, Karn 2-20) by 18 runs

In the previous meeting between Royal Challengers Bangalore and Lucknow Super Giants, 425 runs were scored in 40 overs on the batting paradise at the M Chinnaswamy Stadium. On Monday night, LSG served a black-soil pitch on their home ground where the ball gripped and held into the surface. The result: 234 runs in 39.5 overs with RCB coming out on top by 18 runs.

After Faf du Plessis opted to bat, he and Virat Kohli set the platform by adding 62 in nine overs. But the innings never really came out of the first gear. Krunal Pandya, Ravi Bishnoi, Amit Mishra and K Gowtham combined to bowl 13 overs of spin and picked up 5 for 73

between them. Naveen-ul-Haq, too, reaped the rewards of bowling his cutters into the pitch and picked up three wickets at the death to restrict RCB to a modest 126 for 9.

Related

Kohli vs Gambhir: 'If you can give it, you got to take it'

LSG receive injury blows to Rahul and Unadkat

In response, LSG had a nightmarish start. They were 38 for 5 after seven overs, and when Marcus Stoinis and Gowtham too fell in back-to-back overs, they were soon 77 for 8. LSG's only hope at that point was KL Rahul. He had hobbled off the field after hurting his right leg in the second over of the game. But by the time he came out at No. 11, LSG needed 24 off eight balls.

It was clear Rahul was not going to run between the wickets. He played three dots, one of which was a free hit, and then saw Mishra trying and failing to score the required 23 in the final over. A post-match altercation between Kohli and LSG's mentor Gautam Gambhir, though, took the shine off RCB's win.

RCB's slow start

After RCB scored only 20 runs in the first three overs, du Plessis and Kohli tried to break the shackles. In the fourth over, du Plessis hit Naveen for a straight six and Kohli followed it with a four. However, Krunal and Bishnoi conceded only ten in the next two, and RCB finished the powerplay on 42 for no loss.

Bishnoi gets Kohli and Maxwell

Du Plessis and Kohli had put on 62 when Kohli decided to skip down the track against Bishnoi but reached nowhere near the ball. It also turned out to be a googly and beat him on the inside edge for Nicholas Pooran to effect an easy stumping.

No. 3 Anuj Rawat managed only 9 before being dismissed by Gowtham. That brought Glenn Maxwell, arguably RCB's best batter against spin, in the middle. On his fifth ball, he tried to reverse-sweep a Bishnoi legbreak only to get hit on the thigh and be given out lbw.

In the 15th over, Mishra had Suyash Prabhudessai caught at long-off, courtesy an excellent diving catch by Gowtham, to leave RCB 90 for 4.

2:24

Moody unhappy with the pitch in Lucknow

Rain but no runs

After a brief spell of rain that halted play for around 25 minutes, Dinesh Karthik resumed by hitting Naveen over midwicket for four. In the next over, the 17th, he pulled a half-tracker

from Mishra for a six and du Plessis also tried to take Mishra on but ended up miscuing his attempt. Krunal ran to his right from point and completed the tumbling catch near extra cover.

RCB were relying on Karthik for some late blows but Yash Thakur dashed their hopes. In the 19th over, Wanindu Hasaranga hit one back towards Thakur who fielded the ball and nailed the direct hit at the non-striker's end to find Karthik well short after he had taken off a long way.

RCB bounce back

Mohammed Siraj has been lethal with the new ball this season, and he once again struck early, having Kyle Mayers caught at mid-on with the second ball of the chase. After two overs, LSG were 2 for 1.

Krunal hit Siraj for three successive fours in the third to move the needle, but LSG lost four wickets in the next four overs. Krunal was the first to go, chipping Maxwell to long-off. From the other end, Josh Hazlewood removed Ayush Badoni, who had come in as Impact Player for Thakur and opened the innings.

Wanindu Hasaranga dealt a blow with his first ball, drawing Deepak Hooda out of the crease with a googly and having him stumped. Pooran started with a first-ball six but when he tried to go for another big hit against Karn Sharma, he holed out to deep square leg.

LSG slip further

LSG still looked to attack their way to the target. Gowtham hit Karn for a six and four, and followed it with another six off Hasaranga. That reduced the equation to 64 needed from the last ten overs. But when Stoinis tried to go big against Karn, he sliced it to long-off. In the next over, Gowtham too perished, his casual running while returning for a second run leading to him being run-out.

Rahul leaves it too late

LSG needed 49 in the last five overs with two wickets in hand. Mishra and Naveen were in the middle; Rahul was still padded up in the dugout. The required rate kept ballooning, and when Rahul finally walked in, it was too late because he couldn't run and Mishra couldn't get the boundaries.

Match 44

Delhi Capitals 130 for 8 (Aman 51, Shami 4-11, Mohit 2-33) beat Gujarat Titans 125 for 6 (Hardik 59*, Ishant 2-23, Khaleel 2-24) by five runs

In a game with twists of epic proportions, tenth-placed Delhi Capitals trumped table-toppers Gujarat Titans in Ahmedabad, winning by five runs in dramatic fashion.

The game's pendulum swung numerous times, starting with Mohammed Shami picking up four wickets inside the powerplay to reduce Capitals to 23 for 5. But Aman Hakim Khan's maiden T20 fifty and contributions from Axar Patel and Ripal Patel dragged the Capitals to 130 for 8.

Capitals then took the upper hand when Khaleel Ahmed, Ishant Sharma and Kuldeep Yadav left the Titans on the mat at 32 for 4. Even though Hardik Pandya steadied the chase with a half-century, the momentum was with Capitals going into the final two overs.

Just when the game seemed lost, Rahul Tewatia hit a hat-trick of sixes off Anrich Nortje in the 19th over to bring Titans to within touching distance of victory. But Ishant held his nerve in the final over and conceded just six against Hardik, Tewatia and Rashid Khan to seal the deal for Capitals.

Ishant Sharma kept a rampant Rahul Tewatia at bay in a sensational final over•Associated Press

Tewatia sets up thrilling finish

When Titans needed 42 off the last four overs, the game could have gone either way. But quiet overs from Kuldeep and Khaleel to end their respective spells made the equation 33 off the last two overs.

When Nortje began the 19th over with three pinpoint yorkers, the game was in the Capitals' grasp, only for Tewatia to bring the home crowd alive once again with three successive leg-side sixes. When Ishant ran in to bowl the 20th, the momentum was with the Titans, but Hardik and Tewatia couldn't find the early boundary in the over. Ishant then had Tewatia caught at cover, and when Rashid Khan needed a six off the final ball to force a Super Over, he conceded just a single to finish with figures of 2 for 23.

Capitals' Indian players stand up

Warner, who was run out, Phil Salt and Rilee Rossouw all failed with the bat, and were the first three men gone after Capitals opted to bat at the toss. When Shami also sent Manish Pandey and Priyam Garg packing, there was a chance Capitals would fold for a sub-100 score.

But Aman and Axar put on 50 off 54 balls for the sixth wicket to resurrect the innings. The pitch was not hugely difficult but the early jolts forced the pair onto the defensive. As their partnership grew, their scoring rate increased but Capitals suffered another setback when Axar fell at the end of the 14th over, miscuing Mohit Sharma to the deep. Aman, though, took charge after Axar's dismissal and got to his half-century. He combined with Ripal to help Capitals take 41 runs from overs 16 to 18, a passage of play that allowed them to set Titans 131 to win.

Aman Khan scored 51 off 44 balls•Associated Press

Then, it was Khaleel, Kuldeep, Axar and Ishant who hurt Titans in the chase. Khaleel bowled a first-over maiden that included the wicket of Wriddhiman Saha. Returning to the team after a long hamstring-injury break, Khaleel beat Saha's edge three times off his first three deliveries and then found the edge to the keeper off the last ball of the over.

Two overs later, Shubman Gill was out to Nortje, finding cover with a drive, but the body blows came when Ishant rattled Vijay Shankar's stumps with a knuckleball and Kuldeep disturbed David Miller's poles. That had the Titans reeling at 32 for 4, almost as bad a situation as Capitals' 23 for 5.

Hardik and Abhinav Manohar battled away, putting on a 62-run fifth-wicket partnership, but they consumed 63 balls, allowing the required rate to climb steadily. Axar conceded just 24 in four wicketless overs, while Kuldeep finished with a frugal 1 for 15, including a five-run 17th over. Khaleel and Ishant then bowled terrific overs either side of Nortje's expensive 19th to make it a day to celebrate for Capitals.

Mohammed Shami picked up four wickets inside the powerplay • Associated Press

Shami's super spell

Shami's first-ball wicket was a lucky one, a slot delivery hit straight to cover by Salt, but it was all skill after that. He delivered four overs straight after taking the new ball and finished with figures of 4 for 11, with 19 dots in 24 balls. He operated on a good length and had Rossouw edging a delivery angling across to Saha in his second over.

In his third over, he stayed on a similar length with a more prominent upright seam to right-handers Pandey and Garg, and both batters were caught behind fishing at deliveries outside off. Shami, who took the Player of the Match award, extended his lead at the top of the IPL 2023 list for most powerplay wickets. Sandwiched between Shami's first two wickets was Warner's dismissal, run out at the non-striker's end after a mix-up with Garg.

Once Shami's spell was done, the pitch didn't turn much for Noor Ahmad or Rashid Khan. Mohit and Josh Little did not find much grip with their cutters either. The two seamers eventually finished with relatively expensive figures as they failed to control the flow of runs at the death. Capitals scored 52 in their last five overs, propelled by Ripal's unbeaten 13-ball 23 and Aman's 44-ball 51, which proved to be the difference in the end.

Match 45

19.2 overs Lucknow Super Giants 125 for 7 (Badoni 59, Moeen 2-13, Pathirana 2-22)
v Chennai Super Kings

Match abandoned

Rain had the final say in Lucknow, where MS Dhoni's Chennai Super Kings had taken the upper hand against the Super Giants after 19.2 action-packed overs of the first innings. CSK

spinners ran through the home team's line-up, but 23-year-old Ayush Badoni scored a counter-attacking fifty before the game was called off at 6.56 pm local time.

The game had started 15 minutes late due to an afternoon shower, and the surface ended up assisting spin big time. Moeen Ali dismissed Kyle Mayers for the second time in the season, and Maheesh Theekshana accounted for Manan Vohra and Krunal Pandya off successive deliveries in the sixth over. Moeen held on to a tough caught-and-bowled chance to remove Karan Sharma, but the best wicket was Ravindra Jadeja bowling Marcus Stoinis with one that pitched outside the right-hander's leg stump and spun sharply to hit off, leaving the batter dumbfounded.

At 44 for 5 in the 10th over, the Super Giants were sinking but Badoni and Nicholas Pooran steadied the innings. They added 59 for the sixth wicket, but Pooran's contribution was only 14, with Badoni taking charge. He smashed two sixes off Theekshana and reached fifty with another six off Deepak Chahar in the 19th over to give the Super Giants a fighting chance.

Rain forced the players off the field in the 20th over of the first innings and did not ease up enough for play to resume, leaving both Super Kings and Super Giants with one point each from the contest. Both teams are on 11 points after ten games.

The fixture was also significant for the return of two fast bowlers. Chahar was fit again for CSK after missing six games because of a hamstring injury and returned figures of 0 for 41 in four overs. Mohsin Khan was named in the Super Giants XI for the first time this season, after spending almost the entire year since the previous IPL recovering from injury, but did not get the chance to bowl because of the bad weather.

Match 46

Mumbai Indians 216 for 4 (Kishan 75, Suryakumar 66, Ellis 2-34) beat Punjab Kings 214 for 3 (Livingstone 82*, Jitesh 49*, Chawla 2-29) by six wickets

Punjab Kings have a deep batting line-up, which allows them to approach their innings in a fearless manner. They duly posted 200-plus for the fourth time in a row - an IPL record - courtesy an unbroken stand of 119 in 8.4 overs from Liam Livingstone and Jitesh Sharma. Yet, they ended up on the losing side. And that was down to a masterclass in T20 batting from Suryakumar Yadav and Ishan Kishan, who helped Mumbai Indians hunt down 215 with plenty to spare just three days after they had also successfully chased 213.

Livingstone and Jitesh had swung, slapped and sliced Mumbai's bowlers all around during their century stand, to lift Kings from 95 for 3 in the 12th to 214. Livingstone cracked 82 off 42, while Jitesh missed his half-century by one run, getting to 49 from 27. But then Suryakumar hammered 66 at more than two runs a ball and Kishan slammed 75 to further clog the points table, where four sides - including both these teams - sit on ten points each.

The race to playoffs has indeed heated up.

Ishan Kishan goes aerial in his 75 off 41 • BCCI

Suryakumar, Kishan bat fearlessly

Mumbai were 54 for 2 after the powerplay, as Rohit Sharma's inconsistent run continued - out for a three-ball duck today - and Cameron Green fell after a cameo. Another 161 were required at 11.50 an over when Impact Player Suryakumar joined Kishan. By then, Kishan had settled in, having raced to 26 off 15 with two fours and two sixes. Three overs later, the required rate had risen further to 12.54. And that is when the carnage began.

Kishan went after Harpreet Brar to pick up 14 from the tenth over, and then combined with Suryakumar to slam 14 more off Rahul Chahar the next. PBKS were still very much in it, though, when MI were 100 away with eight overs remaining, but then the turning point of the chase truly arrived.

Suryakumar helped thrash 23 off a Sam Curran over - 6, 6, 4, 4 came off consecutive legal deliveries and this final boundary got him to his fifty from 23 deliveries. Soon after, Kishan targeted Arshdeep Singh: 6, 4, 4, and the game was almost done. Mumbai needed just 45 from 30 from that point on.

Livingstone and Jitesh merciless on Mumbai

The match had seemed in the balance earlier in the day, when Matthew Short's struggle ended. Jitesh came in at No. 5, with Livingstone already set at the other end. By the time the pair was done, they had slammed the last eight overs of Kings' innings for 115. Jofra Archer had given away only five runs in his first over, but in the 13th, the two Kings batters belted 21, including four leg-byes, off him.

Some luck went Jitesh's way when a top edge flew over the short-third fielder and a heave fell short of deep midwicket, but no such close calls could stop him from going hard at the bowlers.

At the other end, Livingstone's knock included deft touches between point and short third, as well as forceful swat-pulls. And when Rohit brought Archer back for the 19th over, Livingstone smacked three sixes in a row before five wides meant the over cost 27. In all, Archer leaked 56 in four overs. Who knew then that Livingstone and Jitesh would eventually finish on the losing side. Some of the credit for that should also go to Piyush Chawla.

Piyush Chawla spins a web

Having gone for 14 off his first seven balls - including three fours by Shikhar Dhawan - the experienced Chawla hit back in the eighth over of the innings. He tossed the ball up again to invite Dhawan down the track, but this was a wrong'un. Dhawan was beaten and stumped for an attacking 30. Chawla went on to put the lid on Kings' scoring over the next few overs, finishing with 2 for 29. That spell included subtle changes of pace and constant use of variations; Short was his second victim, misreading a googly to be bowled for 27.

Livingstone and Jitesh got together thereafter, but Chawla would still be one up on them come the end of the game.

Match 47

Kolkata Knight Riders 171 for 9 (Rinku 46, N Rana 42, Jansen 2-24, Natarajan 2-30) beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 166 for 8 (Markram 41, Klaasen 36, Thakur 2-23, Arora 2-32) by five runs

Varun Chakravathy bowled overs 16, 18 and 20 for 12 runs - four of them off byes and leg byes - and one wicket as Kolkata Knight Riders pulled off an improbable win over Sunrisers Hyderabad, only their fourth in 10 matches this season. The defeat left SRH in an identical situation to KKR's before the match: three wins in six matches. Both sides remained in must-win territory.

When Heinrich Klaasen was dominating at the start of the second half of the chase, it seemed like a cruise for SRH in their pursuit of 172. When they needed 48 off the last six overs, Klaasen fell to Shardul Thakur's golden arm, and then Varun choked SRH with help from Vaibhav Arora, who got the wicket of Aiden Markram in the 17th over.

Varun Chakravathy was KKR's hero in the closing stages • Associated Press

Jansen's bounce

KKR's seventh opening combination of this IPL was the most anticipated: Jason Roy and Rahmanullah Gurbaz, both of whom have batted breathtakingly in different matches. The promise didn't materialise as Gurbaz walked at Marco Jansen the first ball he faced, and ended up top-edging to mid-on. Later in the over, Venkatesh Iyer got a snorter: extra bounce from just short of a length, and straight at his face. Off the glove to the keeper.

Bhuvneshwar Kumar frustrated Roy with his movement, and Kartik Tyagi, playing his first match this year, benefited as Roy went to manufacture a pull from well outside off and toe-ended it to short third: 35 for 3 in the fifth over.

The recovery

Helped by some waywardness from Jansen in his third over, Nitish Rana and Rinku Singh set about rebuilding the innings at a fair clip. Aiden Markram saw the opportunity to slip in a couple of overs to two left-hand batters, and found some grip. It was when Tyagi tried to bounce Rana that KKR finally found proper momentum with two sixes and a four in the 10th over to move to 90 for 3.

ESPNcricinfo Ltd

Spinners shackle KKR

With KKR looking to dominate, Markram went to his No. 1 spinner Mayank Markande, who immediately applied the brakes. Markram himself got a change of ends, and Rana took a risk only to top-edge a slog-sweep.

With Sunil Narine not in batting form, KKR didn't have an option but to send Andre Russell out to face wristspin. He managed to hit two sixes off overpitched balls, but Markande still overpitched, only wide of his reach, and had him caught at short third.

Wickets then kept falling. KKR sacrificed Suyash Sharma by substituting in Anukul Roy with 15 balls to spare, but they never found the big overs at the death.

Harshit gives KKR new-ball bonus

KKR have mainly relied on their spinners to win their matches but they received a bonus through the impressive burly fast bowler Harshit Rana. He bowled with some heat, and had Mayank Agarwal gloving a bouncer. Shardul Thakur's golden touch continued with Abhishek Sharma nonchalantly skying one up. Rahul Tripathi took Russell on with four, six and four in the sixth over, but fell to a ramp off a slower ball against the same bowler.

Having taken three early wickets through the quicks, KKR fancied their chances, especially with Anukul getting Harry Brook for a duck on the paddle sweep in the seventh over. At 54 for 4, with their two main spinners in the pocket, KKR proceeded to tighten the screws.

Heinrich Klaasen took on the spinners to put SRH in control of their chase•BCCI

Klaasen shifts the momentum

Klaasen and Markram, SRH's two best batters, went 19 straight balls without even attempting a boundary let alone hit one. They knew there wasn't much behind them so they were content to rebuild. KKR were holding back their main spinners, telling them the batters would have to take big risks on a slow low pitch to get the 97 they needed in the last 10 overs.

Klaasen chose Anukul's third over as the moment to start the pushback. He charged the first ball of the 11th over, and went over long-off for a six. Then he slogged a 101m hit over midwicket. It rubbed on to Markram - he was on 11 off 21 then - who welcomed Varun with two square-cut fours.

It was as though the floodgates had opened with 49 coming off four overs, leaving Sunrisers just 48 to get off six overs.

Thakur inspires, Varun executes

Brought back, Thakur again imparted the golden touch. This length ball, to start the 15th over, looked on-pace and in the slot, but it was a fast cutter, and Klaasen toe-ended it to long-on. SRH still had Markram in charge, and he had now moved up to a run a ball after his slow start. Two boundaries in that Thakur over calmed SRH's nerves.

However, Varun sucked the life out of their innings. Bowling around the wicket, he denied them any hits down the ground by bowling into the pitch. Nor did he give them any pace to work with.

Markram felt obliged to take on Vaibhav, but chose a bouncer too high to go after. He ended up holing out to long-off for 41 off 40. Varun kept tightening the noose. No boundary came off the 18th over. With 21 required off two overs, Gurbaz took a stunning left-handed catch off Jansen's inside edge. Arora then overcame a no-ball, which Abdul Samad sliced for four, to leave Varun eight to defend in the last over.

Samad, 20 off 16 at the start of the over, ended up hitting a slow short ball straight to deep midwicket. Bhuvneshwar Kumar had never ended up on the winning side on the 33 previous occasions when he had batted in a chase in the IPL; left with too much to do now, he finished on the losing side once again.

Match 48

Gujarat Titans 119 for 1 (Saha 41*, Hardik 39*, Chahal 1-22) beat Rajasthan Royals 118 (Samson 30, Rashid 3-14, Noor 2-25) by nine wickets

Clinical. That's what Gujarat Titans were against Rajasthan Royals on Friday night in Jaipur. After bowling out Royals for a mere 118, they chased the target down in just 13.5 overs with nine wickets still in hand.

The win helped Titans stretch their lead at the top of the points table and put one foot in the playoffs. Royals, meanwhile, have now lost four of their last five games, and are still stuck in the ten-point cluster in the middle.

Royals, though, had a decent start after winning the toss. They were 50 for 2 in six overs, but Yashasvi Jaiswal's run-out triggered a collapse they could never recover from. Rashid Khan picked up three wickets and Noor Ahmad bagged two as the innings lasted just 17.5 overs.

In response, Wriddhiman Saha and Shubman Gill added 71 in 9.4 overs to make the target look even smaller. Hardik Pandya then belted an unbeaten 39 off 15 balls, striking at 260, to give everyone an early finish.

The powerplay battle

Coming into this game, the Titans had the best economy powerplay economy rate in IPL 2023. Royals, meanwhile, had the best scoring rate in that phase. And Jaipur got to witness a bit of both. Mohammed Shami got the new ball to move in the opening over, and despite using their feet to counter the movement, Jaiswal and Jos Buttler could manage only one run off the bat.

From the other end, Hardik got Buttler caught at short third after being hit for two successive fours. But Royals stuck with their attacking template. Jaiswal hit Shami for six and four in the third over and Samson did the same to Hardik in the fourth.

Royals seemed to be winning the powerplay battle before a misunderstanding between Jaiswal and Samson resulted in the former being run out. Samson cut Rashid towards backward point where Manohar dived to his left to make a partial stop. Jaiswal was more than three-fourths down when he realised Samson had hardly moved. Unfortunately for him, Manohar's deflection went towards Mohit Sharma at short third whose throw to Rashid found Jaiswal well short.

Rajasthan Royals slump • ESPNcricinfo Ltd

The Afghan magic

R Ashwin entered at No. 5 to try to arrest the collapse. But he lasted only six balls as Rashid pinged his off stump with a legbreak, forcing Royals to bring in Riyan Parag as their Impact Player. That meant Royals would have only five specialist bowlers in the second innings; the original plan might have been to bring in left-arm seamer Kuldeep Yadav. The move didn't work. Rashid's googly trapped him lbw for 4.

Rashid was taken off after his third over. But there was no respite for the Royals. Noor struck with his third ball, uprooting Devdutt Padikkal's off stump for a run-a-ball 12. In his next over, he had Dhruv Jurel lbw. From the other end, Rashid returned to send back Shimron Hetmyer, leaving Royals 96 for 8. The last two wickets took Royals to 118, which was never going to be enough.

Wriddhiman Saha finally found some form • Associated Press

Saha off to a flier

It's not often when a team is all out and the opposition's wicketkeeper isn't involved in any of the dismissals. Still, Saha showed his class behind the stumps with a diving one-handed save when Noor sprayed one way down the leg side to Hetmyer.

Saha wasn't done, though. With Gill taking his time in the chase, he smashed five fours in the first 13 balls he faced. Four of them came off Trent Boult, the Royals' powerplay weapon.

Hardik in a hurry

After Titans' defeat to Delhi Capitals, Hardik had taken "full ownership" for not closing out the chase as he struggled to find any rhythm despite scoring an unbeaten half-century. He corrected that here.

After Yuzvendra Chahal broke the opening stand by having Gill stumped for 36 off 35 balls, Hardik teed off straightaway. He had faced just two balls before smashing Adam Zampa for

6, 4, 6, 6 off successive deliveries. Despite Saha slowing down after the powerplay, Hardik's assault meant Titans crossed the line with 37 balls left.

Match 49

Chennai Super Kings 140 for 4 (Conway 44, Gaikwad 30, Chawla 2-25) beat Mumbai Indians 139 for 8 (Wadhera 64, Suryakumar 26, Pathirana 3-15) by six wickets

On a pitch where the ball was stopping, it was actually Chennai Super Kings' pace trio of Matheesha Pathirana, Deepak Chahar and Tushar Deshpande which combined to take seven wickets and restrict Mumbai Indians to 139. Super Kings never looked in trouble during the chase at Chepauk, where Ruturaj Gaikwad's rapid cameo in the first four overs set them up for the six-wicket win.

Chahar's twin strikes had reduced Mumbai to 14 for 3 in the third over; and although Nehal Wadhera and Suryakumar Yadav added 55 to stage a recovery, Pathirana applied the brakes in the death overs. Mumbai managed only 17 - while losing four wickets - in the last three overs, as Wadhera's maiden T20 fifty turned out to be a solitary effort.

The win takes Super Kings to the second spot on the points table, even as third-placed Lucknow Super Giants have an extra game in hand. Mumbai on the other hand, remain sixth.

Pathirana, middle- and death-overs specialist

Only twice in the seven matches this season has Pathirana been introduced before the 11th over. For anyone to have bowled at least 120 balls in that period, he has the best economy rate and average during that phase.

On Saturday, he was introduced in the 13th over, just after Wadhera and Suryakumar had given Mumbai hope of a respectable total. Pathirana's first two overs went for only eight off the bat, and MS Dhoni kept his remaining overs for the death. He returned to start the 18th after the two overs before that were taken for 29 and gave only two runs aside from bowling Wadhera. Seeing the batter make room, he fired a yorker which hit middle stump at 145kph.

Mathesha Pathirana celebrates the wicket of Tristan Stubbs•BCCI

Pathirana mixed his lengths as much as he varied his pace. That - combined with the two-paced nature of the pitch - might have been why Tristan Stubbs struggled for timing, eventually slicing to cover-point on being foxed by a slower ball. Pathirana ended with 3 for 15 - all wickets came in the death overs - and further enhanced his reputation of being the season's best death bowler so far for a minimum of 60 balls bowled in that phase.

Wadhera propels Mumbai to 139

With Tilak Varma out injured for this game, Mumbai were missing a solid middle-order batter. And forced to rebuild after the top-order failure, Wadhera opened up after the

powerplay when he gently cut Ravindra Jadeja for four to deep backward point, and then drilled Moeen Ali to deep extra cover.

Once Wadhera picked up some momentum, he looked confident enough to keep attacking spin: Jadeja was slog-swept over short fine to start the 11th over, before he beat short fine leg with another sweep off Maheesh Theekshana in the 14th. And with five overs to go, he cracked the innings' first six by launching Theekshana over long-on.

Wadhera's fifty took 46 deliveries when it was raised in the 17th over, after which he swept, pulled and scooped Jadeja for fours, although his knock of 64 didn't prove enough.

Nehal Wadhera scored his maiden IPL fifty • BCCI

Gaikwad starts in a hurry, Dube finishes in style

Super Kings posted 46 in the first four overs, out of which Gaikwad had bashed 30. That included four fours and two sixes, as he got Super Kings' chase rolling alongside Devon Conway. The first over included a drive and a flick for four off Cameron Green, while he turned the screw in the third over.

Mumbai introduced left-arm seamer Arshad Khan, and Gaikwad went 6, 4, 4, 6: a pull over midwicket, a guide behind point, a punch past the bowler and a swivel-pull over long leg. Gaikwad was dismissed off the first ball of the fifth over by Piyush Chawla, who again turned out to be the standout performer with the ball for Mumbai.

Although Chawla was hit for a four and a six by Ajinkya Rahane, he had the last laugh when he trapped the Super Kings batter with a googly in the ninth over. That came after earlier getting Gaikwad with the legspinner. Chawla's four overs went for only 25, and he was bowled out inside 11 overs.

Soon after, the platform that Gaikwad had laid was further built by Shivam Dube, who provided the finishing kick. Two sixes off debutant left-arm wristspinner Raghav Goyal in the 14th over and one swung off Arshad Khan to Mumbai's dugout two balls before the winning run took Super Kings to a comfortable win after they had lost two and had a game washed out just before.

Match 50

Delhi Capitals 187 for 3 for D (Salt 87) beat Royal Challengers Bangalore 181 for 4 (Kohli 55, Lomror 54*, Marsh 2-21) by seven wickets

The Delhi Capitals' batting might has turned up a little late in the tournament but they gave their home crowd a dazzling display of boundary hitting, the centerpiece of which was Phil Salt's 87 off 45 balls, to finish off a chase of 182 against RCB with 20 balls to spare.

After three ducks and only one score over 10 in his last five T20 innings, Salt sent five of his six sixes over the leg-side boundary during an assault that featured a lot of horizontal-bat

shots. The Capitals chase got going with their first half-century opening stand of the season, and Salt kept attacking to bring the asking rate under six in almost no time. They raced to 70 in the powerplay, 115 at the halfway mark with Salt's 28-ball fifty, before plundering 24 runs off a Harshal Patel over to reduce the chase to 32 off 42 balls.

Salt was eventually bowled for 87 but his eight fours and six sixes helped Capitals beat RCB for the first time in three years. It was Capitals' fourth win in their last five games, and lifted them off the bottom of the table.

DC's best powerplay

The Capitals chase was unlike any of their batting displays this season. David Warner began with two fours off the first three balls from Mohammed Siraj, before sweeping Wanindu Hasaranga's first ball for six in the fourth over. In between, Salt took on Josh Hazlewood for two fours before a feisty fifth over from Siraj.

Salt top-edged the first ball for six over the wicketkeeper, slapped the second one over cover and into the stands, and then flicked one bounce into the square-leg boundary. Siraj responded with a bouncer that was called wide and there followed a heated conversation between the bowler and the batter, and some animated finger-pointing from Siraj towards both Salt and Warner.

Warner skied a catch off Hazlewood for 22 off 14 in the last over of the powerplay but Mitchell Marsh ended the over with a big six over midwicket and an edged four to power Capitals to 70 after six overs. They might not have got so much had Dinesh Karthik held on to a tough chance from Salt - an inside edge off Hasaranga - in the fourth over.

It got heated between Phil Salt and Mohammed Siraj • Associated Press

Salt's boundary bonanza

Salt was on 35 off 17 at the time and he threw his bat at anything wayward: wide balls disappeared over cover, short ones were pulled disdainfully, and a few edges also raced to the boundary.

Marsh holed out off a full toss but the attack on RCB's bowlers did not abate. Salt began the 13th over, from Harshal, with a six over the leg side and Rilee Rossouw smashed two more down the ground, before a misfield on the long-off boundary from Suyash Prabhudessai made it 24 runs off the over.

Salt belted out two more boundaries before falling to Karn Sharma and Rossouw ended the game in the 17th over with his third six.

Kohli and Du Plessis solid but not spectacular

After RCB chose to bat on what was considered to be a slow pitch at the Arun Jaitley Stadium, Virat Kohli started by playing nine dot balls in the first three overs, but also found the boundary in each of them.

RCB got a boost when Faf du Plessis struck Mukesh Kumar for three fours in the fifth over before he hit Khaleel Ahmed for a straight six and a four to make it 51 from the powerplay.

Marsh goes bang, bang

Kohli and du Plessis batted into the 11th over of the innings, when Marsh had du Plessis caught slapping a short and wide slower ball to deep point. He then had Glenn Maxwell caught first ball to reduce RCB to 82 for 2. Kohli was on 36 of 31 at the other end, and the run rate dipped slightly.

Mahipal Lomror lifts RCB

Mahipal Lomror raised the tempo of RCB's innings quickly. He pulled his fifth ball for six off Kuldeep Yadav, and used the reverse-sweep and the loft down the ground to find the boundary, before pulling Marsh for another six to lift the run rate over eight an over.

Kohli, meanwhile, found short fine leg for 55 off 46 and RCB were 137 for 3 with four overs left. Lomror didn't get a lot of support and ended up doing most of the hitting himself. His two fours off Ishant Sharma, an edge for four off Khaleel, along with Dinesh Karthik's six helped RCB collect 29 runs from the 17th and 18th overs. Mukesh then nailed a few yorkers and Khaleel used his cutters to keep RCB to 15 off the last two. Kohli said he thought 181 was a good score during the innings break, but the Capitals ran down the target with ease.

Match 51

Gujarat Titans 227 for 2 (Gill 94*, Saha 81) beat Lucknow Super Giants 171 for 7 (de Kock 70, Mayers 48, Mohit 4-29) by 56 runs

Gujarat Titans are all but through to the playoffs of IPL 2023 after their 56-run win over Lucknow Super Giants in Ahmedabad. Titans now have 16 points from 11 games and a net run rate of 0.951, by far the best in the league.

The win was set up by Wriddhiman Saha and Shubman Gill who added 142 in 12.1 overs for the first wicket - the highest partnership for Titans. Saha scored 81 off 43 and Gill finished on an unbeaten 94 off 51 to power them to 227 for 2.

In response, Quinton de Kock, playing his first match of the season, and Kyle Mayers gave LSG a start of 88 in 8.2 overs. But once Mohit Sharma dismissed Mayers to break that stand, the incoming batters couldn't keep up with the required rate.

The contest was also significant because Hardik Pandya and Krunal Pandya became only the second set of brothers to captain their respective sides against each other in T20 cricket.

The Hussey brothers faced off twice during the Big Bash League in 2015-16 when Mike was leading Sydney Thunder and David Melbourne Stars.

Saha blazes away

At Titans, Saha's role with bat is to attack in the powerplay, and he couldn't have done more justice to it. He started with two fours off Mohsin Khan in the opening over. The first one had come via an outside edge but that didn't bother Saha. In the next over, he picked up a six and four off Avesh Khan.

Mohsin came in for more punishment in the fourth over with Saha hitting two fours and two sixes. By the end of that over Titans had cruised to 53; Saha's contribution was 46.

With a six over long-on off Yash Thakur, Saha brought up his half-century, off just 20 balls in the sixth over. By the halfway stage, Saha had moved to 74 off 37 but his innings came to an end when he dragged Avesh Khan to deep square leg.

Rashid Khan took a brilliant catch to dismiss Kyle Mayers•BCCI

Gill takes over

Gill had spent most of the powerplay watching Saha from the non-striker's end. He faced just five balls in the first four overs and was on 9 off ten at one point. But soon he was matching Saha shot for shot, even outshining him.

It started with a six off Krunal; Deepak Hooda jumped at long-off and tried to lob it back but failed. Shortly after that, Gill launched Ravi Bishnoi for two sixes in one over, and raised his fifty off 29 balls. There were six sixes but no four in his first 68 runs.

After Saha fell, and Gill started tiring a bit in the harsh Ahmedabad heat, Hardik and David Miller chipped in with cameos. Gill had reached 85 when Thakur started the last over of the innings. He hit the first two balls for a six and a two, reaching 93 with four to go. But that was followed by a dot and single. Miller pulled the penultimate ball for a four and took a single off the final one, with Gill finishing six short of what would have been his maiden IPL hundred.

Mayers, de Kock respond in kind

Mohammed Shami started Titans' defence with a four-run over. But in the next three overs, Mayers and de Kock smashed nine fours and six. With LSG racing to 50 in four overs, Hardik was forced to introduce both wristspinners Rashid Khan and Noor Ahmad inside the powerplay. Still, there was no respite for Titans. The LSG openers hit three fours and a six in the Afghan duo's first two overs.

Mohit brings Titans back

When Titans were batting, a couple of slower balls had stuck in the surface. Mohit used the same trick to dismiss Mayers as the batter miscued one towards deep square leg, where Rashid, after running in diagonally to his right, completed the catch with a slide.

Mayers' wicket slowed LSG down drastically. The next six overs, including the one in which he fell, brought LSG just 33 runs. It left them needing 107 from the last six overs.

De Kock tried to revive the chase with a six off Mohit but the bowler bounced back by dismissing Marcus Stoinis with yet another slower ball. In the next over, Rashid sent back de Kock to effectively end the game. Ayush Badoni tried to reduce the margin of the loss before Mohit dismissed him and Krunal to finish with 4 for 29.

Match 52

Sunrisers Hyderabad 217 for 6 (Abhishek 55, Tripathi 47, Chahal 4-29) beat Rajasthan Royals 214 for 2 (Buttler 95, Samson 66) by four wickets

Just when Rajasthan Royals thought they had collected two points by defending 214 and had started to celebrate, their last-ball wicket transformed into a no-ball from Sandeep Sharma (called belatedly by the third umpire), and Abdul Samad smoked a straight six off the free hit to get Sunrisers Hyderabad the four more runs they needed, sparking wild celebrations in the orange camp while the players and home fans in pink were left stunned.

Royals were well ahead of Sunrisers almost throughout the chase, with the asking rate rising and wickets falling regularly towards the end. Sunrisers, however, kept fighting back with big hits. The biggest turnaround came when they needed 41 from 12 and Glenn Phillips, in for Harry Brook, blasted three sixes and a four to reduce it to 19 off eight. The chase turned again when he fell on the next ball, and they needed 17 to win from the last over with Samad on strike.

Samad was nearly caught twice in two balls, first dropped by Obed McCoy at short third resulting in two runs and then hitting a six just over Joe Root's fingertips at long-on. Sandeep's near-yorkers conceded just four off the next three and with five to win off the last ball, Samad found long-on while attempting another straight six, and Sandeep lifted his finger in celebration. But those smiles soon disappeared because Sandeep had overstepped and when he re-bowled the last ball - another attempted yorker, the length off by a few inches - Samad completed Sunrisers' heist with a successful straight six right over the bowler's head.

Sanju Samson and Jos Buttler put on a rollicking 138-run stand • BCCI

Royals will rue the two dropped catches and a run-out chance in between which meant Jos Buttler's scintillating return to form with a 95 off 59 and Sanju Samson's unbeaten 66 off 38 went in vain. Despite their third loss in a row and fifth loss in six games, Royals are still in fourth position on the table, but RCB, Mumbai Indians and Punjab Kings are level with them

on 10 points and all have a game in hand. Sunrisers lifted themselves off the bottom and pushed Delhi Capitals back to the last spot.

Brisk but not the quickest start for SRH

After dropping Mayank Agarwal and Brook, Sunrisers were off to a brisk start with quick knocks from their top three. Anmolpreet Singh opened with the in-form Abhishek Sharma and started finding the boundaries, especially against the experienced Sandeep and R Ashwin. Abhishek joined in as well and with three fours off Sandeep in the fifth over, Sunrisers looked set for a strong powerplay finish except that Yuzvendra Chahal had Anmolpreet caught off a sweep for 33 and the visitors were a middling 52 for 1 after the powerplay.

SRH (seemingly) leave too much too late

Soon after the powerplay ended, the asking rate shot up over 12 but Rahul Tripathi and Abhishek started with the big hits only when they needed 142 from 11 overs. Tripathi started with a six off M Ashwin and Abhishek collected sixes off both Ashwins before edging to short third for 55 when attempting another big shot.

With Heinrich Klaasen promoted to No. 4 and the equation at 98 off 42, Samson gave M Ashwin a third over despite his first two going for 23 and despite having other bowling options around, and he leaked another 19 which kept Sunrisers in the game.

Yuzvendra Chahal strikes before Glenn Phillips takes charge

Samson turned to Yuzvendra Chahal, who was taken for a six and a four in the first four balls of his spell before fighting back with wicket of Klaasen for 26 off 12. With 57 to get from 24, Tripathi got a life when Samson dropped him down the leg side off McCoy and he cashed in with a six off the next ball. In his last over, when SRH needed 44 off 18, Chahal landed the big blows when Tripathi found deep midwicket right on the boundary and Markram missed a reverse sweep to be given lbw. Finishing with 4 for 29 after a three-run 18th over, Chahal also went level with Dwayne Bravo for the most IPL wickets and had almost done the job for Royals.

The steep equation of 41 from 12 - and having not batted in a match situation for more than a month - didn't make any difference to Phillips. He belted out three sixes at the start of the 19th when Kuldip Yadav missed his yorkers, and edged one for four before another twist came in the form of Phillips' wicket when Shimron Hetmyer completed an excellent catch running towards the boundary on the leg side.

With Sunrisers needing 17 from the last over, Samad kept going after the straight boundaries and eventually left Royals bewildered.

ESPNcricinfo Ltd

Another quick start from Yashasvi Jaiswal

Having opted to bat, Royals saw Yashasvi Jaiswal continue his imperious form with a combination of intent and luck. He struck the first ball just over mid-on for four and on the fourth ball he could have been caught at fine leg, but debutant Vivrant Sharma misjudged the catch to concede another four. While Buttler was still searching for rhythm, Jaiswal hit Marco Jansen and Bhuvneshwar Kumar for sixes before collecting back-to-back fours off Jansen in the fifth over.

Jaiswal fell for 35 off 18 when his attempt to clear short third off Jansen's short ball resulted in an easy catch because of the extra bounce.

Jos Buttler flicks the switch on

Buttler was on 20 off 20 at the end of the eighth, but Samson came in and started finding boundaries straightaway. The ninth over, by Mayank Markande, lifted Royals' scoring rate further and that's when Buttler got going too. After seeing Samson strike back-to-back sixes, Buttler ended the over with a pulled six to take the over for 21 overall.

He brought out straight pulls and flourishing drives off the spinners to bring up a 32-ball fifty and keep the run rate comfortably over 10. Markande came back only to be hit for three more sixes, and Buttler jumped from 78 to 91 with three fours in the cover region, off Bhuvneshwar, in the 17th over.

T Natarajan, Bhuvneshwar Kumar rein in Royals at the end

Despite the barrage of boundaries, T Natarajan and Bhuvneshwar bowled the 18th and 19th overs - peppered with yorkers - for just 12 runs, even as Samson reached his fifty off 33 balls. Their accuracy also accounted for Buttler when he walked across and Bhuvneshwar's searing yorker trapped him lbw in front.

Expecting more yorkers in the last over, Samson ramped and steered two fours, with a straight six in between, in a 17-run over to finish. It would not be enough for Royals in the end.

Match 53

Kolkata Knight Riders 182 for 5 (Nitish 51, Russell 42, Roy 38, Chahar 2-23) beat Punjab Kings 179 for 7 (Dhawan 57, Varun 3-26, Harshit 2-33) by five wickets

Kolkata Knight Riders hung on by the skin of their teeth, both in their match against Punjab Kings and in the tournament. Rinku Singh sealed another last-ball win for them, but this was no miraculous comeback from the dead. This was a topsy-turvy contest set up by KKR's spinners, but even their batters struggled on a slow surface.

Rana fined INR 12 lakh

The KKR captain was handed an INR 12 lakh fine after his side were deemed to be maintaining a slow over-rate during their fixture against Kings at the Eden Gardens. This

was KKR's first offence of the season under IPL's Code of Conduct relating to minimum over-rate offences.

Nitish Rana set up the chase with 51 off 38, but it took Andre Russell to finally turn up and take 20 runs off the 19th over, bowled by Sam Curran, to bring the equation down to six required off the last over. Arshdeep Singh managed to push them all the way to the last ball, before Rinku Singh found the boundary with two runs required.

The result left KKR and PBKS level at 10 points from 11 matches. Five teams are currently tied on that points total in the middle of the table, but both Royal Challengers Bangalore and Mumbai Indians - who meet on Tuesday - have a game in hand.

Rinku Singh leaps in joy after hitting the winning boundary•BCCI

Harshit Rana keeps a check

PBKS were always going to target the new ball because they expected the spinners to be effective on this pitch, which is why they batted first. Prabhsimran Singh was up early, using Vaibhav Arora's inswing to pick up three boundaries in the first over.

The impressive Harshit Rana, though, bowled hard lengths and got disconcerting bounce from the pitch. He had both Prabhsimran and Bhanuka Rajapaksa caught at the wicket while looking to hit big shots. Rajapaksa's return to the side ended with a three-ball duck. Liam Livingstone still kept going hard, helping PBKS take 19 off the fifth over, bowled by Russell, to make it 51 for 2.

The spin choke

KKR are not shy to use spin during the powerplay or at the death. They had picked three spinners. So they began the spin attack in earnest. Varun Chakravarthy got the first shot, and produced a beautiful legbreak to trap the rampaging Livingstone in front.

Having lost a third wicket inside the powerplay, PBKS had to go into rebuild mode especially with the KKR spinners bowling well. Jitesh Sharma then hit Suyash Sharma for a six, and Shikhar Dhawan had just about begun to open up again with sweeps and reverse-sweeps when Varun came back for the 13th over.

Once again, Varun produced the breakthrough, spinning the ball away from Jitesh, taking the edge through to the keeper. Nitish brought himself on when two left-hand batters were at the wicket, and got Dhawan for 57 off 47. Suyash proceeded to tighten the screws with the wicket of Sam Curran. In effect, PBKS were tied down on a slow pitch by 13 straight overs of spin, which brought them just 92 runs for five wickets.

Varun Chakravarthy picked up three wickets including those of Liam Livingstone and Jitesh Sharma•AFP via Getty Images

Pace on, game on

As soon as KKR went back to pace for the last two overs, PBKS came back to life and took 36 runs to make it a total of 87 from just seven overs of pace. Shahrukh Khan scored 21 off 8, and Harpreet Brar 17 off 9.

Nathan Ellis gives PBKS early lead

A similar pattern of batters going after pace followed but Nathan Ellis, deservedly playing ahead of Kagiso Rabada, flummoxed Rahmanullah Gurbaz with his slower one. At 39 for 1 after five overs, with Venkatesh Iyer not allowed to bat at No. 3 at that moment because he had spent time off the field during the PBKS innings, KKR needed something special.

Rana attacks Livingstone

PBKS went to take pace off the ball, but Jason Roy and Nitish managed to hit Livingstone for a total of five boundaries in his two overs. It softened the blow of KKR losing Roy to Brar with the ball arriving too late for his slog-sweep. The equation had got tricky - 104 from 10 overs on a tricky surface - when Nitish took down Livingstone's second over, bringing KKR's task down to 88 from 54 balls.

Arshdeep Singh sinks to the ground after conceding a four off the final ball•BCCI

Chahar keeps PBKS in it

He might not be having the greatest season, but Rahul Chahar turned up for PBKS with the wickets of Iyer and Rana, earned through the slowing down of pace, which he himself carried out. At the fall of Rana's wicket, KKR needed 56 off 28, and it was down to Russell and Rinku.

The finishing touches

Chahar bowled out in the 16th over, leaving KKR 51 to get off 24, but PBKS had a question to answer: bowl four overs of pace or go to Brar's left-arm spin. They took the safe route. Ellis bowled out in the 17th, but went for 15 as Russell hit a four and Rinku a six. Ellis' figures of 4-0-29-1 almost made up for the absence of the extra spinner, but KKR were still ahead in the game.

With 26 required off two, though, Curran made a couple of errors in execution, and Russell climbed in with two sixes over the bigger boundary. For good measure he skimmed one over the short side too.

Arshdeep bowled a superb last over, denying Russell the big hit, and then running him out as he scrambled for a bye to tie the game off the fifth ball. Off the last ball, Arshdeep finally erred, and Rinku flicked the full-toss square of fine leg to get twice the requirement.

Match 54

Mumbai Indians 200 for 4 (Suryakumar 83, Wadhera 52*, Vyshak 2-37) beat Royal Challengers Bangalore 199 for 6 (Maxwell 68, du Plessis 65, Behrendorff 3-36) by six wickets

If ever you needed an example of a team walking home in a 200 chase without any stress, this was it. And in doing so, Mumbai Indians fired their IPL 2023 campaign into orbit as they made a stunning climb from No. 8 to No. 3 after razing Royal Challengers Bangalore in another six-fest at the Wankhede.

At the forefront of their march were Suryakumar Yadav and Nehal Wadhera, who put together 140 off just 64 balls in a sensational spell of on-demand boundary hitting that had seasoned bowlers such as Josh Hazlewood, Wanindu Hasaranga and Harshal Patel searching for answers.

From 101 needed off 60, Suryakumar's pyrotechnics that brought him his IPL best - a 35-ball 83 - brought the equation down to 8 off 26 when he walked off to a standing ovation. It was his fourth fifty-plus score in his last six outings, marking a sensational turnaround in fortunes after a cold first half.

Suryakumar's partner for much of that innings, Wadhera, made the most of his promotion up the order in Tilak Varma's absence due to a niggle. The ferocity of their partnership had a deflating effect on RCB, who now join a cluttered mid-table that has four teams on 10 points with a possibility of a fifth joining there on Wednesday night.

Behrendorff's powerplay act

Long before there was an inkling of what was to come, Jason Behrendorff set the stage alight at Wankhede by stinging his former team with the wickets of Virat Kohli and Anuj Rawat. Kohli was out giving him the charge off his fourth ball, nicking a heave that was overturned through DRS, while Rawat's top edge to an attempted scoop landed in Cameron Green's lap as he ran back from slip.

Prior to the double-strike, Behrendorff could've also had du Plessis first ball if Wadhera hadn't dropped him at midwicket. Du Plessis, though, made them pay along with Glenn Maxwell as the pair quickly offset RCB's early losses to fire them from 16 for 2 to 56 for 2 after six overs.

The Maxwell-Faf show

RCB's soft middle order has been a cause for concern all season, but Maxwell and du Plessis weren't going to die wondering. In fact, du Plessis took two fours off Chawla and continued the attack against Green. On the other side of the powerplay, Maxwell welcomed Chris Jordan - Jofra Archer's replacement in the XI - by pumping him for two sixes in his very first over to raise the half-century of the partnership off just 25 balls. As it turned out, it was just the start of the mayhem that was to follow.

Du Plessis was all muscle, backing away to swing cleanly if he wasn't lofting through the line on instinct. Maxwell was a mix of the inventive and the ridiculous, switch-hitting, slog-sweeping, scooping and reverse-ramping his way, treating the bowling with such disdain that you wondered if Mumbai were in for a target in the vicinity of 230. The pair had put on 120 off just 60 balls when Maxwell dragged one across the line to deep midwicket for a 33-ball 68.

Suryakumar Yadav celebrates after bringing up his half-century off 26 balls•BCCI

The RCB slowdown

RCB would lose Mahipal Lomror and du Plessis, for a 45-ball 61, in the next two overs to expose that brittle lower middle order. It's at this point that RCB decided to summon their Impact Player by bringing in Kedar Jadhav. It was now on him and Dinesh Karthik to give the finishing kick.

Karthik struggled for rhythm, but flicked a switch from 8 off 7, to slam Kumar Kartikeya's left-arm spin in the 18th over. But his dismissal with 11 balls left had RCB shortchanged. Akash Madhwal, the rookie seamer, delivered an excellent final over, only his second in the game, that went for six as RCB finished with 199; the last five had just brought them 48 runs.

The Kishan turbocharge

Five runs, four innings, two ducks.

Rohit Sharma shredded that with a ferocious flat-bat off Hazlewood first ball. Ishan Kishan followed Rohit's cue to take the attack to Mohammed Siraj, flicking and whipping his way to sixes. In trying to sustain his onslaught against spin, he was out to Hasaranga after hitting him for a four and six. Two balls later, Rohit was out lbw to a delivery he tried to nudge against the turn to one that didn't turn as much as he expected. Mumbai were up against it at 52 for 2 in five overs.

SKY takes over

Over the next five overs, Suryakumar and Wadhera kept up with the asking rate by playing risk-free cricket, before the flick was well and truly switched on. Hasaranga's return to deliver the 11th with Mumbai needing 101 more led to a torrent as both batters picked a six apiece.

Du Plessis now went back to Hazlewood to stifle the scoring, especially with Harshal Patel struggling for rhythm. But Suryakumar's grand hitting behind the V, where he used pace to takedown Hazlewood and Siraj for sixes behind square on either side, left everyone awestruck. He brought up his half-century off just 26 balls, and then raised the tempo even more by nonchalantly lofting a slot-ball from Siraj into the second tier down the ground.

By now, Suryakumar was seeing it like a football, so big that even a beamer aimed at his body was swatted away for six like it was child's play. His dismissal to Vyshak Vijaykumar in

a double-wicket over was somewhat of an anti-climax at the end, but by then the result was a foregone conclusion.

Wadhera fittingly finished it off with a lofted six over cover to bring up a second-straight fifty. By then, Mumbai had razed down the fastest 200 chase in IPL history - with 21 balls to spare - and the second-fastest overall.

Match 55

Chennai Super Kings 167 for 8 (Dube 25, Marsh 3-18) beat Delhi Capitals 140 for 8 (Rossouw 35, Pathirana 3-37, Chahar 2-28) by 27 runs

An all-round effort from Chennai Super Kings helped them trounce Delhi Capitals by 27 runs at Chepauk, helping the four-time champions get one step closer towards the IPL playoffs.

CSK's highest run-scorer was Shivam Dube with 25, but six batters entered the twenties, including MS Dhoni who made 20 in nine deliveries.

Dhoni's late hits lifted CSK to 167, and after that Deepak Chahar gave them the upper hand by removing both Capitals openers inside three overs.

Moeen Ali and Ravindra Jadeja then provided the squeeze after Capitals slid to 25 for 3, and in the back end it was Matheesha Pathirana providing the finishing touch that sealed an NRR-boosting win for the hosts.

CSK are now almost certain of a top-four finish with 15 points in 12 games, while another win in their next two matches should secure a top-two position. The Capitals can now reach 14 points at best, which realistically might not be enough this season.

Capitals fail to recover

Even though Chahar's early dismissals of David Warner and Phil Salt had rattled Capitals early, the visitors were hoping that Manish Pandey - returning to the XI - and Mitchell Marsh would dig them out of the difficult situation. But Pandey mistakenly ran for a single that wasn't there, then turned back, and left Marsh stranded outside his crease.

That forced Pandey and No. 5 Rilee Rossouw to start a recovery job, with the score reading 25 for 3, but the CSK spinners' stranglehold after the powerplay restricted them. Pandey made 27 in 29 while Rossouw scored 35 in 37, and while they were around, there was hope for a late blast to bring up the run-rate.

However, both fell in quick succession after struggling to up the tempo - Pandey lbw to Pathirana and Rossouw caught off Jadeja - and that sucked the momentum out of the chase. Axar Patel gave a brief glimmer of hope by racing to 20 in 11 balls, but his dismissal in the 18th over to Pathirana realistically ended Capitals' hopes.

A tidy 19th over from Tushar Deshpande left Capitals needing 43 off the final over. And even though Pathirana was hit by Lalit Yadav for a hat-trick of fours in the final over, the Sri Lankan Impact Player picked off a third scalp in the game's penultimate delivery to finish with 3 for 37.

"We threw our wickets at the top," Warner said after the game. "I don't think there was any good bowling to get us out, but that run-out put some pressure on us.

"Fifty-odd dot balls as well [55 dots] and you don't win many games where that happens. There were four overs where we failed to rotate the strike."

MS Dhoni, not for the first time this season, struck meaty blows towards the end • Associated Press

Dube injects energy into CSK's first innings

After Ishant Sharma was hit for 23 in his first two overs of the first innings, Warner moved to spin early and found success when Axar had Devon Conway dismissed early, followed by the wicket of Ruturaj Gaikwad for 24 just after the powerplay.

Lalit then held on to a stunning caught-and-bowled chance to get rid of Ajinkya Rahane for 21 and when Kuldeep Yadav dismissed Moeen for only 7, there was a risk that CSK would finish with an under-par total.

But Dube, also battling a finger injury from the Mumbai Indians game, walked in and thumped Lalit for a 23-run over with some help from Ambati Rayudu too. Their partnership of 36 in only 19 balls went against the run of play.

Even though Dube fell for 25, his runs at a strike-rate of 208.33 served as a reminder that poor deliveries still deserved to be dispatched. When he fell, CSK were 113 for 5 in 14.2 overs.

Dhoni provides the midas touch

Jadeja was slow off the blocks, but began CSK's charge in the 18th over by hitting Kuldeep for a six. Then Dhoni, who was struggling with his running, ruined Khaleel Ahmed's figures. Khaleel had an economy of four after three overs but erred against Dhoni by being predictable. Khaleel pushed deliveries across to Dhoni and he pounced on them by pulling him for six, then getting an edge for four before finishing the over with a straight six. That 21-run over in the 19th helped CSK touch 160, and even though Marsh took two wickets in a seven-run 20th over, the total of 167 proved too much on a sluggish Chepauk surface where batting first at the toss proved to be the right call.

"That's what my job is," Dhoni said about his nine-ball 20 after the game. "I told them this is what I'm supposed to do, don't make me run a lot. This is working, others are doing their job, and I'm happy to contribute. Accordingly, I am practicing as well.

"We frankly did not know what a good score was. When you get 160-170, you never know if it is enough."

Match 56

Rajasthan Royals 151 for 1 (Jaiswal 98*, Samson 48*) beat Kolkata Knight Riders 149 for 8 (Venkatesh 57, Chahal 4-25, Boult 2-15) by nine wickets

Rajasthan Royals reignited their IPL campaign in spectacular fashion, brushing aside the despondency of winning just one of their previous six games with a brutal takedown of Kolkata Knight Riders at Eden Gardens. Two of their big names stood up in big ways: Yuzvendra Chahal became the leading wicket-taker in IPL history while bagging his second successive four-wicket haul, and Yashasvi Jaiswal made a two-paced pitch look like a belter while scoring the IPL's fastest-ever fifty.

Having restricted KKR to 149 for 8 after choosing to bowl, Royals chased down their target in just 13.1 overs, lifting their net run rate from an already healthy 0.388 to 0.633, the second best in the league behind table-toppers Gujarat Titans. It should hold Royals in good stead if they get into an NRR battle for playoffs qualification. They are now third on the table with 12 points from 12 games, above Mumbai Indians who have the same points total with a game in hand.

Buttler fined 10% of his match fee

Rajasthan Royals' Jos Buttler was fined 10% of his match fee for breaching the IPL Code of Conduct. Buttler admitted to the Level 1 offence under Article 2.2, which covers the abuse of cricket equipment or clothing, ground equipment or fixtures and fittings during a match.

Royals' catching sets the tone

Trent Boult was back for Royals after missing their heartbreaking loss to Sunrisers Hyderabad, and he immediately made an impact with wickets in his first two overs. He usually takes early wickets by defeating top-order batters with new-ball swing - on this occasion he took them with some help from the fielders. Shimron Hetmyer sent Jason Roy back with a sprinting, jumping grab at deep square leg, while Sandeep Sharma ended Rahmanullah Gurbaz's stay at the crease with a diving catch to his right at mid-off.

Venkatesh's innings of two halves

On a pitch where the odd ball was stopping on the batter, Venkatesh Iyer and Nitish Rana made a ponderous start to their third-wicket partnership. The first 30 balls after Gurbaz's dismissal brought KKR just 30 runs, with just the one boundary, and Venkatesh endured a particularly difficult struggle while moving to 11 off 20 balls.

Related

Stats - All the records that Jaiswal broke during his 13-ball fifty

How Chahal rose to the top of IPL's all-time wickets chart

Chahal becomes the highest wicket-taker in the IPL

But he started finding the boundary regularly from that point. He hit R Ashwin - who had conceded just eight runs in his first two overs - for a pair of sixes in an 18-run ninth over, and then hit Chahal for two sixes and a four in the 13th over. He was eventually dismissed at the start of the 17th over, for 57 off 42 balls.

Chahal runs through KKR

Venkatesh's dismissal was a classic death-overs wicket from Chahal - a loopy delivery hung wide outside off stump after angling across the left-hander, inviting the big hit that was miscued to a fielder inside the circle.

Chahal had already gotten among the wickets before that, having Nitish caught at deep backward square leg in the 11th over to go past Dwayne Bravo and become the IPL's top wicket-taker.

Yuzvendra Chahal exults after removing Venkatesh Iyer • BCCI

There would be two more on the night: Shardul Thakur lbw while missing a sweep in a double-wicket 16th over, and Rinku Singh caught at long-off in a three-run 19th.

Jaiswal takes Nitish apart

If you bowl the first over for your team, Jaiswal is the last batter you want to bowl to. Coming into this game, Jaiswal had hit more fours (13) and more sixes (two) in the first over than any other batter in IPL 2023. It was interesting, then, that Nitish brought himself on to bowl the first over of Royals' chase.

Nitish is better than part-time, but he hasn't bowled regularly this season. He may have thought his offspin would match up nicely against Jaiswal's left-handedness, or he may have gambled on buying a wicket if either opener went after him too hard.

In the event, Jaiswal tore into Nitish, going 6, 6, 4, 4, 2, 4 in the second-most expensive first over in IPL history, falling one run short of the record of 27, set by Royal Challengers Bangalore - Chris Gayle, mostly - against Mumbai's Abu Nechim in Qualifier 2 in 2011.

Jaiswal shrugs off Buttler run-out in record-breaking display

A mix-up in the second over cost Jos Buttler his wicket, but that did nothing to slow Jaiswal down. He picked up a lucky four later in the over thanks to overthrows, and then hooked Harshit Rana for six. Then he went 4, 4, 4 off Shardul Thakur in the third over, driving and pulling and finding gaps as if there were no fielders on the 30-yard circle. Having thus moved to 49 off 12, Jaiswal tucked a single off his hip to bring up the IPL's fastest fifty, going one ball better than KL Rahul and Pat Cummins.

Jaiswal and Samson finish in a hurry

Jaiswal's masterful timing and placement suggested this pitch may have eased up, but Samson showed it still wasn't straightforward to bat on, moving to 21 off 21 balls at the other end while having a skied return catch dropped by Sunil Narine.

Then he joined the party with three clean, straight sixes off Anukul Roy in the 11th over, and the end was nigh. All that remained to see was whether Jaiswal could get to his hundred, and it was still possible when the 14th over began with Jaiswal on 94 and Royals three runs from victory. A six would do it, but Jaiswal was going to get the winning runs as quickly as he could, however they came. He shuffled across to a wide full-toss from Thakur, and swiped it behind square for four, to finish on 98 off 47.

Match 57

Mumbai Indians 218 for 5 (Suryakumar 103*, Rashid 4-30) beat Gujarat Titans 191 for 8 (Rashid 79*, Madhwal 3-31) by 27 runs

For a little while, it looked like Suryakumar Yadav would actually finish a T20 without playing that one shot that made people's jaws drop. And then he hit the most incredible six. It propelled him to his first IPL century and Mumbai Indians to a comfortable victory over the defending champions Gujarat Titans.

You know how Kane Williamson dabs to third man to get singles? Well, Suryakumar accessed the same area, except he cleared the boundary. He saw a ball on off stump. He knew he could get under it. At the point where he made contact, he opened the face, just as Williamson does, and then the strength in his forearms and his wrists did the rest.

This is Suryakumar. He sees T20 cricket the way nobody else sees it.

Rashid ends up a footnote

Titans came into this game knowing a win would not only secure a spot in the playoffs but give them two shots at making the final.

And they turned to their main man to make it happen. Rashid Khan produced four wickets for 30 runs in a format that continues to be hostile to his kind. Even today, Suryakumar spent 49 balls proving that bowlers and their plans exist just so batters could come in and rip them all to shreds.

But Rashid wouldn't buy that. He had Rohit Sharma caught at slip with a gorgeous legbreak. He upended Ishan Kishan by a simple change in length, the premeditated sweep shot failing against a ball that was too full for it. Titans saved the last six balls they had from Rashid for the match up against Tim David. Those are high stakes. It was the 17th over. This is the time David comes to life. Except he couldn't because Rashid took him out for 5 off 3.

Very few are capable of producing wickets on demand like this. Even fewer are able to do so when the opposition comes hard at them.

Hardik Pandya gave Suryakumar Yadav a hug after he brought up his hundred off the final ball•AFP/Getty Images

Suryakumar turns it on

When Mumbai lost their third wicket in the ninth over, they spent a little while scoring just a run a ball. 15 off 15. And then all of a sudden, they crashed 32 in 10.

It was during this time that Vishnu Vinod, the Kerala wicketkeeper making his Mumbai debut, carved Mohammed Shami for a scarcely believable six. A ball ending up on top of off stump scythed over point thanks to his fast hands and wicked wrists.

That would have been shot of the game if not for SKY doing SKY things.

He needed 32 balls to get to his fifty. That's slow by his standards, and he was building his innings with orthodox shots. The only luxury he afforded himself were those straight sixes, where his weight is usually on the back foot, right up to the point where he meets the ball, and then he hops, lifting both himself and the ball up off the ground. That's how he creates leverage. It's his own unique thing.

Then Rashid took David out and something snapped. Suryakumar was 53 off 34 at the start of the 18th over. He hit Mohit Sharma for three fours and a six to move to 73 off 40. Then he met Shami in the 19th over and played a front-foot drive for six over third man, just by opening the face of the bat. Finally, on 97, with only one ball left in the innings, he did what he has done to fast bowlers all over the world, sweeping Alzarri Joseph from way outside off into the crowd past the square leg boundary.

Rashid Khan smashed 10 sixes in his innings of 79 off 32 balls•BCCI

Rashid or bust for Titans

As good as Titans are in a chase, they were up against it very quickly when all of their top three batters fell for single digits. Shubman Gill, Hardik Pandya and Wriddhiman Saha totalled 12 runs between them.

Vijay Shankar kept hopes of the improbable alive with a sweet little cameo. But he fell to Piyush Chawla's first ball of the match, this IPL legend having the best season of his career at 34 years of age.

Way on the other end of the spectrum is Akash Madhwal. He came into the tournament because Mumbai were having so much trouble with their bowling attack. This was only his fourth game of the IPL and the 26th of his T20 career. And already he has shown an appetite for the tough job. Bowling at the death, bowling to big hitters, bowling with games on the line.

Madhwal has a lovely yorker. And now, it appears his other balls are just as deadly, because when he hits a hard length, they keep skidding through. He bowled Gill with one that stayed lower than the batter expected. And he had David Miller lbw in just the same way.

Rashid carried the Titans with the bat as well, making his highest score in T20s, 79 off 32 with 10 sixes. A total of 103 for 8 in 14 overs rose to 191 for 8 in 20. But it was not enough. Imagine going three-fourth of the way to a century after picking up one short of five wickets and still losing the game.

Match 58

Lucknow Super Giants 185 for 3 (Mankad 64*, Pooran 44*) beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 182 for 6 (Klaasen 47, Krunal 2-24) by seven wickets

Lucknow Super Giants resurrected their flailing campaign with their first win in four matches and pushed Sunrisers Hyderabad to the brink of elimination. With five overs to go and 69 runs to get on a slow pitch, it was Super Giants who were staring at a possible defeat, but Nicholas Pooran and Marcus Stoinis took 31 off the 16th, bowled by part-time left-arm spinner Abhishek Sharma, turning the game completely on its head. Pooran stayed unbeaten on 44 off 13.

Krunal Pandya showed how tough a pitch it was with successive wickets of Aiden Markram and Glenn Phillips with sharp turn at high pace, but there was one difference: there was bounce in the pitch to work with. Ravi Bishnoi and Amit Mishra made errors and went for 63 in their six. Sunrisers' Mayank Markande went for 39 in his three, which perhaps made Markram go to Abhishek for that fateful 16th over.

The win took Super Giants to 13 points from 12 matches, back in the top four, and Sunrisers only have a mathematical chance left with just 8 points from 11 matches.

Sunrisers start well

They are not quite used to it but Sunrisers didn't get off to a disastrous start even though they didn't have big stands. Yudhvir Singh bowled with fire and got rid of Abhishek early, but Anmolpreet Singh and Rahul Tripathi kept hitting. They took two boundaries each off Avesh Khan's first over, the fifth; even though Yash Thakur bounced Tripathi out, Sunrisers got 56 off 2 in the powerplay.

On a surface with some turn, Bishnoi and Mishra frequently overpitched or went too short. Klaasen and Markram tucked into it, reaching 115 for 3 in 12 overs.

The Krunal Pandya over

Then suddenly, Pandya showed what the pitch was capable of. He extracted big turn even at his pace to get Markram and Glenn Phillips in successive deliveries. Markram was stumped when defending on the front foot as the ball turned from leg and dragged him out. Phillips

went back to a similar delivery, and was bowled. Pandya now bowled three overs for 13 runs and two wickets, knocking the wind out of Sunrisers' sails.

Two short balls - duly deposited by Klaasen - and Avesh missing his yorkers in the 19th over helped, but 182 was underwhelming after that start.

Klaasen fined, Mishra reprimanded

SRH wicketkeeper Klaasen was fined 10% of his match fee for a level 1 offence that deals with the "public criticism/inappropriate comment." Klaasen was talking to the on-field umpire after a no-ball call from the TV umpire that did not go Sunrisers' way, and later told broadcasters that the umpiring was "not great."

In a separate incident, Amit Mishra admitted to a level 1 offence under Article 2.2 of IPL's Code of Conduct which states abuse of equipment during the match. He had thrown the ball into the ground after dismissing Anmolpreet Singh.

Sunrisers control start of chase

It didn't quite look underwhelming the way Sunrisers began their bowling. Bhuvneshwar Kumar and Fazalhaq Farooqi gave Kyle Mayers and Quinton de Kock absolutely nothing. Phillips benefited from those dry overs as Mayers hit him straight to mid-on.

Prerak Mankad and de Kock struggled to get going as Sunrisers kept using changes of pace. The one bowler that provided some relief was Markande as de Kock hit him for a six and a four at the end of seventh over. He targeted Markande again in the ninth, but a reverse-sweep got him out.

Mankad and Stoinis too got stuck, adding just 34 off the first 28 balls they faced. It was a typical slow Stoinis start, but the youngster Mankad - 36 off 29 at that point - looked under more pressure.

1:16

Muzumdar: Impact Player rule has given players like Mankad an opportunity

Time-out followed by knockout

This is when Gautam Gambhir and Andy Flower had an animated chat with the two batters during the time-out. With eight wickets in hand, they still needed 94 off seven. Mankad jumped out of the crease first ball after the Time Out, and a hit a six. It helped that the bowler was Markande, who still had one over left after this.

That attack on Markande also perhaps necessitated the early return of Bhuvneshwar, but even he went for a six in the 15th over. Markram now had two overs from Natarajan and one each from Bhuvneshwar and Farooqi. They were all bowling superbly. To get that final over in, Markram went to the left-arm spinner presumably because of the two right-hand batters at the wicket.

To be fair to Sunrisers, Abhishek had already bowled two overs for just 11 runs. So perhaps it was the right time to sneak one over in. However, instead of sneaking in quietly, Abhishek announced himself with a change-up first ball: an arm ball gone horribly wrong, and Stoinis hit the full toss for a giant six. Then Abhishek went over the wicket. Wide. Back around. Overpitched, and an even bigger six.

When Abhishek had Stoinis caught third ball, it actually turned out to be bad news for him. Out came a left-hand batter. Not just any left-hand batter but a spin hitter who can go from ball one. And go from ball one Pooran did. Massive slog sweep followed by a straight six followed by another slog sweep. Pooran was 18 off 3, Super Giants needed 38 off 24, and despite the best efforts of Natarajan, it was a walk after that.

Match 59

Punjab Kings 167 for 7 (Prabhsimran 103, Ishant 2-27) beat Delhi Capitals 136 for 8 (Warner 54, Harpreet 4-30, Chahar 2-16) by 31 runs

A special century from Prabhsimran Singh knocked Delhi Capitals out of IPL 2023 and pushed Punjab Kings up to sixth place, well within reach of a playoff spot.

In demanding batting conditions, the Punjab opener, who had begun the season with a highest IPL score of 16, found ways not just to survive but to keep scoring quick runs in a way nobody else managed to. It felt like a coming-of-age innings.

How it started

When there is pace in the pitch, it's easy to hit through the line and keep scoring runs steadily. When it is not there, it's hard to even get the ball off the square. So you get your runs in fits and spurts.

Kings suffered 22 balls for no runs in the powerplay, but hit seven others for 32 runs (5x4 and 2x6).

A lot of this work was the result of Prabhsimran's enterprise. His role in the team is to do whatever is necessary to maximise the field restrictions. And he performed admirably, switch-hitting spin for sixes and moving around all over the batting crease, just to throw the bowlers off their plans.

But then his role changed. From being the guy who could not place any price on his wicket, he became the guy who simply could not get out. So he settled in. Got used to the pitch. And by around the 11th over or so, he was finding ways to hold his shape and exert complete control over his shots.

Prabhsimran was 53 off 44. Then he was dropped on 68. Then he was 102 off 61.

Prabhsimran Singh soaks in the applause as he walks back after his ton • BCCI

That's 49 in 17 balls. On a pitch where none of his team-mates crossed 20, and only two others managed to score at better than run-a-ball. This was a spectacular display of perseverance, even if he did have a tiny bit of help.

In conditions where the ball isn't coming onto the bat, all you have to do is take pace off, hit a hard length and, most importantly, target the stumps. Do not let the batter free his arms.

Prabhsimran though was basically invited to free his arms. According to ESPNcricinfo's data, a majority of the balls he faced (33) were either outside off stump or worse, wide outside off stump. And he took 60 runs from them including seven fours and three sixes.

Capitals should have known better. The chance they created - the catch that Rilee Roussouw dropped - was the result of a mis-hit to a ball that arrived in line with this body. They didn't learn. And they were punished.

How it ended

Capitals had a great start to the chase. They came out knowing 168 was a tricky target, and that they had to knock off a significant portion of it within the powerplay. David Warner helped them accomplish that goal, taking them to 65 for 0 in six overs. He cruised to a 23-ball fifty, scoring 42 of those runs in boundaries. But the thing is, Capitals only faced six balls of spin in that period.

It didn't make sense why Kings would have let any of that happen on a pitch where the ball was both stopping on the batters and turning more than a fair bit.

Eventually, Shikhar Dhawan turned to spin and the game changed.

Cornered by Harpreet Brar (4 for 30) and Rahul Chahar (2 for 16), Capitals lost three wickets for two runs between the ninth and the 11th overs. ESPNcricinfo's forecaster quantified this swing in momentum - in a mere eight balls, Kings went from a lowly 20% chance of winning this game to 78% favourites.

By the end, Capitals needed seven players to combine just to reach the total they allowed one batter to get. These were not the conditions to give away a century.

Match 60

Royal Challengers Bangalore 171 for 5 (Du Plessis 55, Maxwell 54, Zampa 2-25)
beat Rajasthan Royals 59 (Hetmyer, Parnell 3-10, Bracewell 2-16, Karn 2-19) by 112 runs

With their campaign on the line in Jaipur, Royal Challengers Bangalore ambushed Rajasthan Royals, smashing them by 112 runs to stay in the race for the playoffs. It was their largest margin of victory away from home and it did wonders for their net run rate: RCB are now in fifth place with 12 points and two games to go.

Glenn Maxwell blasted a 30-ball half-century on a tough pitch, while Faf du Plessis and Anuj Rawat played contrasting support acts. Yet the biggest contributor to RCB's win was their

bowling, and the five wickets they took in the powerplay set up the Royals' decimation for 59 - the third lowest total in the IPL.

Wayne Parnell was in top form, picking up three of those wickets: Jos Buttler, Sanju Samson and Joe Root. He wouldn't have played had Josh Hazlewood been fit, and his spell of 3-0-10-3 won him the Player of the Match award.

While RCB can get to 16 points, the Royals can now only reach 14 if they win their final game, and their playoff hopes are extremely slim.

RCB's steady powerplay

Royals trusted their match-ups in the powerplay.

Virat Kohli v Sandeep Sharma: seven dismissals, the most he's got out to any bowler in T20s.

Kohli v legspin: strike rate of 110. So it wasn't a surprise to see three overs in the powerplay bowled by Adam Zampa and Yuzvendra Chahal.

RCB hit only four boundaries in the first six overs, but Faf du Plessis and Kohli ensured they didn't lose a wicket on a tricky pitch, scoring 42. Kohli was eventually caught off a knuckleball from KM Asif, for 18 off 19 balls.

Glenn Maxwell scored a fifty off just 29 balls on a tough pitch • BCCI

Du Plessis drops anchor; Maxwell flies

Maxwell walked in at No. 3 and thumped his third ball, off R Ashwin, for a near 100-metre hit down the ground. In the next over, Chahal tried to bowl away from his hitting arc as Maxwell tried to outfox him by employing the reverse sweep. After two failed attempts, Chahal perhaps played on Maxwell's ego by dangling the carrot for a third. Maxwell used the depth of his crease to slap a fierce cut to the boundary. This injection of momentum allowed du Plessis to drop anchor.

After a lull - RCB didn't score a boundary from overs 9.2 to 12.3 - Maxwell tore into Sandeep. The first of two boundaries was a reverse ramp over the wicketkeeper and the second was slashed over point. Maxwell then raised the tempo further by blasting Chahal into the stands to bring up a 30-ball half-century. And when Chahal went wide, Maxwell went wider to shovel one over the shorter leg-side boundary. The platform had been set.

RCB stumble after du Plessis falls

RCB lost three wickets in six deliveries beginning with du Plessis in the 15th over, with Zampa taking out Mahipal Lomror and Dinesh Karthik in the same over. That meant that Maxwell had to delay the charge at the death, and when he eventually went after Sandeep, he was bowled trying to reverse sweep a yorker. At 137 for 5 in the 18th over, RCB were in danger of finishing poorly.

Wayne Parnell picked up three wickets in the powerplay to derail the Royals•BCCI

Rawat comes to RCB's rescue

Anuj Rawat gave RCB the finishing kick in the final over by taking down KM Asif. Standing deep inside the crease to convert yorkers into half-volleys, he muscled two sixes and a four to end with 29 off 11 balls. RCB finished with 171, which was above par on a tough batting surface.

Parnell's powerplay punch

Fastest IPL fifty two nights ago. Two-ball duck today. Yashasvi Jaiswal drilled Mohammed Siraj to Kohli at mid-off to trigger a stunning collapse. Parnell was playing his first game since April 20 and he made the most of it, dismissing Buttler, Samson and Root inside the powerplay. Buttler was also out for a duck, slapping one straight to point; Samson was cramped for room and top-edged a pull; and Root was lbw playing all around a full delivery.

Bracewell, Karn complete the rout

A niggler to Wanindu Hasaranga meant Karn Sharma got a game, but he was taken for three back-to-back sixes by Shimron Hetmyer. Ashwin was then run out by a nifty flick between the legs from the wicketkeeper Rawat, and Hetmyer holed out to long on for 35 off 19 balls. Bracewell returned to pick up his second wicket - Dhruv Jurel - and Karn made a strong comeback by taking the final two wickets to close out the game in the 11th over of the chase

Match 61

Kolkata Knight Riders 147 for 4 (Rana 57*, Rinku 54, Chahar 3-27) beat Chennai Super Kings 144 for 6 (Dube 48*, Conway 30, Narine 2-15, Varun 2-36) by six wickets

Kolkata Knight Riders tripped Chennai Super Kings in their last home game of the league season, out-spinning them and out-batting them on a tricky Chepauk pitch to stay in contention for the playoffs. CSK would have become the first team to seal a playoffs spot if they had won; they're still in a good position to go through, but this defeat may have hurt their chances of a top-two finish.

KKR's mystery spinners played a massive role in restricting CSK to 144 for 6, with Varun Chakravarthy continuing his excellent season and Sunil Narine returning to wicket-taking ways after taking just one in his last eight games. KKR were always favourites from there, particularly with dew setting in, but they kept the contest interesting by losing three wickets within the powerplay before Rinku Singh and Nitish Rana put them back on top with a 99-run stand for the fourth wicket.

KKR fined for slow over-rate

Nitish Rana and his team-mates have been penalised for KKR's slow over-rate in the Sunday night game against CSK. Since it was KKR's second such offence this season, Rana was fined

Rs 24 lakh and the others in the playing group Rs 6 lakh or 25% of their match fee, whichever is lesser.

KKR eventually won with nine balls to spare. They may have hoped for a more comprehensive win, but Rinku and Rana had little choice but to put NRR considerations on the back burner after KKR lost three early wickets.

Varun, Narine dominate after Dhoni chooses to bat

Interviewed at the end of the game, MS Dhoni said CSK would have needed 180 to have any chance of defending a total once dew set in, but there was no way they could have scored 180 in the conditions that prevailed through the first innings.

It was, of course, Dhoni's decision to bat first. Their innings began promisingly enough, with the first two wickets putting on 31 and 30 respectively. Varun ended both partnerships, with his carrom ball turning significantly both times to have Ruturaj Gaikwad and Ajinkya Rahane caught off miscues.

Rahane's wicket sparked a collapse, as CSK slumped from 61 for 1 to 72 for 5, with Shardul Thakur dismissing a scratchy Devon Conway for 30 off 28 balls before Narine struck twice in the 11th over to send back Ambati Rayudu and Moeen Ali.

Dube repairs CSK innings from one end

With the odd ball stopping on the batter or turning sharply, or both, and with not a lot of batting to come, Shivam Dube and Ravindra Jadeja cut out risk-taking and looked to take the innings deep. But while Dube still found the boundary every now and then, Jadeja stagnated; he hit just the one six and no fours while scoring 20 off 24 balls.

Dube, though, ensured CSK passed 140, hitting Suyash Sharma for two sixes, and clearing his front leg to clatter Varun for another in the 18th over. He found a way to score even when Varun bowled his typically strangulating lengths, working the ball between long-on and deep midwicket for a pair of doubles in that 18th over.

Deepak Chahar picked up three wickets in the powerplay•BCCI

Chahar picks up an unusual three-for

At the innings break, it felt as if the result would hinge on how KKR dealt with CSK's spinners. As things happened, though, the powerplay was all-pace, with Deepak Chahar from one end and Tushar Deshpande from the other. Chahar struck in each of his overs, but this was no vintage display of swing bowling: the wickets, instead, came off catches to deep point, short third and short third.

Rinku and Rana bat CSK out of the game

By the time the powerplay was done, Rana and Rinku had already showed signs of rhythm. Rana had whipped Chahar off his hip for six in the fifth over, and Rinku had hit Deshpande for a straight six to end the sixth over.

Spin came on immediately, with Dhoni bringing on his two offspinners against the two left-handers. They began well, conceding just seven runs across the seventh and eighth overs, before Rinku relieved the pressure with a pair of fours off Moeen Ali in the ninth.

Moeen continued to go for runs thereafter, with Rana hitting him for three fours across his third and fourth overs - a reverse-sweep and two inside-out drives. In all, he took 34 off 22 balls against the offspin pair of Moeen and Maheesh Theekshana. It was a demonstration of a well-known fact, that Rana is among the best left-hand batters against offspin in the IPL.

ESPNcricinfo Ltd

Rinku usually prefers pace onto the bat, but on this day he was excellent against the spinners too, and made sure that he dominated his favourable match-up, hitting Jadeja for two sixes.

It didn't help Super Kings that they put down the one chance they got to break this partnership when it could have still mattered, with Matheesha Pathirana putting Rana down at deep backward square leg when he miscued a sweep off Moeen in the 11th over. Rana was on 18 at that point.

Both batters went on to bring up their fifties before Rinku was run out in the 18th over, attempting to take a tight single that would have brought up the century stand. By then, the contest was all but over, with KKR needing just 13 from 17 balls.

Match 62

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Deepak Chahar picked up three wickets in the powerplay•BCCI

Chahar picks up an unusual three-for

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ESPNcricinfo Ltd

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Match 63

Lucknow Super Giants 177 for 3 (Stoinis 89*, Krunal 49*, Behrendorff 2-30) beat Mumbai Indians 172 for 5 (Kishan 59, Bishnoi 2-26) by 5 runs

Mohsin Khan missed the first half of IPL 2023 with a shoulder injury. In fact, Lucknow Super Giants' head coach Andy Flower had "written him off" for the season. Still, LSG didn't release him and bring in a replacement player.

On Tuesday night, Mohsin repaid that trust. Chasing 178 at the Ekana Cricket Stadium, Mumbai Indians needed 11 from the final over with Tim David and Cameron Green in the middle. Mohsin, though, denied Mumbai's big-hitters. Bowling a mix of hard lengths and wide yorkers, he conceded only five to take LSG closer to the playoffs.

Earlier, Marcus Stoinis scored an unbeaten 89 off 47 balls - his highest IPL score - to lift LSG to a competitive total on what looked like a difficult pitch to bat on. After being sent in, LSG lost three early wickets, but Stoinis and Krunal Pandya revived the innings before Stoinis went berserk at the death. He smashed 44 off his last 12 deliveries.

Ishan Kishan and Rohit Sharma started the chase at a rapid pace, adding 90 in 9.4 overs, but Ravi Bishnoi dismissed both to give LSG an opening. With Suryakumar Yadav getting out cheaply - scooping one onto his stumps - and Nehal Wadhwa struggling, the home team were suddenly favourites.

Mumbai needed 30 from the last two overs. David hit Naveen-ul-Haq for two sixes to reduce it to 11 from six balls, but Mohsin's excellent over sealed a crucial win for LSG.

Marcus Stoinis made his highest score in the IPL•AFP/Getty Images

Behrendorff gives MI early wickets

With LSG bringing in Naveen for Kyle Mayers, it was Deepak Hooda who opened the innings with Quinton de Kock. But the move didn't work. After being dropped off Chris Jordan in the second over of the innings, Hooda charged Jason Behrendorff in the next over. It turned out to be a slower one and Hooda mis-timed it to David at mid-on. Prerak Mankad then bagged a first-ball duck, edging Behrendorff to Kishan.

De Kock and Krunal took the side to 35 for 2 at the end of the powerplay, before Piyush Chawla had de Kock caught behind off a googly. It was the fourth time this IPL that Chawla had picked up a wicket with his first ball of the match.

Stoinis and Krunal revive LSG

Stoinis and Krunal then took control of the innings. The pair used the dimensions of the ground to their advantage: Stoinis targeted the short boundary, and Krunal placed the ball in long pockets to pick up ones and twos. The pair took the side to 100 in 14 overs. But by then, Krunal was feeling discomfort in his leg; he eventually retired hurt for 49 off 42 balls.

Stoinis in Hulk mode

Stoinis was on 45 off 35 balls at the end of the 17th over. After that, he went on a rampage. He hit Jordan for three fours and two sixes to take 24 runs off the 18th over. Behrendorff was next in the firing line. Stoinis hit back-to-back sixes off his slower balls before wrapping up the innings with yet another maximum, off Akash Madhwal.

With Mumbai needing 11, Mohsin Khan conceded only five in the final over•BCCI

Kishan, Rohit give Mumbai a great start

At halftime, Stoinis said the pitch was not easy to bat on, but if you gave yourself some time, it got much easier. Kishan didn't need any sighters, though. He hit three fours and a six in his first 12 balls. Rohit faced just four balls in the first three overs. In the next three, he smashed three sixes to power Mumbai to 58 for no loss. It was the highest powerplay total of the season in Lucknow.

LSG fight back

It started with Bishnoi breaking the opening stand by dismissing Rohit, and then removing Kishan in his next over. Mumbai were still ahead in the game, but a couple of quiet overs pushed the required rate above ten.

With 63 needed from six overs, Suryakumar fell to Yash Thakur. Two overs later, Nehal Wadhera's laboured innings - 16 off 20 balls - came to an end when he pulled Mohsin to deep-backward square leg. Vishnu Vinod didn't last long either, leaving David and Green to get 33 from 14 balls. David put Mumbai ahead once again with a 19-run penultimate over, only to be denied by Mohsin in the end.

Match 64

Delhi Capitals 213 for 2 (Rossouw 82*, Shaw 54, Curran 2-36) beat Punjab Kings 198 for 8 (Livingstone 94, Taide 55, Nortje 2-36, Ishant 2-36) by 15 runs

A dazzling display of boundary hitting all around the ground from Rilee Rossouw in his unbeaten 82 off 37, combined with useful contributions from the other Delhi Capitals top-four batters, handed Punjab Kings a 15-run defeat and severely dented their playoff chances.

Kings got close to the finish line in the end, thanks to a belligerent 94 off 48 from Liam Livingstone, but he fought a lone battle. The loss kept Kings on the eighth spot with 12 points. They now depend on many other results going their way to stay alive in the playoffs race because they have only one match to go, and three teams are already above 14 points, which is the most Kings can get to.

Kings were mostly behind the asking rate right from the start because their only other batter who scored over 25 was Atharva Taide, who struggled for fluency and retired out on 55 off 42 balls. Livingstone's pursuit of boundaries in the end kept Kings' slim hopes alive, whether they needed 79 off 24 or 38 off 12. In the last over too, when they needed 23 from the last three balls, they got a lifeline when Ishant Sharma sent down a no-ball which Livingstone sent for six, making it 16 required from three with a free hit coming. But Livingstone failed to connect with the subsequent full toss and holed out to long-off on the last ball.

Warner, Shaw flick the switch on

In the first IPL game in Dharamsala in ten years, David Warner and Prithvi Shaw saw out the first 16 balls for no boundaries before racing away. Warner broke the shackles with consecutive fours off Sam Curran before pulling Kagiso Rabada for two sixes. Shaw too got going when he saw Arshdeep Singh's short balls didn't have much pace. He pulled and glanced him for 4, 4 and 6 in a 16-run over. When Warner also put away Nathan Ellis' slower balls for fours, Capitals ended the powerplay on 61 and soon brought up their highest opening stand of this IPL.

Prithvi Shaw and David Warner got going gradually in the powerplay•BCCI

Rossouw's fifty takes it up a notch

Rahul Chahar wasn't having a good day. Soon after he was put away for three fours in his first two overs by Shaw, he dropped a tough chance to give Warner a life on 39. Warner continued to attack because Capitals had all ten wickets in hand at the halfway mark. But when he skied one more, Shikhar Dhawan completed a spectacular catch at mid-off to remove him for 46 off 31.

Capitals kept the left-right combination by sending out Rossouw at No. 3, and he attacked literally from ball one. That he pulled his first ball for four and drove his third for four more showed how good the pitch was for batting. The range he showed in the 13th over off Rabada epitomised his innings; a length ball hit straight for six, another length ball placed just wide of short third for four, and yet another length ball dispatched over square leg with a lovely pick-up shot for six in a 17-run over. Not long after Rossouw also punished Chahar and Curran for sixes, Shaw holed out for 54 in the 15th over.

Kings trust Brar for death overs

Rossouw had raced away to 45 off 21, and Capitals to 148, with five overs to go when Dhawan bravely brought on Harpreet Brar, who gave away just 14 runs in the 16th and 18th overs combined, before Phil Salt and Rossouw made up for it in the last two. Salt smoked Ellis for two sixes over long-on while also edging one delivery for four.

For the final over, Dhawan once again trusted Brar instead of the designated death bowler Arshdeep, who had been expensive in his first two. Rossouw mercilessly muscled Brar, who also gifted two wides, for two sixes and a four on the leg side. A misfield on the last ball from Rabada at fine leg gave Capitals their first 200-plus total of the season.

Liam Livingstone fought a lone battle•Associated Press

Kings also start slow

The Capitals quicks hardly gave any freebies early on. Khaleel Ahmed started with a maiden to Prabhsimran Singh, Ishant had Dhawan caught at slip for a duck, and Khaleel nearly bowled another maiden to keep Kings on 10 for 1 after three. Prabhsimran then hit the pedal with three consecutive fours before Taide also collected boundaries to get out of the hole of 1 off eight balls. Prabhsimran and Taide also enjoyed a fair share of luck. Their leading edges fell safe, and Capitals missed a few direct hits. Taide's edges even fetched him some boundaries. Kings finished the powerplay on 47 for 1, with the asking rate almost 12 an over.

Livingstone stands tall but alone

As soon as Prabhsimran holed out to long-on off Axar Patel, it was all a Livingstone show. It started with Livingstone getting a life on 3 off Kuldeep Yadav when Anrich Nortje put him down at deep midwicket, and Taide too got dropped off Kuldeep in his next over. Taide, however, could not score freely as he struggled to find the gaps or go over the fielders.

Livingstone, meanwhile, made use of his big bat swings for plenty of hits in the 'V' down the ground when the bowlers missed their lengths even marginally. He hit a boundary nearly every over and was only beaten by Kuldeep a couple of times. In the 15th over, he dispatched two full tosses from Mukesh Kumar for fours but Taide was labouring at the other end and he retired out when Kings needed a stiff 86 from 30 with their hitters Jitesh Sharma, Shahrukh Khan and Curran yet to come.

Despite the firepower in the dugout, the heavy lifting was left for Livingstone. Jitesh holed out to long leg for a duck in the 16th and Shahrukh found long-on in the 17th. Meanwhile, Livingstone blasted two sixes and a four off Khaleel, and three sixes came off Mukesh in the 18th to make it 38 required from 12. Nortje then rattled Curran's leg stump with a yorker and when 33 were left from the last six balls, Ishant started with a dot to all but seal it. His no-ball was thwarted for six, but he finished the game with three dots and send Kings' hopes crashing.

Match 65

Royal Challengers Bangalore 187 for 2 (Kohli 100, du Plessis 71) beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 186 for 5 (Klaasen 104, Bracewell 2-13) by eight wickets

A stunning chase from Virat Kohli and Faf du Plessis significantly strengthened Royal Challengers Bangalore's hopes of making it to the playoffs despite one of the great T20 hundreds by Heinrich Klaasen to set up a target of 187. Kohli scored his sixth IPL hundred, making it the first IPL match with hundreds from either side. When Kohli left, RCB needed just 15 from 13 balls, which they got with relative ease with four balls to spare.

RCB momentarily reached the top four with 14 points to their name, level with Mumbai Indians. Both sides have a game left but RCB have the better net run rate. It might well come down to these two teams' final matches on the final day of the league stages.

Virat Kohli celebrates his century•BCCI

SRH's top-order woes continue

Asked to bat first on what began as a slowish surface, the new SRH opening combination of Abhishek Sharma and Rahul Tripathi struggled to get bat on ball. In the first three overs they scored just 11 runs. And just after Tripathi began going with a four and a six in the fourth over, they both gifted their wickets to Michael Bracewell. Abhishek cut a short and wide loosener straight to cover point, and Tripathi lapped him to short fine leg.

Klaasen checks in

It might be rude to say so but the early strikes were a blessing in disguise for SRH. They brought out their best batter to bat early. And to the first ball he faced, Klaasen showed why he is their best. This offbreak from Bracewell turned appreciably, ending at the top of the leg stump, but Klaasen went back and punched it past extra cover for four.

Klaasen's ability to hit off the back foot anything marginally short of a length or slow in the air forced the spinners every now and then to overpitch. Whenever they did overpitch, Klaasen was quick to come forward and launch them down the ground. The ease with which Klaasen hit spin - he eventually scored 70 off 29 against them, with five fours and five sixes - forced RCB to bring back the quicks sooner than they would have liked to.

Mohammed Siraj and Wayne Parnell bowled economical overs, but Klaasen got the better of Harshal Patel. It left RCB needing to bowl an over of spin at the death, which is when Klaasen hit Shahbaz Ahmed for successive sixes.

Heinrich Klaasen punished the RCB spinners for 70 off 29 balls•BCCI

Parnell, Siraj finish off well

Even when Klaasen was going great, he didn't get much support from the other end. Parnell and Siraj bowled overs 18 and 20 for seven and four runs respectively to keep SRH down to 186. Klaasen scored 104 off 51, the other batters 76 off 69. This was a special innings with a control percentage of 97.1 and a strike-rate of 204. Only AB de Villiers has ever scored a better-controlled hundred at a strike rate of 175 or above in the IPL.

The Kohli-du Plessis show

This match was taking place in Hyderabad, but you wouldn't have known it from the Aar See Bee chants. It took the significant RCB-supporting section of the crowd just one ball to come back to life after Klaasen had lowered their volume. Kohli drove at an outswinger from Bhuvneshwar Kumar, and got four for it. The next ball he drove off the back foot and over cover-point. The roof came off.

An experimental attack made up mainly of medium-pace and one full-time spinner was under the pump right away. SRH went for Abhishek Sharma's part-time left-arm spin with the new ball, and Kohli rightly pre-empted arm balls, made room, and hit him for fours too. It was apparent that RCB, who love to bat first, had made the right call at the toss as the grip in the surface had come down from the first innings.

Faf du Plessis pulls one away•BCCI

SRH make errors

There were two moments of luck for du Plessis. First Kartik Tyagi drew a top edge from him in the fourth over, and Glenn Phillips, of all fielders, dropped him at deep square leg. Then, even after a lot of damage had been done, Mayank Dagar took a screamer diving to his right at deep midwicket off debutant Nitish Reddy, but because there was a dismissal involved, the umpires could check the height of this bouncer on replay. By a few centimetres, it was the second bouncer of the over, and instead of celebrating his maiden IPL wicket, Reddy was now bowling a free-hit.

Intent on during the middle overs

This was a chase, net run rate was important, the pitch had quickened up, the SRH attack wasn't flash, but it was still a sight for sore eyes seeing Kohli not drop his intent in the middle overs. He was 29 off 19 at the end of the powerplay, and he scored 26 off the next 19 he faced.

Time and again, du Plessis stood and admired Kohli's shots in awe. And when the spinners did manage a quiet three-over period of 18 runs, Kohli broke the spell with a slog-sweep against the turn of a left-arm spinner.

Landmarks arrived as matters of fact. Well before the 171-run stand ended, Kohli and du Plessis had had brought up the most prolific single IPL for an opening pair. Du Plessis went past 50 for the eighth time this IPL, the last three of them on the trot. Kohli went past 50 for the seventh time. The successful chase was only the third time RCB had won chasing 185 or more in the IPL, out of 36 times of asking. In less than two seasons, Gujarat Titans have done it the same number of times.

Match 66

Rajasthan Royals 189 for 6 (Padikkal 51, Jaiswal 50, Hetmyer 46, Rabada 2-40) beat Punjab Kings 187 for 5 (Curran 49*, Jitesh 44, Saini 3-40) by four wickets

It got quite nervy in the end, but Rajasthan Royals finished on the right side of the result in Dharamsala, beating and eliminating Punjab Kings in a four-wicket win while also keeping their outside playoff chance alive.

While Dhruv Jurel hit a six on the fourth ball of the 20th over to seal the win, Royals' victory was set up by their left-hand batting trio of Yashasvi Jaiswal (51), Devdutt Padikkal (50), and Shimron Hetmyer (44).

Jaiswal and Padikkal dragged Royals out of a sticky position - with Jos Buttler and Sanju Samson failing - while Hetmyer ensured the run rate did not go out of hand at the back end.

Related

Amid constant chopping and changing, Punjab Kings invest heavily in the future

Bowlers a letdown as Punjab Kings miss out on playoffs yet again

Scenarios: Royals keep playoff hopes alive; CSK and LSG eye top-two finish

Kings had a realistic chance of victory after Jitesh Sharma, Sam Curran and Shahrukh Khan overcame a top-order batting collapse to take them to 187. They came into the game needing a mammoth win to boost their net run rate, and even though they knew that wouldn't happen midway through the chase, they fought till the very end to make Royals squirm.

Royals now set their eyes on Sunday's action. To qualify, they need Mumbai Indians to lose to Sunrisers Hyderabad and also for Royal Challengers Bangalore to lose by at least six runs to Gujarat Titans in the league stage's last fixture.

Navdeep Saini, playing just his second game this season, picked up a couple of early wickets•AFP/Getty Images

Kings' disappointing start

Shikhar Dhawan said at the toss that the Kings didn't mind batting first in Dharamsala, but their top order was blown away early, leaving them reeling at 50 for 4 in 6.3 overs.

It began with Trent Boult picking his seventh first-over wicket with a caught-and-bowled of Prabhsimran Singh, followed by Atharva Taide falling victim to a Navdeep Saini short ball.

Adam Zampa then closed out the powerplay with the wicket of Dhawan lbw sweeping and Saini, added a second when he rattled Liam Livingstone's stumps with the batter swinging wildly across the line.

That the Kings batters kept going for their shots despite losing wickets was understandable. For them to have any outside chance of qualifying for the playoffs, they had to go hard in the powerplay in pursuit of a big total. On this occasion, though, they didn't succeed.

Sam Curran and Shahrukh Khan added 73 runs in 6.1 overs•Associated Press

A middle-order resurrection

Then came the rebuild, kickstarted by Jitesh Sharma and Sam Curran. Together, they hit only two fours and two sixes by the time they put up a fifty-run stand. At the time, their partnership run rate of 7.69 did not do justice to the good batting conditions, but they were forced to play in that manner because of Zampa and Yuzvendra Chahal's tidy spells.

All that appeared to change, though, as Jitesh tore into the 14th over bowled by Saini. Jitesh went 4, 6, 4 at the start but it proved to be anti-climactic with the batter out on 44 next ball. Nonetheless, their partnership of 64 in 7.2 overs gave Kings hope of a respectable total.

Chahal, Boult leak runs

With Kings on 141 after 18 overs, Chahal came to bowl. But the purple-cap holder's over proved to be the innings' most expensive as both Shahrukh and Curran walloped him all over for 28 runs.

Then the Kings duo rode on the back of some streaky shots to add 18 more in Boult's final over. Together, they added 46 in the last 12 balls, Kings scored 70 in their last five overs, and Royals were left chasing a tricky 188.

Devdutt Padikkal brought up his fifty off just 29 balls•BCCI

Padikkal clicks at No. 3

After Buttler registered his third duck in a row, Padikkal and Jaiswal collected boundaries through the point region with the Kings bowlers trying to bowl wide. They didn't let Arshdeep Singh, Curran or Kagiso Rabada settle and together added 73 runs in 8.1 overs.

While Padikkal dominated, Jaiswal looked to build his innings while the required run rate also remained in check. However, Padikkal and Samson fell in quick succession and the Royals slid from 85 for 1 to 90 for 3.

Hetmyer, Parag, Jurel seal the deal

Hetmyer was quick off the blocks with two sixes, allowing Jaiswal to continue playing his role. Even though Jaiswal fell soon after getting to fifty, Hetmyer carried on to blitz 46 off 28 and Riyan Parag also chipped in with two sixes off Rabada to play a cameo of 20 off 12.

However neither could bring the team home, falling late in the game. The responsibility of that fell to Jurel, who held his nerve in Boult's company to seal the match with a straight six off Rahul Chahar in the final over.

Match 67

Chennai Super Kings 223 for 3 (Conway 87, Gaikwad 79) beat Delhi Capitals 146 for 9 (Warner 86, Chahar 3-22, Pathirana 2-22, Theekshana 2-23) by 77 runs

Devon Conway and Ruturaj Gaikwad made merry in Delhi, enjoying the kind of batting conditions David Warner had hoped to maximise for home advantage. It allowed Chennai Super Kings to dominate from start to finish in a 77-run win and assure themselves of a playoff berth, and a No. 2 spot.*

Up next for them are Gujarat Titans, the defending champions, on their home turf at Chepauk in Qualifier 1.

For Capitals, the end was as tame as the start of the season. Warner was the only top-order batter to show any semblance of form and consistency throughout. His 86 off 58 had its thrilling moments, particularly against Ravindra Jadeja, but the collapse around him meant everything he did was merely limiting damage.

Conway's powerplay surge

MS Dhoni felt it was a dry surface. Warner agreed. So it was no surprise to see spin early in the powerplay. But CSK's approach two overs in told you the surface seemed better than anticipated.

Conway stepped out to launch Lalit Yadav's offbreak for his first six, the season's 1000th, in the second over to begin the sixathon. It was no different even when there was pace on the ball. Khaleel Ahmed was flicked disdainfully and when Anrich Nortje went short into the body, Conway cleverly got inside the line to ramp for four.

CSK's fifty was up in just the fifth over, with Gaikwad and Conway going almost neck and neck.

Gaikwad overcomes slight blip

Overs six to nine produced just one boundary, but Gaikwad broke the shackles when he pulled Axar Patel's short balls for two consecutive sixes in the 10th over. Off the next delivery, he raised a 37-ball half-century.

Two overs later, Kuleep Yadav found himself under the pump. Enthused by Gaikwad getting a leading edge to a tossed-up googly that drifted away earlier in the innings, he generously tossed them up again, away from the hitting arc. This time, though, Gaikwad got to the pitch and went 6, 6, 6, by peppering different arcs in the 'V' down the ground to turn the innings into overdrive.

Soon, Gaikwad and Conway raised 1000 runs as an opening pair in just their 20th innings.

Gaikwad's fury ended when he was caught on the ropes trying to muscle a short ball out of the ground, but the two overs following his dismissal went for three fours and two sixes. Conway pressed the pedal after his 33-ball half-century, galloping towards a century as the death overs loomed.

Delhi Capitals' batting effort was almost entirely about David Warner•BCCI

The high-power finish

Dhoni promoted himself to No. 4 ahead of Jadeja, but when Shivam Dube fell with 12 balls left, it brought Jadeja out anyway. And he smashed three fours and a six off the seven balls he faced as CSK finished with 223 for 3. The last six overs went for 83 runs.

Chahar dents Capitals

Tushar Deshpande removed Prithvi Shaw early to an outstanding catch from Ambati Rayudu at mid-off. Deepak Chahar made further incisions in the powerplay when he removed Phil Salt and Rilee Rossouw to slow Capitals down. Salt found cover trying to force a length ball up and over the infield, while Rossouw chopped on.

Warner's lone battle

Warner found his hitting gear after a slow powerplay as he got stuck into Jadeja by muscling him down the ground. He brought up his fifty off just 32 balls and then upped the tempo even more in Jadeja's last over that went for 23 and made him finish with 4-0-50-1. Warner, who kept hitting him with the spin into the short leg-side boundary, outfoxed him with a switch hit for six as Jadeja tried to fire it away from his hitting arc. The hand-eye coordination, the wrist work, the execution were all top notch.

As wickets continued to fall, Warner kept counter-punching, but the bowling meltdown and their own top-order collapse in a slow start meant the asking rate had spiralled beyond

reach very early. When Warner was out, dragging a cutter off Matheesha Pathirana down to long-on, it seemed as if there would be not much else left in the game.

But Maheesh Theekshana delivered a thrilling final over in which he picked up two wickets in two balls and was heartbreakingly denied a hat-trick in the wicket maiden. There were smiles all round as the review for the hat-trick wicket was turned down, but CSK were through with a big net run rate boost.

Match 68

Lucknow Super Giants 176 for 8 (Pooran 58, Shardul Thakur 2-27, Narine 2-28)
beat Kolkata Knight Riders 175 for 7 (Rinku 67*, Roy 45, Bishnoi 2-23, Yash Thakur 2-31)
by one run

Lucknow Super Giants survived a Rinku Singh scare to become the third team to qualify for the playoffs of IPL 2023 as they beat Kolkata Knight Riders by one run at Eden Gardens. They ended with 17 points, tied with Chennai Super Kings, but LSG's inferior net run rate meant they finished third. They will now face the fourth qualifying team in the Eliminator in Chennai on May 24.

At the start of the day, LSG had a chance to secure a top-two finish. However, CSK's 77-run win over Delhi Capitals in the earlier game meant LSG needed to beat KKR by a margin of around 97 runs to go above CSK. That was not going to be easy, especially after LSG posted 176 batting first. At 73 for 5 in the 11th over, they didn't look like scoring even that many, but Nicholas Pooran's 30-ball 58 lifted them.

KKR had a flying start before they lost their way in the middle overs. It came down to 56 needed from the last four overs, and then 41 from two. Rinku took 20 off Naveen-ul-Haq in the 19th, leaving 21 for the last.

Vaibhav Arora took a single on the first ball of the final over, bowled Yash Thakur. That was followed by two dots and two wides, making it 18 required from three balls. Rinku hit the next one for a six but could pick up only a four off the fifth. A six on the final delivery only reduced the margin of defeat.

LSG's hit-and-miss start

After being sent in, LSG lost a wicket in the third over of the innings when Harshit Rana bounced out Karan Sharma for 3. Prerak Mankad tried to attack but he was more like a cat on a hot tin roof. After being on 4 off eight balls, he picked up five fours in the next two overs but hardly looked comfortable. Once the powerplay ended, his attempted upper cut against Arora was taken at deep cover. Two balls later, Arora bounced out Marcus Stoinis for a duck, making it 55 for 3.

Varun Chakravarthy and Sunil Narine dragged LSG back further. Narine had Krunal Pandya mistiming a slog sweep to deep square leg in the tenth over, and Varun got Quinton de Kock

to top-edge to deep midwicket. De Kock, who picked up two sixes in the powerplay - his only boundaries on the night - ended with 28 off 27 balls.

Pooran hits them beyond the boundary

Pooran came in at No. 7, a ball after the halfway mark in the innings. Varun induced an outside edge straightaway but Pooran had played it with soft hands, resulting in the ball falling short and to the left of first slip and going for four. The next ball, though, was too short, and Pooran cut it for four. Varun then overcompensated, erring on the fuller side and was duly smashed for a straight six.

With another six in the spinner's next over, Pooran moved to 23 off just ten balls. KKR had brought in Suyash Sharma as the Impact Player for Harshit, who had bowled three overs for 1 for 21. Pooran welcomed Suyash with yet another six, and ended the over with a four, making sure the legspinner didn't bowl another over in the game.

In the 19th over, Pooran brought up his half-century with a six off Shardul Thakur. He sent the next ball over the boundary line as well, but Thakur had him caught at deep third when the batter attempted a hat-trick of sixes. Andre Russell conceded only three off the first four deliveries of the 20th over before K Gowtham hit the last two for a six and four to take LSG past 175.

KKR quick out of the blocks

KKR had an almost impossible task in front of them: they needed to win in 8.5 overs to lift their net run rate above Rajasthan Royals' to stay alive for the playoffs. Jason Roy and Venkatesh Iyer smashed 30 in the first two overs but the next two brought only 15. Roy did hit three fours off Krunal's first three balls in the fifth over but Iyer fell to Gowtham in the next, and KKR finished the powerplay on 61 for 1.

Rinku takes it close

As far as this match was concerned, KKR were well ahead of the required rate. After eight overs, they were 78 for 1, but could score only 30 in the next six for the loss of three wickets. Ravi Bishnoi had Nitish Rana caught at extra cover, Krunal bowled Roy for 45 off 28, and Yash Thakur's slower ball accounted for Rahmanullah Gurbaz for 10 off 15.

With 63 needed from 28 balls, Russell hit Bishnoi for a six but was bowled on the next ball. Rinku was still in the middle, and if there is one thing this season has taught us, it is that no game is over till Rinku is batting. En route to his unbeaten 67 off 33 balls, he took Naveen for three fours and six in the 19th over but with 18 needed from three balls, he could hit only 6, 4 and 6.

Match 69

Mumbai Indians 201 for 2 (Green 100*, Rohit 56) beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 200 for 5 (Agarwal 83, Vivrant 69, Madhwal 4-37) by eight wickets

Mumbai Indians did what was asked of them quite emphatically, to win the game and move to fourth. And then after nearly five hours of waiting, had their playoff spot confirmed following Gujarat Titans' win over Royal Challengers Bangalore in Bengaluru.*

Having chased down 201 courtesy a 47-ball 100 not out from Cameron Green, Mumbai needed RCB to lose their fixture, and that's what happened in the end. Having got to 16 points, they now face Lucknow Super Giants in the Eliminator on May 24.

Victory at one stage seemed far-fetched for Mumbai when Sunrisers openers Mayank Agarwal and Vivrant Sharma blasted an opening stand of 140 in just 13.5 overs. Then Mumbai hit back in the death overs to take the momentum with them; Sunrisers managed just 32 off their last four overs. It seemed as if the slowdown at the time would prove costly, but the manner of Mumbai's chase made it amply clear that even another 20 runs would perhaps not have made any difference.

Only just briefly in their defence, Sunrisers had it under control when Bhuvneshwar Kumar removed Ishan Kishan early with the first three overs going for just 24. The turning point came in the fifth over when Rohit Sharma was reprieved on 12 by Sanvir Singh. He made them pay along with Green.

The Mayank-Vivrant show

But long before the carnage that the majority of the strong 30,000 crowd anticipated, Agarwal and Vivrant overcame a slow start to set the game up. Vivrant ended the powerplay with two bludgeoning hits down the ground off Piyush Chawla to go from 10 off 16 to 27 off 24.

The slow start wasn't due to lack of trying, though. It was possibly a case of nerves and some good shots finding the fielders. He soon brought up his half-century off just 36 deliveries.

Agarwal said 'I'm in too' as he galloped to his half-century by hitting Jason Behrendorff superbly inside-out over cover for six and scything the follow-up wide yorker behind point. His half-century was up off just 32 balls. Now, Sunrisers were beginning to get into overdrive.

Madhwal leaves a mark

Tasked to deliver the tough overs, Akash Madhwal brought Mumbai some interim relief when he had Vivrant caught at the boundary for 69. It was the highest score by an Indian in a debut IPL innings, and second-best overall. But any joy at having broken through quickly dissipated as the in-form Heinrich Klaasen helped himself to a first-ball four.

Agarwal then galloped towards a century, racing from 62 off 36 to 83 off 45, courtesy of a sensational takedown of Kumar Kartikeya and Chawla off successive overs. But his dismissal to Madhwal off a knuckleball dug in to have him heaving across the line and nicking, brought Mumbai back.

Sunrisers went for 19 balls without a boundary in the death overs as Madhwal also removed Klaasen and Harry Brook off consecutive deliveries to finish with 4 for 37. The last four overs produced just 32 as Sunrisers eventually just past 200 after a last-ball six by Aiden Markram.

Akash Madhwal nailed his yorkers at the death•BCCI

The Rohit-Green run torrent

After removing Kishan early, Sunrisers could have had a second when Rohit mistimes a heave to midwicket. Sanvir put down a straightforward chance to open the floodgates.

The next ball was pummeled over deep midwicket by Green. It was the difference between young Nitish Kumar Reddy having figures of 2-0-12-1 and 2-0-19-0 in the powerplay. Kartik Tyagi too kept bowling hittable lengths and compounded his misery by overstepping. Green hit four fours and two sixes off his first 10 balls to kick Mumbai into high gear.

He soon brought up his half-century off just 20 balls, while Rohit went past 11,000 T20 runs as runs bled against spin with Sunrisers unable to have any grip over proceedings. A part of this was down to some poor bowling by the spinners, who were all over the pace on a surface where there was hardly any purchase as the ball slid on nicely.

Rohit had a second reprieve, again by Sanvir on 51, but fell soon after. But when Suryakumar Yadav coolly walked in and lofted his first ball inside-out for four, it seemed as if he was in a hurry.

Suryakumar and Green next took down an erratic Umran Malik for 20 off the 16th to bring down the equation from 41 off 30 to 21 off 24. From there on, it was a walk home with two overs to spare, the winning runs also delivering Green a maiden T20 hundred as Mumbai ensured they did enough.

Match 70

Gujarat Titans 198 for 4 (Gill 104*, Shankar 53, Siraj 2-23) beat Royal Challengers Bangalore 197 for 5 (Kohli 101*, Noor 2-39) by six wickets

Shubman Gill broke tens of thousands of hearts by responding to Virat Kohli's second hundred in two matches with a double of his own as Gujarat Titans chased down 198 to knock Royal Challengers Bangalore out and give Mumbai Indians a passage into the playoffs.

It was hard not to see this as a symbolic passing of the baton in the larger context of the Indian batting kingdom. Gill took eight balls fewer than Kohli to get to the hundred, hit seven more sixes, but Kohli's circumstance was different. He had wickets falling around him whereas Vijay Shankar - Gill's partner for the second-wicket stand of 123 - enjoyed much more luck than RCB batters did. In fact, Titans scored 45 runs in false responses, more than any innings in this IPL.

Ink boys get going

It was a long agonising night for the Bengaluru hopefuls as thunderstorms and intermittent drizzle pushed the start of the match right to the brink of the point where you start losing overs. RCB then lost the toss, and were put in. To brighten up their evening, Kohli and Faf du Plessis continued their opening domination with a 67-run stand. They took even Mohammed Shami for runs and denied him a powerplay wicket. First job done.

Titans own middle overs

There was some luck involved in the first wicket. It was a skilful wrong'un from Noor Ahmad that dipped on du Plessis, but the thick outside edge was never going to be caught except in freakish circumstances. It happened as the ball hit Wriddhiman Saha's pad and lobbed for an easy catch at slip. At least Titans had the slip in place despite that start.

Poignantly for the RCB fans, the partnership ended at a season aggregate of 939, the same that Kohli and AB de Villiers scored together in 2016.

Rashid Khan then burst through the opening, bowling Glenn Maxwell with a wrong'un, taking away the purple cap from Shami, who duly returned to end a cameo from Michael Bracewell and reclaim the purple cap. Between the two wickets, Saha showed real skill to stump Mahipal Lomror down the leg side. When Yash Dayal marked his comeback with a golden duck for Dinesh Karthik - his 17th duck in all IPL, a record - RCB were 133 for 5 in 14.2, and face to face with their lack of big hitters down the order.

Virat Kohli scored a 60-ball century•AFP/Getty Images

Kohli manages both

Kohli has batted with much less price on his wicket this IPL, and his natural game has backed his intent. He did more of the same but it still has suffered in the absence of the lower-order hitting. Here he went from 36 off 22 in the first six to 16 off 14 in the next six, but he is a different proposition when he gets into the death overs. Because of the loss of five wickets, he was probably forced to play Rashid out in the 17th but he lived up to his reputation of being one of the best at the death, scoring his second 50 in just 25 balls. He did so with just one six, only the fourth time a hundred with just one six has been scored in the IPL.

The Gill riposte

Kohli has scored two of those hundreds, Shikhar Dhawan one, and Gill one, in his last innings. Here, though, he was in no mood to miss out on the small boundaries off Chinnaswamy Stadium.

The new ball held in the surface, which showed in the struggles of Saha and Shankar, but Gill looked like he was batting in a parallel universe. Short-arm jabs flew for sixes, the cover

gap looked bigger than it was, and the slow start of 25 for 1 in three overs soon began to look up.

The only time Gill looked like slogging was when Shankar was 21 off 20. He ran at the legspinner Himanshu Sharma, was beaten in the flight, but got an outside edge for four. He followed it up with a clean six, and never looked back.

Shankar enjoyed much more luck than Gill, and survived long enough for some hits to come off. In what is cruel but true nature of T20, Shankar got to his fifty quicker than Kohli did even though Kohli hardly mis-hit a ball.

The moment the asking rate went past 11, RCB gave the two right-hand batters the offspin of Bracewell, whom Gill deposited for two sixes. When Shankar fell, Titans kept promoting batters other than Hardik Pandya. They struggled, two of them got out, but Gill was unstoppable at the other end even though he got to face only 12 balls in the last six overs. He scored 33 in those to take Titans home with five balls to spare.

Playoff

Qualifier 1

Chennai Super Kings 172 for 7 (Gaikwad 60, Conway 40, Shami 2-28) beat Gujarat Titans (Gill 42, Jadeja 2-18) by 15 runs

MS Dhoni has led Chennai Super Kings to their tenth IPL final. He's had the whole country wrapped around his fingertips without even trying, and nights like these are the reason why. Even the umpires couldn't win against him.

He met Gujarat Titans on a pitch that he likes - the kind that used to greet international teams during his reign as India captain - and turned their comfort zone into anything but. A team that likes batting second lost for only the fourth time in 18 chases.

It really did feel like destiny was at play here. CSK's batters mis-hit a lot but they still managed 172. Their quicks then sprayed it around but those short balls down leg and wide full tosses actually got wickets. The spinners, however, were in their element with Ravindra Jadeja and Maheesh Theekshana picking up four wickets for 46 runs.

Titans aren't done, of course. They were the dominant team in the league stage, which earned them a second shot at a place in the final. They'll have to make the most of that now against either Mumbai Indians or Lucknow Super Giants in Ahmedabad.

Abraca-Jadeja

There are times when it feels like Dhoni's players become extensions of his will and there is one who knows that feeling more than most. To be fair, that implication has hurt Jadeja as much as it has helped him.

The left-arm spinner was always going to be crucial in conditions where the new ball was stopping on the pitch and the old one was keeping low. By the time he got it in his hands, it began to take appreciable amounts of turn as well.

His second wicket - that of David Miller - was magic. High pace. From around the wicket. Pitching on middle stump. But the angle made the batter think he had the room to whip it away. A split second later his stumps were in disarray.

This was Jadeja's eighth wicket of a left-hander, doubling his previous best in an IPL season.

Deepak Chahar had Shubman Gill caught on the long-leg boundary for 42•Getty Images

Theekshana shows why

There was always a question about him in the press conferences. Why is he in the side? Why didn't they play Mitchell Santner? What is the point of a spinner who couldn't take wickets in Chennai? Well this is it.

Theekshana got rid of Hardik Pandya. At the time, it felt like the Titans captain was preparing to take the bowler on. It was his second big move, after coming out at No. 3 and hitting his first ball for four. The logic was if he could defang one of CSK's go-to men in conditions that were perfect for him that'll send a shockwave right through the team. It was a calculated risk. It didn't come off. The battle lasted three balls.

Towards the end of the game, with Dhoni working to push up the required rate, he turned to Theekshana again and he went straight through Rahul Tewatia. It was part of a period in which Titans lost four wickets for 26 runs in 24 balls.

Recovering from 98 for 6 was not possible, even with heroics from Rashid Khan.

Gill vs Conway

At the end of CSK's powerplay, Devon Conway was 14 off 11 with a control percentage of 64. Those stats combine to suggest he was trying a lot of things and very few of them were coming off. Coming down the track. Looking for those scoops. Anything. Everything. But nothing worked. He was stuck and for as long as he was so were the Super Kings. They hit no boundaries for 29 balls between the 10th and the 15th overs. Just a little after that, Conway's control percentage dipped to 50. He was playing a false shot once every two balls.

Meanwhile, Shubman Gill had unlocked batting. Even here, he played a shot that barely made sense. It was a flick, but he hit it in front of short midwicket, which meant he had to limit the amount of wrist he put into it. He had to limit the one thing that gives the shot its power and it still went screaming away to the boundary.

Dhoni knew he could not let Gill bat till the end. So he called on Matheesha Pathirana a little earlier than he usually does. And the young slinga got a bit of stage fright. His first over in his first IPL playoff match contained 10 balls, including four wides.

Gill survived so Dhoni went to plan B. If he couldn't be prised out, maybe he could be tempted. Deepak Chahar came on. And with the first ball of the 14th over - short, slow and so damn juicy - he had Titans' biggest hope caught on the long-leg boundary. Gill walked away with a control percentage in the 90s. Conway walked away with the win.

MS Dhoni has a chat with Chris Gaffaney about Matheesha Pathirana's availability to bowl • BCCI

Dhoni vs the umpires

With the set batter gone, Dhoni reigned supreme. He had three overs of Pathirana left to combat Titans' finishers. And he would use them all even if it meant inviting an over-rate penalty. That's 16, 18 and 20. Only Pathirana had left the field for a while. So he couldn't bowl the 16th until he had been on the pitch for the same time he had been off. So Dhoni went to the umpires and just had a little chat, seemingly letting the clock tick on down until he could unleash his death bowler.

This is what Dhoni does. He defends totals. It's part of his mystique. Hardik actually said it best: "That's the beauty about him. With his mind and the kind of way he uses his bowlers, he will make sure you feel like he is adding 10 runs extra to the score."

That Super Kings got to 172 was down to Ruturaj Gaikwad and his 14th IPL half-century. He too had to struggle but whereas other batters let the pressure get to them, he keeps his composure. For example, in the fifth over, Rashid had tied him down by bowling into the wicket and at the stumps. Sensing that the batter would be looking for a release shot now, the legspinner dangled one outside off. Gaikwad went after it, as he was supposed to, but he hit it inside out over cover where there were no fielders. That is a high-quality shot in a high-pressure situation against a high-class bowler. It represented both Gaikwad's skill and his clear-headedness at the crease. CSK were very lucky he was reprieved on 2 off 6 by a no-ball.

Eliminator

Mumbai Indians 182 for 8 (Green 41, Naveen 4-38, Thakur 3-34) beat Lucknow Super Giants 101 (Stoinis 40, Madhwal 5-5) by 81 runs

Look out, Ahmedabad. Mumbai Indians are coming. The five-time champions put on a clinic to rout Lucknow Super Giants on Wednesday night and march into Qualifier 2. They are now two wins away from lifting a trophy they might soon trademark.

Akash Madhwal was the star of the show, picking up the joint-best figures by an Indian in IPL history - 5 for 5 in 3.3 overs. He might have taken more but Super Giants kept running themselves out in ridiculous ways. One was the result of a collision, it ended their best batter's stay at the crease, Marcus Stoinis gone for 40 off 27. Another had both players at the same end.

Super Giants fell from 74 for 3 to 101 all out in a chase of 183.

Mumbai's boundary bash

Mumbai do the little things right. They saw the opposition opening the bowling with spin and exploited the fact that only two men are allowed outside the 30-yard circle. Rohit Sharma and Ishan Kishan hit four fours in the first three overs - all just placed into gaps behind point and past fine leg because they knew that would be enough. These were the conditions that were supposed to stop the biggest hitters in the IPL. But they didn't. Mumbai cruised to 98 for 2, the third-highest 10-over score in Chennai this year. They hit 15 boundaries in this period.

2:08

Moody: 'Naveen has three versions of the slower offcutter'

Naveen intervenes

Cameron Green and Suryakumar Yadav were not just clearing the boundary, they were spraying the second tier. This season, a few teams have experimented with three openers in their line-up. They come into play when there's an early wicket. They stay in the hut when there isn't. Mumbai are one of these teams and it helped them keep a very healthy tempo. They were on course to clear 200.

That's when Naveen-ul-Haq came on and did the simple thing right. At Chepauk, everybody needs to take pace off. Including the fast bowlers. After getting bashed for a first-ball six in the 11th over, he slipped in a legcutter to Suryakumar and had him caught on the straight boundary, and two balls later, an offcutter gripped in the pitch and bowled Green through the gate.

Naveen, the Afghanistan quick, celebrated each of his four wickets by putting his fingers in ears, perhaps a response to the hate he's received on social media for his part in the blow-up with Virat Kohli earlier in the tournament.

1:19

Manjrekar: 'Brilliant move to have Wadhera come in as Impact sub'

The impact of the Impact Sub

Mumbai had gone in a batter light in their bat-first XI. The logic was that if they needed the guy, they would sub him in for someone who was already dismissed.

Which is exactly what happened. Nehal Wadhera walked in as Suryakumar's substitute to face the last 21 balls of the innings.

If they hadn't needed him, they might have brought in an extra spinner to help defend whatever total they got. Mumbai kept both options open. It's a fun way to use the Impact Sub. It's not formulaic.

Wadhera played a massive role. He came in at a time when Mumbai had managed only 30 runs in the previous 4.2 overs. And he smashed 23 off 12, including two fours and a six in the final over.

Madhwal stands tall

Madhwal went to Mumbai for INR 20 lakh. Money extremely well spent.

He wasn't part of Plan A. An entire month had gone by before he played his first game, and there he went for 37 runs in three overs. Two of them were at the death.

Madhwal has bowled 129 balls this season. Fifty-one of them have been in overs 17 to 20. A rookie has been bowling 40% of his deliveries in the hardest phase of a T20 game while maintaining an economy rate of 7.5. Only one fast bowler has done better (min 18 deliveries) and he belonged to the opposition - Mohsin Khan.

Madhwal's biggest impact in this game, though, came in the middle overs when he picked up two wickets in two balls, including an absolute peach from around the wicket, angling into the left-handed Nicholas Pooran and nipping away off the pitch to have him caught behind.

Seventeen dots in 21 balls and five wickets for five runs. Nobody had done this much damage in the entire history of IPL playoff matches. Most teams wouldn't be able to recover from losing bowlers of the class of Jasprit Bumrah and Jofra Archer.

Mumbai aren't most teams.

Qualifier 2

Gujarat Titans 233 for 3 (Gill 129, Sudharsan 43, Chawla 1-45) beat Mumbai Indians 171 (Suryakumar 61, Varma 43, Mohit 5-10) by 62 runs

Shubman Gill's majestic 129 off 60 balls powered Gujarat Titans into the final of IPL 2023 with a 62-run win over Mumbai Indians in Ahmedabad. Titans will face Chennai Super Kings at this very ground on Sunday in a bid to defend their title.

Earlier, rain delayed the match by 30 minutes. With the weather around, Rohit Sharma opted to chase after winning the toss. Titans didn't have a great start, but Gill's knock lifted them to a mammoth 233 for 3. This was Gill's third hundred in four matches; only Virat Kohli and Jos Buttler (four each) have scored more in a single edition of the IPL. The knock took Gill's run tally to 851. Once again, only Kohli (973 in 2016) and Buttler (863 in 2022) have had more productive seasons.

No team had chased down this many in the IPL. And then Mumbai lost two early wickets. But they didn't go down without a fight. Suryakumar Yadav and Tilak Varma took them to 72 in six overs before Rashid Khan castled the latter. From there on, Suryakumar kept them in the contest almost singlehandedly with his 61 off 38. But Mohit Sharma uprooted his leg

stump when the batter missed a scoop. In the next over, Rashid trapped Tim David lbw to end Mumbai's hopes.

Mohit, who hadn't bowled till the 14th over, used his slower balls to good effect and finished with figures of 2.2-0-10-5.

Shubman Gill earned praise from everybody, including the opposition captain Rohit Sharma•BCCI

Unstoppable Gill

Despite scoring at least one four in every over from the second to fifth, Titans reached only 38 for no loss after five. Gill then latched onto Chris Jordan in the last over of the powerplay. The second legal delivery of the over was too short and sat up on this sticky pitch. Gill waited for it and pulled it with disdain over deep square leg. The next one was slightly short outside off. Gill once again showed no mercy and cut it ferociously to the cover boundary.

Luck too was on Gill's side. In the same Jordan over, he punched one uppishly to the right of mid-on where Tim David dived, got both hands to the ball but couldn't hold on to it. He was on 30 at that point.

Titans finished the powerplay on 50 for no loss but Wriddhiman Saha was struggling for timing. In the fourth over of the innings, Akash Madhwal had hit him on the helmet with a skiddy bouncer, and soon after Piyush Chawla had him stumped with a leg-side wide. It was the sixth time in 16 innings this season that Chawla struck in his first over of the match.

Gill brought up his fifty off 32 balls. And then he cut loose. In a space of nine balls, he hit five sixes and a four off Madhwal and Chawla. He didn't slow down even in the 90s; his second fifty took just 17 balls. Immediately after reaching his hundred, he smashed Cameron Green for 6, 4 and 6. By the time Gill holed out to deep midwicket, off Madhwal, Titans had reached 192 in the 17th over.

Titans retire out Sudharsan

All this happened while Sai Sudharsan was playing second fiddle to Gill. But with nine wickets in hand, Titans needed both batters to attack. The 18th and 19th overs combined went for just 16, after which Titans retired out Sudharsan who scored 43 off 31. Rashid replaced him in the middle and hit his first ball for four. Hardik Pandya then applied the finishing touch, hitting the last two balls of the innings for four and six.

Suryakumar Yadav lost his leg stump to Mohit Sharma•BCCI

Shami strikes twice in powerplay

Coming into this game, Mohammed Shami had represented Titans three times against Mumbai. On all three occasions, he went wicketless. Tonight, though, he struck twice inside the powerplay to put Mumbai on the back foot. Nehal Wadhera, who came in as Impact

Player for Madhwal, was caught behind in the first over of the chase, and Rohit top-edged a pull in the third.

In between those two dismissals, Hardik hit Green on the left forearm with a short ball, forcing the batter to retire hurt. During the first innings, Ishan Kishan had walked off the field after Jordan's elbow hit him in the eye when the two were crossing each other. So when Rohit departed, leaving Mumbai 21 for 2, it felt like they were effectively 21 for 4. But Green came out to resume his innings later, and Kishan's injury had seemingly resulted in a concussion, so Mumbai replaced him with Vishnu Vinod.

Rashid, Mohit trump mighty Mumbai

Varma started by hitting two sixes in his first four balls, and then smashed Shami for four fours and a six in a 24-run over. He had moved to 43 off just 13 with 100% control over his shots. Hardik turned to Rashid in an attempt to put the brakes on the scoring rate. The spinner duly obliged his captain by bowling Varma when the batter tried to sweep him.

At the fall of Varma's wicket, Green came out once again, and was looking dangerous. He and Suryakumar added 52 in 5.2 overs before Josh Little pinged his leg stump with a delivery that seamed in from good length.

Suryakumar, though, was still battling in the middle. He reached his fifty, off 33 balls, with a scoop-pull over the wicketkeeper's head. He brought down the equation to 79 needed from 34 balls before Mohit sent him packing. Two balls later, the seamer had Vinod caught at extra cover.

David was Mumbai's last hope. Hardik, as always, had saved Rashid's one over and brought him on in the 16th. With his third ball, Rashid trapped David lbw. The batter reviewed the decision but he couldn't have been more out. From the other end, Mohit cleaned up the tail to pick up his maiden five-for in T20 cricket.

Finals

Chennai Super Kings 171 for 5 in 15 overs (Conway 47, Dube 32*, Mohit 3-36) beat Gujarat Titans 214 for 4 (Sudharsan 96, Saha 54) by five wickets via DLS method

At 1:35am on the third day of a T20 match, Chennai Super Kings emerged as the new IPL champions, winning their fifth title to draw level with Mumbai Indians.

Ravindra Jadeja pierced the silence built by tens of thousands of people when he hit the final two balls of an incredible, chaotic, unbelievable chase for boundaries. One straight in front of him. The other behind.

An equation of 171 off 15 overs reduced to 13 off one. Mohit Sharma made it even tougher - 10 off two balls. CSK hadn't hit a boundary in 13 balls. They had, however, lost two wickets. One of them was MS Dhoni, for a duck.

That was looking like it might be his last act on a cricket field. He will be 42 soon. He said preparing for the IPL at his age was taking a "heavy toll". When he came in, Ahmedabad broke the sound barrier. When he left, the crowd was bereft.

But, an hour and a half later, they looked on, having suffered through the rain, braving difficult journeys to and from the ground, as their hero walked up onto the podium and picked up his fifth IPL trophy. In a rare show of emotion, once the winning runs were hit, Dhoni wrapped his arms around Jadeja and lifted him clean off the ground. That's how much it meant to him. It even convinced him to keep playing for another year.

None of this would have been possible though without the impact of Ambati Rayudu. He tweeted that this would be his final IPL match. When he walked out, ESPNcricinfo's forecaster suggested CSK only had a 35% chance of victory. He lashed Mohit for 6, 4 and 6 and with those three hits, his team became overwhelming favourites - 93%.

Ravindra Jadeja finished the job for CSK with a six and a four on the last two balls•AFP/Getty Images

The highlights

The IPL final began on May 28. Not a ball was bowled because of rain. Then it shifted to May 29. Two-hundred and ten balls took six hours to be bowled because of another weather intervention.

B Sai Sudharsan made the final the spectacle it was. The 21-year old Chennai boy took it to his hometown franchise, scoring 96 runs off 47 balls. Mohit made it last the distance. He came back from the Rayudu assault to pick up two wickets in two balls.

Later, facing some of the greatest pressure a player can be under - bowling the last over with an IPL final on his shoulders - he nailed three perfect off-stump yorkers that were simply unhittable.

Super Kings had been propped up by yet another strong opening partnership from Ruturaj Gaikwad and Devon Conway. But once the field spread - after four overs - they found the going tougher. Especially against Noor Ahmad. The 18-year old left arm wristspinner did not concede a single boundary in a spell of 3-0-17-2. His Afghanistan team-mate though was battered around.

Rashid Khan was about to finish his spell well. The first four balls of his last over went for just three runs. The rest went for 12. Shivam Dube got the tossed up balls he wanted and he smashed them both for sixes.

CSK needed to go 6, 6, 6, 4, 6 between the 12th and the 13th overs just to get ahead in this game. They were trailing until that five-ball sequence. Imagine being the Titans right now. Those five balls - and then the last two - ended up deciding their fate.

Ambati Rayudu joined Rohit Sharma as the only men to win six IPL titles•BCCI

They finally roar for Jadeja

At the end of the league stage, Jadeja had a strike rate of 149.47 between overs 15 and 20. That is the lowest of the 14 finishers who have faced at least 75 balls in this phase. His closest competitor for a place in the Indian team in T20 cricket - Axar Patel - was up at 175.55.

To make matters worse, every time he fell, he was greeted to the sound of the crowd roaring as one for the incoming batter. Dhoni. It got to the point where he rounded on the fans, in jest of course, and, in response, the next time he walked out to the middle, the Chepauk DJ played a song called Mannippaya, which in Tamil translates to 'will you forgive me?'

Jadeja faced only six balls in the final. He was at the crease for only 13. There were no boundaries hit for the duration of his stay ... until the penultimate ball. A yorker that fell only inches short from Mohit was launched down the ground, and then the last ball, another attempted yorker that became a low full toss, was flicked to the left of short fine.

Chennai would have roared as one. This time for Jadeja.

The blinder from Rayudu

CSK needed 72 from 36. Eleven balls, two fours and a wicket later, they needed 54 from 25 and that's what Rayudu walked into. He has played 204 matches in his IPL career, which began in 2010. This season he's had to play a reduced role. He was CSK's Impact Player at the start. None of his innings lasted more than 17 balls. Yet he kept telling his team-mates in the dressing room that he would win the final for them. Deepak Chahar made a point of saying that by cutting across Rayudu himself when he was doing an interview with the host broadcaster.

The second six he hit was especially stunning. Off an into-the-wicket slower ball that was designed to rob the batter of his balance, Rayudu kept his, and smashed it over extra cover. As far as cameos go, this 19 off 8 will remain long in memory.

B Sai Sudharsan hit six sixes in his 47-ball 96•BCCI

The forgotten hero

Sudharsan arrived on the back of a stumping that Dhoni pulled off in 0.1 seconds to get rid of Shubman Gill. He was 10 off 12 with no boundaries after 11 overs. He was the man that had to retire out in Qualifier 2 so Titans could get a better ball-striker in. But even that night, they let Sudharsan bat till the start of the 20th over and only then pulled him out. They trust this guy. They trust all their guys. That's their whole thing.

Sudharsan seems to understand his limitations. And that gives him his power. He can't hit sixes like Tim David or Suryakumar Yadav. Even the ones he manages to hit look like they take a lot out of him. That bat goes as high as it can in the back-lift and comes thundering down. He holds nothing back because he knows he can't afford to.

Defensive bowling is all about protecting one side of the pitch. Usually, the leg side. That's why most teams station more men in the deep there. It's instinct to slog the ball in T20s.

But Sudharsan is different. He is a really good off-side player. On Monday, he found six of his eight fours there. Two of them were slaps in the face of CSK's plans. In the 17th over, with mid-off and cover up and Tushar Deshpande trying to tuck him up on middle and leg, Sudharsan made room and flat-batted two beautiful boundaries where he knew he didn't need power. Just placement.

This was part of a three-over period in which he scored all of the Titans' boundaries - three sixes and five fours. When a batter pillages runs both sides of the wicket, the opposition unravels.

No CSK bowler was spared. Not even Matheesha Pathirana. He had gone entire games - 9 of 14 - without giving away as many runs as he did on Monday to just one player. Sudharsan whacked the Sri Lankan sensation for 34 in 14 balls.

2024

MATCH 1

Chennai Super Kings 176 for 4 (Ravindra 37, Dube 34*, Green 2-27) beat Royal Challengers Bengaluru 173 for 6 (Rawat 48, Karthik 38*, du Plessis 35, Mustafizur 4-29) by six wickets

Chennai Super Kings, under a brand-new captain, enjoyed a winning start to their defence of the IPL title in front of a raucous Chepauk crowd on Friday night. Mustafizur Rahman, who was among four debutants for CSK, took out four of Royal Challengers Bengaluru's top five in the space of ten balls to set up an eighth successive defeat for RCB in Chennai.

Rachin Ravindra, who was playing his first IPL game, also played his part in the victory, with 37 off 15 balls at a strike rate of 246.66 on a pitch that slowed down later in the night. In his first game as CSK captain, Ruturaj Gaikwad started with a first-ball four, but RCB's Impact Player Yash Dayal cut his innings short on 15 in CSK's chase of 174.

Cameron Green and Alzarri Joseph then briefly silenced the Chepauk crowd with their contrasting styles. While Green bowled slower cutters into the pitch, Joseph operated at high speeds and generated steep bounce, taking the pitch out of the equation.

Shivam Dube, who was working his way back from injury, replaced Mustafizur as an Impact Player for CSK and laboured to 7 off 13 balls. But he then turned up the tempo to usher CSK home with an unbeaten 34 off 28 balls along with Ravindra Jadeja, who scored an unbeaten 25 off 17. MS Dhoni didn't get to bat in the chase, but perhaps this is what he had hoped for when he handed over the keys of the CSK kingdom to Gaikwad.

RCB's Jekyll-and-Hyde powerplay

After opting to bat in what was his first IPL game as an opposition player in Chennai, Faf du Plessis dashed out of the blocks, hitting seven fours in the first three overs. He latched on to any width that Deepak Chahar and Tushar Deshpande offered, repeatedly pumping them over the off-side infield. Gaikwad got into the act and pushed extra cover back to deep cover and, on cue, Mustafizur had du Plessis holing out to Rachin Ravindra there for 35 off 21 balls. Three balls later, Mustafizur found a bit of extra bounce to have Rajat Patidar nicking off for a duck. Then, in the final over of the powerplay, Chahar had Glenn Maxwell guiding one straight into Dhoni's gloves, also for a duck.

After being on 37 for no loss in the first four overs, RCB lost three wickets for five runs in the next two.

Mustafizur goes bang-bang once again

Mustafizur then returned in the 12th over and dismissed Virat Kohli and Green in the space of three balls. While Kohli dragged a pull off a seam-up delivery to deep midwicket for 21 off

20 balls, Green was bowled by a whippy cutter for 18 off 22 balls. It was Mustafizur's second double-wicket over.

Mustafizur might not even have played had CSK's death-overs specialist Matheesha Pathirana been fit. He ended up with figures of 4-0-29-4 on a night where the other two seamers in his team - Chahar and Deshpande - went at well over nine an over. When Pathirana returns to action, CSK will have a happy selection headache.

Rawat and Karthik prop up RCB

That RCB finished with 173 for 6 was down to a counterattacking 95-run partnership for the sixth wicket off just 50 balls that ended off the last ball of the innings courtesy a Dhoni direct hit.

At one stage, RCB went 28 balls without a boundary, but Rawat then hit two in six balls to set RCB up for the end overs. He then walloped Deshpande for 6,6, 4 in a 25-run 18th over. At the other end, Karthik looked rusty to start with, but mixed power with inventiveness to give RCB's innings more impetus.

Dube gets the job done for CSK

After CSK lost Gaikwad in the powerplay, Ravindra lined up RCB's quicks with pulls and pick-up shots. He even whacked Karn Sharma over midwicket for six, but when he went for another six, he holed out to deep square-leg.

Ajinkya Rahane (27 off 19 balls) and Daryl Mitchell (22 off 18) made cameos to take the chase deep in typical CSK style. But when Green snagged Mitchell, CSK still needed 64 off 45 balls. The two-bouncer rule empowered Joseph to run in hard and hit the deck even harder. Dube, however, just about passed the short-ball test and sealed the chase with six wickets and eight balls to spare.

MATCH 2

Punjab Kings 177 for 6 (Curran 63, Livingstone 38*, Kuldeep 2-20, Khaleel 2-43) beat Delhi Capitals 174 for 9 (Hope 33, Porel 32*, Arshdeep 2-28, Harshal 2-47) by four wickets

Sam Curran and Liam Livingstone spoiled Rishabh Pant's comeback as Punjab Kings started their IPL 2024 campaign with a four-wicket win at their new home ground in Mullanpur.

After being sent in, Delhi Capitals were 137 for 7 in the 18th over when they decided to bring in Abishek Porel as the Impact Player. Porel smashed 32 off just ten balls to lift them to 174 for 9.

But that also meant Capitals were going to be a bowler light during the chase. Ishant Sharma's injury - he hurt his ankle after bowling just two overs - set them back further.

Related

Pant on his comeback to cricket: 'I was pretty nervous'

Shikhar Dhawan and Jonny Bairstow started the Kings' chase positively but both fell in the fourth over. Kuldeep Yadav then dismissed Prabhsimran Singh and Jitesh Sharma to keep Capitals in the game.

But Curran and Livingstone took over after that and added 67 off 42 balls for the fifth wicket. Curran was out in the 19th over, for 63 off 47, but Livingstone stayed till the end and finished the game with a muscular six with four balls to spare.

Warner, Marsh give Capitals a breezy start

With Prithvi Shaw left out, David Warner and Mitchell Marsh opened the innings for Capitals and gave them a fast start. Marsh got going by hitting two fours off the first two balls he faced, from Curran. Warner joined in by carting Arshdeep Singh for a six and a four in the next over.

Marsh then hit a six each off Kagiso Rabada and Arshdeep. He fell for 20 off 12 when he drove Arshdeep to cover-point where Rahul Chahar took a sharp, overhead catch.

Warner kept batting aggressively and even flick-scooped Rabada for a six as Capitals finished the powerplay on 54 for 1. In the seventh over, Shai Hope, on IPL debut, danced down the track and lofted Chahar for a straight six.

It was all Capitals at that stage till Harshal Patel came to Kings' rescue, having Warner caught behind with a slower bouncer.

Pant's first outing after the accident

Warner's wicket brought Pant to the crease, and the Mullanpur crowd welcomed him with a standing ovation. Playing his first competitive game in 15 months, Pant looked a bit rusty. He was given a life on 4 when Harshal lost the ball in the sun at deep midwicket and ended up gifting a four.

As if to rub it in, Pant then drove Harshal for his second boundary. Two balls later, though, Harshal bowled a slower bouncer; Pant failed to spot it and ended up popping it to backward point. His first outing with bat on comeback ended on 18 off 13 balls.

3:06

Moody on Porel: That's how impact subs should be used

The Porel gamble pays off

Harpreet Brar and Chahar dented Capitals further. Brar had Ricky Bhui caught down the leg side, and Tristan Stubbs holed out to long-off while trying an inside-out shot against Chahar.

When Axar Patel was run out coming back for a second, Capitals were reduced to 137 for 7 with 2.5 overs to go. But, coming in as the Impact Player, Porel slashed hard at a short and wide delivery from Harshal and picked up a boundary to deep third.

After 19 overs, Capitals were 149 for 8. With Harshal bowling the last over, Kings would have expected to restrict Capitals under 160. But that's when Porel decided to have a say in matters, and smashed three fours and two sixes in a 25-run final over.

That lifted Capitals to 174 for 9. At the start of the 20th over, ESPNcricinfo's Forecaster had Capitals' chances of winning at 38.9%. Porel singlehandedly lifted that number to 56.7%.

Dhawan, Bairstow start with a flurry of fours

Just like the Capitals openers, Dhawan and Bairstow also started with positive intent. In the first three overs, they hit a combined six fours and looted 34 runs. However, both fell in the fourth over. Dhawan was bowled as he charged down the ground to Ishant, and Bairstow was run-out at the non-striker's end when a Prabhsimran drive brushed a diving Ishant's fingers and crashed into the stumps.

But, in the sixth over, Prabhsimran tucked one towards midwicket, from where Ishant charged and fielded the ball. But as he was about to throw, he twisted his right ankle and had to be carried off the field.

1:47

Has Harshal become too predictable?

Kuldeep keeps Capitals in the game

In the tenth over, Prabhsimran tried to go big against Kuldeep and holed out to long-on for a 17-ball 26, which included five fours. In the spinner's next over, Jitesh attempted a reverse sweep, but not only did he miss the ball, he also lost his balance and ended up out of his crease. Pant was alert behind the stumps and broke the wickets.

Kuldeep finished with figures of 2 for 21. He could have easily picked up a third, but Tristan Stubbs, running to his right from long-on, put down Curran, who was on 33 at that point.

Curran, Livingstone take over

Kings needed 63 from the last six overs when Curran and Livingstone clubbed Marsh for 18 to calm the nerves.

Capitals still had hope when 28 were required from three overs. But with Ishant off the field, Pant had no option but to bowl Marsh again. He conceded another 18 to finish with 52 from his four wicketless overs.

In the 19th over, Khaleel dismissed Curran and Shashank Singh off successive deliveries but it was too late by then. Warner dropping Brar on the last ball of the Khaleel over didn't help either.

With just six required from the final over, Sumit Kumar, who was making his IPL debut, had little chance against a set Livingstone. He started with two wides, and after a dot, Livingstone launched him over deep midwicket to seal the win.

MATCH 3

Kolkata Knight Riders 208 for 7 (Russell 64*, Salt 54, Ramandeep 35, Natarajan 3-32) beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 204 for 7 (Klaasen 63, Abishek 32, Agarwal 32) by four runs

Heinrich Klaasen of Sunrisers Hyderabad very nearly stole victory away from Kolkata Knight Riders at Eden Gardens on Saturday, but the 22-year-old Harshit Rana successfully defended 12 off the final over to take KKR over the line in a last-ball thriller.

With momentum on their side, Sunrisers had a dream start to the 20th over when Klaasen pulled Harshit for six over square leg. But the seamer followed it up with two singles, two wickets and one dot in the next five balls to seal the deal.

Earlier, it was Sunil Narine's 1 for 19 in four overs on a batting-friendly surface - the spell included zero boundaries - which kept Sunrisers quiet through the middle overs. His economy of 4.75 was a complete outlier on a surface where bowlers, whether experienced or not, went for a lot. That had given KKR the upper hand with three overs to go, with Sunrisers needing 60 in 18 balls. But Klaasen's 29-ball 63, laced with eight sixes, dragged Sunrisers back into the contest.

KKR also had Andre Russell, Phil Salt and Ramandeep Singh to thank for their first-innings score of 208. From 51 for 4, the hosts rebuilt courtesy Salt's 40-ball 54 on KKR debut and a 17-ball 35 from Ramandeep. Russell put the finishing touches to the KKR innings by smacking seven sixes in his 25-ball, unbeaten 64.

Klaasen's near-heist

The last 18 months have belonged to Klaasen, who has turned into a rampaging spin-hitter to go with his strong range of shots against pace. He came in at No. 5 with Sunrisers needing 102 in 8.2 overs. Even though he started slowly, he found his range against Varun Chakravarthy, racing from six in seven balls to 18 off 12 with the help of two sixes in the 14th over.

When Chakravarthy returned for the 18th and the target looking improbable, Klaasen again opened his shoulders by pummelling two more sixes. Then when Mitchell Starc, the most expensive player in IPL history, returned to close out the game in the 19th over, Klaasen clubbed him for three sixes in a 26-run over.

With 47 runs scored in the 18th and 19th overs, Sunrisers had turned the game around. The 12-ball assault had sent ESPNcricinfo's forecaster swinging from being 99.27% in favour of KKR to putting Sunrisers at 81.95% favourites before the final over. However, Klaasen's dismissal at the hands of Harshit, one ball after smacking his eighth six, deflated Sunrisers and allowed KKR to close the game out.

Heinrich Klaasen single-handedly took it deep for Sunrisers Hyderabad•BCCI

Russell mauls Bhuvneshwar and Co

With just six overs to go in the first innings, KKR were 123 for 6 and still needed a glorious finish if they were to reach 200.

After scoring two runs in his first five balls, Russell ruined Mayank Markande's bowling figures by muscling three sixes in the 16th over - two down the ground and one over midwicket - to race to 20 off 11.

When Bhuvneshwar Kumar returned for his back-end spell, Russell made full use of a favourable match-up to maul the experienced pacer, hitting six and four in the 17th, with Rinku Singh adding another boundary in an 18-run over.

The 18th bowled by T Natarajan also went for 15, and when Bhuvneshwar returned for the 19th, Russell clobbered him for four, six, six and four - using his power and the small boundaries to muscle 26 runs. In the process, he also hit his 200th six for KKR in franchise cricket and reached his fifty in 20 balls.

That helped KKR touch 200 in 19 overs even as Rinku fell for a 13-ball 25 to become Natarajan's third scalp of the night. Russell finished unbeaten on 64 at a strike rate of 256 as Sunrisers conceded 85 runs in the last five overs to end up chasing an improbable 209.

2:54

Moody: Six-hitting machine Russell showed why he's paid the big bucks

Narine stifles Sunrisers after powerplay

Twin 32s at a rapid pace from openers Mayank Agarwal and Abhishek Sharma gave Sunrisers the kind of start they needed to chase down 209, a target that would've required the fourth-highest chase in IPL history. But both fell in the sixth and eighth overs to short balls from Harshit and Russell respectively. It was around that time, just after the powerplay had ended, that Shreyas Iyer went to Narine.

Narine bowled consistently on a good length and found turn in both directions to keep Rahul Tripathi and Markram quiet. He conceded only two runs in his opening over and very nearly had Tripathi dismissed in his second when the batter mistimed a slog sweep. But a dropped chance from Chakravarthy gave Tripathi a second life.

Tripathi would then receive a third life when Narine had him pinned in front of the stumps in the 11th over. But the umpire turned the appeal down and KKR did not review it.

When Narine finally dismissed Tripathi in the 17th over, caught at deep square leg off the penultimate ball of his spell, he let out a roar, a rare display of emotion, as he earned just rewards for his impressive spell. Narine finished with eight dots bowled and zero boundaries conceded.

Salt finds support in Ramandeep

The KKR innings had begun disastrously when Narine - promoted to open again - fell cheaply to a run-out. Then Natarajan picked off Venkatesh Iyer (7) and Shreyas (0) in the same over to leave KKR 32 for 3.

That forced Salt to rein his shot-making in, having initially started his innings with a hat-trick of sixes off Marco Jansen. The KKR batters, Salt included, struggled when Bhuvneshwar bowled in the fourth-stump channel in the powerplay, and by the eighth over they were 51 for 4 when Nitish Rana reverse swept Markande to backward point.

But in No. 6 Ramandeep, Salt found a partner who could counterattack. Ramandeep was not intimidated by the short-ball barrage attempted by Sunrisers captain Pat Cummins or Marco Jansen. He pulled both bowlers for sixes in the ninth and 11th overs respectively and then began the 12th with an inside-out six off Shahbaz Ahmed. He was eventually caught at cover by a diving Markande off Cummins for a 17-ball 35 but by then he had ensured the KKR innings did not stagnate in the middle overs.

Salt finally reached his third IPL fifty in the 14th over off Markande's bowling and looked disappointed when he fell for 54 in the same over. However, a KKR recovery from 51 for 4 to 119 for 6 in the space of 6.2 overs had given Rinku and Russell enough of a platform to capitalise on. And capitalise they did.

MATCH 4

Rajasthan Royals 193 for 4 (Samson 82*, Parag 43) beat Lucknow Super Giants 173 for 6 (Pooran 64*, Rahul 58, Boult 2-35) by 20 runs

Sanju Samson led from the front with an unbeaten 82 from 52 balls as Rajasthan Royals opened their IPL campaign with a hard-earned 20-run victory over Lucknow Super Giants in Jaipur.

After winning the toss for his team, Samson's knock was the mainstay of Royals' imposing 193 for 4, and a tight contest hadn't seemed remotely likely when Trent Boult and Nandre Burger reduced LSG to 11 for 3 in the first four overs of their reply.

However, KL Rahul - on his return from injury - teamed up with Nicholas Pooran to take the chase deep in a fifth-wicket stand of 85 from 52 balls that ended from the first ball of the

17th over, as Sandeep Sharma popped up with a priceless spell of death bowling that left LSG with too much to do.

With 38 still needed from 12 balls, Sandeep's penultimate over was arguably even more important, as he limited the hard-swinging Pooran to just a brace of boundaries in an 11-run over, allowing Avesh Khan to close out the contest with ease. Pooran finished unbeaten on 64 from 41 balls.

Samson saves his best for first

Samson certainly knows how to launch an IPL campaign in style. For the fifth consecutive IPL campaign, dating back to 2020, he opened Royals' account with a half-century, this time in an innings featuring three fours and six sixes, the best of which - from the penultimate ball of the innings - was a formidable inside-out drill over extra cover from Mohsin Khan.

The bulk of Samson's work was done in the course of a 93-run stand with Riyan Parag, that spanned 62 balls and bridged a potentially tricky period at the end of the powerplay, in which Jos Buttler's streaky 11 from nine balls, and Yashasvi Jaiswal's more focussed cameo of 24 from 12, had telegraphed a potentially tricky pitch for comfortable strokeplay.

Sanju Samson's 82 powered Rajasthan Royals to a strong total •BCCI

Certainly, LSG's spinners found some purchase on the cracked, dry surface. Krunal Pandya, on his 33rd birthday, wheeled through his four boundary-less overs for 19, and could have dismissed Parag for a golden duck when he induced a leading edge back down the pitch, only for Samson at the non-striker's end to get in the way, completely inadvertently, as he stood his ground with the ball lobbing towards his helmet.

Both men, however, stepped up their intensity after the strategic time-out, when the extra pace of Yash Thakur entered the fray. Three sixes poured forth in a 21-run over, including back-to-back pulls from Samson off undercooked bouncers, and after bringing up Royals' 100 with another six off Ravi Bishnoi in the 11th over, Samson marched onto his fifty from 33 balls - by which stage Parag should have been removed for 29, only for Mohsin at square leg to make a hash of a top-edged sweep.

Lightning Boult strikes twice

Boult and first-over wickets are a staple of the IPL experience. This time, it was Quinton de Kock in his sights at the top of the powerplay, his 24th such victim - second only to Bhuvneshwar Kumar's 27 - and it set in motion a catastrophic top-order implosion for LSG.

De Kock's only scoring shot was a classy punch down the ground to a full-length outswinger, but when Boult fired one into his legs in the same over, he lured a loose flick in the air to Burger at backward fine leg.

Two balls into his second, Boult struck again, delivering a merciless one-two to Devdutt Padikkal, to ensure his reunion with his former Royals team-mates was a miserable one. A

sharp bouncer pinged Padikkal's helmet and sent his neck-guard spinning; Boult's follow-up skidded through low and pegged back his middle and leg stumps as he flapped loosely across the line from deep in the crease.

And LSG reached their nadir one ball into the fourth over, as Burger - the most literal impact sub imaginable - fired down a 147kph delivery that Ayush Badoni could only spoon to Buttler at mid-off. At 11 for 3, the fightback would have to be a remarkable one.

KL Rahul's 58 off 44 balls was in vain • BCCI

Rahul's role in the spotlight

It's a tricky time for Rahul across formats. In the absence of Virat Kohli, he had looked set to be the wise old head in India's Test team, until his untimely injury against England opened the door for the same generation of young guns who are pushing him to the fringes in the white-ball set-up too.

And so, his innings of 58 from 44 balls was an important reminder of his enduring class, albeit his dismissal at the start of the 17th over, caught at deep cover moments after the strategic time-out, effectively spelt the end of LSG's challenge, with first Marcus Stoinis and then Pandya unable to find their timing from the get-go. The fact that he took the gloves, ahead of both Quinton de Kock and Pooran, was arguably a sign of his desire to remind the India selectors of his enduring versatility.

Either way, while it lasted, Rahul's knock provided, first, the stability his team so desperately needed, and latterly the power to stay in touch with a run rate that was pushing two a ball by the tenth over. His own contribution at that point had been a run-a-ball 26, but in crashing the dangerous Burger for 6, 4, 4 from his next three deliveries, he rushed towards a 35-ball fifty, and signalled a charge that would not fizzle until his departure.

Deepak Hooda, LSG's impact sub, has come and gone with a degree of purpose too, making 26 from 13 balls before taking on Yuzvendra Chahal, into the breeze, and holing out at deep midwicket. But it took Pooran's more focussed power to truly ignite his team's belief.

At 102 for 4 in the 12th over, Boult returned for his final over as Royals strove for the partnership-breaking wicket. Pooran was waiting to take him down in a 20-run over that finished with a low full-toss being smashed over wide long-on for six.

Sandeep, however, was still lurking up Samson's sleeve, and his introduction proved pivotal. His first over, in the 15th of the innings, stemmed the flow of boundaries with just five singles, one of which could have been a direct-hit run-out. And when, in his second, Rahul chased his wide line to pick out Dhruv Jurel in the deep, Royals had seized back control.

MATCH 5

Gujarat Titans 168 for 6 (Sudharsan 45, Bumrah 3-14, Coetzee 2-27) beat Mumbai Indians 162 for 9 (Brevis 46, Rohit 43, Mohit 2-32) by six runs

Keep your eyes on Shubman Gill. The captain. With Mumbai Indians on 107 for 2 after 12 overs, chasing 169, he barracked his team to get back in the game. And boy, did they ever.

A batting line-up that is the envy of the T20 world came undone even with conditions pretty much in their favour, with two set batters at the crease and dew all over the park. And Titans, who had less than 8% chance of victory, went on to achieve a famous one. Or maybe it isn't. Because they keep doing this. They keep defying the odds.

Here they had their former captain - the one who built them into IPL winners - give them a huge scare. Hardik Pandya went 6 and 4 to start the last over when 19 were required. He looked in the mood. His old coach Ashish Nehra, who spent a vast majority of the chase patrolling the boundary, issuing instructions - seemingly spoon-feeding Spencer Johnson what he had to do in a 19th over that produced two of the five wickets that fell in the last 13 balls - turned away. He couldn't watch.

But he should have. Because Umesh Yadav, who doesn't really bowl at the death, took full advantage of the two-bouncers-an-over rule and sent one up at Hardik's right ear, which, even with his power, only went as far as the fielder at long-on. Eighty thousand and eighty one people roared in unison. They sensed it. They sensed that yet another incredible win was theirs.

Pace off, game on

This game turned between overs 13 and 17 in the chase. Because only one of them yielded more than a-run-a-ball.

R Sai Kishore, who doesn't always make the Titans XI but has never come across like he's been on the outside looking in, produced a very mature performance. He took out Rohit Sharma with some style, slowing his pace right down, pulling his length right back, and having an excellent player of spin so badly reaching for the ball that he fell over in his crease as he played the sweep.

Sai Kishore picked up the all-important wicket of Rohit Sharma •BCCI

Rashid Khan took over from there on and created a moment that signalled the shifting of the balance. Mumbai's best power-hitter, Tim David, was hidden from the strike because he has been averaging 7.6 against legspin since IPL 2022. This was the 17th over and the required rate was still in the eight-and-a-bit range. The batting side had six wickets in hand. They really shouldn't have been under pressure with an equation like that.

But they were and the wickets as a result of that pressure went to Mohit Sharma, who is a wonderful case study because his biggest strength goes against his job description. The fast bowler who is far more dangerous when he bowls his slower ball. That came in very handy on a two-paced pitch. He dismissed David with an offcutter-boucnar that rose up to the batter's helmet and took away all his power.

A Titans comeback, which only ever looked fanciful till then, became reality.

The story of the first innings

The Titans innings was a bit staccato. Five of their 20 overs produced five or fewer runs. Four others produced 60 - including 30 back-to-back from the 10th and 11th - and 19 from the 18th over where Luke Wood lost his plans. The field was set for the slower ball, his slower ball went for six, he went for pace, and it was too easy for Rahul Tewatia with third in the circle. A two-paced pitch - which kept low too at times - was creating this kind of game.

Gill made a fast start (31 off 22) and Sai Sudharsan (45 off 39) kept away the doubt that fills a batter's mind when very few of the shots they play go for boundaries. He hit only four and his strike rate was 115 but in between innings he mentioned that the ball was holding up in the pitch and keeping low as well, and that they weren't too displeased with the total they had got to.

Bumrah magic in vain

Jasprit Bumrah bowled only one of the first six overs and perhaps that's why they yielded 47 runs. He struck with a glorious yorker thudding into the base of Wriddhiman Saha's middle stump. This was vintage from perhaps the best cricketer on the planet right now. The most inimitable one anyway.

Jasprit Bumrah's double-wicket 17th over put the brakes on Gujarat Titans' scoring •BCCI

Bumrah's dismissal of David Miller contained even more of his genius. He has that awkward action. He has unbelievable pace (for a guy who basically walks for about half his run-up). He has the best yorker in the business. The batter has all this in mind when he takes strike. And is completely unprepared for the slower ball.

Miller was done. He was cooked. His body moving one way - because his feet were stuck on the crease, worried about the high-pace ball, maybe the yorker - and his bat moving the other - responding to the utter lack of pace, wandering so far in front of his body - his balance lost to the night. And so too his wicket.

Bumrah finished with figures of 4-0-14-3. All of them were one over spells. He was given no opportunity to build rhythm because he can be peak right from the get-go. It was unthinkable at that point that he'd also be needed out there with bat, but you always run the risk of that when you play Titans.

MATCH 6

Royal Challengers Bengaluru 178 for 6 (Kohli 77, Karthik 28*, Brar 2-13, Rabada 2-23) beat Punjab Kings 176 for 6 (Dhawan 45, Jitesh 27, Siraj 2-26, Maxwell 2-29) by four wickets

A Virat Kohli masterclass in a tricky chase at a packed Chinnaswamy Stadium. A last-over thriller. An RCB win.

Everything that Royal Challengers Bengaluru fans would have wanted from their team's first home game of the season, they got it. In spades. But, it didn't come without a scare.

For the longest time, Kohli - the king of the chase - had things under control. Chasing 177, he had the crowd dancing to his tune as he smashed the Punjab Kings bowlers all around the park for a 49-ball 77.

Till he didn't.

Harpreet Brar's frugal spell of 2 for 13 after Kagiso Rabada's two-wicket burst in the powerplay had RCB in a bind. The crowd was silenced. Were RCB going to become the first team this IPL to lose a home game?

Enter finisher Dinesh Karthik.

His bio says he is 38. He is! But you wouldn't believe that seeing him move around the crease, and up and down the pitch. With RCB requiring 47 off 22, Karthik walked in and smoked an unbeaten 28 off ten balls, with three fours and two sixes, to take RCB over the line with four balls to spare.

Virat Kohli did the early scoring in RCB's chase and ended with a 49-ball 77•BCCI

A Kohli special for the Chinnaswamy to remember

But, it so nearly wasn't.

Striding out to bat with a vociferous crowd behind him, Kohli took strike. Sam Curran got the ball to tail away from him first ball. It took a thick edge and went to short third. The next ball, Curran went closer, inviting a drive. Kohli took the bait and got a thick edge but the ball went too fast for Bairstow to react at first slip and burst through his hands. That was just the luck Kohli needed. He drove Curran through the covers next ball, then clipped him past short fine-leg, before creaming a half-volley through the covers to make it 16 runs off the first over.

Rabada then came on but Kohli was in no mood to show any respect, haring down the track and slamming him over cover. Kohli then took on Arshdeep Singh, thumping him for three fours in an over to race to 33 off 15 balls, the most runs he has scored in the first 15 balls ever in a T20 innings. Eight fours in his first 15 balls. Kohli was away, RCB were away.

Harpreet Brar bowled brilliantly, keeping RCB quiet and picking up wickets at the same time•Associated Press

RCB slow down, courtesy Brar and Rabada

Rabada got among the wickets first. He accounted for Faf du Plessis - the third time in three IPL innings - and then had Cameron Green edging behind with Jitesh Sharma taking a good low catch.

The real squeeze, though, was applied by Harpreet Brar and he did it with his length.

Four overs, 13 runs, two wickets and that's while Kohli was on a rampage.

Sixteen of the 24 balls Brar bowled were on a length. From quite high up. He kept the speed on the quicker side, and more importantly, didn't give the batters a chance to get under the ball. Both his wickets came off balls bowled at a length.

Rajat Patidar, frustrated at not getting anything away, went back to a flatter delivery looking for a hoick to the leg side, but missed and looked back to see his stumps in a mess. Glenn Maxwell then tried to open the off side up but was undone by an arm ball, and could only get an under-edge back on to his stumps. Brar did not concede a single boundary in his four-over spell. In fact, he only went for one double. The rest of it was all singles.

Dinesh Karthik lived up to his billing as a cool finisher • BCCI

The scare and the finish

Kohli, meanwhile, reached his 100th 50-plus score in T20 cricket. But the required rate was soaring. He got two fours away off Harshal but fell soon after with his slash reaching only as far as deep third. Anuj Rawat fell two balls later and the equation suddenly seemed to be going out of hand for RCB.

Karthik, though, found an ally in Mahipal Lomror, the impact sub. Lomror clipped Curran past short fine-leg for four first ball and then slammed Arshdeep for a six and four next over. Karthik took over after that as Harshal Patel leaked 13 off the penultimate over. With ten to win in the final over, Karthik brought out the scoop first ball against Arshdeep for six. A wide followed, before Karthik aced the chase with a hit over the bowler's head.

The Chinnaswamy went delirious, and so did the RCB changeroom.

But there were big performances in the first half of the match too.

1:29

Yash Dayal was 'absolutely phenomenal' in powerplay - McClenaghan

Yash Dayal puts the brakes on in the powerplay

Before Monday, Yash Dayal had played only one game at M Chinnaswamy Stadium in his T20 career. That was last season against RCB when he was with Gujarat Titans. He didn't have the best of times finishing with 1 for 39 off his four overs.

But on the day, or night, Dayal was on the money.

He bowled three overs in the powerplay and went for just ten runs, conceding only one four.

Mohammed Siraj was picked up for a four first ball of the innings, and then conceded two more against Jonny Bairstow, but he had the last laugh. Bairstow took a swipe at a length ball, only to get a top-edge that ballooned straight up.

Dayal kept things tight at the other end, even if he didn't get wickets.

It was that Test-match length that did the job for him. He kept the ball short of a good length 12 out of 18 times in the first six overs, and went for just four runs with those. There was not a lot of swing on offer, but he made sure to keep the ball as close to the batter, and found just a hint of movement, not giving room to the batters to swing. The Kings batters could only manage 40 for 1 in the first six overs.

1:07

'Punjab Kings' tactics an absolute disaster'

RCB chip away with the ball

None of the Kings batters were able to convert their starts into anything substantial. Shikhar Dhawan scored 45 but took 37 balls for it. Prabhsimran Singh got 25, Jitesh 27, Liam Livingstone 17. And that hurt them as RCB kept chipping away.

Maxwell picked up two wickets in the middle over, while Siraj also got two and it seemed Kings would fall well short of a par score, which is quite high at the venue. But Shashank Singh clobbered Alzarri Joseph for two sixes and a four in the last over to take Kings to a respectable total, even if it seemed a bit below par at the halfway stage. And that's how it turned out to be.

MATCH 7

Chennai Super Kings 206 for 6 (Dube 51, Ravindra 46) beat Gujarat Titans 143 for 8 (Sudharsan 37, Chahar 2-28, Deshpande 2-21) by 63 runs

The new faces of Chennai Super Kings impressed against the team they took down in the IPL 2023 final, signalling that the post-MS Dhoni era could also be filled with lots of success.

Rachin Ravindra (46 off 20), Shivam Dube (51 off 23), Sameer Rizvi (14 off 6) and the captain Rituraj Gaikwad himself (46 off 36) led them to a total of 206, which proved plenty more than enough for a bowling attack that is also undergoing change.

Gill fined for slow over rate

Shubman Gill, the Gujarat Titans captain, has been fined after his team maintained a slow over rate during their match against Chennai Super Kings on Tuesday. As it was Titans' first such offence of the season, Gill received a fine of INR 12 lakhs.

For the second game running, Chopra offered no wickets to the home team's spinners. Instead, it was the fast bowlers led by Deepak Chahar (2 for 28) and Tushar Deshpande (2 for 21) who did all the damage. The times, they are a'changin'.

Rachiiiiin Rachin!

Rachin is a back-foot player. Yet his drives are the best part of his game. They look so natural. Almost instinctive. This is basically a result of a switch in mindset, which was very apparent at the ODI World Cup, where he gave himself permission to go hard at the ball. Now watching him, there's almost no bias.

He was straight-driving sixes. He was front-foot pulling boundaries. He was pouncing on rare short balls from Rashid Khan. This was a batter showing off just how early he was picking length and just how good his hand-eye coordination is. He was never out of position. He was never rushed. He never even looked like he was trying. His 46 off 20 balls is already in the Super Kings hall of fame because he hit nine boundaries, the joint-fifth-most by any CSK batter inside the powerplay in all IPL history.

Dube destroys spin

Left-arm spinner Sai Kishore and Rashid Khan were immense in helping Titans shut down Mumbai Indians in their first match of the season. Here they were almost not allowed to finish their full quota of overs. Because Shivam Dube.

The first ball of the 11th over resulted in Ajinkya Rahane's wicket with the score on 104 for 2. The second and third were sent up into orbit by the one of the league's best spin-hitters.

Dube's story might well be the strongest argument in favour of role-clarity in T20 cricket. Here was a power-hitter who had only one fifty from his first 22 IPL innings because teams kept using him as a finisher. He isn't that, because he is still a work in progress against fast bowling.

All the power he had was going to waste, until CSK came calling in 2022 and decided they'd use him against the slower bowlers; against the kind of people he can just plant that front foot down and use all of his wingspan. Even Rashid wasn't able to keep Dube quiet. That's the quality of his spin-hitting. He has 57 sixes since the switch to yellow and that puts him level with IPL legend Andre Russell and Liam Livingstone and behind only Jos Buttler (59).

Sameer Rizvi hit his first ball in the IPL for six, off Rashid Khan • BCCI

Rizvi rises

At the fall of Dube's wicket, with less than two overs to go, Chopra might have expected Dhoni to stride out to the middle. The camera certainly did. It kept panning to him in the dressing room.

Instead, it was 20-year old Rizvi who stepped up. And he swept the first ball that he faced in the IPL for six. That it happened to be Rashid bowling and that he hit him for another six - this one a bit of a mis-hit as he charged out of his crease and swung himself almost off his feet - only added to the occasion. If this is the new CSK, there's going to be a few more special years ahead.

Pace, not spin, in Chennai

Deepak Chahar was finding that his slower ball wasn't working tonight; that the pitch instead of offering grip only let it slide onto the bat. But Chepauk didn't totally bail on its team. There was a moment in the third over when a little bit of a low bounce resulted in Shubman Gill's wicket. He was lbw while playing that front-foot pull shot with an angled bat that usually goes to the boundary.

More mischief happened as a team that is not really known for their fielding pulled off three incredible catches - Dhoni diving full length to his right to get rid of Vijay Shankar, Ajinkya Rahane running in from midwicket and diving forward to snap up a David Miller helicopter shot at deep midwicket, and Ravindra gobbling up a skier from Azmatullah Omarzai.

The Titans chase never got going. They had only 34 on the board when their openers fell, 114 when their top-scorer Sai Sudharsan fell, and at 129 for 8 they were even in danger of being bowled out. That didn't happen but this loss was their worst in terms of runs in the IPL.

MATCH 8

Sunrisers Hyderabad 277 for 3 (Klaasen 80*, Abhishek 63, Head 62) beat Mumbai Indians 246 for 5 (Tilak 64, David 42*, Cummins 2-35) by 31 runs

Sixes were being hit for fun. Runs were flowing at a breakneck pace. You wouldn't be blamed for thinking you were watching a video game. The carnage in Hyderabad resulted in an 11-year-old IPL record falling, RCB's seemingly insurmountable total of 263 from 2013 falling by the wayside thanks to a breathtaking, collective show from the Sunrisers Hyderabad batters. They notched up the highest total in the 16-year history of the IPL - 277 for 3 - but then, just as incredibly, Mumbai Indians almost paid them back with the same coin, their batters coming out with a nothing-to-lose attitude. Eventually, they ran out of steam and finished on 246 for 5, the highest IPL total in a losing cause.

Travis Head set the pace on the night, striking an 18-ball half-century, the fastest for SRH in the IPL. His record lasted roughly four overs, Abhishek Sharma slamming a 16-ball fifty to relegate him to No. 2. An hour after that, Heinrich Klaasen cut loose to seemingly bat MI out of the contest. But the sixes kept rolling off the Mumbai bats too, helping them keep up with the asking rate for most of the chase, eventually falling only 31 short.

Related

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'They missed a trick up front' - Moody (and Klaasen) on Mumbai holding back Bumrah

IPL and Hawk-Eye join hands to end debate over above-waist no-balls

Stats - Sunrisers break record for highest ever IPL total

Never were more runs scored in a men's T20 match (523). Never were most sixes hit in a men's T20 (38). At the end of the close to four-hour six-fest, only two bowlers returned with an economy rate of under ten an over.

The perfect Head-start

Head, in for Marco Jansen, continued from where he had left off on his previous tour of India. He was off the mark with a four off IPL debutant Kwena Maphaka, the 17-year-old who played for South Africa at the Under-19 World Cup earlier this year. Head was given a life when Tim David dropped him at mid-off off Hardik Pandya's first ball. But there was no looking back from there.

Head smacked two fours and two sixes in a 22-run Maphaka over before hitting two fours and a six off Gerald Coetzee in an over that went for 23 to end the powerplay. Head had scored 59 of the 81 SRH made in the first six overs. In his next over, though, Coetzee bowled a short and wide one, which the batter could only carve to deep backward point.

Abhishek shows his mettle

Head's inclusion in the XI meant Abhishek had to move down the order, and he walked in at No. 3 after Mayank Agarwal fell in the fifth over. Abhishek got going with a pull off Coetzee and then meted out a special treatment to the legspin Piyush Chawla, hitting him for three sixes in an over. That helped SRH notch up their 100 in just seven overs, their second-fastest in the IPL.

Abhishek also tore into Maphaka's third over, hitting him for a sequence of 4, 6, 6, 4 to complete his fifty and snatch the record from Head. The key was how early he picked the length of the bowlers. He hit seven sixes in his 23-ball stay for 63 runs, before heaving a half-tracker that Chawla fired in seam-up at 112.8kph straight to deep midwicket.

Heinrich Klaasen hit another rampaging half-century•AP Photo / Mahesh Kumar

Klaasen, Markram add finishing touches

With nine overs to go and two right-hand batters in the middle, Hardik Pandya sensed an opportunity to get left-arm spinner Shams Mulani in the game. That played into the hands of Klaasen, though, who is a spin-basher. In T20s since January 2022, no batter who has faced at least 500 balls had a higher strike rate against spin than Klaasen's 174.38 before the start of the game.

True to form, he smacked Mulani over long-off to get his rhythm going. Klaasen then hit a six each off Hardik and Jasprit Bumrah as SRH crossed 200 in the 15th over. Aiden Markram,

at the other end, hit a six and a four but was happy to give the strike to his South Africa team-mate. Klaasen brought up his fifty off 22 balls, which was only the third quickest on the night.

Klaasen hit two successive sixes in the last over bowled by Mulani to take Sunrisers past RCB's record score. SRH added 63 in the last four overs to post the fourth-highest total in all men's T20s.

Mumbai lose their fizz

Rohit Sharma and Ishan Kishan kicked off Mumbai's reply in fine fashion. Rohit muscled Bhuvneshwar Kumar down the ground before hitting Jaydev Unadkat - brought in for T Natarajan, who had a niggle - for back-to-back sixes. Kishan meanwhile took 23 off Bhuvneshwar's second over, hitting him for a four and three sixes. Kishan then slogged Shahbaz Ahmed to deep midwicket, but Rohit kept going.

He whipped Pat Cummins' second ball over midwicket before miscuing a pull to fall for 26 off just 12. Only twice in the IPL has Rohit scored more - 37 in April 2015 vs RCB, and 27 in May 2015 vs Chennai Super Kings - off the first 12 balls he faced.

Naman Dhir and Tilak Varma also kept Mumbai abreast with the required rate. They found boundaries regularly, with Tilak leading the charge, and added 84 off 37 for the third wicket. But once they fell within 21 balls of each other, MI lost momentum. David managed to hit a few into the stands, but by then it was too late.

MATCH 9

Rajasthan Royals 185 for 5 (Parag 84, Ashwin 29, Axar 1-21, Khaleel 1-24) beat Delhi Capitals 173 for 5 (Warner 49, Stubbs 44*, Chahal 2-19, Burger 2-29) by 12 runs

On a night that their big three batters managed 31 off 37 between them, Rajasthan Royals overcame a big conditions handicap through what many feel is the coming of age of Riyan Parag. When the ball seamed and swung, accounting for Yashasvi Jaiswal, Sanju Samson and Jos Buttler, Parag played watchfully but turned 16 off 20 into a match-winning 84 off 45.

Despite the Parag assault, Delhi Capitals would have felt confident they could chase down 186 what with the dew and reduced seam movement on offer, but Nandre Burger, Royals' Impact Player, made early dents with the ball, Yuzvendra Chahal picked wickets, and Avesh Khan and Sandeep Sharma closed out superbly with yorkers and wide lines.

RR batters dance to the ball's tune

DC's new-ball bowlers might not have the extreme pace, but Mukesh Kumar and Khaleel Ahmed maximised the early seam movement by bowling areas where they kept attacking the stumps. Even though RR looked to weather the storm, they couldn't afford to do so for too long lest they batted themselves out of the game.

Related

It's time to change your opinion about Riyan Parag, even if he won't

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Sangakkara: Maturity and hunger set Riyan Parag 2.0 apart

Parag: I have the power to deal with yorkers, short balls

Mukesh bowled Jaiswal, Khaleel drew an edge from Samson during his third over in the powerplay, and Kuldeep Yadav trapped Buttler lbw on the reverse-sweep. At 36 for 3 in the eighth over, it could be argued decisive damage had been caused already.

Ashwin the batter takes flight

Even as Parag struggled to reach even a run a ball in the first half of his innings, R Ashwin was promoted and he hit three sixes. The idea probably was to delay the introduction of Shimron Hetmyer and, in the process, make sure they didn't use their Impact substitution on a batter. Not only did Ashwin hold out until the ideal point of entry for the bigger hitters, he hit DC's best bowlers on paper, Kuldeep and Anrich Nortje, for three sixes. These blows took RR's run rate past six for the first time. In the 11th over of the innings.

Parag takes over

Playing on painkillers and flu medication after three days of illness, Parag took over after Ashwin got out. The switch up started with a pulled six off Kuldeep in the 13th over, continued with 6,4 and 4 in the 15th to somewhat damage Khaleel's figures, and ended with a glorious takedown of Nortje in the 20th over, which went for two sixes and 25 runs in all. Hetmyer, who started his innings in the 18th over, ended with an unbeaten 14 off seven.

Sizzling Burger worth the wait

It was clear RR were going lengths to get the services of Burger over Powell. The Parag assault in the final third of the innings helped them make their minds up. And Burger immediately vindicated the decision by getting rid of the marauding Mitchell Marsh and Ricky Bhui in the fourth over. On a night that Trent Boult went wicketless, forget taking his usual first-over wicket, Burger made sure RR caused the early damage. Marsh was bowled through swing at high space, and Bhui gloved a bouncer.

Chahal and Co apply middle-overs squeeze

The two big left-arm seamers took on the challenge of bowling inside the powerplay, which also probably meant less pressure on the remaining four bowlers to bowl 14 between them.

3:23

Moody: Sandeep is the most underrated bowler in the IPL

David Warner looked threatening, especially with a known asking rate and the conditions generally improving for batting, but then Avesh got him out with a full and wide ball. Pundits have already pointed out his open front foot has opened up the off side on straight balls but has also taken him far away from the ball when it is bowled wide. It seemed here that he took out a fishing pole to reach this one, and the edge flew to Sandeep at short third.

Yuzvendra Chahal then took out two left-hand batters, Risbhabh Pant and Ishan Porel. Ashwin could have ended the match in the 17th over had Boult taken the straightforward catch from Tristan Stubbs, but the reprieved batter made it interesting with three sixes and a four off the next six balls that he faced. However, 22 off 10 is the closest the equation would get for them as Sandeep and Avesh nailed their yorkers and kept making the batters hit into the bigger boundary.

MATCH 10

Kolkata Knight Riders 186 for 3 (Venkatesh 50, Narine 47) beat Royal Challengers Bengaluru 182 for 6 (Kohli 83*, Russell 2-29, Rana 2-39) by seven wickets

It took 10 matches for IPL 2024 to produce a victory by the away team. Though it was perhaps predictable that it came at the M Chinnaswamy stadium, where the small ground really does favour the chasing team. That, on Friday, was Kolkata Knight Riders, who overcame a Virat Kohli masterclass to chase down 183 and claim the two points.

Narine stars in 500th game

KKR's opening partnership had been a problem area in recent years. But they won this game with it. They had to score a lot of their target inside the first six overs, not just because of the field restrictions, but because that's when the ball is hard and new and that's when it comes onto the bat. RCB's innings already showed that as it got softer and older, going into the wicket and taking pace off became mighty effective. Andre Russell (2-29) and Harshit Rana (2-39) used it to good effect.

This, though, is the KKR gameplan regardless of the venue they're playing at because they keep using Sunil Narine at the top, giving him a licence to play those 30 off 10 cameos. He overachieved, which was fitting on his 500th T20, making 47 off 22. Phil Salt did plenty of damage too. He very nearly didn't play this IPL. At the end of the powerplay, KKR had 85 for 0. They'd taken down almost 50% of their target in just 30% of the overs with 100% of their wickets still in hand.

Upon that platform, Venkatesh Iyer raised a half-century and Shreyas Iyer ensured he was there till the end, which came as early as the 17th over. RCB's lopsided line-up - world-class batters and inexperienced bowlers - was laid bare. The most economical of their three main bowlers was Yash Dayal (11.5)

Venkatesh Iyer worked past back pain and made a half-century • Associated Press

Kohli going big

"I've still got it," he said, before realising he's being broadcast all over the world and he needed to be a bit less. "I guess."

Kohli has often said he has nothing to prove, but the fact that he said that at the end of RCB's last match suggests there has been talk about the way he bats in T20 cricket.

Usually cricketers don't get riled up by talk that comes from outside. That's white noise and they spend their whole lives ignoring it, hard though it certainly is.

Kohli saying he's still got it feels like there's some input from within the Indian team about how they want him to go about his business. His performance in this IPL - which has become a bit of a showcase for players hoping to make it to the T20 World Cup in June - has reflected a change in his game.

A previously risk-averse batter, a limited-overs run-machine who sets his stall out to play the whole innings, is willing to put less of a price on his wicket. And he's been doing that by hitting the ball in the air a lot more than he used to. This is from data collected from the 2014 season onwards. It really does tell a tale.

It is well known that Kohli hits pace as well as anybody in world cricket. He smashed Mitchell Starc for 33 in 17 balls with three fours and two sixes. The revelation was he was showing the same kind of intent against the slow bowlers. Having hit Narine for just one six in 106 balls across all IPLs, Kohli launched the mystery spinner out of the Chinnaswamy off just the fifth ball on Friday. In the course of this belligerence, he went past Chris Gayle (239) as RCB's most prolific six-hitter (241).

The Chinnaswamy disadvantage

Faf du Plessis, in the post-match presentation, mentioned that RCB did try to take the learning from the first innings - how the slower balls were sticking in the surface - and put it to use but they were impeded by the dew that had set in. Venkatesh, who was the top-scorer for KKR, mentioned that it got easier for batting at least from one end. How easy?

Well, according to ESPNcricinfo's ball-by-ball data, both RCB and KKR bowled a similar number of slower balls - 21 and 22 - but that still cost RCB 13.42 an over whereas KKR slipped by with an economy rate of 5.45. Russell was particularly hard to hit, varying his pace from 150kph all the way down to the 110s kph. When he does the Narine job and Narine does the Russell job, where is an opposition supposed to go? KKR are looking dangerous this season.

MATCH 11

Lucknow Super Giants 199 for 8 (de Kock 54, Krunal 43*, Curran 3-28) beat Punjab Kings 178 for 5 (Dhawan 70, Mayank 3-27, Mohsin 2-34) by 21 runs

Justin Langer has arrived in the IPL. It took just one game of tired old T20 cricket, and the consequent heavy defeat of course, for Lucknow Super Giants to burn that book of conservative T20 cricket and play with much higher intent. As a result they didn't have the ideal players operating in the death overs of each innings, but they had done enough damage in the middle overs on both occasions to win by 21 runs.

The 103 that LSG scored in the middle overs is the second-highest in their history; both the efforts featured Nicholas Pooran and Marcus Stoinis batting a higher number of balls unlike in the first match when they were held back for the death overs. With the ball, LSG unleashed Mayank Yadav's extreme pace - highest being 155.8kmph - and awkward bounce to take five wickets for 84. As it turned out, they lost out on some runs in the final few overs and had to bowl Krunal Pandya in the 19th, but the game was over by then.

The first step - either made easier by a quad strain or a huge tactical move considering how it is near-impossible to remove Indian captains - was to give the captaincy to Pooran, leaving KL Rahul with just batting responsibilities.

The enterprising start

It would be indulging in pop psychology to say if that meant Rahul batted with more intent because he had only one field to make an impact in, but the change was there for all to see. Having taken the dew on by batting first, LSG needed all the intent from everyone. Rahul began attacking from the fourth ball he faced, didn't stop after hitting a six and a four in the next over, and Quinton de Kock batted the way he usually does.

The intent might have resulted in two wickets but LSG managed 54 runs in the powerplay.

Pooran, and best-laid plans

The first two overs after the powerplay suggested it might be difficult to take down spin, but in the third, Stoinis, batting much earlier than in the last game, punished Rahul Chahar's errors in length brutally with two sixes, and got out trying for a third six in the same over.

The introduction of Pooran as early as in the ninth over meant Kings took off both their spinners despite Harpreet Brar's four-run first over and a decent record against left-hand batters this IPL.

Two overs in, it was plain why spin was taken off. Pooran slogged a wrong'un from Chahar over the longer boundary for a six followed by a cut for four in front of square and then just a nonchalant loft back over his head for another six.

The slightly slower finish

This kind of batting can, at times, result in wickets. LSG had played only three overseas players in the first XI so their choice of the fourth would be between Ashton Turner and Naveen-ul-Haq. When de Kock fell in the 14th over for 53, or when Pooran did in the 16th

for 42, LSG didn't make any panicked move, trusting Naveen over the limited marginal impact a batter could make over Krunal and Ayush Badoni.

Krunal did his part of the job well by scoring 43 off 22. The last nine balls got LSG only 10 runs, but they had effectively decided the extra runs they could have got off such deliveries was not worth giving up middle-overs runs for.

Jonny Bairstow and Shikhar Dhawan put on a 102-run opening partnership•BCCI

Kings set off running

Under the lights, a bit of dew, and nice medium pace to work with, Shikhar Dhawan and Jonny Bairstow made a quick start to their chase, taking 61 in the first six overs. Dhawan got to a fifty off just 30 balls, the exact required rate to win the match. Like Stoinis did after the spin slowdown in the first innings, Bairstow broke the shackles with two sixes off Bishnoi in the ninth over.

Enter Mayank Yadav

Langer is not the only who "arrived" on Saturday night. Mayank is a 21-year-old fast bowler from Delhi who has had to struggle with injuries. LSG scouted him and looked after him while he was injured during the Ranji Trophy season. When they unleashed Mayank, Kings needed to go at pretty much the same asking rate as at the start of the innings and had all their wickets in hand.

They weren't quite prepared for the unerring pace of Mayank, though. He kept bowling uncomfortable lengths, went past 155kmph, and took out three batters, all three with the short ball, all three late on the shot. Bishnoi did his job at the other end, bowling the 11th over for just three. Mohsin Khan kept the pressure up. An injury to Liam Livingstone, which reduced him to hobbling between the wicket, didn't help Kings.

Dhawan went from 50 off 30 to caught on 70 off 50. He later acknowledged how he tried to use Mayank's pace by moving around, and Mayank immediately started bowling yorkers at the stumps.

LSG kept going for wickets, which is acknowledgement that even the best can get hit at the death so they are probably better off bowling in phases that have more correlation between quality and outcomes. By the time that they went to that one "weak" over, LSG had 48 to defend in the last two. Krunal conceded only seven.

MATCH 12

Gujarat Titans 168 for 3 (Sai Sudharsan 45, Miller 44*, Cummins 1-28) beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 162 for 8 (Samad 29, Abhishek 29, Mohit 3-25, Noor 1-32) by seven wickets

Pat Cummins won the toss in Ahmedabad, but unlike the ODI World Cup final, he did not make the right call as Sunrisers Hyderabad's score of 162 for 8 was comfortably chased by Gujarat Titans in Ahmedabad to make it 11 wins out of 12 for home teams in IPL 2024.

Noor Ahmad, Mohit Sharma and former Sunriser Rashid Khan suffocated the big-hitting team in orange to keep them down to a below-par score, and as the surface got better in the evening, the Titans rode on contributions from Shubman Gill, Sai Sudharsan and David Miller to see them through.

Noor, Rashid rock Sunrisers

An afternoon start in Ahmedabad promised a dry surface with help for spinners, and that's why Cummins wanted Sunrisers to make first use of the pitch. Expecting the same, the Titans dropped fast bowler Spencer Johnson to give left-arm wristspinner Noor his first outing of the season.

Noor struck in his first over when he got a googly to rattle Travis Head's stumps right after the powerplay before the opener could do heavy damage. Noor's googly was particularly effective on this surface. He bowled 13 of them and only conceding ten runs. His spell of 1 for 32, numbers partly ruined by some late hits from Sunrisers, gave Titans their first foothold in this game.

Related

It's all in the plan - how Gill and his bowlers brought SRH down to earth

Noor's bowling also lifted his senior Afghanistan team-mate Rashid, who conceded 49 against Chennai Super Kings in his last game and started Sunday's spell with a 15-run over courtesy Abhishek Sharma's twin sixes.

However, Rashid returned strongly to keep Heinrich Klaasen relatively quiet, and eventually he took him out as well, a skiddy legbreak going on to shatter the stumps in the 14th over. Rashid then made an equal contribution next over in Aiden Markram's dismissal when he dived forward to complete a difficult catch running in from long-on. He finished with 1 for 33 and apart from that catch, also played a role in Abdul Samad's run-out in the final over.

Mohit leaves Sunrisers short

Unlike the Mumbai Indians game - where every Sunrisers batter who got starts went big - they fell after getting set this time. Perhaps the idea was to maximise the runs that a hard-hitting batting-order could generate, but on this occasion, they were dismissed before the big flourish.

One of them was Abhishek, dismissed for 29 via a Mohit cutter. Mohit slowed things down and forced an error from Abhishek by getting a length ball wide and forcing a mis-hit to cover. With the surface assisting pace-off deliveries, Mohit bowled another tidy over against Klaasen and Markram to finish his first spell for 1-12. Titans saved the rest of his overs for

the death and he showed just why they do that, conceding only 13 further runs and picking up two more wickets.

Mohit was instrumental in Sunrisers scoring only 40 runs in their last five overs. The only six he conceded was when he delivered a full toss, but otherwise his playlist of change-up deliveries worked wonderfully. After dismissing Shahbaz Ahmed and Washington Sundar in the 20th over, Mohit led the team out with only 163 to chase, and earned a well-deserved rest, substituted by Sudharsan for the second innings.

David Miller and Sai Sudharsan ensured Gujarat Titans did not slip up in the chase•BCCI

Titans' top three gel well

Like the Titans, the Sunrisers too made a strategic change from their previous game by opting for Washington as the impact player instead of Umran Malik. They also started the bowling innings with Shahbaz's left-arm orthodox spin.

But it soon got clear that as afternoon turned to evening, the pitch had eased off. Wriddhiman Saha began in trademark fashion, attacking the new ball and hit his former Bengal team-mate Shahbaz for a six in the opening over. He then ran down the pitch to hammer Bhuvneshwar Kumar straight back and accepted a gift from Umesh Yadav to deposit a full toss over the leg side. Even though Saha fell in the fifth over to Shahbaz, his 13-ball 25 had given Titans a quick start and allowed Gill to find his feet.

From scoring only 11 in his first 12 balls, Gill hit 25 runs off his next 16 to accelerate after the powerplay. He relied on the odd boundary amid risk-free grounded shots to keep the score moving. Even though Gill holed out for 36 right after the first time-out in the tenth over, he did what Saha helped him do, letting the No. 3 Sudharsan also settle.

Sudharsan struggled to put Markande and Cummins away initially, but changed gears in the 12th over when he found his second boundary against Jaydev Unadkat by driving over mid-off. He then clubbed Cummins and Washington in the space of three balls and played his best shot when he came down the track to hammer Markande for six. Cummins did dismiss him with a slower ball for 45 in the 17th over, but by then the win was almost guaranteed.

Miller puts finishing touch

The year 2024 has been a forgettable one for Miller after two fantastic years of T20 cricket. Coming into the game, he had a strike rate of 119, his lowest in 13 years, and his struggles looked to surface when he could not find a boundary in his first 16 deliveries. But then came a small break as Miller got some treatment for a niggle. After that, he looked a player transformed.

With his mobility hampered, Miller decided there was no point holding anything back and pounced on Markande's predictable full-and-wide deliveries to club a 26-run 16th over. He then picked Cummins' slower balls to club both of them for four in the 17th. And when

Unadkat delivered the first ball of the 20th, Miller saw it land in his arc, and expectedly, sent it out of the park to finish unbeaten on 44.

MATCH 13

Delhi Capitals 191 for 5 (Warner 52, Pant 51, Shaw 43, Pathirana 3-31) beat Chennai Super Kings 171 for 6 (Rahane 45, Dhoni 37*, Mitchell 34, Mukesh 3-21, Khaleel 2-21) by 20 runs

At approximately 11 on Sunday night, Visakhapatnam came alive. 'Hosts' Delhi Capitals were on their way to their first win, but the result suddenly seemed irrelevant.

MS Dhoni strode to the middle to bat for the first time since last year's final and immediately sent the decibel levels soaring, walloping his first ball for four behind square leg and bludgeoning his third through extra-cover.

Pant cops over-rate fine

Delhi Capitals captain Rishabh Pant was fined INR 12 lakh (USD 14,000 approx.) after his team was found to be short of the minimum required over rate after taking time allowances into account. It was his first over-rate offence of IPL 2024.

When he hit Khaleel Ahmed for an inside-out six in the next over, the crowd threatened to blow the roof off. Chennai Super Kings still needed 46 off 12; one run more than a side had ever made off the last two overs to win in the IPL.

Mukesh Kumar was tasked with bowling a clutch over. His figures until then read 2-0-16-3. One more good over would close the game out, more or less, and he delivered, bowling a series of wide yorkers that Dhoni and Ravindra Jadeja couldn't get underneath.

MS Dhoni smoked an unbeaten 37 off 16 in his first innings of IPL 2024•BCCI

The over went for 5, and Super Kings needed 41 off six. Impossible if extras didn't come into it.

That was no reason for the crowd to stop. Dhoni was on strike. They wanted him to turn the clock back. And he did, walloping Anrich Nortje for two fours and two sixes. Dhoni finished 37 not out off 16, Super Kings fell short by 20 runs, but you couldn't quite say if the fans in yellow were disappointed at the result or ecstatic at watching their hero do his thing.

After he scythed a full-toss for six to finish the game, the realisation dawned that the Capitals had picked up their first win of the season, a result set up by David Warner and Rishabh Pant with the bat, and finished off by Khaleel and Mukesh.

Matheesha Pathirana ended with 3 for 31•Associated Press

Shaw, Warner lay down the marker

Prithvi Shaw made 106 runs in eight innings in IPL 2023, at an average of 13.25. When he didn't begin the season, you wondered if the Delhi Capitals were looking beyond him already.

Turns out they weren't.

Coming in for local boy Ricky Bhui and slotting in at the top of the order, Shaw laid the foundation with a 93-run opening stand in 9.3 overs with David Warner.

All the trademark elements of a Shaw innings were on display: sumptuous driving, fierce cuts and delectable wristwork. Warner was more muscle, but he also had a tantalising effect with his leg-side strokeplay. When he brought up his half-century off just 32 balls, Capitals were flying.

Rishabh Pant hit four fours and three sixes•BCCI

Pathirana makes a splash

You didn't know until last week if Matheesha Pathirana would feature in the tournament at all. But in taking a blinder at short third in the 10th over, leaping full-stretch and pulling off a one-handed stunner while airborne, he put to rest any concerns over his back. Warner saw his jaw-drop in disbelief at the athleticism, and had to drag himself off.

Pathirana was only warming up.

His second act was even more sensational, even though it's something we've come to expect.

A ball after being dismissed for six in the 15th over, he splayed Mitchell Marsh's middle stump with a pinpoint yorker. Two balls later, he had Tristan Stubbs with another toe-crusher. Capitals were fast ceding momentum, and by the end of that over had slipped to 134 for 4.

Pant comes to the party

The early part of Pant's innings seemed like a struggle. He kept losing his shape when balls were dug into the pitch on a length. At 23 off 23, the frustration seemed all too evident. But he backed himself to emerge from the rut, and when he did, it was breathtaking.

He took down Mustafizur Rahman first and Pathirana next, peppering the long-on boundary with his strong bottom hand and the shovel he's known for. When he sliced Pathirana in the same over to the point boundary, he'd brought up a 31-ball half-century. A 19th over that went for 17 helped give Capitals momentum to finish on 191 for 5.

Khaleel Ahmed put Capitals on top with the early wickets of Ruturaj Gaikwad and Rachin Ravindra•BCCI

Khaleel's stunning spell

3-0-9-2.

The left-arm quick left Super Kings in a rut right at the top. Ruturaj Gaikwad was taken out by late seam movement back in. Rachin Ravindra holed out to mid-on, frustrated by his inability to put bat on ball. Khaleel's first 12 balls brought three runs.

Daryl Mitchell and Ajinkya Rahane treaded cautiously, seemingly to try and bat deep. Occasionally, they played shots that delighted the purist. Like a flicked six by Rahane off Rasikh Salam. The pair revived the innings with a 68-run stand, but the asking rate had swelled to 11.70 with 10 overs remaining.

Capitals didn't have Kuldeep Yadav due to a niggle. Axar Patel had a job to do. And he broke the partnership by having Mitchell caught and bowled. He could have had Impact Sub Shivam Dube third ball as he tried to hack one over cow corner, but the bottom edge was put down by Pant.

Mukesh leaves his imprint

Tasked to bowl the tough overs, Mukesh picked up two in his first over, the 14th, to leave Super Kings gasping. He felled Rahane with a slower one that he hit to long-on, and Sameer Rizvi with a superb seam-up delivery that he nicked to short third.

With Super Kings needing 79 off 30, Anrich Nortje bowled a gun third over full of wide yorkers to deny the batters. The over went for just seven and all the pressure that had crept up consumed Shivam Dube as he picked out long-off in the 17th over to give Mukesh his third wicket.

The game seemed done. And then Dhoni walked out, sending everyone into throwback mode even though the game had gone beyond Super Kings' reach.

MATCH 14

Rajasthan Royals 127 for 4 (Parag 54*, Madhwal 3-20) beat Mumbai Indians 125 for 9 (Hardik 34, Tilak 32, Chahal 3-11, Boult 3-22, Burger 2-32) by six wickets

Hardik Pandya's return to the Wankhede Stadium as Mumbai Indians captain was far from a fairy tale, as the five-time champions lost their third game in a row, this time with 27 balls to spare. Rajasthan Royals - led by superb performances from Trent Boult, Yuzvendra Chahal and Riyan Parag - gave them a thorough hammering to move to No. 1 on the points table with a hat-trick of victories.

Boult left Mumbai gasping within minutes of the start of the match when he dismissed Rohit Sharma, Naman Dhir and Dewald Brevis for first-ball ducks in his first eight balls. His 3 for 22 was only matched by the 3 for 11 taken by Chahal, who controlled the middle overs to ensure Mumbai did not stage a batting comeback.

Chasing 126 for victory, Parag dragged Royals out of some early trouble and shepherded the chase. He finished the game with six, six, and four to stay unbeaten on 54 to take the No. 1 spot on the orange cap leaderboard - tied on runs with Virat Kohli but ahead of strike rate.

Boult sets up the demolition job

Rohit had all the support from the crowd, who chanted his name even as they booed Hardik, but his time with the bat lasted only one ball when Boult got one to swing away from him and get him to edge it behind. Next ball, Boult swung it the other way, getting a full ball to nip into Dhir.

With two wickets gone inside the game's first six balls, Mumbai brought in impact sub Brevis in the second over itself, but he too fell prey to the ball angling across, edging it to Nandre Burger at short third.

Trent Boult picked up three wickets in his first eight balls - par for the course • Associated Press

With three wickets in his first eight deliveries of the game, Boult gave Royals an advantage that they never let go.

Scintillating Chahal

After Boult's searing opening spell, Burger got in on the action. Playing as a replacement for the injured Sandeep Sharma, Burger came around the wicket to pick off Ishan Kishan with a length ball that angled away and took his edge.

With Mumbai Indians 20 for 4 in three-and-a-half overs, Tilak Varma and Hardik looked to build a recovery, almost succeeding with a 56-run fifth-wicket stand, but Chahal dismissed both batters to snuff out any chance of a comeback.

After hitting six boundaries early in his innings, Hardik fell on 34 when he holed out at mid-on trying to hit Chahal. Tilak was sent packing on 32 soon after when Chahal's googly was edged to R Ashwin at short third.

Chahal finished his spell with the wicket of Gerald Coetzee late in the innings. In all, 16 of Chahal's 24 deliveries were dots, and his four-over spell ended with an economy of only 2.75.

A late wicket for Avesh Khan and a second for Burger ensured Mumbai finished on 125 for 9, a score too low on a surface that is traditionally batting-friendly.

Madhwal comes good on season debut

Only wickets could save Mumbai after that batting effort, and they played their trump card early when Jasprit Bumrah shared the new ball, with Kwena Maphaka, for the first time this season.

But even though Bumrah bowled three of the six powerplay overs, the Royals batters did not give a wicket away to him. Yashasvi Jaiswal fell to Maphaka in the first over itself, while the other three wickets went to Akash Madhwal, playing his first game of IPL 2024.

Madhwal struck with the second ball of his spell when he got Sanju Samson to chop on to his stumps, and added a second when Jos Buttler pulled him to fine leg. He added a third later, in the 13th over, when Ashwin sent a leading edge off a short delivery to point. Madhwal was the standout bowler for Mumbai Indians with 3 for 20.

Riyan Parag scored another half-century, and claimed the orange cap•BCCI

Parag's form continues

Parag walked in ranked No. 5 on the orange cap list and finished the day with the cap on his head. With no real scoreboard pressure on this occasion, No. 4 Parag played risk-free cricket early on, but tore into Coetzee with four fours and two sixes.

It all started with back-to-back boundaries off Coetzee in the eighth over, followed by another lofted four over the covers in the 11th. He then smoked Bumrah through mid-off in the 14th over before depositing Piyush Chawla over long-on in the 15th.

Parag then put the finishing touches on the result by hammering Coetzee for 16 runs off the first three balls of the 16th over. The first ball went for a clubbed six over the covers, and he reached his fifty next ball with a slog over midwicket. The winning runs came over wicketkeeper Kishan's head and sent Royals and Mumbai Indians to opposite ends of the points table.

MATCH 15

Lucknow Super Giants 181 for 5 (De Kock 81, Pooran 40*, Maxwell 2-23) beat Royal Challengers Bengaluru 153 (Lomror 33, Mayank 3-14, Naveen 2-25) by 28 runs

Mayank Yadav set the speed gun on fire once again and ripped out Glenn Maxwell and Cameron Green on his way to figures of 4-0-14-3 as Lucknow Super Giants successfully defended 181 to hand Royal Challengers Bengaluru their second successive defeat at the M Chinnaswamy Stadium.

It was Quinton de Kock who laid the base for LSG's victory with his second successive half-century. KL Rahul returned to action as their captain but he could only manage 20 off 14 balls. But Nicholas Pooran, who had captained LSG in their last game against Punjab Kings, clicked into a higher gear, smashing an unbeaten 40 off 21 balls to drag his team past 180 on a two-paced pitch.

The back-of-the-hand slower balls from Reece Topley and Yash Dayal were sticking in the surface, but Mayank doesn't do slow. He repeatedly breached 150kph - and even cranked it up to a season-high 156.7kph - to shut down RCB's chase.

Quinton de Kock has reasserted his authority at the top this IPL with back-to-back half-centuries•BCCI

De Kock dashes out of the blocks

De Kock had started the last IPL season on the bench as Kyle Mayers was preferred ahead of him. De Kock was then removed as Durban's Super Giants captain ahead of SA20 2024, which followed. In the SA20, he got only two innings as an opener, but he has now reasserted his authority at the top this IPL with back-to-back half-centuries.

When Topley, de Kock's team-mate in the SA20, offered him width, he stayed leg side of the ball and crunched him through the covers. Mohammed Siraj didn't offer de Kock as much width, but when he erred on height and bowled at the thigh, de Kock picked him over square leg. De Kock claimed 32 of the 54 runs LSG scored in the powerplay for the loss of Rahul.

De Kock could have been dismissed for 32 in the next over, but Maxwell dropped him. He added 49 to his tally before Topley eventually had him holing out to long-off for 81 off 56 balls.

Maxwell impresses with the ball

On a night when RCB's specialist spinner Mayank Dagar bowled just two overs for 23 runs, Maxwell stepped up with 4-0-23-2, including 12 dots. He fronted up to bowl two overs in the powerplay, where he had Rahul caught at extra-cover with a hard-length delivery.

He then returned after the powerplay to remove another right-hander - Marcus Stoinis (24 in 15) - by hiding the ball away from his reach. Maxwell also won his match-up against de Kock, keeping him to four off eight balls. That Maxwell, with four strikes, is RCB's highest wicket-taker this season after four games shines the spotlight on the inefficiency of the frontline bowlers.

Pooran tees off

Pooran had a slow start: he was on eight off ten balls at one point. He then smote five sixes off the last two overs to silence a capacity crowd at the Chinnaswamy. The pick of the lot was the shanked six off a 110.4kph slower ball from Topley that landed on the roof the stadium.

The margin for error is wafer-thin against elite power-hitters like Pooran. When Topley missed his wider yorkers marginally, Pooran scythed him for a brace of sixes at point and put LSG back on top.

M Siddharth dismissed Virat Kohli early in big chase•BCCI

Siddharth arrives in the IPL

M Siddharth, the Tamil Nadu fingerspinner, was born in Chennai and then grew up in Jakarta in Indonesia. He moved back to Chennai along with his family to become a professional cricketer. He wanted to become the next Irfan Pathan, but the coaches at his academy noted that he didn't have enough pace to become a fast bowler.

So, Siddharth switched to left-arm spin, but he continues to swing the new ball. That's his calling card in the Tamil Nadu Premier League. LSG's team management had so much faith in him that they backed him to bowl with the new ball against Virat Kohli and Faf du Plessis on the night.

After darting inswingers at speeds north of 110kph, Siddharth slowed his pace down, found grip, and drew a leading edge from Kohli. In the next over, du Plessis was run-out, leaving RCB at 42 for 2 in the sixth over.

Mayank's rockets

Maxwell managed to evade the first bouncer from Mayank, but when he dug one in and got it to climb towards Maxwell's ribs at 151kph, the batter was rushed into flapping a catch to mid-on to leave for a duck.

Then, in his next over, Mayank nailed the top of Green's off stump with another scorching delivery. The reading on the speed gun was 146.2kph but the belated response from Green suggested that it might have been a lot quicker than that.

Green was bred on the pacy, bouncy tracks in Perth, but an Indian rookie, only playing his 12th T20 game, made the international allrounder look like a rookie. Green simply stayed leg side of the ball and wafted at it. Mayank wheeled away in celebration and there would be no stopping him.

He proceeded to bounce out Rajat Patidar for 29 off 21 balls. RCB needed 79 off 34 balls at that point and though Mahipal Lomror hit 33 off 13 balls, the chase was always beyond RCB's reach.

Mayank didn't get a single game at LSG over the past two seasons, largely because of injuries. He has now become the first player in IPL history to win two Player-of-the-Match awards in his first two matches.

MATCH 16

Kolkata Knight Riders 272 for 7 (Narine 85, Raghuvanshi 54, Russell 41, Nortje 3-59) beat Delhi Capitals 166 (Pant 55, Stubbs 54, Arora 3-27, Chakravarthy 3-33) by 106 runs

Last Wednesday at the IPL, Sunrisers Hyderabad set the record for the highest IPL score: 277. What should have been a once-in-a-decade effort was very nearly taken down by a marauding Kolkata Knight Riders batting unit tonight in Visakhapatnam. Sunil Narine plundered his personal best in T20s - 85 off 39 - almost home-grown Angkrish

Raghuvanshi matched him with 54 off 27, and Andre Russell added the finishing touches with 41 off 19.

A searing yorker from Ishant Sharma to get Russell in the last over prevented the record being broken, but the 272 KKR put up was more than enough to register a comfortable win - by 106 runs - and join Rajasthan Royals with three wins from three matches at the top of the table. In taking four wickets in the powerplay, two each for Vaibhav Arora and Mitchell Starc, KKR ticked another box in a season in which they have presented themselves as serious title contenders.

Pant fined for slow over-rate again

Rishabh Pant, the Capitals captain, has been fined after his team maintained a slow over-rate against KKR in their 106-run loss in Visakhapatnam. As it was Capitals' second offence of the season - in just four matches - Pant was fined INR 24 lakh, while the rest of the members of the playing XII, were each fined either INR 6 lakh or 25% of their respective match fees, whichever is lower.

Narine, Raghuvanshi hammer Capitals

Khaleel Ahmed and Ishant Sharma set Capitals' win in the previous match in Vizag with swing early on. Here, though, probably because of Narine's presence, both of them started slightly short of a length. The one ball that Khaleel pitched up swung to beat Narine.

It seems ridiculous now but Narine took six balls to get off the mark. Capitals had managed to keep Narine quiet, but had they missed the small window of swing to try to get him out? Another chance would arrive soon to a short-of-a-length delivery, but neither Ishant Sharma nor Rishabh Pant heard the edge. No appeal, no review.

Narine and Phil Salt had got down to work by then, but Capitals could still have got Narine for 24 off 13 had they listened to Mitchell Marsh and reviewed. Then again, reviews were not the only thing they were getting wrong. They kept offering Narine room, when they went short they didn't get it high enough, and the ball had stopped swinging by now.

Sunil Narine smacked seven fours and as many sixes in his 39-ball innings•AFP/Getty Images

Anrich Nortje got rid of Salt in the fifth over, but Raghuvanshi, trained from the age of 11 by KKR's own Abhishek Nayar, walked out and laced fours off the first two balls he faced. Mukesh Kumar is not express, but his injury has left DC with even less of a pace threat. Narine jumped on Rasikh Salam's medium-pace in the last over of the powerplay, hitting him for three fours and a six to bring up his half-century in just 21 balls. Their 88 for 1 in the powerplay was the highest by any team so far at IPL 2024.

The end of the powerplay brought DC relief only for one over, bowled by Sumit Kumar, but Narine ended any threats of variations in the attack by hitting two sixes off Axar Patel, who wouldn't bowl again. Raghuvanshi matched him with a reverse-pull over short third for a

six. Their 135 for 1 was the third-highest 10-over score in the IPL - all three have come this season.

Wickets fail to slow KKR down

Eventually it was the short ball from Marsh that got the better of Narine, but it wasn't just one short ball. He kept bowling short and wide outside off with changes of pace. Narine still ended with a boundary every two-and-a-half balls, and the wicket came too late anyway. The 13th over was the right point of entry for Russell, and he punished the samey attack. Capitals didn't go back to spin despite right-hand batters at the wicket, and Nortje was the only one who presented the batters with an inbuilt challenge.

Andre Russell and Rinku Singh smashed 32 runs off 11 balls for the fifth wicket•AFP/Getty Images

Russell was too good for the rest, and when Nortje started the 19th over with one fewer fielder on the fence because of a poor over-rate, Rinku Singh got stuck into him, taking 25 off the over.

Ishant then produced a beauty that drew an applause from Russell himself and prevented Capitals from ending up on the wrong side of the record.

Arora announces himself

One of the two tall domestic fast bowlers in the KKR stable, Arora came on as the Impact Player and found inswing immediately. It wasn't just swing, though. He mixed it up with accurate bouncers. Prithvi Shaw fell to the inswinger before Abhishek Porel top-edged a bouncer.

Vaibhav Arora took 3 for 27 in KKR's clinical win•BCCI

At the other end, Starc took care of his Australia team-mates, Marsh caught trying to square-drive and Warner playing on immediately after slogging him for a six. These were his first wickets this IPL after his eight overs in the first two matches had gone for 100 runs.

At 33 for 4 in the fifth over, even batting for net run rate would need heavy hitting and risks. For a while Pant and Tristan Stubbs managed to score quickly. Pant was especially pleasing as he continues his return from a life-threatening accident, but their fifties were never going to be enough to deny KKR a third consecutive win - the first time they have started a season with three wins in three in their history.

MATCH 17

Punjab Kings 200 for 7 (Shashank 61*, Noor 2-32) beat Gujarat Titans 199 for 4 (Gill 89, Rabada 2-44) by three wickets

Punjab Kings only had 9% chance of victory and 18 balls to beat the odds with the guy they seemed to have bought by mistake at the auction. Guess what happened next?

Shashank Singh hit 10 of the 29 balls he faced to the boundary. He survived a very close lbw shout off Noor Ahmad when he was 1 off 2, but was soon carting around a bunch of former IPL champions. Rashid Khan, launched over midwicket, Umesh Yadav, helped over fine leg, Noor Ahmad, skewered over long-off, Mohit Sharma, even when he tried to go pace off and into the wicket, ramped over the keeper. These were unbelievable shots because they came from a place where victory was only fantasy.

It was less than four months ago that the Kings' management was huddled around the auction table trying to offload this guy, then sending out a clarification tweet, which Shashank replied to, hoping to shut down the stories that were swirling around. Tonight, in a twist that the IPL should consider trademarking, both the unfancied team and their unfancied purchase came good facing impossible odds in a chase of 200.

More magic at the IPL

Kings only had two batters among their five substitutes in a bowling first XI. It looked a lopsided selection. But the man they chose as the Impact Sub played a massive role in their victory. Ashutosh Sharma, playing his very first IPL game, and only the 15th T20 of his career, looked at an equation that read 41 off 18 balls square in the eye and took it down with brutal precision. He hit three fours in Azmatullah Omarzai's 18th over. Another six to start the 19th from Mohit. In those 12 balls, the Kings got 34 runs. In those 12 balls, the Kings' chances of victory rose from 9.23% to 94.56%.

This is what happens when two players look for the best boundary option they have with every single ball. But the fact that they were both uncapped, that they had very little experience at this level of the game - Shashank had played 13 matches in the IPL, but batted in just eight of those and had a high score of 25 prior to this - and were coming up with the goods even against bowlers of the calibre of the Titans was incredible.

They waited for Mohit and Azmatullah's variations - whether they were slower balls or short balls - and it wasn't just that they were looking to slog 'em across the line. Shashank (previously) and Ashutosh (in the death) ramped fours over the keeper. It was nerveless. It was glorious. And by the end of it, Kings had conquered their sixth target of 200 or more, a men's T20 record.

ESPNcricinfo Ltd

Rashid's problems

It is still early - only four matches - but Rashid Khan has an economy rate of 9.06, his worst in an IPL season. In this game, he was lined up twice by Jitesh Sharma, leaking back-to-back sixes in the 16th over. He has already been hit out of the park nine times in IPL 2024. That's as many sixes as he'd given up across 14 matches in 2021 and 16 matches in 2020. Titans are turning to him a little more often now because they don't have Mohammed Shami in the powerplay and the death and it seems like he is yet to cope with that extra responsibility. The Kings were in a squeeze at 70 for 4 in the ninth over and then 111 for 5 in the 13th over.

Liam Livingstone was injured. Shikhar Dhawan, Jonny Bairstow and Sam Curran were out. Only Jitesh and some unknowns were left. This match should've been done but it wasn't.

Top-heavy Titans

Six. The total number of boundary attempts made by Wriddhiman Saha and Kane Williamson from a combined 35 balls faced. Titans were a top-heavy line-up with David Miller out injured. That automatically puts pressure on their best batter and Shubman Gill could have cracked if not for the man coming out at No. 4 and flaying at everything that came his way. Sai Sudharsan looked for a boundary off 12 of the 19 balls he faced. He outscored Gill - 33 off 19 vs 20 off 13 - in a 53-run partnership that reset the game.

Shubman Gill made his highest individual score of IPL 2024 • BCCI

Peak Shubman Gill

Gill faced only 10 balls in the powerplay. Even after 10 overs, he had only been on strike for 19 deliveries. He looked in glorious form but wasn't getting opportunities to influence the game. External pressure could have made him take a risk too soon and end up back in the hut, but Sudharsan's innings gave him chance to bat at his tempo, and that was only ever going to spell trouble for the opposition.

Gill made 89 off 48 batting well within himself. Even the most jaw-dropping shot of his innings was a simple consequence of seeing a length ball and knowing he can get under it. Kagiso Rabada, who is IPL royalty thanks to his strike rate of 14.8, the best out of everyone who has at least 100 wickets in this tournament, was launched straight down the ground for an effortless six. Gill thrived just by responding to what was coming down because nine times out of 10, he had the perfect one. He was in the zone, striking at 185.42 and combining it with a control percentage of 91.67. That is rare. Typically when you're looking to go big, you end up with a few more mis-hits. It must feel like pretty small consolation, though, on a night where he watched his team lose from a winning position.

MATCH 18

Sunrisers Hyderabad 166 for 4 (Markram 50, Abhishek 37, Head 31, Moeen 2-23)
beat Chennai Super Kings 165 for 5 (Dube 45, Rahane 35, Bhuvneshwar 1-28, Cummins 1-29) by six wickets

Sunrisers Hyderabad sussed out the conditions quicker than Chennai Super Kings on a black-soil surface and cruised to their second successive win at home. In the absence of Mustafizur Rahman, who had returned to Bangladesh to sort out his US visa for the upcoming T20 World Cup, and Matheesha Pathirana, who is nursing a niggle, a depleted CSK side slid to their second successive defeat on the road.

Last week, Hyderabad had rolled out a red-soil pitch that produced a 277 for 3 vs 246 for 5 contest. Friday's pitch was a whole lot slower and Sunrisers' seamers used it to their advantage by bowling one cutter after another into it. After Pat Cummins and Co limited

CSK to 165 for 5, Sunrisers smashed 78 for 1 in just the powerplay, with Abhishek Sharma clattering 37 of those runs, off just 12 balls.

Related

Abhishek: 'We knew we had to take the powerplay on'

Gaikwad, the anchor at the top weighing CSK down

Live Blog - SRH trump CSK on slow Hyderabad pitch

CSK had scored 30 runs fewer in their powerplay and their batting machine was shut down in the slog overs too.

Sunrisers eventually completed their chase with six wickets in hand and nearly two overs to spare, Aiden Markram doing the heavy lifting with a 36-ball 50.

Dube does Dube things

Rachin Ravindra was dismissed by Bhuvneshwar Kumar for 12 off nine balls in the fourth over. Ruturaj Gaikwad got off to a start, but Shahbaz Ahmed, the left-arm fingerspinner, had him swiping a catch to long-on for 26 off 21 balls.

Ajinkya Rahane hit Cummins and Bhuvneshwar over the top for boundaries in the powerplay, but he struggled to get the ball away once it became softer and the field was spread out in the middle overs.

Shivam Dube took down Sunrisers' spinners but the rest of CSK's batting struggled on a slow pitch•AFP/Getty Images

Shivam Dube, though, got cracking immediately against spin. He launched the third ball he faced, from Shahbaz, for six and scored 25 off his first ten balls, from Shahbaz and legspinner Mayank Markande.

Dube also lined up T Natarajan, who was returning from injury, for back-to-back sixes before Cummins stopped him on 45 off 24 balls. The Sunrisers captain hid a slower short ball away from Dube's swinging arc and had him popping a catch to backward point.

SRH pin down CSK

CSK could score only 50 runs in their last seven overs. Cummins, Natarajan and Unadkat kept taking pace off the ball. CSK's power-hitters failed to manufacture pace for themselves on the night.

Rahane was undone by a 105kph slower delivery while Mitchell fell to an on-pace Natarajan delivery that stopped in the pitch. Ravindra Jadeja's down-the-track swatted four off a 111kph cutter from Unadkat was only an aberration.

The decibel levels soared when MS Dhoni came out to bat at No.7, ahead of Moeen Ali, with just three balls left in CSK's innings. But even he could manage only one off two balls.

Abhishek Sharma played 12 balls and hit seven of them for fours or sixes•AFP/Getty Images

Head, Abhishek tear up the powerplay

With the target in front of them and the knowledge that the pitch would become even slower later in the night, Sunrisers maximised the powerplay.

According to ESPNcricinfo's logs, Sunrisers attempted to hit 16 balls in the powerplay to the boundary. CSK, on the other hand, had looked to hit only eight balls to the boundary during that phase.

Travis Head stayed leg-side of the ball and cracked Deepak Chahar and Tushar Deshpande through the off side. He finished with 31 off 24 balls. He could have been dismissed on 0 in the very first over had Moeen not dropped him at slip.

Abhishek faced only half as many balls as Head did, but produced a bigger impact, pumping 37 at a strike rate of 308.33. Twenty-seven of those runs came in the first over from left-arm seamer Mukesh Choudhary, who bowled like someone who was playing his first competitive game since December 2022.

After Head and Abhishek departed, Markram controlled the chase with a half-century. Moeen trapped Markram (50) and Shahbaz (18) lbw with the old ball, but it was too late for CSK. Sunrisers had already inflicted irreparable damage in the powerplay.

MATCH 19

Rajasthan Royals 189 for 4 (Buttler 100*, Samson 69) beat Royal Challengers Bengaluru 183 for 3 (Kohli 113*, du Plessis 44, Chahal 2-34) by six wickets

Jos Buttler celebrated his 100th IPL match with a 58-ball century to return to form and lead Rajasthan Royals to their fourth win in four games in IPL 2024. Buttler got to the mark in style by hitting the winning runs - a six over midwicket - to finish unbeaten on 100, and his 148-run stand with Sanju Samson (69 in 42) for the second wicket set up the chase.

Their partnership was also the season's highest, breaking the record set by Virat Kohli and Faf du Plessis earlier in the day. Kohli led from the front to smack 113 in the first innings - his eighth IPL century and third in his last seven IPL innings - but it was also his slowest century, getting to the mark in 67 balls.

With no batter apart from du Plessis contributing, the onus was on Kohli to lift the Royal Challengers Bengaluru innings. And he did so successfully, carrying the bat till the end, but their total of 183 proved insufficient, sending them to their fourth defeat in five games.

Buttler leads, Samson follows

With scores of 11, 11, and 13, Buttler came into the game needing to change his fortunes. More so after he saw Yashasvi Jaiswal fall for a duck to Reece Topley. Then came a trademark Buttler scoop over wicketkeeper Dinesh Karthik in the fourth over, his first boundary of the night.

Having got that one away, Buttler survived a tough catching chance on 6 the next delivery. That, however, did not slow him down. He launched into Yash Dayal and then hit left-arm spinner Mayank Dagar for three fours and a six in a 20-run sixth over. With Samson also matching him shot for shot, Buttler reached his first fifty of the season in the tenth over.

Buttler was especially strong against the inexperienced spinners Dagar and Himanshu Sharma. They often erred with their lengths, and he pounced on short balls by pulling over the leg side. He also pierced boundaries through the covers and ran down the pitch to hit both spin and pace down the ground.

Jos Buttler and Shimron Hetmyer celebrate the century and the victory • AFP/Getty Images

His connections got better as the innings progressed, on display when he picked Dayal's slower ball in the 13th over, had to wait ages for it to arrive where he stood and still flat-batted him for six. With one to win at the start of the 20th over, Buttler had a fairytale end to his evening when he pulled a six to reach his ton and seal the deal.

Kohli's ton ends in defeat

Put in to bat, RCB needed their opening pair to get some runs, but it was meant to be a challenge against the team that was averaging three powerplay wickets per game. However, Trent Boult and Nandre Burger could not get the early breakthrough, and the Kohli-du Plessis pair put on 53 in the powerplay.

The start was promising for RCB since du Plessis survived the powerplay for the first time this season and Kohli looked fluid at his worst IPL venue (he averaged 21.90 in Jaipur before this game). Kohli was the majority contributor in their 125-run opening stand, scoring 72 compared to du Plessis' 44 before the latter fell in the 14th over.

As he peppered boundaries off the pacers through the leg side, in particular by flicking off his toes through midwicket, Kohli also used his feet against Yuzvendra Chahal, the best Royals bowler, hitting him for two sixes. He saved his best for Avesh Khan, whom he struck for three fours through the off side in the 16th. Kohli then reached his ninth T20 century and eighth in IPL in the 19th over off Burger, before launching into Avesh again with two fours in the 20th to finish with a career-best IPL score of 113. He contributed 61.70% of runs for RCB and was one of two players batters in the innings to reach double-digits in a total of 183 for 3.

Chahal, Ashwin outbowl RCB's spinners

It was an unusual bowling effort from Royals. They did not take a powerplay wicket, and Boult's ineffectiveness up top meant it was the first game where he did not bowl a third over in the powerplay.

It was then that Samson turned to Ashwin and Chahal consecutively. Together, they went for 62 in eight overs - economy of 7.75. Their array of tricks kept a well-set Kohli, and others like du Plessis, Cameron Green and Glenn Maxwell fairly quiet.

On the other hand, take RCB's two spinners: rookies Dagar and Himanshu. Dagar was traded in from Sunrisers for Shahbaz Ahmed and Himanshu is a product of RCB's scouting system. In only four overs (two apiece) they conceded one more than the total given away by Ashwin and Chahal in eight.

They missed their lengths too many times, and when they got it wrong, Samson and Buttler did not spare them. In all, 11 of their 24 balls went for either four or six, a clear determinant in Royals' win with five balls to spare.

MATCH 20

Mumbai Indians 234 for 5 (Rohit 49, David 45*, Kishan 42, Axar 2-35) beat Delhi Capitals 205 for 8 (Stubbs 71*, Shaw 66, Coetzee 4-34) by 29 runs

Having lost the first three games, Mumbai Indians finally opened their account in IPL 2024 as they beat Delhi Capitals by 29 runs at the Wankhede Stadium.

After being sent in, Rohit Sharma and Ishan Kishan gave Mumbai a start of 80 in seven overs. Capitals staged a comeback in the middle overs but Tim David (45* off 21) and Romario Shepherd (39* off 10) muscled 96 in the last five overs - Shepherd hit Anrich Nortje for 32 in the 20th - to lift Mumbai to a daunting 234 for 5.

Prithvi Shaw kept Capitals in the contest with 66 off 40 balls. After he got out, Tristan Stubbs took over and ransacked an unbeaten 71 off 25 balls. But that Nortje over proved to be the difference in the end as Capitals fell short by 29 runs.

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Hamstring injury rules Delhi Capitals' Mitchell Marsh out for at least a week

Shepherd: 'It's my strength vs your strength when I'm at the crease'

Shepherd blasts 4, 6, 6, 4, 6 off Anrich Nortje in the 20th over

Rohit gives Mumbai a blazing start

Given a flat pitch and small boundaries at the Wankhede, Mumbai knew they needed to score big, and Rohit and Kishan laid the perfect foundation.

Kishan started by hitting Khaleel Ahmed for three fours in the seamer's first two overs. From the other end, Rohit hit Ishant Sharma for two successive fours. He took it a notch higher against Jhye Richardson by launching him for two back-to-back sixes.

Seeing the fast bowlers leaking runs, Rishabh Pant turned to his spinners. But Rohit was into overdrive by now. In the next nine balls, he hit four fours and a six against Axar Patel and Lalit Yadav. At the end of six overs, he had moved to 49 off 23 balls and Mumbai to 75 for no loss.

Capitals pull it back

Once the field restrictions were relaxed, Capitals staged a comeback with Axar dismissing Rohit. On the last ball of the seventh over, Rohit stepped out of his crease but Axar bowled it short and fast to beat the batter and rattle his stumps.

In the next over, Nortje spoiled Suryakumar Yadav's return. Nortje welcomed him to the crease with a searing yorker before having him caught at mid-on for a two-ball duck.

Thanks to their quick start, Mumbai reached 100 in the tenth over before Axar hurt them again. Having hit a six off the previous ball, Ishan Kishan smashed the next to the left of Axar who stretched out his hand to pull off a stunning return catch.

With Hardik Pandya taking his time - he was on 19 off 20 balls at one point - Mumbai could manage only 63 runs in the nine overs after the powerplay.

Romario Shepherd muscled away a 10-ball 39 to lift Mumbai Indians•BCCI

The David-Shepherd show

Mumbai were 138 for 4 after 15 overs. At that stage, Capitals must have harboured hopes of restricting them under 200. David and Shepherd, though, had other plans.

David started the 16th over by smashing Richardson for a six. In the next two overs, he hit two more sixes and Hardik also chipped in with one but it was Shepherd who made the bigger dent. In the 20th over, he bludgeoned Nortje for 4, 6, 6, 6, 4, 6 to crush Capitals' morale.

Shaw keeps Capitals' hopes alive

Shepherd was not done hurting Capitals. In the fourth over, he had David Warner holing out to mid-on with a wide slower ball.

Shaw was slow to start. After four overs, he was on 13 off 15 but soon found his range. In the eighth over, he hit Piyush Chawla for 6, 4, 4 off successive deliveries. With a pulled four off Gerald Coetzee, he brought up his half-century, off 31 balls.

Along with Abishek Porel, Shaw took Capitals past 100 in the 11th over but Bumrah ended his innings on 66 by uprooting the leg stump with a searing yorker.

Stubbs' blitz goes in vain

Stubbs wasted no time to get going. Facing his third ball, he heaved Chawla over deep midwicket for a six and repeated the dose three balls later. Bumrah dismissed Porel for 41 off 31, and Pant fell cheaply, but Stubbs kept going.

He hit Akash Madhwal for two fours and a six on the first three balls of the 17th over and brought up his half-century - his second in two games - off just 19 balls.

His hitting meant Capitals reached 172 for 4 after 17 overs, five runs ahead of Mumbai at the same stage. But Bumrah conceded only eight in the next to make it 55 needed from two overs.

Stubbs hit two sixes off Shepherd at the start of the 19th and ended it with another six. But with little support from the other end, Capitals were left needing 34 from six balls. Coetzee conceded only four and also picked up three wickets as Stubbs got stuck at the non-striker's end.

MATCH 21

Lucknow Super Giants 163 for 5 (Stoinis 58, Umesh 2-22) beat Gujarat Titans 130 all out (Sudharsan 31, Thakur 5-30, Krunal 3-11) by 33 runs

Lucknow Super Giants claimed their third win in a row, and first over Gujarat Titans in five attempts, with a fighting defence of 163 in Lucknow. Marcus Stoinis' first half-century of the season provided the ballast after the home side had chosen to bat first and, although Titans started well in their run chase, Yash Thakur claimed a maiden five-for to help demolish the innings.

The LSG batting effort was rarely fluent, captain KL Rahul and Stoinis opting for accumulation after Umesh Yadav had struck twice with the new ball. Both fell when looking to up the ante and it needed flashes of power from Nicholas Pooran plus a cameo from Ayush Badoni to get them up to a respectable score.

Related

Mayank 'seemed okay, which was quite a relief' - Krunal

In their favour was the fact LSG had never been beaten defending a target of 160-plus. Titans looked set to threaten that record after racing to 54 without loss inside the powerplay, only for a stunning collapse of 8 for 48 to make it 13 from 13 for LSG. After Yash skidded one through Shubman Gill, Ravi Bishnoi's spectacular caught-and-bowled dismissal of Kane Williamson provided the spark, while Krunal Pandya raced through his four-over allocation for figures of 3 for 11 as Titans imploded.

That they managed such a comfortable defence was even more remarkable given LSG lost the services of their new pace sensation, Mayank Yadav, after just a single over due to a side strain - the one sour note as Rahul's team moved to six points and third in the table.

Titans start strong then stumble

Chasing what seemed a middling target, Titans eased out of the blocks with a fifty opening stand inside the powerplay. Sai Sudharsan was all poise and wrists, hitting four early boundaries - including two off Mayank in his only over, during which the LSG fast man barely breached 140kph - while Shubman Gill looked to play himself in. With Mayank having to leave the field and M Siddharth struggling with front-foot no-balls, Titans looked to be cruising.

Krunal Pandya finished with three wickets•BCCI

However, the dismissal of Gill from the final ball of the sixth over sparked an extraordinary collapse. Krunal whizzed through a tidy over, before Ravi Bishnoi struck with his second ball, leaping to hold a brilliant one-handed return catch off Kane Williamson, Titans' impact sub. Sudharsan then holed out to deep square leg from the first ball of Krunal's second over, which was followed by BR Sharath top-edging a sweep to deep backward square. Titans had shipped four wickets for seven runs in the space of 18 balls and suddenly had it all to do.

Yash we can!

Titans' chase never recovered. Krunal claimed a third wicket as the asking rate rose towards 12 an over, with the canny Yash returning to dismiss Vijay Shankar and Rashid Khan in the space of four balls to leave the score 93 for 7. Rahul Tewatia presented the only danger of an upset, twice clearing the ropes in 30 off 25 balls, but he picked out deep square leg before Yash wrapped up the innings for career-best T20 figures.

Rahul's slow-and-steady rebuild

LSG were after a fast start against the new ball, with Quinton de Kock marking his 100th IPL appearance by clattering Umesh Yadav into the stands second ball. He didn't survive the over, however, an attempted repeat resulting in a big top edge to deep third. With Devdutt Padikkal notching a fourth single-figure score in a row for his new franchise, Lucknow were 18 for 2 in the third over and looking vulnerable.

Marcus Stoinis and KL Rahul rebuilt after two early blows•AFP/Getty Images

Rahul is the perfect man for a rebuild, though, and he helped resurrect the innings in the company of Stoinis. After taking three boundaries off Spencer Johnson's second over, the pair batted watchfully through the middle of the innings, until what almost appeared to be Rahul's first shot in anger, in the 13th over, as the LSG captain attempted to hit Darshan Nalkande over long-on only to hole out. The partnership was worth 73 from 62 balls but ended just when LSG were hoping to push on.

Spinners squeeze but Pooran finishes

Stonis should have been dismissed in the following over, mishitting Noor Ahmed straight up only for Rashid to grass the chance running in from long-off. Noor bowled his four overs off the reel for just 22 runs - conceding a single boundary - and although Stoinis broke the shackles to pump Nalkande twice over long-on for a 40-ball half-century, he fell trying to target the same bowler, top-edging a skier to the keeper.

With two new batters at the crease going into the death overs, and Rashid still with two up his sleeve, LSG were facing an uphill struggle. Rashid conceded five singles off the 17th, but Pooran and Ayush Badoni released some pressure by taking Mohit Shah for three boundaries in the next. Although Badoni holed out looking to take on Rashid, Pooran carted the legspinner over midwicket for the only boundary of his allocation, with another six in the final over - in which Johnson conceded just eight - taking LSG beyond the magic 160-mark.

MATCH 21

Chennai Super Kings 141 for 3 (Gaikwad 67, Arora 2-28) beat Kolkata Knight Riders 137 for 9 (Iyer 34, Jadeja 3-18, Deshpande 3-33, Mustafizur 2-22) by seven wickets

After two back-to-back defeats on the road, Chennai Super Kings returned to the comforts of home and to winning ways, consigning Kolkata Knight Riders to their first loss of IPL 2024.

On a surface that was typical of the one we have been used to at Chepauk in seasons past, CSK bowled first and restricted KKR to 137 for 9. This after KKR had raced to 56 for 1 in the powerplay. But as the ball got older, the CSK bowlers, led by Ravindra Jadeja who picked 3 for 18, came into their own.

In the chase, Ruturaj Gaikwad got back into form, shepherding the innings with an unbeaten 58-ball 67 to take CSK over the line with seven wickets and 14 balls to spare. He added 70 off 55 balls with Daryl Mitchell (25 off 19) before Shivam Dube came in and tonked 28 off 18 to take CSK closer.

With three to win, in walked MS Dhoni, causing bedlam in the Chepauk stands. But it was Gaikwad who fittingly finished off the chase by crashing Anukul Roy through covers.

Gaikwad's welcome return to form

It hasn't been the strongest of starts for Gaikwad in IPL 2024. Coming into the game, he had only managed 88 runs in four innings, averaging 22 in the tournament. But with a modest target in front of him, he bedded in for the long haul. After a watchful first over, he got going with a ramp off Vaibhav Arora and moved from 4 off 9 to 32 off 23 by the end of the powerplay.

Ruturaj Gaikwad and MS Dhoni saw CSK home •BCCI

The early impetus was provided by Rachin Ravindra who went after Mitchell Starc, but once he fell, Gaikwad made sure to keep the things moving forward. With Ajinkya Rahane struggling with a calf strain, he had additional responsibility and took up the role well.

Gaikwad took on the left-arm spin of Anukul Roy, backing away first ball of the fifth over and creaming him through covers. He repeated those shots twice over before smashing Vaibhav Arora for two back-to-back fours. CSK had raced to 52 for 1 at the end of the powerplay.

CSK make it 3/3 at home

Gaikwad got excellent support from Mitchell and Dube in helping CSK get over the line. Mitchell, promoted up the order to No. 3, hit his straps by thumping Sunil Narine for a six and four immediately after the powerplay. The duo did not always keep the boundaries flowing but they kept the scoreboard ticking. In the 36 balls between overs six to 12, they scored 44 runs - 17 singles, five doubles, two fours and one six - and that was all CSK needed as the asking run rate crept below the six an over mark.

Once Mitchell fell, it was the Dube show as he continued his merry run in IPL 2024. He hammered Varun Chakravarthy for back-to-back sixes and then muscled Arora for another one over deep midwicket. Dube is the current leading run-scorer for CSK this season and has a strike rate of 193.93 against all spinners. On Monday, he only enhanced his credentials. It didn't take long for CSK to finish off the chase after Dube fell, wrapping up the game in 17.4 overs.

Win contribution CSK vs KKR•ESPNcricinfo Ltd

Sunil Narine - the powerplay king

After losing the toss and a wicket off the first ball of the game, KKR were propped up by Sunil Narine, their powerplay wrecker-in-chief this season. He went after Tushar Deshpande in his second over. A four through square leg, one over mid-off and then a six over deep square - Narine was up and away. Not even a shoulder injury seemed to stop him.

During his innings, Narine also went past Virat Kohli to now have the most runs in the powerplay this season - 127 at a strike rate of 201.58. He found an ally in Angkrish Raghuvanshi, who continued on from his debut innings as the duo added 56 runs off 36 balls for the second wicket.

The slowdown courtesy Ravindra Jadeja

The CSK spinners had not picked up a single wicket at Chepauk in the first two matches there in IPL 2024. And Jadeja seemed to take it personally. He picked up three wickets in his first eight balls of the match, putting a big dent in the KKR middle order.

Ravindra Jadeja turned the game on its head with three wickets in eight balls•BCCI

He first sent back Raghuvanshi, who shaped up for a reverse sweep, missed and was caught right in front. Then he got rid of Narine for the fourth time in five T20 innings, the batter slicing a length ball straight to long-off. Venkatesh Iyer was Jadeja's third victim holing out to deep midwicket with Mitchell taking a good catch diving forward. Normally Jadeja's plan in these conditions is to be as accurate as possible. Here he knew he had to do one other thing as well. Not bowl full. Let the natural variation that this pitch was offering do its thing.

After scoring 56 in the first six overs, KKR only managed 43 in the next nine, losing four wickets in the process.

The quicks go slow

Once 15 overs were done, Gaikwad got the fast bowlers into play, and they relied more on the cutters. Deshpande had Rinku Singh chopping one back onto his stumps before Mustafizur Rahman took over. He might have been coming off a long run-up but got slower cutters in, which would have made any slow left-arm orthodox spinner proud.

He delivered a stellar final over picking up two wickets and conceding just two runs. While Deshpande finished with 3 for 33 off his four overs, Mustafizur picked 2 for 22, and became the highest wicket-taker in the competition. Sixteen of the 24 balls delivered by the duo in the last four overs were cutters, and KKR had no clue.

MATCH 22

Sunrisers Hyderabad 182 for 9 (Reddy 64, Samad 25, Arshdeep 4-29, Harshal 2-30)
beat Punjab Kings 180 for 6 (Shashank 46*, Ashutosh 33*, Bhuvneshwar 2-32) by two runs

Sunrisers Hyderabad dropped three catches of Ashutosh Sharma in the final over off which Punjab Kings needed 29 runs. Two of them went over the ropes for sixes and nearly turned the match. But when the third went down, only one delivery remained and Kings needed nine. Shashank Singh sent the last ball miles over the long-off boundary, but Kings fell short by just two runs in their chase of 183 to give Sunrisers their third win of the season.

It was Jaydev Unadkat who bowled that last over which went for 26. As fate would have it, it was Unadkat who Harshal Patel had dropped on the final ball of Sunrisers' innings and the ball had popped up over the rope for six. Fine margins.

What a dream it would have been had Shashank and Ashutosh pulled off another heist like they did five days back against Gujarat Titans. But eventually, they were left with too many to get in the final over of the chase.

Shashank, Ashutosh at it again

They joined forces when Kings were 114 for 6 halfway into the 16th over. The required rate at the time was 15.33 which soon shot up to 16.75 with 24 balls remaining. Different bowlers bowled each of those four overs, and each one of them was taken to the cleaners.

In the 17th, Shashank took on Bhuvneshwar Kumar. He got a streaky outside edge over short third first ball of the over for four. The next ball was drilled to wide long-off, and the fifth one slashed to deep extra cover.

Ashutosh then kept Kings in the hunt, swatting and ramping Pat Cummins for back-to-back fours in the 18th over. The odds still remained with SRH, with Kings requiring 39 in the last two overs. T Natajaraan was taken for ten, an excellent over in the context of things, which left Unadkat with 28 to defend in the 20th.

Unadkat's final over started with a six, two wides and another six. Fourteen runs gone in two balls. But he came back well conceding just six runs in his next three balls. Shashank deposited the last ball for six, but Kings narrowly missed out on getting over the line.

Nitish Kumar Reddy's 37-ball 64 took Sunrisers Hyderabad to an above par total • BCCI

Reddy rescues SRH

Nitish Kumar Reddy's heart would have been in his mouth during the carnage in the final over. After all, he had spilled Ashutosh's catch the first ball of the final over. But it was Reddy's knock of 64 from 37 balls that rescued SRH from a precarious 64 for 4 in the tenth over and took them to 182.

After Travis Head, Abhishek Sharma, Heinrich Klaasen and Aiden Markram fell cheaply, it was down to Reddy to do the repair work. On 14 from 18 balls at one stage, he slammed Harpreet Brar for four and a six in the 11th over. Kagiso Rabada was hooked over long leg for six, and Sam Curran was smashed over deep square. But Reddy really turned the screws in the 15th over, when he deposited Brar for 4, 6, 4, 6 off successive balls.

Arshdeep sets things right

Coming into the game Arshdeep Singh had four wickets in as many games in IPL 2024. Against SRH, he doubled his season tally on his way to figures of 4 for 29. The first of those came when on the second ball of the third over, Dhawan turned around 180 degrees and back-pedalled from mid-off to catch Head. Two deliveries later, Arshdeep angled one across Markram, and had him edging behind to the wicketkeeper. Arshdeep's first spell figures were 2-0-8-2, and as a result, SRH had their worst powerplay of the season, being restricted to 40 for 3.

Before Tuesday night, Arshdeep had only one wicket in 20 balls in the death overs this season. His economy rate was 11.70. But against SRH, he was brought back for the death overs, where he bowled two out of the four.

Reddy and Abdul Samad had added 50 in just 19 balls when Arshdeep went full and wide to Samad on the third ball of the 17th over, who found deep point. The fast bowler then removed Reddy, who only managed to loft a low full toss to long-on. Shahbaz Ahmed took 15 from the 19th over of the innings to somewhat spoil Arshdeep's figures, but it was still an excellent day out for the quick despite ending on the losing side.

MATCH 23

Gujarat Titans 199 for 7 (Gill 72, Rashid 24*, Tewatia, 22, Kuldeep 3-41) beat Rajasthan Royals 196 for 3 (Samson 68, Parag 76, Rashid 1-18) by three wickets

Rajasthan Royals did almost everything they could to go 5-0 on top of the IPL 2024 points table. But Rashid Khan happened.

Rashid conceded just 18 off his four overs, and should have had at least one more wicket but for dropped catches; without his effort, Gujarat Titans could have been chasing a lot more than 197. That was a difficult ask in itself, and it came down to 40 off 15 balls when they lost their sixth wicket.

Guess who walked in then? Yes, him again.

It's never over if Rashid is at the crease, especially if Rahul Tewatia is at the other end, and so it proved. It came down to 15 off the last over, which Avesh Khan bowled with only four fielders on the boundary with Royals having incurred an in-game over-rate penalty. Rashid hit two fours off the first three balls, and got back on strike for the last ball with Tewatia sacrificing his wicket at the danger end while going for a third that would have levelled the scores.

Two to get, one ball left, and Avesh went short and outside off. Rashid unfurled his wrists, among the strongest and most flexible in world cricket, and carved the ball to the vacant boundary beyond point, and Titans had ended Royals' unbeaten run.

Rashid vs Royals, part 1

Yashasvi Jaiswal threatened to break his run of low scores with a series of thrilling off-side boundaries early on, but both he and Jos Buttler fell inside the powerplay, leaving Royals 42 for 2.

Buttler departed in Rashid's first over, the sixth of the innings, edging a sharply turning legbreak to slip while trying to drive inside-out. The first ball he had faced from Rashid had kept low and beaten him outside off, giving Royals an early clue of how difficult they would find it to score against Rashid.

Rashid could have dismissed Riyan Parag later in that over, or in his next over, as Royals' No. 4 reached away from his body and edged a pair of legbreaks. Keeper Matthew Wade, however, put him down.

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Parag and Samson set up challenging total

At times, Noor Ahmad looked just as threatening as his Afghan spin twin at the other end, but he didn't quite bowl with the same control of length. Parag took every opportunity he got to slog-sweep Noor, when he went a little too full or a little too far down the leg side, and that shot brought him three sixes and a four against the left-arm wristspinner. In all, Parag hit 33 off 17 against Noor, the centrepiece of another impressive display, his third fifty in five innings this season.

Sanju Samson didn't have as much of the strike as Parag early on in their partnership - he was on 29 off 20 when Parag reached his half-century off 34 balls. He made a telling impact when he did get on strike, however, showing off his range of shots, including a stunning pair of hits off Spencer Johnson in the 15th over: two short-of-length balls, punched wide of extra-cover for four and flat-batted over long-on for six.

The one bowler the third-wicket pair didn't go after, though, was Rashid. Parag scored 13 off 15 against him, and Samson five off six. His final over, the 16th, produced five singles and a dot.

You could see why Royals played him this way. R Ashwin was slotted at No. 7, and Royals have tended not to use a batter as their Impact substitute even when they've lost early wickets. They've preferred to stack their bowling, and by playing out Rashid they ensured they could do this again: Keshav Maharaj came in for his IPL debut, partnering Ashwin and Yuzvendra Chahal in a formidable spin attack.

With Rashid's quota done, Royals went hard, taking 57 off their last four overs. Parag fell in the 19th, and Shimron Hetmyer, who has seldom got a chance to get his eye in this season, clattered an unbeaten 13 off 5 as he and Samson hit 24 off the last eight balls of the innings.

3:09

Moody: Boult bowling just two overs doesn't make sense

Gill sets the platform, Sen and Chahal wreck it

Titans hit some sumptuous shots in their powerplay - Sai Sudharsan uppercut Avesh for six, Shubman Gill launched Maharaj inside-out over the cover boundary - but they went at less than eight an over in that phase, ending it at 44 for no loss.

Even their good overs weren't ending up as truly big overs - Sudharsan punched Chahal for back-to-back fours to start the eighth, but Titans only scored 12 off the over, and could have lost Sudharsan had Chahal not dropped a return catch.

When Kuldeep Sen, playing his first game of the season, made a dramatic entry with the wickets of Sudharsan, Wade and Abhinav Manohar in the space of 10 legal balls, Titans

appeared to be going nowhere, needing 118 off the last 9.2 overs with seven wickets in hand.

Vijay Shankar showed a bit of initiative and inventiveness to hit three fours in his first nine balls, but he was bowled missing a sweep off Chahal, and Titans went into their last six needing 86. Gill, on 53 off 37, hadn't hit a boundary since the 10th over.

Gill changed gears at that point, hitting Ashwin for a pair of fours in the 15th over and starting the 16th with two more fours, freeing his arms to take full toll of Chahal's line wide of off stump. Then came what seemed a decisive moment: Gill stepped out, perhaps a touch too early, and Chahal, seeing him coming, fired it even wider - a genuine wide - to have him stumped for 72 off 44.

1:51

Moody: Rashid is very difficult to bowl to

Titans' finishers finish it off

The last four began with Titans needing 59, and the extra muscle in their line-up - they had included the out-and-out T20 hitters Manohar and Shahrukh Khan for the first time this season - began to pay off. Ashwin's final over, the 17th, went for 17, as Shahrukh and Tewatia hit him for a six and two fours between them, bringing the equation down to 42 off 18.

Royals have used Avesh and Sandeep Sharma as their main death bowlers this season, with Trent Boult not used even once in this phase. Boult conceded only eight in his two powerplay overs here, but Royals continued to not use him at the death here, trusting Avesh to do his assigned job and Sen to step into the absent Sandeep's shoes.

Avesh conceded just seven in the 18th over, along the way spearing in a full ball to trap Shahrukh lbw, playing across it.

The momentum seemed to be with Royals, but Sen's 19th reversed it, as Tewatia, Rashid and extras combined to shave 20 off the 35 that Titans required. The last ball of that over, shortish and angled across the left-handed Tewatia, produced a terrific shot under pressure, flat-batted calmly over mid-off.

This left Titans needing 15 off 6. This team, with largely the same personnel, had successfully achieved last-over chases of 15 or more on three occasions during their fairytale debut season of 2022. Tewatia and Rashid had been stars of that season and their runners-up second season in 2023, and they were in the middle again. Was there any way for Titans not to win?

MATCH 24

Mumbai Indians 199 for 3 (Kishan 69, Suryakumar 52, Rohit 38, Jacks 1-24) beat Royal Challengers Bengaluru 196 for 8 (Du Plessis 61, Karthik 53*, Patidar 50, Bumrah 5-21) by seven wickets

The bash-through-the-line Wankhede pitch and dewy conditions contributed to five 50-plus scores, including a 17-ball half-century from Suryakumar Yadav, but it was Jasprit Bumrah who produced the most decisive performance on the night to set up Mumbai Indians' second successive victory at home.

Bumrah's 5 for 21 - he was on a hat-trick twice - kept Royal Challengers Bengaluru to 196 for 8, despite Dinesh Karthik's inventive 53 not out off 23 balls. Karthik hit four sixes and a four off the last seven legal balls he faced to give RCB a bigish total.

But it looked smaller than it was when Ishan Kishan cracked a 23-ball half-century inside the powerplay in the chase. It looked a whole lot smaller when Suryakumar, playing only his second game back from injury, reminded the world of his power and range. MI eventually mowed down the target with seven wickets and nearly five overs to spare.

Captain Hardik Pandya was booed when he bowled a solitary over earlier in the night, but a packed crowd celebrated with him when he finished the chase with a six.

ESPNcricinfo Ltd

Patidar, du Plessis prop up RCB

RCB were 23 for 2 in the fourth over when Faf du Plessis and Rajat Patidar came together.

Before that, Bumrah had Virat Kohli swiping and edging behind for three off nine balls in his first over, the third of the innings. In the next over, Akash Madhwal generated his signature skid to have Will Jacks, who made his IPL debut in place of Cameron Green, flapping a catch to mid-on for eight.

Du Plessis tried to salvage the powerplay by staying leg side of the ball and using his hands to pump the ball over the top. Patidar, too, started quickly and later overtook du Plessis to become the first of many half-centurions in the game.

Patidar reached the landmark with back-to-back sixes off Gerald Coetzee, but the South Africa quick hit back the next ball to bounce Patidar out for 50 off 26 balls.

2:03

'Bumrah does his research, he doesn't leave a stone unturned'

Bumrah's masterclass

After removing Kohli with the new ball, Bumrah returned with the old one to almost shut down RCB's innings.

In a 17th over, which was full of yorkers or low full-tosses, he dismissed du Plessis (61) and Mahipal Lomror (0). Du Plessis failed to get under a hard-to-hit low full-toss and holed out to long-on while Lomror was pinned lbw by a yorker off the next ball.

In his next over, Bumrah found himself on a hat-trick again but didn't get to it this time either. He bounced out Saurav Chauhan, RCB's impact player, and Vyshak Vijaykumar off successive balls, but Akash Deep somehow kept out the hat-trick ball, which was a yorker.

Bumrah's five-wicket haul, though, had his former captain Rohit Sharma lifting him off the ground, and his former bowling partner and current bowling coach, Lasith Malinga, on his feet, applauding him from the dugout.

On Sunday, against Delhi Capitals, Bumrah came away with 4-0-22-2 on a day when 439 runs were scored. Thursday's performance was even more special on a dewy night.

Karthik finishes with a flourish

Karthik, who has represented MI in the past, had the Wankhede crowd chanting his name when he picked a slower ball from Bumrah and launched it over extra-cover, providing a throwback to his six that won India the Nidahas Trophy in 2018.

He played a number of other sensational shots as well. When Madhwal denied him easy access to the shorter square boundary on the leg side, Karthik scooped him for a pair of fours over short third in the 16th over that cost MI 19 runs. Karthik also helped take 19 off Madhwal's final over, also the final over of the innings, but it would not be enough for RCB.

Ishan Kishan was unstoppable at the top•Associated Press

Kishan blasts off

Mohammed Siraj and Reece Topley swung the new ball in the early exchanges, but that didn't stop Kishan from maximising the powerplay.

When Siraj swung one into his pads, he picked it up over square leg for six. Then, when Topley moved one away from him, Kishan crunched him over point. Kishan had a nervy moment on 12, when Topley found his edge, but it flew between keeper and first slip for four more.

Kishan continued to deal in boundaries and repeated his feat of smashing a fifty in the powerplay for MI.

Suryakumar Yadav, playing his second game of the season, got a 17-ball fifty•Associated Press

A new high for SKY

Akash Deep stopped Kishan on 69 and Jacks removed Rohit for 38, but there would be no respite for RCB.

Their bowlers kept missing their lengths as the dew set in and Suryakumar went about making life even more difficult for them.

Suryakumar could have been dismissed on 15 but Maxwell dropped him at backward point and then left the field, writhing in pain. Suryakumar then unfurled his Supla shot and used his wrists and fast hands to scythe wide balls over point. He charged to his fastest T20 fifty with a sequence of 4, 6, 4, 4 off Topley in the 13th over. He holed out in the next over, but Hardik and Tilak Varma sealed a NRR-boosting win for MI with 27 balls in hand.

MATCH 25

Delhi Capitals 170 for 4 (Fraser-McGurk 55, Pant 41, Shaw 32, Bishnoi 2-25) beat Lucknow Super Giants 167 for 7 (Badoni 55*, Rahul 39, Kuldeep 3-20, Khaleel 2-41) by six wickets

Delhi Capitals ended Lucknow Super Giants' stranglehold on 160-plus defences and lifted themselves off the bottom of the IPL 2024 table with a six-wicket win in Lucknow on Friday. Kuldeep Yadav provided the inspiration on his return from injury before a sparkling half-century on IPL debut from Australia's Jake Fraser-McGurk saw them reel in their target with 11 balls to spare.

After choosing to bat, LSG produced a stuttering innings that still finished above the 160-mark - from which they had never lost when batting first. KL Rahul gave them a fast start with 39 off 22 before Kuldeep ripped out the guts of their line-up in the space of his first nine balls. Rahul's dismissal by Kuldeep left LSG 77 for 5 and their position got worse before it got better.

With the score 94 for 7 after 13 overs, DC appeared to be on course for a walkover. But Ayush Badoni's 31-ball fifty and an unbroken stand of 73 with Arshad Khan - an IPL record for the eighth wicket - at least gave LSG's vaunted spin attack something to bowl at.

DC, on a run of four defeats in five, might have wondered if their chance had gone. Prithvi Shaw gave the chase a punchy start to settle some of the nerves and then it was over to Fraser-McGurk, the 22-year-old from Melbourne, to provide the fireworks. His first scoring shot was a wallop for six over deep midwicket and he cleared the ropes four more times to raise his half-century from 31 balls. He and Rishabh Pant departed after a stand of 77 off 46 but by then DC were well on track.

Rishabh Pant and Jake Fraser-McGurk set up the chase for Delhi Capitals • Associated Press

Fraser-McGurk continues stunning rise

It is only six months since Fraser-McGurk grabbed headlines worldwide by breaking AB de Villiers' record for the fastest List A hundred when he reached the mark off just 29 balls while batting for South Australia. Remarkably, that was his first century in professional cricket, but he enjoyed a breakthrough summer that culminated in him being capped during Australia's ODI series against West Indies. He hit his third ball on debut for four, his fourth for six, and then was out to his fifth.

Coming in at No. 3 in Lucknow, following the dismissal of David Warner by Yash Thakur, he stayed true to first principles. His second ball was swatted insouciantly off the front foot over midwicket - a shot his DC coach, Ricky Ponting, would doubtless have enjoyed - and he then launched an even bigger hit over wide long-on from his fifth.

Another slash for four took him to 16 off seven (with three scoring shots) before the arrival of the LSG spinners to present a new challenge.

A slowdown duly followed, with nine runs coming from his next 16 balls. But just when the game appeared to be back in the balance, Fraser-McGurk let loose against Krunal Pandya, carting him over midwicket, extra cover and long-off for three consecutive sixes that effectively put a nail in the home side's chances.

Pant leads from the front

Amid Capitals' struggles, Pant has carried a particularly heavy burden: captain, wicketkeeper and star batter, and all this after more than a year out of the game after a car crash. His anguished chat with umpire Rohan Pandit during the LSG innings, having unsuccessfully tried to review a wide - Pant seeming to say he hadn't reviewed it in the first place - summed up how things have been going.

But after Ravi Bishnoi dismissed Shaw, via a superb diving catch in the deep from Nicholas Pooran, Pant played an astute hand. After ticking along initially, and with Fraser-McGurk becalmed, he skipped out to his 12th delivery to launch Bishnoi down the ground for an enormous straight six, following it up with a smash through the covers for four. Two more boundaries came in Marcus Stoinis' over, including an audacious reverse-scoop, to keep DC up with the rate before Fraser-McGurk unleashed.

The requirement was below a run a ball by the time Fraser-McGurk carved to deep third and although Pant was stumped in the next over, charging at Bishnoi, the hard work had been done.

ESPNcricinfo Ltd

Rahul rules early exchanges

LSG have a tried-and-trusted template for batting first and looked to be well on track at the end of the powerplay. Quinton de Kock took a brace of fours off the opening over, Rahul's third ball was emphatically thrashed over cover for a flat six, and although Khaleel Ahmed hit back to remove de Kock and Devdutt Padikkal - who extended his run of single-figure scores in an LSG shirt to five - there was no sense of panic in the stands (although things might have been different if Khaleel had held on to a sharp return catch off Stoinis' first ball).

Rahul responded by punching Khaleel back down the ground for four, before finding the boundary twice more off Mukesh Kumar as LSG ended the powerplay comfortably on 57 for 2. Ominously for DC, Rahul's 30 off 14 represented his joint-highest six-over score for LSG.

Kuldeep back with a bang-bang

Capitals' premier wristspinner had missed their last three games with a groin injury but he immediately grabbed the LSG innings by the throat. Stoinis was unable to make the most of his early reprieve, slicing a googly to backward point to give Kuldeep a wicket with his third ball. The next delivery was even better, another expertly disguised wrong'un duping LSG's leading run-scorer Pooran, who played all around the ball to lose his off stump.

In his second over, Kuldeep snuffed out Rahul's punchy knock, too - a review confirming a thin edge behind as the LSG captain attempted to cut a quicker, wide delivery. With impact sub Deepak Hooda top-edging tamely to point and Krunal gloving a Mukesh bouncer behind, LSG had slumped to 94 for 7 and were seemingly in deep trouble.

2:37

Jaffer: Badoni continues to surprise us

Badoni finishes like Dhoni

The LSG innings went six full overs without a boundary as the middle order crumbled, but Badoni and Arshad steadily resurrected their chances. Badoni ended the drought with back-to-back fours off Mukesh, pulled fine and slapped over backward point, but otherwise focused on hoovering up ones and twos against the spin of Kuldeep and Axar Patel.

With the return of pace for the 18th, Badoni decided it was time to go. Khaleel was duly smoked over deep midwicket for six, before Arshad followed suit by muscling his first boundary over mid-off. The No. 9 was dropped by Shaw off the final ball of the over, to compound Khaleel's pain. Badoni lofted and then swept Mukesh on the way to a 31-ball fifty in the 19th, as the eighth-wicket pair successfully drove LSG above the 160-mark. This time, however, the magic deserted them.

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MATCH 27

Rajasthan Royals 152 for 7 (Jaiswal 39, Hetmyer 27*, Rabada 2-18) beat Punjab Kings 147 for 8 (Ashutosh 31, Jitesh 29, Maharaj 2-23) by three wickets

Shimron Hetmyer came in with Rajasthan Royals needing 35 from 20. Perhaps it should never have got this close, given Punjab Kings' 147 for 8 felt at least ten runs too light on a pitch that had some bounce but no known witchcraft performed upon it. It had also seemed from Royals' own solid - but not rampant - 56-run opening stand, that they weren't sweating it.

But then Kagiso Rabada bowled his four overs for 18, and suddenly the back end of this match became tight. Rabada had taken two big wickets as well - of Yashasvi Jaiswal and Sanju Samson - and as such was doing as much as any Kings player to produce a match-winning hand.

The final word, though, went to Hetmyer, who, despite an excellent penultimate over from Sam Curran and a good effort from Arshdeep Singh, won with a six off the penultimate ball. There had been two sixes from Hetmyer in the lead-up to that.

The last over

Curran dismissed Rovman Powell and Keshav Maharaj in the 19th over while conceding ten runs, and Royals needed another ten off the 20th over. Hetmyer was on strike, so it always seemed likely, but then Arshdeep delivered two glorious yorkers first up, which the batter could not make anything of, and the equation came down to ten from four.

The key shot in the final over was Hetmyer's desperate wallop down the ground off the third ball. Arshdeep had not missed his length by much, but this was not quite in the blockhole. Hetmyer swung hard and managed to bully this ball into the boundary cushion - not over it - behind the bowler.

Only centimetres were in it. Had Arshdeep pitched a fraction fuller, Hetmyer would not have been able to get under it. Had Hetmyer not hit it with slightly fewer newtons of force behind it, the shot would have only brought four, and six would have been required from the last three.

Hetmyer muscled the next ball towards long-on and got two, but the worst ball of Arshdeep's over was the fifth one, and almost anyone could have hit that for a boundary. This came juicy, knee-high, and on the stumps. Hetmyer shuffled across and thwacked it over deep fine leg, clinching a thriller.

Kagiso Rabada removed Yashasvi Jaiswal and Sanju Samson in successive overs•BCCI

Rabada's charge

In defence of a modest target, Rabada was intense. He bowled two tight powerplay overs, off which just 12 runs came, and then bowled aggressively through the middle overs, as Kings were looking for wickets. He got Jaiswal with a short wide one the batter toe-edged, then claimed the prized wicket of Royals captain Samson when he jagged one back to hit the batter on the back leg. Rabada conceded only two boundaries, which was also the number of wickets he took.

Kings' underwhelming innings

Until the last two overs, in which Impact Sub Ashutosh Sharma made the most of a let-off and hit 20 off the last nine balls he faced, Kings never seemed capable of moving into high gear. Every time some semblance of a partnership seemed to be forming, a wicket fell. Often this was because batters fell for cross-bat shots to short balls that got big on them. They were 38 for 1 after the powerplay, 53 for 4 after ten overs, and 86 for 5 after 15.

From that point, Ashutosh, Rabada and, to some extent, Curran did well to make such a tight game out of this.

MATCH 28

Kolkata Knight Riders 162 for 2 (Salt 89*, Shreyas 38*, Mohsin 2-29) beat Lucknow Super Giants 161 for 7 (Pooran 45, Rahul 39, Starc 3-28) by eight wickets

Phil Salt and Mitchell Starc made it a Bengali New Year to remember for the Kolkata Knight Riders fans at Eden Gardens, helping the hosts thump Lucknow Super Giants by eight wickets on Sunday. Starc picked up important LSG wickets to finish with 3 for 28, his best figures of the season, while Salt led the charge in the chase with an unbeaten 47-ball 89. KKR now sit second on the points table, having begun a string of five straight home games in fabulous fashion.

KKR were also left chasing a comfortable target courtesy their spinners' efforts in the middle overs; they did not let LSG break away despite having wickets in hand. Sunil Narine took 1 for 17 in four while Varun Chakravarthy claimed 1 for 30. Together, their eight overs went for only 5.88 per over.

As for LSG, there were two silver linings, provided by Nicholas Pooran and Mohsin Khan. From No. 6, Pooran struck four sixes and two fours to make a 32-ball 45 to give LSG a competitive total while Mohsin picked up the only two KKR wickets to fall, both in the powerplay.

Phil Salt attacked from one end even as KKR lost two early wickets•Associated Press

Salt shakes up LSG

After the game, KL Rahul described the defeat as a "proper hammering", and the prime reason for that was Salt. Having been dismissed for a duck in Chennai in KKR's previous game, Salt was very nearly out for a duck again when he clipped debutant Shamar Joseph to short-fine leg. Luckily for Salt, Yash Thakur dropped him and even if he hadn't, Joseph's front-foot no-ball would've given him a reprieve anyway. After that let-off, Salt finished the first over with a six down the ground, and then continued to go for it through the powerplay. That helped KKR stay on course even as Sunil Narine and Angkrish Raghuvanshi fell cheaply. He clubbed Krunal Pandya for a hat-trick of boundaries in the third over and that set up a 58-run powerplay.

On 31, Salt was dropped again at deep-square leg in the seventh over, and it perhaps made him tentative for a couple of overs. But Salt once again found momentum in the tenth over, bowled by Arshad Khan (the bowler paying the price for having dropped him three overs earlier). Salt struck consecutive fours in the tenth to reach his fifty in 26 balls and bring up KKR's hundred inside ten overs.

Salt then began to apply the finishing touches when he struck Thakur for three fours in the 14th over, followed by a massive six over midwicket off Mohsin in the 15th. His pull for four in the 16th over off a half-tracker from Bishnoi summed up both the KKR batting innings and the LSG bowling performance.

From the other end, Shreyas Iyer made up for a slow start to finish unbeaten for the second time this season. He did not need to take risks, given Salt's brisk scoring and the two early wickets.

He played aggressive shots only as the target got closer. He struck Ravi Bishnoi and Arshad for boundaries through the middle overs to move from 6 off 12 to finish unbeaten on 38 off 38. He was particularly strong off his hips as the LSG pacers erred by bowling too many times on a leg-stump line. His unbroken partnership of 120 with Salt was the highest third-wicket stand for KKR in the IPL.

0:54

Starc: 'Taken me longer than I would've liked to get back into rhythm'

Starc leads KKR's bowling charge

After Vaibhav Arora struck early to remove Quinton de Kock, Shreyas gave Starc a third powerplay over in the afternoon heat to find another wicket. He did that when an out-of-form Deepak Hooda sliced him to backward point in the fifth over.

Rahul and the No. 4 Ayush Badoni then consolidated to take LSG to 72 for 2 in ten overs, however Rahul's attempt to up his scoring rate resulted in his dismissal. Rahul struck Andre Russell for a six to start off the 11th over but while attempting a repeat next ball, he holed out for 39 at deep midwicket. That brought in Marcus Stoinis, but his stay was short lived

when he was deceived by Varun, inside-edging a catch to the off-side which the wicketkeeper Salt smartly collected.

At 109 for 4 in 14 overs, LSG were at risk of finishing well under-par. The situation become more dire when Badoni top-edged Narine in the 15th for a laboured 27-ball 29. Narine would concede no boundaries as he finished with 1 for 17.

But while Pooran was around, LSG still had hope, and he offered just that with his 32-ball 45. He went after the inexperienced pair of Harshit Rana and Arora in the death overs, helping LSG score 29 runs off the 18th and 19th overs. However, Starc stopped further damage in the 20th over, when he had Pooran nicking behind off the first ball. That ensured LSG would score only 52 runs off the final six overs, with Starc embellishing his returns with a third wicket off the final delivery of the innings.

MATCH 29

Chennai Super Kings 206 for 4 (Gaikwad 69, Dube 66*, Hardik 2-43) beat Mumbai Indians 186 for 6 (Rohit 105*, Tilak 31, Pathirana 4-28) by 20 runs

Sensational defensive bowling from Chennai Super Kings did what might have seemed unthinkable: successfully defend a total in the night at Wankhede Stadium. And it was not a huge total: pushed just over 200 by a MS Dhoni cameo of 20 off the last four balls of the innings after Shivam Dube had continued his dream season with an unbeaten 66 off 38.

For large parts it was a contest that fit the billing: between the two most successful teams in the IPL and two of the three most popular teams. For large parts, it seemed the defending champions CSK would be outgunned. Jasprit Bumrah restricted them with four overs for just 27 and the Mumbai innings looked like it was going smoothly, but Matheesha Pathirana started the comeback with two wickets in his first over.

Still, Mumbai were favourites going into the last seven, needing 83 with eight wickets in hand, but their fast bowlers led by Pathirana executed their plans of making batters hit into the bigger part perfectly, eventually winning by 20 runs. Rohit Sharma scored a century but it was only to Mumbai's detriment: he scored just 14 off 14 between overs 13 to 18 and then found another wind when the task had become mathematically impossible.

1:38

Is Shivam Dube booking his ticket to the T20 World Cup?

Cat and mouse for starters

This match was also a tactical classic from both sides. CSK promoted Ajinkya Rahane to open because he was carrying a niggle and thought it was better if he just batted in the powerplay. In a way it worked tactically too: Ruturaj Gaikwad hasn't been going at a million miles an hour in the powerplay and could also be there for when Bumrah bowled. Either

way, Rahane didn't last, and Gaikwad had to come out in the second over. Mumbai then started to bowl cheap overs of spin before Dube got a chance to bat.

When Dube came in, that was it for spin, and Bumrah came back to bowl a second over inside the first ten for only the second time this IPL. Except that Mumbai did have to bowl overs of less-than-express pace. Dube took a toll of Hardik Pandya and Romario Shepherd as Gaikwad slowed down from his starts of 24 off 12 to offer a catch on 39 off 31. Rohit dropped him, and Gaikwad took 29 off nine before he got out.

Bumrah stifles but Hardik blinks

Hardik started reining CSK back in with clever use of a wide slower ball to get Gaikwad. Then Bumrah just bowled two ruthless overs full of attempted yorkers. Only one boundary came off the 17th and 19th, leaving CSK at 180 for 3. The problem for Mumbai was, that they had to now go to Hardik, Shepherd or spin for the last over.

The captain took the challenge on, but came a distant second to Dhoni, offering him the length to hit a hat-trick of sixes. Dhoni's IPL this year: 25 balls, 59 runs, no dismissal.

2:06

Was Pathirana's spell among the best-ever at Wankhede?

Pathirana has to intervene

Yet again Mumbai started like they would make short work of a target around 200 after gunning RCB's 196 down in 15.3 overs. Rohit and Ishan Kishan looked smooth and brutal. Seven overs, 70 runs, not a sweat broken.

Enter Pathirana, coming back from an injury break. The first ball was a loose one on the pads, and Kishan found midwicket with precision. Six feet on either side and it would have left a hole in the boundary boards. However, following that lucky break, Pathirana was sensational. He welcomed Suryakumar Yadav with a 151.2kmph wide yorker and followed it up with a wide bouncer with the deep third placed fine just for the ramp. The assist came from Mustafizur Rahman, who took it overhead, flicked it back up, stepped outside, and came back to take the catch.

The middle overs

Ravindra Jadeja bowled four overs on the trot for 37, which is commendable in dewy conditions on a Mumbai night. Rohit, though, seemed to have overcome his recent threat of left-arm spin by taking 22 off 13 Jadeja deliveries. Runs kept coming from the other end until Pathirana came back.

2:54

Was Hardik Pandya's decision to bowl the final over sound?

A defensive masterclass

It was all in Pathirana's basket now. Three overs to bowl out of seven with Mumbai needing just 83 with all the firepower in the dugout. Pathirana began with a dot to push it over two a ball for the first time. Then a subtle slower ball got the fluent Tilak Varma out. Then both former and current captains of Mumbai froze.

Shardul Thakur followed that over with wide-line slower balls. Both Rohit and Hardik faced three each for a single each. A frustrated Hardik even wasted a review on a wide. Tushar Deshpande followed it up with a boundary-less over and the wicket of Hardik. Rohit seemed to have run out of gas and timing.

Tim David raised some hope with successive sixes off Mustafizur but he again went wide and out of David's reach to get the wicket. Pathirana provided the finishing touch by rattling Shepherd's stumps with a quick, straight delivery, the license for which he got because he had the bigger leg-side boundary to play with.

However, it was the slower balls from the other end that complemented Pathirana. At one point, they had bowled 13 for just four runs. They ended up with 27 slower balls for 36 runs, which was still way better than Mumbai's execution of the delivery.

MATCH 30

Sunrisers Hyderabad 287 for 3 (Head 102, Klaasen 67, Ferguson 2-52) beat Royal Challengers Bangalore 262 for 7 (Karthik 83, du Plessis 62, Cummins 3-43) by 25 runs

Sunrisers Hyderabad showed how merciless modern T20 batting can look, obliterating the record they had themselves set earlier this season to post 287 for 3, the highest total in the IPL.

Travis Head, who has won Australia the World Test Championship and the ODI World Cup final over the last year, sent another warning signal for his opponents ahead of the T20 World Cup. He had scored a 24-ball 62 when Sunrisers made 277 for 3 against Mumbai on March 27; now he belted a career-best 102 off 41 against Royal Challengers Bengaluru.

Related

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Stats - Sunrisers Hyderabad break their own record for highest-ever IPL total

The big hits were incessant. Head hit eight sixes, and Heinrich Klaasen seven in a 31-ball 67, out of a Sunrisers total of 22 - another IPL record. RCB did their bit too, on a dream day for batters, sending 16 hits soaring over the M Chinnaswamy Stadium's boundaries as they made a superb effort to restrict the damage to their net run rate. They finished on 262 for 7, Dinesh Karthik leading the way with 83 off 35 balls.

The match aggregate of 549 runs was the highest in all T20 cricket.

Travis Head hit eight sixes out of a Sunrisers total of 22, an IPL record for a team innings•BCCI

Head breaks RCB's hearts

RCB went into the match without a single frontline spinner. But with two left-handers in Head and Abhishek Sharma opening for Sunrisers, they began with the offspin of batting allrounder Will Jacks. He found turn in the first over, and conceded just seven. His second over was even better, going for just four.

And yet, Sunrisers put up 76 in the powerplay, the third time they had gone past 70 during that phase of the innings this season. By then, Head had motored to his half-century off 20 balls. Head hit four sixes across the fifth and sixth overs as RCB debutant Lockie Ferguson went for 18 and then Yash Dayal for 20.

Head's second fifty was even quicker, taking only 19 balls, and the century came up in the 12th over. Ferguson had Head ballooning a catch to mid-off halfway into the 13th, but Klaasen had arrived by then, and SRH already had 165 on the board. That was enough indication of what more was to come on a flat pitch surrounded by small boundaries.

Klaasen continues six fest

Promoted to No. 3 after the openers hammered 108 in 8.1 overs, Klaasen kept Sunrisers' party going. He managed only three runs from his first five deliveries, but soon got into the six-hitting groove that has made him among the world's most dangerous T20 hitters. He swung Dayal and Ferguson for sixes over midwicket just before Head was dismissed, and that wicket did nothing to temper Klaasen's aggression.

Dinesh Karthik ensured RCB didn't suffer too much net-run-rate damage•BCCI

With Head's dismissal bringing a second right-hander to the crease in Aiden Markram, RCB brought on the left-arm spin of Mahipal Lomror in the 14th over. The match-up didn't bring any joy, as Klaasen carted him for two sixes.

Klaasen hit three more sixes - including a 106m straight hit off Ferguson that sailed over the roof - before being dismissed with three overs remaining, with Sunrisers on 231. The only question then was if they could breach their own record total of 277. Abdul Samad and Markram put all doubts away with stunning cameos, as the last two overs produced 46 runs.

Karthik fights to limit the damage

There was only one way for RCB to bat in their response, and Virat Kohli and Faf du Plessis counterattacked their way to 79 in the powerplay, three more than what Sunrisers had managed at that stage. RCB's opening pair smashed 11 fours and four sixes in that phase alone. Even so, RCB were behind the asking rate, which had now climbed to nearly 15.

Sunrisers' Impact Sub Mayank Markande, who replaced Head at the start of the chase, beat Kohli with a googly just after the powerplay, and that began something of a mini-collapse, as RCB slipped to 122 for 5 by the end of the 10th over, with Pat Cummins striking twice including getting du Plessis for 62.

That is when Karthik entered to keep the crowd entertained. He was the dominant partner in a 59-run partnership with Lomror, which briefly stirred hopes of an outlandish finish, as Markande and Jaydev Unadkat leaked 46 across the 13th and 14th overs.

A six-run 15th over from Cummins, which also included the wicket of Lomror, effectively ended RCB's hopes, but Karthik kept going, hitting at least one six ever over until he was dismissed with eight balls remaining. Seven sixes came off his bat including a switch-hit off Bhuvneshwar Kumar, but he couldn't prevent RCB from slumping to a fifth successive loss and remaining rooted to the bottom of the points table.

MATCH 31

Rajasthan Royals 224 for 8 (Buttler 107*, Parag 34, Narine 2-30, Varun 2-36, Rana 2-45) beat Kolkata Knight Riders 223 for 6 (Narine 109, Raghuvanshi 30, Avesh 2-35, Sen 2-46) by two wickets

Jos Buttler started slightly slow as Rajasthan Royals (RR) aimed to travel at more than 11 an over, making only 25 off his first 18 balls. He was at the crease during what seemed like a debilitating mid-innings slowdown, in which Royals scored only 30 from six overs, and lost three wickets in that time.

But although clearly still struggling with the injury that kept him out of the last RR game, and although rapidly running out of batting partners, Buttler stayed the course. He was there turning down singles in the 18th over, after Rovman Powell got out following a decent cameo. He was there to clobber two sixes and a four off the penultimate over, to get the equation down to nine off the final six balls.

Related

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And despite Varun Chakravathy having bowled three dots in that final over, Buttler was there to heroically hit the winning run off the final ball of the match. Off the first ball of that over, he had also bashed a six down the ground that made RR the clear favourites to get over the line, and in the course of that completed his second century this IPL, to follow the 100 not out he had struck against Royal Challengers Bengaluru only ten days ago.

Buttler's feat meant that Sunil Narine's century, a staggering accomplishment in itself, was overshadowed. As were his figures of 2 for 30 off four overs.

Rovman Powell's 13-ball 26 put the Royals chase back on track•AFP/Getty Images

The 17th over of the chase

After 16 overs of Royals' innings, they needed 62 runs off 24 balls, six of which were to be bowled by Narine, who had not conceded a boundary up till then.

But Rovman Powell then walloped two sixes and a four off the first three balls of the 17th over, which Narine bowled, and suddenly Royals' challenge didn't seem so sharp. Narine, however, would nail Powell lbw with the fifth ball of that over.

Shreyas Iyer fined for slow over-rate

Shreyas Iyer, the Kolkata Knight Riders captain, has been fined after his team maintained a slow over-rate against Rajasthan Royals in their last-ball defeat at Eden Gardens on Tuesday. As it was KKR's first offence of the season - in six games - Iyer was fined INR 12 lakh.

The last three overs

With Powell gone, and no batter he could trust to hand the strike over to, this is where Buttler really shone. He smashed a six down the ground first ball of Starc's last over, before swivel-pulling him around the corner for four later in the over. Starc did not help himself by bowling five wides soon after, either.

Then, with 28 required off 12, Buttler clobbered three sixes and a four off the next seven balls, never losing strike. With the requirement down to three off five, he bided his time. He collected two off the penultimate ball, then pierced a packed infield with a leg-side clip last ball to see RR to their sixth win this season, and arguably their most hard-earned one.

3:16

Narine had told me a decade back that he would get a hundred - Bishop

The Narine show

As good as Buttler was, though, Narine was the game's MVP - he just had less support from his team-mates. Though known as a powerplay aggressor, he let Phil Salt and Angkrish Raghuvanshi take the lead early on, before blooming in the middle overs against the

spinners. He smacked R Aswhin for two sixes, and Yuzvendra Chahal for three, as both those bowlers conceded in excess of 12 an over.

It was Narine's fours, though, that truly powered his innings. He hit 13 of them, all but four of them on the off side.

Although Narine had been impressive through the middle overs, he also accelerated towards the death. He hit 35 runs off the last 14 balls he faced. Most impressively, he motored from 79 to KKR's third IPL hundred in the space of one Chahal over, in which he crashed two sixes and two fours.

Rinku Singh provided some closing fireworks to the KKR innings, but Narine's best stand had been the 85-run second-wicket partnership with Raghuvanshi, who made only 30 of those runs. Such was Narine's early dominance.

MATCH 32

Delhi Capitals 92 for 4 (Fraser-McGurk 20, Warner 2-40) beat Gujarat Titans 89 all out (Rashid 31, Mukesh 3-14) by six wickets

At the start of the fourth over, Gujarat Titans were projected to reach 169. By the start of the sixth over, they were trending much lower, to 120. In the end, they were bowled out for double-digits, 89. It was their lowest-ever IPL total, having been brought into the tournament in 2022.

Four of the six bowlers Delhi Capitals used returned economy rates of 4.5 or less, setting up the batters to go out there and do their thing. The chase was done in 53 balls, with six wickets to spare, and that mattered. Capitals are now in sixth place, above Titans on the points table, because their net run-rate rose from -0.975 to -0.074.

How the Titans fell

A slow, low, and turning pitch had the home team spiralling all through their innings. Shubman Gill tried to get ahead of it by going hard at everything. He hit two cuh-risp fours in five balls and in going for another he got caught at cover. Eventually it became clear why he was so desperate for early boundaries.

The ball began holding in the pitch. Wriddhiman Saha went after it but was too early into the pull and dragged it onto his stumps. It began spinning. Tristan Stubbs, who had bowled only 177 balls in his 79-match T20 career, helped himself to two wickets in an over with his offbreaks.

Four of the top six with single-digit scores. Rahul Tewatia batting in the powerplay. Sacrificing the option of R Sai Kishore as an Impact Player against the right-hander-heavy Capitals line-up to send in Shahrukh Khan. He was meant to fire. He was the in-case-of-emergency-break-glass option. He returned with a duck. Out stumped even though the wicketkeeper didn't collect the ball cleanly. It was that kind of day.

Tristan Stubbs is thrilled after Rishabh Pant completes a second stumping - albeit a bit fortuitously - in his over •BCCI

Pant is a joy

Right at the start, a giggle was caught on the mic. It sounded very Rishabh Pant-y. He and Gill were just staring at each other and everybody else was stuck waiting as the Capitals skipper tried to remember what the plan was after winning the toss. "I think we're going to bowl," he said.

Pant took two catches, one requiring a little more effort than normal, from how he needed to dive low and quickly to his left to take it and then call on DRS to confirm suspicions that David Miller had indeed nicked it.

There were a couple of stumpings as well, one that almost didn't happen. Pant had seen that Shahrukh's back foot was nowhere near where it needed to be. He was beyond excited. That might have played a part in how he grabbed for the ball, hard-handed, and therefore couldn't collect it cleanly. But it didn't matter because the ball just bounced off his gloves and straight onto the wicket, prompting child-like glee at how a mistake he'd made actually turned out okay.

This is why the world needs Rishabh Pant. A lot of his fans - and India fans - must be thrilled that he's back playing cricket again because he is a game-changer. But really, he's so much more than that. He reminds people to smile. To enjoy themselves. To have fun. Just by smiling and having fun himself.

After the eighth over, when Kuldeep Yadav was upset with a wayward throw, acting like he had suffered a mortal wound, Pant ran down to the bowler, put one hand around his shoulders and used the other one to stroke his chest. There, there. Don't worry. Be happy.

He had a good game as captain too, bringing back Khaleel Ahmed for a third over inside the powerplay to see if he could sneak a fifth Titans wicket. That wasn't possible but a maiden was. For some reason he bowled Stubbs ahead of Axar Patel which turned a score of 47 for 4 to 48 for 6. Pant spent the rest of the innings chirping away behind the stumps. It was like he was never even away.

Rishabh Pant Gujarat Titans Delhi Capitals GT vs DC

MATCH 33

Mumbai Indians 192 for 7 (Suryakumar 78, Harshal 3-31) beat Punjab Kings 183 all out (Ashutosh 61, Shashank 41, Bumrah 3-21) by nine runs

Ashutosh Sharma's heroic 28-ball 61 went in vain as Punjab Kings suffered yet another close defeat in IPL 2024, this time going down to Mumbai Indians in Mullanpur by nine runs.

Early in the chase, Kings were at the risk of being bundled out cheaply when Jasprit Bumrah and Gerald Coetzee combined to leave the hosts 14 for 4 in 2.1 overs. Soon that became 77 for 6. But Ashutosh - and Shashank Singh with a 25-ball 41 - injected life into the contest.

Hardik fined for slow over rate

Mumbai Indians captain Hardik Pandya has been fined for his team maintaining a slow over rate during their match against Punjab Kings in Mullanpur. He was fined INR 12 lakhs, this being his team's first over-rate offence of IPL 2024 under the IPL's code of conduct.

With three overs to go, Kings needed only 25 runs more. However, Ashutosh fell at the start of the 18th over, and Mumbai never let that advantage go. Kings suffered their fourth final-over defeat of the season, and their fifth loss in all, as Mumbai climbed from ninth to seventh on the table.

Bumrah, Coetzee bowl thunderbolts

Kings were on the mat early in their chase of 193 when Coetzee had Prabhsimran Singh caught behind down the leg side in the first over. At the other end, Bumrah took the new ball and struck right away, removing franchise debutant Rilee Rossouw for a duck and the new opener Sam Curran for 6.

Liam Livingstone, batting at No. 4, then lasted two balls when his attempted pull off a 150kph Coetzee delivery was sliced back to the bowler. A score of 14 for 4 soon became 49 for 5 when Harpreet Singh Bhatia was caught by legspinner Shreyas Gopal, and then became 77 for 6 when Jitesh Sharma was lbw for nine by Madhwal.

Ashutosh Sharma played an innings to remember•BCCI

The near miracle

By the time Ashutosh walked in, Shashank had already kept Kings' score moving with the occasional boundary. Shashank pumped three sixes and two fours to make 41 in 25 balls from No. 6, but it was only when Ashutosh joined him that runs flowed from both ends.

Ashutosh hammered Madhwal for a six over fine leg in the tenth over and then took Romario Shepherd for four and six in the 11th. He clubbed Hardik Pandya for a six in the 12th too, and even after Bumrah had dismissed Shashank in the 13th, he swept the fast bowler for an audacious six in the same over. Ashutosh and Harpreet Brar then took Coetzee for a 13-run 15th over as they made 65 runs in that five-over period.

But it was the 16th over that took Kings ahead in the game for the first time in the chase. Madhwal missed his lengths and Ashutosh punished him with consecutive sixes. Harpreet smacked another six to bring the equation down to 28 off four overs.

The required run-rate of only seven gave Ashutosh and Harpreet the breathing room to see out Bumrah's final over for only three runs, which ended with Kings needing a manageable 25 off 18. But Coetzee's uncanny habit of breaking partnerships came through again, and he had Ashutosh pulling to deep midwicket at the start of the 18th over. Harpreet was then dismissed by Hardik in the 19th over. Rabada, the No. 11, struck a six off Hardik's last ball to make it 13 required off seven balls. A single off the last ball of that over, and a wide off the first ball of the final over, bowled by Akash Madhwal, brought it down to 11 off six.

However, he was run out in pursuit of a second run next ball, and Mumbai could celebrate a great escape.

Suryakumar Yadav was slightly more subdued than usual, but still unfurled some of his trademark shots • BCCI

SKY anchors Mumbai's 192

Before this game, Suryakumar Yadav had made two ducks and two half-centuries in his four innings this season. On Thursday, he walked in at No. 3 after Ishan Kishan fell to Rabada in the third over, and got off the mark with consecutive fours off the same bowler. It wasn't a duck, so he inevitably got to the 50 mark.

Suryakumar then used his wrists to put away Harshal Patel for another boundary in the fifth, and followed it up with a cut over the off side off Sam Curran in the sixth. Along with Rohit Sharma, he helped Mumbai to 54 for 1 in the powerplay.

Together, they would put on 81 in 57 balls, with Rohit contributing only 26 to the stand. Suryakumar dominated spinners Harpreet and Livingstone after the powerplay, but Rohit could not find the same fluency having been starved of strike for most of the stand. He fell in the 12th over for 35 when he tried to hit Curran over the covers but found the point fielder instead.

By the time Rohit was gone, Suryakumar had already reached his fifty in 34 balls. His innings was unusually sluggish by his standards, but the two-paced surface and the change-up deliveries bowled by Harshal and Arshdeep Singh forced false strokes too.

It needed Tilak Varma's take-down of Arshdeep in the 15th over for Suryakumar to also break free in his familiar, trademark fashion, and he did that by bashing Rabada for four, six and six in the 16th after successfully reviewing an lbw decision earlier in the over.

That 18-run Rabada over took Mumbai to 148 for 2 in 16 overs, and with big hitters to come, a score of over 200 seemed to be on. But Curran removed Suryakumar for a 53-ball 78 - only the second time he had faced 50-plus balls in an IPL innings - and Mumbai could not get a lot out of Hardik or Tim David. Harshal bowled a seven-run 20th over, which included three wickets, to keep Mumbai down to under 200.

After the innings finished on 192 for 7, the highest first-innings IPL total in Mullanpur, Suryakumar told the broadcasters he felt the score was "way above par," and his prophecy came true, but not without Mumbai surviving a massive scare.

MATCH 34 Lucknow Super Giants 180 for 2 (Rahul 82, de Kock 54, Pooran 23*, Pathirana 1-29) beat Chennai Super Kings 176 for 6 (Jadeja 57*, Rahane 36, Moeen 30, Dhoni 28*, Krunal 2-16) by eight wickets

The Ekana Stadium crowd in Lucknow was served the perfect buffet on Friday night: spectacular MS Dhoni fireworks that powered Chennai Super Kings to a competitive 176 for 6 and then the home team Lucknow Super Giants chasing it down with a classy 82 off 53 from captain KL Rahul.

LSG's chase was set up by a dominant century opening stand - the first for them this season - between Rahul and Quinton de Kock, which didn't allow any CSK bowler to settle in. They collected boundaries regularly to score 54 in the powerplay, they didn't let CSK fight back in the middle overs (which they have done often this IPL), they didn't let the asking rate touch ten, and by the time de Kock fell for 54 in the 15th over, they needed a comfortable 43 from 30 balls.

Rahul and Gaikwad fined for slow over rate

LSG captain KL Rahul and CSK captain Ruturaj Gaikwad were fined INR 12 lac each for maintaining a slow over rate during the match. It was the first offence of IPL 2024 for each team.

Rahul also fell before the close, to a stunning catch by Ravindra Jadeja at backward point, but that didn't stop LSG from romping home with eight wickets in hand and an over to spare.

Rahul and de Kock set things up

The LSG batters have copped criticism this season for either not scoring quickly at the start, or for throwing their wickets away, or for leaving too much to do for Nicholas Pooran. On Friday, Rahul and de Kock didn't do any of those things, putting up a century stand in just 10.5 overs to set up the chase.

Quinton de Kock scored 54 off 43 balls in a 134-run stand with KL Rahul•AFP/Getty Images

Rahul led the partnership with strokes dripping with class. He middled his pulls against the short balls, drove confidently down the ground, played the pick-up shots like he usually does, and even used the pace of Matheesha Pathirana to upper cut him for six.

Rahul often plays such strokes in T20s but it was the frequency with which he was hitting them on the night that was different. After collecting 12 off Deepak Chahar's second over - the third of the innings - that included a six over midwicket, he drilled Mustafizur Rahman back in the next over. And when de Kock and Rahul combined for 6, 4 and 6 across the fifth

and sixth overs to take them to 54 in the powerplay, it was fairly evident that LSG were in pole position to get home comfortably.

LSG were helped further when de Kock miscued Jadeja in the ninth over but Pathirana shelled the chance at short third. De Kock made CSK pay in Jadeja's next over with a boundary on the leg side before Rahul inflicted more pain with back-to-back fours, which took him past fifty.

With 74 to get from 54, the two slowed down briefly before de Kock also got to his fifty. He fell for 54, caught by Dhoni trying to ramp a Mustafizur Rahman slower ball.

But Pooran came out with the aim of hitting boundaries and finished the game off with his third four that sealed the chase with six balls to spare.

Jadeja walks out at No. 4

CSK are known to pull rabbits out of the hat from time to time, and the latest was to send out Jadeja at No. 4.

Moeen Ali and Ravindra Jadeja put on a vital 51 off 33 for CSK•BCCI

Soon after they were put in, they had lost Rachin Ravindra for a golden duck and, three overs later, Ruturaj Gaikwad edged a Yash Thakur outswinger behind.

Losing two wickets in the powerplay, perhaps, made CSK save Shivam Dube for later and send out Jadeja, and he played a key hand in CSK getting to a competitive score.

Ajinkya Rahane, meanwhile, made CSK tick along nicely with a regular flow of boundaries, his crisp timing in full display. The pick of those was a six over midwicket off Matt Henry and an exquisite drive off Thakur for four.

CSK slip in the middle overs

Rahul brought on spin from both ends as soon as the field spread out and it worked when Krunal Pandya hit Rahane's leg stump to send him back for 36 off 24.

Dube walked out at No. 5, but it was Jadeja who collected boundaries in consecutive overs by hitting with the spin of Krunal and Ravi Bishnoi.

Jadeja, however, did not get the company of CSK's big hitters for long. Dube first miscued a Marcus Stoinis short ball, bowled at 125.4kph, to be taken by Rahul, and Sameer Rizvi, soon after, danced down the pitch to Krunal but couldn't get close to the ball and was stumped. CSK were suddenly 93 for 5 after 13 overs.

The LSG bowlers stifled Moeen Ali and Jadeja - they went 34 balls without a boundary. Jadeja broke the drought in the 16th over, and reached his fifty in the 17th with a six off Mohsin Khan that Deepak Hooda should have taken but only managed to tip over.

MATCH 35

Sunrisers Hyderabad 266 for 7 (Head 89, Shahbaz 59*, Abhishek 46, Kuldeep 4-55) beat Delhi Capitals 199 (Fraser-McGurk 65, Pant 44, Natarajan 4-19, Reddy 2-17, Markande 2-26) by 67 runs

It would have been the highest total in the history of the IPL if it had happened last season, but on Saturday night in Delhi, 266 for 7 almost felt anticlimactic. That's how far Sunrisers Hyderabad have moved the window of batting possibilities this season. It was the fourth-highest total in IPL history, but it was only the third-highest total achieved by Sunrisers in IPL 2024.

At one point it had felt like they could have finished with so much more, with 300 looking like a frighteningly realistic prospect. Sunrisers had gone where no team in any competition had ever gone before in a T20 powerplay, with Travis Head and Abhishek Sharma raising a hair-raising six-over score of 125 for no loss. Kuldeep Yadav and Axar Patel, fortified by the relaxation of field restrictions, brought Sunrisers' innings back to the earthly realm thereafter, but that awe-inspiring beginning would remain the defining passage of the match.

Related

When Head and Abhishek caused carnage at Kotla

125 in 6 overs: Head and Sunrisers shatter T20 powerplay records

When Head stopped worrying and turned a corner

Delhi Capitals began their reply by racing to the joint second-highest powerplay score of IPL 2024, but it was only 88 for 2. Jake Fraser-McGurk bettered Head's 16-ball effort by one ball to bring up the season's quickest half-century, but his dismissal in the seventh over effectively ended the contest. Capitals had suggested they might run Sunrisers close when they began their chase, but they slumped badly through its back half, against some excellent defensive bowling led by T Natarajan. In the end they were bowled out for a symbolic 199, with Rishabh Pant struggling for fluency before he was last man out for 44 off 35 balls.

A powerplay from another planet

The first over of the match went for 19, and ended up being the lowest-scoring over of Sunrisers' powerplay.

Head was batting on 84 off 26 balls at the six-over mark, and his opening partner was scoring significantly quicker than him: Abhishek was batting on 40 off 10 at that point.

ESPNcricinfo Ltd

The hitting was a relentless blur, and no line, length or style of bowling seemed to have any power to stop it. So true was the pitch at the Arun Jaitley Stadium, which was hosting its

first game of the season, and so single-minded the two openers in their desire to hit every possible ball to the boundary. Of the 36 balls bowled in the powerplay - Capitals could have given themselves an ironic pat on the back for bowling no wides or no-balls in that time - 13 went for four and 11 for six.

Kuldeep, Axar intervene

Abhishek hit the first non-powerplay ball of the match for six too, stepping out to Kuldeep and going through his shot despite not reaching the pitch of the ball. This had happened in the fifth over too, off the same bowler, and it seemed to reiterate to Capitals' bowlers that they were on a hiding to nothing.

But sometimes a wicket can come out of nowhere, especially if the batters are going after everything, and this is what happened off the next ball, as a diving Axar intercepted an uppish drive at cover.

Aiden Markram came in at No. 3 ahead of Heinrich Klaasen - who is more noted as a spin-hitter - and fell in the same over, slapping a not particularly good ball from Kuldeep - shortish and wide - straight to cover. But sometimes, even an ordinary ball from a wristspinner can behave oddly, sticking in the pitch slightly longer, or bouncing a little more than expected.

Kuldeep's value came to the fore again in his next over - after Klaasen hit him for a pair of sixes - when Head failed to get hold of a ball that wasn't quite short enough to pull. He had put that length away easily in the powerplay, but there was a man back at long-on now and he was out for 89 off 32.

Klaasen is a master at pulling not-quite-pullable lengths against the spinners, but on the day he was done in by an Axar skidder that beat his inside edge to bowl him. Sunrisers were a surreal 154 for 4 in 9.1 overs.

Nitish Kumar Reddy, Shahbaz apply the finish

Given how many runs they already had on the board, and given the time that remained in their innings, Sunrisers' fifth-wicket pair could afford to bat in a relatively conservative way and make sure that Abdul Samad, a specialist death-overs hitter, wouldn't be called upon too early. Nitish Kumar Reddy and Shahbaz Ahmed did this, putting on 67 off 47 balls.

1:48

Moody: No risks in Sunrisers' game

Shahbaz broke free at the finish, hitting Khaleel Ahmed for two sixes in the 19th over and taking two fours and a six off Mukesh Kumar in the 20th to finish unbeaten on 59 off 29 balls. It was the Bengal allrounder's first fifty in the IPL.

A chase of two halves starring Fraser-McGurk and Pant

Prithvi Shaw hit Washington Sundar for 4, 4, 4, 4 off the first four balls of the chase in a battle of Impact Players. Then Washington had his revenge, looping up a delivery with plenty of overspin - the kind of ball that's rarely seen in T20 cricket, but one delivered now with the hope of stemming the run-flow giving way to the desperation of somehow prising out a wicket - and getting him to miscue a lofted hit.

That first over set the tone for Capitals' powerplay. They also lost David Warner early, but they kept going hard, because they had to, and because Fraser-McGurk knows no other way. His smooth, unfettered golfer's swing was in perfect rhythm on the day, and Washington - handed the unforgiving task of bowling two powerplay overs - was at the receiving end of 4, 4, 6, 4, 6, 6 in the third over. Abishek Porel then carved Pat Cummins through and over the off side with abandon in a 20-run fifth over, and Capitals were somehow keeping themselves in the game.

Fraser-McGurk finally mis-hit one in the seventh over, off Mayank Markande, but despite that wicket Capitals' win probability kept rising, with Porel crunching three fours and a six in the next over off Shahbaz. At that point, ESPNcricinfo's forecaster gave them a 21.23% chance of victory, astonishing given the target they were chasing.

But that was more or less that, as their run-scoring ground to a halt after Markande - who had a similar effect to Kuldeep, conceding runs but inducing just enough false shots with his wristspin - had Porel stumped in the ninth over.

Thanks in part to skillful bowling from Natarajan, Cummins and Reddy - they varied their pace nicely while bowling into the pitch, and used the wide line outside off stump effectively to Pant in particular - and in part to the struggle for fluency that Tristan Stubbs and Pant endured on the day, Capitals went nowhere. From the start of the ninth over to the end of their innings, they scored just 68 runs in 67 balls. The match was long over as a contest when Natarajan took out three wickets in the 19th over to finish with figures of 4 for 19.

MATCH 36

Kolkata Knight Riders 222 for 6 (Shreyas 50, Salt 48, Green 2-35) beat Royal Challengers Bengaluru 221 (Jacks 55, Patidar 52, Russell 3-25) by one run

Mitchell Starc had 20 runs to defend and he nearly didn't. In the course of six balls, he exemplified just how difficult it is to be a bowler in T20 cricket, and how he will always fly in the face of it. Having been hit for three sixes in the final over which reduced the equation down to 3 off 2, he went to his bread and butter. He went pace on. He went yorker. And he produced a wicket. Karn Sharma, who had brought this game back from the dead, was gone. As soon as the catch was taken - Starc himself diving low to his right in his followthrough - RCB knew there were no more miracles.

Ramandeep Singh contrived to give them one. His throw from deep point was poor. It didn't come in quick enough or straight enough. It left the wicketkeeper with a lot to do. Phil Salt, though, was fine with it. He was alert enough to step forward and shrink the distance the

ball had to travel and then agile enough to fling his whole body at the stumps and break it before the No. 11 Lockie Ferguson could make his ground and trigger a Super Over. KKR had won, by one run, and maybe five inches.

Related

RCB and KKR serve up a thriller with a different kind of tension

Virat Kohli fined 50% of match fee for code of conduct breach

Why Kohli's dismissal against KKR was not given a no-ball

Du Plessis: 'Your decision making is clearer when you are winning'

Plans made, plans fall apart

RCB did beautifully to keep Sunil Narine quiet. While most teams do know not to give him any room, they went a step further, dropped all pretense and tried to bowl nothing but leg-stump yorkers. KKR's biggest hitter this season needed eight balls to get off the mark. Salt came to his rescue though hitting 10 of the first 13 balls to the boundary and flirting with the fastest fifty of IPL 2024. He could have had it too but in going for another six - to a ball that was very hittable - he got caught at deep midwicket. Still, 48 off 14 with seven fours and three sixes is nothing to scoff at.

The middle overs slowdown

Karn bowled the first boundary-less over in the 10th. Cameron Green was keeping Rinku Singh quiet, their head-to-head for the first six balls yielding three dots and two singles. The Australian had used his height to great effect earlier, leaping up to catch a ball that was 8.1m off the ground and travelling fast, to dismiss Angkrish Raghuvanshi. Now, he was digging off-pace deliveries into the pitch and getting them to soar past Rinku's bat swing. Even with Shreyas Iyer scoring his first IPL fifty since May 2022, RCB had the better of the middle overs (economy rate 8, from 12.5 in the powerplay). Ferguson, who conceded a boundary with every ball of his first over, gave up only one more after that in the next three. He also took a wicket, a skillful use of the knuckle ball which got big on Rinku and took away his power.

Faf du Plessis fined for slow over rate

RCB captain Faf du Plessis was fined for his side maintaining a slow over rate against KKR. As it was his first such offence, he was penalised with a minimum over-rate fine of INR 12 lakh.

Small margins

Andre Russell had walked in during the 14th over. At the time of the 18th, he was still 11 off 13 with only one hit to the fence, and still, he was toying with the bowlers.

Yash Dayal was desperate to keep the ball out of his hitting arc, which forced him to spray one too wide outside off and another too wide outside leg, which also beat the keeper and went for four. To make matters worse, he had overstepped.

Dayal was only trying to do the right thing but it is so hard in this format. A nine-ball 17th over ended with Shreyas pinging the long-on boundary twice and yielding 22 runs. RCB trusted him to close the innings out but that over went for 16. Once again, he did the right things. Went wide yorker, but missed the mark and got hit. Took pace off, but Muscle Russell found a way. Recovered to string two yorkers and a bouncer that cost only three runs but the last ball was cleverly ramped for four by Ramandeep. KKR 222 for 6.

MATCH 37

Gujarat Titans 146 for 7 (Tewatia 36*, Gill 35, Harshal 3-15) beat Punjab Kings 142 (Prabhsimran 35, Brar 29, Sai Kishore 4-33) by three wickets

The first 11 overs of Gujarat Titans' spin won them the match, essentially. Before Rashid Khan came on to bowl the fifth over, Punjab Kings were going nicely, at 42 for no loss.

Then Rashid bowls a four-run over, and the Titans slow-bowling show begins in Mullanpur. He and compatriot Noor Ahmad lock up the early part of the middle overs, taking three wickets between them. That's before left-arm spinner Sai Kishore rocks up and wrecks Kings' middle over, taking 4 for 33.

Sam Curran fined for breaching code of conduct

Punjab Kings stand-in captain Sam Curran was fined 50% of his match fees for breaching the IPL Code of Conduct against Gujarat Titans. He committed a Level 1 offence under Article 2.8 of the IPL's Code of Conduct, and accepted the Match Referee's sanction after admitting to the offence.

Kings manage no more than 142, but make a fist of the defence, with Harshal Patel taking three wickets for 15, and Liam Livingstone taking two wickets with his offbreaks. In the end, they didn't have a great total to defend, nor the slow-bowling quality that Titans had. The visiting team eased home with five balls to spare.

Titans' spinners wreck Punjab Kings

Rashid made himself almost impossible to hit. He bowled a three-run fifth over when Kings had been going at 10.50, previously. Noor, the left-arm wristspinner, then had Rilee Russouw lbw in the seventh over to kick off the period of massive spin dominance, in which six more would fall to the slow bowlers.

Rashid and Noor bowled in tandem in the five overs after the powerplay and gave away only 24 runs, taking two wickets. Then came Sai Kishore, and by this stage Kings were desperate for boundaries. They kept trying to hit out against him, but he varied his pace and flight beautifully, and kept deceiving them.

His first dismissal - Jitesh Sharma - came via hitting the stumps. His second, was the prized wicket of Ashutosh Sharma, who holed out to the sweeper cover. He later had Shashank Singh caught and bowled, and Harpreet Brar caught at the straight boundary at the death.

All up, the spinners took 7 for 68 from their 12 overs.

1:40

Is Gill's captaincy affecting his batting form?

Tewatia finishes again

It's not like Titans were in serious trouble, but they needed someone to come in and play the match-winning batting innings nonetheless. And Rahul Tewatia was the guy once more. At one stage, Titans needed 38 runs off the last four overs, with five wickets in hand. A couple of wickets for Kings right then would have changed the match completely.

But Tewatia hit two fours off Brar's over to bring the required rate back in hand, and restore Titans' grip on the match. Then he hit three fours - two clubbed down the ground, and one tickled through fine leg - off Kagiso Rabada's 18th over, in which Shahrukh Khan also hit a six. They reaped 20 runs there, and essentially made the game safe, bringing the requirement to five off 12 balls.

Kings shine in spurts

Some Kings players shone, but too briefly to make a defining impact on the game. The first of these was Prabhsimran Singh, who smoked three sixes and three fours in the 35 off 21 balls that raised the Kings innings off the ground. He was out before the powerplay ended though.

When they were defending their poor score, Livingstone took 2 for 19 from his four overs, and Harshal Patel and Sam Curran backed him up - Harshal taking three wickets and Curran one. But Kings had lost too much ground already with the bat.

MATCH 38

Rajasthan Royals 183 for 1 (Jaiswal 104*) beat Mumbai Indians 179 for 9 (Tilak 65, Sandeep 5-18) by nine wickets

Sandeep Sharma announced his return from injury with magnificent figures of 5 for 18, the best by any bowler in this season's IPL, before Yashasvi Jaiswal blazed back to form with a sparkling 59-ball century, as Rajasthan Royals signed off from the Jaipur leg of their campaign with a seventh statement win in eight matches to cement their table-topping status.

Set a middling 180 for victory after a Mumbai Indians' innings that owed everything to a 99-run fifth-wicket stand between Tilak Varma and Nehal Wadhwa, Royals' chase was

signalled and sealed by Jaiswal, who had 31 from 18 balls prior to a 30-minute rain delay, before converting his first fifty of a difficult season into a towering 104 not out from 60 balls.

Jaiswal added 74 in eight overs with the in-form Jos Buttler, who made 35 from 25, and a further 109 in 65 with Sanju Samson, whose terrible reprieve on 19 by Tim David at midwicket was the moment all hope evaporated for Mumbai. By then, Jaiswal had also had a major let-off, on 50, when Wadhera at deep cover dropped a leading-edged swipe off Piyush Chawla over the ropes for six.

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Jaiswal bats himself back to form, for Royals and for India

Sandeep Sharma, the metamorphosis man

Chahal becomes first bowler to take 200 wickets in IPL

Yuzvendra Chahal's milestones on the way to 200 IPL wickets

Mumbai's performance was summed up by the deployment of their two outstanding bowlers of the campaign. After being riled by a first-ball slap for six, Gerald Coetzee bowled like the wind in his solitary powerplay over, visibly troubling Jaiswal with his 150kph-plus pace, in particular with a top-edged pull that flew over the keeper for four. Yet he was not given another over until Jaiswal was into the 80s, when he again got a well-set batter flinching, but by this stage the match was already lost.

And though Jasprit Bumrah bowled with his peerless verve up front, including a two-run first over to limit Buttler's early intentions, he too was held back too late into the chase - and when he did return, his comeback over was not a success. A first-ball no-ball was followed by a second-ball wide on height, where upon Jaiswal swung the rolled-over free hit for six, en route to a 16-run over, Bumrah's most expensive of a stellar season.

Boult, Sandeep boss the powerplay

At the Wankhede three weeks ago, Trent Boult silenced Mumbai's home support with the prized scalp of Rohit Sharma, who grazed his first ball of the match - and the fifth of the innings - through to Sanju Samson behind the stumps. It was a case of rinse-and-repeat in the rematch: Rohit c Samson b Boult, again from the fifth ball, albeit this time with 6 to his name. One filleted four through deep third, then a wild swing through the full length, for Samson to rush round from behind the stumps and gather with a tumble. Remarkably, it was the 26th time that Boult had struck in the first over of his IPL career.

Mumbai had batted first after winning the toss, on the proviso that there's not a lot of dew on offer when chasing in Jaipur. There was, however, sufficient movement off another dry surface to reward Royals' attacking full lengths, and after one ball of the fourth over, Sandeep had launched a memorable performance in style, to reduce his opponents to a ropey 20 for 3.

The first of his victims was Ishan Kishan, caught behind for a third-ball duck as he went fishing to Sandeep's wide line, pushed tantalisingly up into his arc. Then, after a flurry of two fours in three balls that had hinted at riches to come, Suryakumar Yadav swung without timing across the scrambled seam, and was already wincing as the ball plopped into Rovman Powell's hands at midwicket.

Mohammad Nabi ended the powerplay with an 18-run flurry against Avesh Khan's first over, but at 45 for 3, the damage at the top was already telling.

Yuzvendra Chahal is the first bowler to take 200 wickets in IPL•BCCI

200 up for Yuzvendra Chahal

Only two bowlers in the history of T20 cricket had previously taken 200 wickets in a single competition - Danny Briggs and Samit Patel, both in the T20 Blast. With his extraction of Nabi in his first over of the night, Yuzvendra Chahal became the third entry on that list, and against Mumbai too - the team for whom he had made a one-off, wicketless debut in his maiden IPL season in 2013.

The moment arose with another cunning piece of bowling, as Nabi, on 23, closed the face on the front foot to lob a leading edge back to the bowler, off his third delivery. Chahal sunk to his knees as his team-mates engulfed him, fully aware of the feat of excellence and endurance that he'd just recorded. And, at 52 for 4, Mumbai were on their knees too.

Tilak, Wadhera find some fight

Measured at first - particularly while R Ashwin was rattling through four wicketless overs for 31 - and then with mounting assurance, Mumbai's revival was entirely down to two of the younger men in their ranks. Tilak led the line with a combative 65 from 45, bringing up his fifty with a six that also made him, at the age of 21 years and 166 days, the third-youngest player to 1000 IPL runs.

However, it was the less heralded Wadhera, playing his first match of the season, who provided the impetus that met the needs of this extraordinarily high-scoring edition. His 49 from 24 balls included three fours and four sixes - two of them in consecutive balls from Chahal, who moments earlier thought he had managed to trap Tilak lbw for 55 on the reverse-sweep.

DRS, however, showed the ball to be missing off, and the pair celebrated the reprieve with the verve of a century, which spoke volumes for the importance of their stand. But, as it turns out, their alliance would end on 99 from 54 balls when Boult was recalled to the attack for his final over. His first delivery was a slower-ball bouncer, which Wadhera could only lob to backward point.

MATCH 39

Lucknow Super Giants 213 for 4 (Stoinis 124*) beat Chennai Super Kings 210 for 4 (Gaikwad 108*, Dube 66) by six wickets

"Fortress Chepauk," proclaimed a huge banner in CSK colours in the stands. By the end of the contest, though, Lucknow Super Giants had breached it to hand Chennai Super Kings their first defeat at home this season. It was their second loss against LSG in five days.

The star of the night was Marcus Stoinis, whose unbeaten 124 off 63 balls helped LSG pull off the highest successful chase at Chepauk in T20 cricket. He was batting at No. 3 for the first time this season and achieved the target of 211 with three balls and six wickets to spare.

Stoinis' century came off 56 balls, just like Ruturaj Gaikwad's did earlier in the night after the CSK captain lost his seventh toss in eight games. Gaikwad's unbeaten 108 off 60 balls and Shivam Dube's 66 off 27 powered the Super Kings to 210 for 4.

CSK had looked in control for the majority of the defence. LSG needed 74 from the last five overs but Stoinis, with help from Nicholas Pooran and Deepak Hooda, silenced the Chennai crowd. The result took LSG to fourth place with ten points from eight games; CSK are fifth with eight points after eight games.

Gaikwad powers CSK

After LSG opted to bowl, Matt Henry struck in the first over. He bowled four balls on a good length, one slightly short of it, and then pitched the last one full. Ajinkya Rahane edged the drive, and with first slip wider than usual, KL Rahul dived full length to his right and completed a stunning, one-handed catch.

Rahul's athleticism, though, was followed by some shoddy fielding from LSG. In the second over, Yash Thakur dropped Daryl Mitchell off Mohsin Khan at short third. A little later, at the same position, Henry could not get his hand to a tougher chance from Gaikwad off Ravi Bishnoi.

Mitchell could not take advantage of the reprieve and fell for 11 off 10 but Gaikwad did not miss out. He was on 20 when he was dropped and hit two fours off Henry in the next over. CSK ended the powerplay on 49 for 2, with Gaikwad scoring 37 off 19 balls. While the other CSK batters struggled for timing, he looked sublime and brought up his fifty off 28 balls, with seven fours.

Gaikwad, Dube take CSK past 200

Ravindra Jadeja, sent in at No. 4, got out in the 12th over for 16 off 19 balls. By that time, Gaikwad had scored 71 off 39; the other CSK batters 29 off 32.

Gaikwad found an ideal partner in Dube, who also hit the first six of the innings in the 13th over. After that, there was no respite for the LSG bowlers. Given Dube's reputation of being

a spin-hitter, Rahul did not risk bringing on either Bishnoi or Krunal Pandya - both turn the ball in to Dube - for the rest of the innings.

Dube showed he had improved his game against pace as well. He hit Yash for three successive sixes in the 16th over and Mohsin for two sixes and a four in the 19th.

Gaikwad, too, was severe on Yash, hitting him for 6, 4, 4 off successive balls - a sequence during which he also brought up his hundred.

Marcus Stoinis is mobbed by his team-mates after his match-winning century•Getty Images

LSG's stuttering start

Deepak Chahar got the new ball to swing in both directions and had Quinton de Kock chopping one onto his stumps in the opening over. Rahul and Stoinis kept LSG on track with a flurry of boundaries before CSK struck again.

Having hit a boundary earlier in the over, Rahul tried to go aerial against Mustafizur Rahman but failed to clear Gaikwad at extra cover. LSG finished the powerplay on 45 for 2.

Stoinis keeps LSG in contest

Devdutt Padikkal came in as Impact Player but struggled with timing. Meanwhile, Stoinis singlehandedly kept LSG in the contest by hitting boundaries at regular intervals. He brought up his fifty off 26 balls, with six fours and two sixes.

Still, it was an uphill task. LSG needed 128 from the last ten overs, of which Matheesha Pathirana was to bowl four and Mustafizur three. Pathirana ended Padikkal's struggle on 13 off 19 balls with a 151.4kph length ball that uprooted leg stump.

The dew effect

Dew in the second half of the game was the only reason LSG had opted to chase. They have otherwise preferred to set the target this season. The first obvious sign of dew having an impact came in the 13th over, when Tushar Deshpande bowled a beamer. Stoinis hit it for four. And when Mustafizur dug a cutter into the pitch, the ball came onto the bat nicely, and Stoinis launched it to the straight boundary off the back foot.

When Shardul Thakur got the 16th over, Stoinis and Pooran knew they had to cash in, with the remaining four shared by Mustafizur and Pathirana. Pooran hit the first three balls for 6, 4, 6 and LSG eventually took 20 runs off Shardul.

Stoinis silences Chepauk

Pooran holed out to long-off against Pathirana when LSG needed 53 from 22 balls. Once again, it was all up to Stoinis. He hit Pathirana for a four before pulling Mustafizur for a six in the 18th over. Two balls later, he brought up his hundred.

With 32 required from two overs, Stoinis and Hooda picked up three boundaries in the first four balls from Pathirana. It left them needing 17 from six balls.

Stoinis launched the first delivery from Mustafizur over long-on before drilling the next straight back for four. Luck, too, favoured him as the next one raced past short third for another boundary. It turned out, Mustafizur had overstepped as well, which reduced the equation to two needed from four balls. Stoinis then moved across and pulled a short-of-length ball over backward square leg to complete the job.

At the toss, Rahul had said that it was not easy to silence Chepauk. By the end of the day, LSG had done that too.

MATCH

Sandeep Sharma removed Ishan Kishan and Suryakumar Yadav in his first two overs•BCCI

Sandeep applies the gloss finish

At 170 for 5 in the 18th over, Mumbai still had designs on a 200-run total, but Royals' death bowlers had other ideas. Avesh was on the mark to pin Hardik Pandya lbw for 10 as he walked across his stumps, and after leaking just six runs, even with Tim David looking to cut loose, Sandeep snapped the innings shut.

Tilak's excellent knock ended with a tumbling take from Powell at long-on, following which Coetzee's first-ball launch picked out Shimron Hetmyer down the ground. David finally got the strike back with three balls remaining but he too picked out a boundary rider to make it three wickets in the over, and 5 for 18 all told for Sandeep.

Not only were they the best figures by an Indian bowler for Royals, Sandeep's figures marked a triumphant return after an injury-plagued season - he had previously managed one wicket in two outings before a side strain had kept him sidelined for most of a month.

Jaiswal finds his range at the right time

After two double-centuries and more than 700 runs in a startling Test campaign against England, Jaiswal's IPL had been something of a comedown - just 121 runs and a top score of 39 in seven previous knocks. But there's never been any doubting his precocity, and when he did finally reach his first fifty of this campaign, the acclaim on the Royals bench was notable. They are already top of the table at the halfway mark, after all ... if he is hitting his straps for the run-in, so much the better for their prospects of a second title.

By the end, it was as if he'd never been away. His innings was studded with eight fours and seven sixes, including the winning carve through point off Tilak with eight balls left unused. On his watch, Royals are four points clear at the top, and getting better with every outing.

Mohammed Siraj is distraught even as KKR celebrate their dramatic one-run win•BCCI

Jacks and Patidar step up

Angry Virat Kohli made an appearance after a long time, disputing the technology that gave him out off a full toss that he was certain was over waist high. Faf du Plessis couldn't stick around for long enough. RCB were in familiar dire straits once again when two of their least heralded players decided to shoot their shot.

Will Jacks took down Starc in the final over of the powerplay, hitting him for three sixes and a four. The whole over was symptomatic of the way KKR had bowled to him, pace on and in the slot. A tall batter with a strong front foot game loves it there. So did the RCB fans who were sat down the ground or at midwicket.

At the other end, Rajat Patidar found his rhythm. He has looked short of confidence ever since he was dropped by India during the Tests against England. A batter who relies on feel more than technique was struggling to get it back, until it all came back, and he was sitting pretty with a 21-ball fifty. He scored 16 off 8 off Narine, with two sixes, and 30 off 9 against Suyash Sharma, with three sixes and two fours.

Russell goes slow, Starc goes fast

RCB were 77% favourites at this point, needing 86 off 54 balls. Then on came Russell for his first over of the night and knocked over both of RCB's half-centurions. For a guy who wants to look like a UFC fighter, he keeps sucker-punching people. Running in nice and hard. Properly powering through his action. That tree-trunk like shoulder whipping the ball down the pitch. But then the fingers do their magic, and all of a sudden, a batter prepping for 140kph is caught off guard with 115kph.

Starc has not learned that lesson yet. He has found all his success - even here in the IPL when he was wearing the opposition's colours - by trusting his pace and his accuracy. According to ESPNcricinfo ball-by-ball data, he has attempted a slower ball only 11 times this season. It is part of why he has given up 44 boundaries, the most by any bowler in IPL 2024. The opposition sets up for his thunderbolts, which in India, don't always kiss the pitch and fly through. They sometimes sit up to be smacked.

However, people under pressure trust what has worked for them in the past and the Starc yorker is still money. He went for it. It came out as a low full toss. Karn, who had already carved three sixes off near yorkers, set up to smash it down the ground. But this time he couldn't get enough power on it. He could only bunt it and Starc was agile enough to dive to his right and come up with a blinder. That was the decisive play in a game full of them. Pace on for the win. Who knew.

MS Dhoni slammed 28 off nine at the death•BCCI

The Moeen and Dhoni show

Moeen set things up for Dhoni with three sixes in a row off Bishnoi in the 18th over, and Dhoni came out to a rapturous reception when Moeen holed out attempting a fourth six off the same bowler.

After a single off his first ball, Dhoni was facing two inexperienced bowlers in Mohsin and Thakur. He first bashed Mohsin to the extra-cover boundary for a one-bounce four, and followed it with the most un-Dhonesque six you'll see: walking across because Mohsin had been bowling them wide outside off and lapping him over the keeper's head. It was a 14-run over that included three wides.

The fans - almost entirely yellow - were having the time of their lives. And when Dhoni got the strike in the last over, he clobbered a six over cow corner. Thakur attempted wide yorkers that resulted in two more fours off the last three balls and Dhoni finished on 28 off just nine balls that helped CSK smash 63 in last four overs. It was fun but not nearly enough.

MATCH 39

Delhi Capitals 224 for 4 (Pant 88*, Axar 66, Warrier 3-15) beat Gujarat Titans 220 for 8 (Sai Sudharsan 65, Miller 55, Saha 39, Salam 3-44, Kuldeep 2-29) by four runs

In a memorable IPL 2024 finish, Rashid Khan nearly took Gujarat Titans (GT) home in a chase of 225 against Delhi Capitals (DC). But Mukesh Kumar held his nerve to defend 19 off the last over as DC completed a thrilling four-run victory.

For Rashid to have a shot at chasing down the tall target, GT had B Sai Sudharsan (65 in 39 balls) and David Miller (55 in 23) to thank. They kept GT within touching distance of the climbing asking rate, and for a brief moment in the end, it felt like they had timed their chase perfectly. However, it wasn't to be, and GT went down to DC for the second time in seven days.

Salam reprimanded for breaching IPL CoC

Rasikh Salam committed a Level 1 offence under Article 2.5 of the IPL's Code of Conduct. The article includes any language, action or gesture used by a Player and directed towards a batter upon his/her dismissal which has the potential to provoke an aggressive reaction from the dismissed batter. The press release from IPL did not specify the incident for which Salam was reprimanded. He admitted to the offence and accepted the match referee's sanction.

DC themselves had to climb out of a hole to post 224 for 4 after being asked to bat first. Sandeep Warrier's 3 for 15 in the powerplay had left them struggling at 44 for 3, but Rishabh Pant's masterful 43-ball 88 and Axar Patel's 66 in 43 from No. 3 resurrected their innings. Axar then took three catches and a wicket, and also ably supported Kuldeep Yadav (2 for 29) with the ball to ensure DC did just about enough on the night.

Sudharsan and Miller make it a contest

Shubman Gill fell early to Anrich Nortje, for the fourth time in seven innings, but that did not slow GT down. Wriddhiman Saha struck 30 in his first 12 balls by clearing the infield expertly, and Sudharsan made full use of an early reprieve off Rasikh Salam's bowling to

race off the blocks. They did not let Nortje or Khaleel Ahmed settle in and collected 67 in the powerplay.

But the spinners then bogged Saha down, and Kuldeep dismissed him for 35 in 29 balls. Sudharsan, though, dominated the middle overs, hitting both seamers and spinners through the off side with cuts in front of and behind square. He also came down the pitch on occasion before falling to Salam in an attempt to clear long-off.

2:31

Review: Did Titans get their tactics wrong?

With Azmatullah Omarzai, Shahrukh Khan and Rahul Tewatia all falling for single-digit scores around Sudharsan's dismissal, GT appeared to have lost steam, needing 73 in 24 balls. However, Miller hit Nortje for three sixes and a four in a 24-run 17th over to give them hope, completing his own half-century off 21 balls along the way.

The see-sawing continued. Mukesh dismissed Miller in the 18th over and, at the time, it seemed like DC had done enough. But Salam leaked 18 runs in the 19th over to make it a shootout between Rashid and Mukesh in the last over.

Mukesh conceded two fours off the first two balls and a six off the penultimate delivery but held his nerve to get the last ball to land so full that Rashid could not find the elevation he needed.

Titans' spinners neutralised

After Warrier's three-wicket burst had given GT the early advantage, they would have expected Rashid, Noor Ahmad and R Sai Kishore to strangle DC through the middle overs. But Axar and Pant kept all three at bay.

Against Rashid, they only attacked the loose balls, half-trackers or wide deliveries, and eked out 37 runs off his four wicketless overs. Against Noor, they attacked to leave him with an economy of 12 in three overs.

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It's too many runs, somebody make it stop

An extra over for one bowler - will it help the bowlers?

Ball-by-ball - A tale of two manic finishes

Such was Pant and Axar's domination in their 113-run stand that Gill did not go to Sai Kishore - their Player of the Match from the last outing - till the 19th over, fearing the

match-up of two left-hand batters against a left-arm spinner. When Sai Kishore did bowl in the penultimate over of the innings, against right-hand batter Tristan Stubbs following the dismissal of Axar, he was hammered for six, four, six and four to concede 22 runs.

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0:56

Should Williamson be Titans' non-playing captain?

Axar's many contributions

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Part-timer Shahrukh also faced the same fate before Axar reached his fifty with a boundary off Rashid in the 15th over. He was the dominant contributor in the 68-ball 113-run stand with Pant, and it was only in his pursuit of a third six in a row against Noor in the 17th over that he fell on the boundary line. The 66 was his highest IPL score.

Axar was then a livewire in the field, first back-pedalling at mid-off in the second over to hold on to a catch to dismiss Gill. He was in action again when Saha tried to cut Kuldeep over cover, jumping high and sticking his hands out to pluck the catch. Then, after dropping Sudharsan early in the powerplay, Axar got a chance at redemption when he was at long-off late to take a tricky one.

With the ball, Axar conceded only two fours and a six in his three overs. Neither Saha nor Miller, both in great touch otherwise, failed to put him away, and it was only Sudharsan's three boundary shots that made him concede 28 in three overs. Axar also dismissed Omarzai in the 11th over, but it was not enough to claim the Player-of-the-Match award, with that one going to his captain instead.

MATCH 40

Delhi Capitals 224 for 4 (Pant 88*, Axar 66, Warrier 3-15) beat Gujarat Titans 220 for 8 (Sai Sudharsan 65, Miller 55, Saha 39, Salam 3-44, Kuldeep 2-29) by four runs

In a memorable IPL 2024 finish, Rashid Khan nearly took Gujarat Titans (GT) home in a chase of 225 against Delhi Capitals (DC). But Mukesh Kumar held his nerve to defend 19 off the last over as DC completed a thrilling four-run victory.

For Rashid to have a shot at chasing down the tall target, GT had B Sai Sudharsan (65 in 39 balls) and David Miller (55 in 23) to thank. They kept GT within touching distance of the climbing asking rate, and for a brief moment in the end, it felt like they had timed their chase perfectly. However, it wasn't to be, and GT went down to DC for the second time in seven days.

Salam reprimanded for breaching IPL CoC

Rasikh Salam committed a Level 1 offence under Article 2.5 of the IPL's Code of Conduct. The article includes any language, action or gesture used by a Player and directed towards a batter upon his/her dismissal which has the potential to provoke an aggressive reaction from the dismissed batter. The press release from IPL did not specify the incident for which Salam was reprimanded. He admitted to the offence and accepted the match referee's sanction.

DC themselves had to climb out of a hole to post 224 for 4 after being asked to bat first. Sandeep Warrier's 3 for 15 in the powerplay had left them struggling at 44 for 3, but Rishabh Pant's masterful 43-ball 88 and Axar Patel's 66 in 43 from No. 3 resurrected their innings. Axar then took three catches and a wicket, and also ably supported Kuldeep Yadav (2 for 29) with the ball to ensure DC did just about enough on the night.

Sudharsan and Miller make it a contest

Shubman Gill fell early to Anrich Nortje, for the fourth time in seven innings, but that did not slow GT down. Wriddhiman Saha struck 30 in his first 12 balls by clearing the infield expertly, and Sudharsan made full use of an early reprieve off Rasikh Salam's bowling to race off the blocks. They did not let Nortje or Khaleel Ahmed settle in and collected 67 in the powerplay.

But the spinners then bogged Saha down, and Kuldeep dismissed him for 35 in 29 balls. Sudharsan, though, dominated the middle overs, hitting both seamers and spinners through the off side with cuts in front of and behind square. He also came down the pitch on occasion before falling to Salam in an attempt to clear long-off.

2:31

Review: Did Titans get their tactics wrong?

With Azmatullah Omarzai, Shahrukh Khan and Rahul Tewatia all falling for single-digit scores around Sudharsan's dismissal, GT appeared to have lost steam, needing 73 in 24 balls. However, Miller hit Nortje for three sixes and a four in a 24-run 17th over to give them hope, completing his own half-century off 21 balls along the way.

The see-sawing continued. Mukesh dismissed Miller in the 18th over and, at the time, it seemed like DC had done enough. But Salam leaked 18 runs in the 19th over to make it a shootout between Rashid and Mukesh in the last over.

Mukesh conceded two fours off the first two balls and a six off the penultimate delivery but held his nerve to get the last ball to land so full that Rashid could not find the elevation he needed.

Titans' spinners neutralised

After Warrier's three-wicket burst had given GT the early advantage, they would have expected Rashid, Noor Ahmad and R Sai Kishore to strangle DC through the middle overs. But Axar and Pant kept all three at bay.

Against Rashid, they only attacked the loose balls, half-trackers or wide deliveries, and eked out 37 runs off his four wicketless overs. Against Noor, they attacked to leave him with an economy of 12 in three overs.

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It's too many runs, somebody make it stop

An extra over for one bowler - will it help the bowlers?

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MATCH 41

Royal Challengers Bengaluru 206 for 7 (Kohli 51, Patidar 50, Unadkat 3-30, Natarajan 2-39) beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 171 for 8 (Shahbaz 40, Green 2-12, Karn 2-29, Swapnil 2-40) by 35 runs

Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) rode on the success of their spinners - considered the team's least-fancied department - to force big-hitting Sunrisers Hyderabad (SRH) into submission in Hyderabad. Their 35-run victory on Thursday, the season's second for RCB, also ended their six-game losing streak and kept them alive for playoff contention.

Favourites to chase 207 down, SRH lost their way right from the opening over when part-time offspinner Will Jacks won the tactical battle against left-hand batter Travis Head. Making his debut for RCB, Swapnil Singh and experienced wristspinner Karn Sharma then caused further damage. By the time the tenth over rolled along, SRH were 85 for 6, and the result was pretty much decided.

RCB also had a strong day with the bat, banking on Rajat Patidar's 19-ball half-century and quick-fire cameos from Cameron Green and Faf du Plessis. Virat Kohli also scored his 53rd IPL fifty, but his 51 in 43 balls came at a strike rate of 118.60, following a big slowdown.

RCB expose SRH's weaker suit

SRH's record-breaking totals in IPL 2024 have all come batting first. So RCB robbed them of that opportunity when du Plessis chose to set a target instead. He said he wanted to put SRH under scoreboard pressure, although 206 could have well been within SRH's territory.

But that changed in the first half of the chase as SRH crumbled to RCB's use of spin. Jacks' offspin, turning away from the two SRH openers, had Head top-edge for 1 in the first over.

Abhishek Sharma counterattacked with 31 in 13 balls, but in his bid to keep going hard, he fell to Yash Dayal in the fourth.

Even though the openers fell unusually early for SRH, Aiden Markram and Heinrich Klaasen showed that they were in no mood to slow down. Together they struck 19 off Swapnil's first over, but their aggression caused their downfall as the left-arm spinner removed both in the same over. Markram was lbw off a full toss coming down the track while Klaasen holed out attempting a big shot.

Du Plessis soon brought on legspinner Karn to attack SRH further, and in consecutive overs he removed Nitish Kumar Reddy and Abdul Samad. Pat Cummins hammered 31 off 15 and Shahbaz Ahmed remained unbeaten on 40, but by then SRH were basically looking to protect their net run rate.

Patidar makes up for Kohli's slowdown

With big overs against Bhuvneshwar Kumar and Cummins with the new ball, the pair of du Plessis and Kohli had given RCB a rollicking start at 43 for no loss after three overs. But the dismissals of du Plessis for a 12-ball 25 and Jacks for 6, along with some tidy overs from T Natarajan and Shahbaz saw Kohli losing his fluency. From racing away to 23 in his first 11 balls, Kohli laboured to score his next 28 runs in 32 deliveries. The squeeze was provided by Shahbaz after the powerplay, and by the left-arm seam-bowling pair of Jaydev Unadkat and Natarajan with both relying on their assortment of slower balls.

But the presence of Patidar did not let RCB's scoring rate drop. He came into the game with a strike rate of 125 against pacers and 197 against spinners in this IPL, and banked on his strength to score the joint second-fastest fifty in RCB's history.

He picked on Mayank Markande from the get-go, first clubbing him for a six in the ninth over, and then ransacking the legspinner for four back-to-back sixes to take 27 off the 11th over. Soon enough, he had overtaken Kohli and reached his fifty well before the opener, but fell to Unadkat in pursuit of another big shot.

Unadkat, playing his 100th IPL game, then dismissed Kohli in the 15th over and Mahipal Lomror in the 17th, but from the other end Green ensured RCB got the strong finish they needed. He was particularly lethal against his Australia captain Cummins, drilling him for four fours across two overs in the last five to finish unbeaten on a 20-ball 37. The success of left-arm spinner Shahbaz (0 for 14 in three overs) may have prompted RCB to bring in spin-bowling allrounder Swapnil as an Impact Player in the 19th over of the first innings, and before his bowling jolts in the chase, he contributed with a six-ball 12 in the 20th over to help RCB past 200.

MATCH 42

Punjab Kings 262 for 2 (Bairstow 108*, Shashank 68*, Prabhsimran 54, Narine 1-24)
beat Kolkata Knight Riders 261 for 6 (Salt 75, Narine 71, Arshdeep 2-45) by eight wickets

Like temperatures across the whole of India, run-scoring and six-hitting in IPL 2024 are going only one way - up. In an unbelievably ruthless display of batting, Punjab Kings hunted down 262 against Kolkata Knight Riders to record the highest successful chase in all of T20 history, and got there with eight balls to spare. They hit 24 sixes, six more than what KKR managed, and the two teams together set the record for the most sixes in any T20 game.

In the process, Jonny Bairstow roared back to form to smack his second IPL hundred. Shashank Singh, one of PBKS' finds of the season, clubbed 68* from only 28 balls, eight of which disappeared over the boundary. Amid all that, Sunil Narine stood apart with figures of 4-0-24-1 for KKR.

That came after he continued his dream season with the bat, pummeling 71 off 32 deliveries in an opening partnership of 138 in 10.2 overs. Phil Salt, Narine's opening partner, also rode on his form - and some luck - to rush to 75 from 37. But all of that went in vain.

Jonny Bairstow shellacked KKR to all parts and brought up his century in 45 balls•BCCI

Prabhsimran dominates the powerplay

Eden Gardens had just taken in the enormity of the home team's batting effort when PBKS replied in kind, pumping their highest-ever powerplay score of 93 for 1. And Prabhsimran Singh dominated this phase despite not getting to face a single ball of the sixth over. Coming on as Impact sub at the start of the chase, he hammered 54 off 20 balls, the highlight of his innings coming when he went after KKR debutant Dushmantha Chameera in a 23-run third over. There were five sixes in his innings, including a scoop over fine leg off Chameera.

Bairstow then went 4, 6, 4, 4, 6 off Anukul Roy in the sixth over, before Prabhsimran, responding to the call for a quick single from the non-striker's end, was run out off the last ball of the powerplay.

Bairstow carts KKR all around

Bairstow was dropped by PBKS after managing just 96 runs in his first six innings this season. And he took his time finding his feet in his return game, scoring just 12 off his first 10 balls. But his assault on Roy gave a hint of what was to come. He found a bit of help in the ninth over, though, when Roy dropped him while flinging himself to his left at long-off, and failed to prevent the ball from going for six. That shot off Varun Chakravarthy brought up Bairstow's fifty, off 23 balls.

Bairstow went after Varun again in the 11th over, launching him for a six over long-off, chipping a four over the bowler's head, and swat-pulling him for another six. When Bairstow got to his hundred off 45 balls to end the 16th over, PBKS needed 52 from 24.

2:07

Rapid fire: Is this the worst time to be a bowler?

Shashank helps PBKS sail through

Shashank came to the crease when Narine, who somehow conceded just two fours and a six in his four overs, dismissed Rilee Rossouw for a 16-ball 26 in the 13th over. It was the first time he had batted above No. 6 for PBKS, and he quickly made his liking for the promotion evident, hitting Varun for back-to-back leg-side sixes when he had just faced three balls.

The game was tilting PBKS' way when the last four overs began, and the 16th made them clear favourites, as Shashank thumped Chameera for three sixes - a swat, a scoop, and a pull - as PBKS' required rate fell to less than two runs per ball. The match ended in a hurry, as Shashank clattered three more sixes, off Harshit Rana and Ramandeep Singh, and the crowd began to disperse even before the result was officially confirmed. Shashank was batting on 25 when Bairstow reached his hundred; the match ended with Shashank on 68 and Bairstow on 108.

Phil Salt and Sunil Narine put on 137 off just 62 balls•BCCI

Salt, Narine set up daunting KKR total

PBKS dropped Salt twice and Narine once inside the first seven overs, and the two turbocharged openers ran away to 83 for no loss in that time. By the time KKR had reached the halfway point of their innings, they had added another 54 to their score. Narine reached his fifty in the eighth over, bringing it up 23 balls, and Salt got to his in the next over.

At the 10-over mark, ESPNcricinfo's Forecaster predicted a KKR total of 282.

PBKS finally separated the opening pair when Rahul Chahar got Narine to mishit a big shot and find Bairstow at long-on. Who knew then that Bairstow would have so much of a say later in the day?

KKR promoted Andre Russell up to No. 4, and he entered in the 13th over. Facing his second ball, he upper-cut Sam Curran for four to deep third. Chahar then bowled a quiet 14th over, conceding just seven runs, but it was only a temporary bit of respite, as Russell, Shreyas Iyer and Venkatesh Iyer - who hit Curran for 6, 4, 6, 6 to end the 19th over - joined hands to take 85 off the last six overs.

KKR's total of 261 for 6 would have been the second-highest in IPL history if it had been made before this season. As it happened, it was only the seventh-highest at the halfway point of this game, and the eighth highest by the time it was done.

MATCH 43

Delhi Capitals 257 for 4 (Fraser-McGurk 84, Stubbs 48*, Hope 41, Nabi 1-20) beat Mumbai Indians 247 for 9 (Tilak 63, Hardik 46, Rasikh 3-34, Mukesh 3-59, Khaleel 2-45) by ten runs

In another run fest in IPL 2024, Jake Fraser-McGurk's 84 off 27 balls proved to be the difference as Delhi Capitals (DC) beat Mumbai Indians (MI) by ten runs in Delhi.

Apart from Fraser-McGurk, Shai Hope and Tristan Stubbs also played crucial knocks for DC as they posted 257 for 4 after being sent in. In reply, MI lost three wickets in the powerplay - the big ones of Rohit Sharma, Ishan Kishan and Suryakumar Yadav - but Tilak Varma and Hardik Pandya kept their hopes alive.

Rasikh Salam, however, turned the game by dismissing Hardik and Nehal Wadhwa in the same over. While Tilak and Tim David fought till the end, MI eventually fell short.

The win took DC to fifth place on the points table with ten points from as many games. MI stay rooted to ninth with six points from nine matches.

2:15

Did Mumbai miss a trick against Fraser-McGurk?

Fraser-McGurk gives DC a blazing start

As he has done often in his fledgling career so far, Fraser-McGurk did not waste time getting his eye in and his bat swinging. With a slightly open stance to left-arm seamer Luke Wood, he smashed the first three balls of the innings for 4, 4 and 6.

After taking 19 from the first over, he greeted Jasprit Bumrah in the same manner. Bumrah started his over with a slower ball only to be launched over long-on for a six. To make things worse, Bumrah had overstepped, and Fraser-McGurk drilled the free-hit past long-on for four. Fraser-McGurk ended the over with another boundary, making it Bumrah's most expensive over (18 runs) of the season.

DC reached 50 in just 2.4 overs, the joint-fastest for a team in the IPL. In the next over, Fraser-McGurk got to his own fifty. Coming off just 15 balls, it was the joint-fourth fastest in the tournament's history.

Kishan fined for Code of Conduct breach

Mumbai Indians' wicketkeeper-batter Ishan Kishan has been reprimanded and fined 10% of his match fee for breaching the IPL's Code of Conduct. Kishan, who scored 20 off 14, was charged with a Level 1 offence under Article 2.2 of the IPL's Code of Conduct. Kishan admitted to the offence and accepted the match referee's sanction.

Hardik brought himself on for the fifth over but there was no stopping Fraser-McGurk, who hammered the MI captain for two fours and two sixes to take DC to 89 for no loss after five overs.

For a moment, it looked like Fraser-McGurk might break the record for the fastest T20 hundred - he already has the fastest List A hundred to his name - but he holed out to deep midwicket against Piyush Chawla for a 27-ball 84.

Shai Hope smashed five sixes in his 17-ball 41 • BCCI

Hope, Stubbs keep DC on course for big total

Walking in at 114 for 1 in 7.3 overs, Hope ensured there was no dip in the momentum. Over the last one year or so, he has worked on his six-hitting skills and has demonstrated the same in ODIs but was unable to do so in T20s. On Saturday, though, he smashed five sixes in a 17-ball 41 to keep DC going in the middle overs.

After Hope fell, Stubbs took over and raced to 48 not out off 25 balls. In the 18th over, he used scoops, reverse-scoops and pulls to hit five fours and a six off Wood. Despite Bumrah dismissing Rishabh Pant in the 19th and conceding only six, DC had no trouble in crossing 250.

DC dominate the other powerplay too

MI had a brisk start to their chase with Ishan Kishan hitting three successive fours off Khaleel Ahmed in the second over. But Khaleel made a good comeback and had Rohit Sharma caught at mid-off in his next over. From the other end, Mukesh Kumar had Kishan miscuing one to make it 45 for 2.

Suryakumar Yadav started with a flurry of boundaries, including two scooped sixes. But in the last over of the powerplay, he failed to pick a slower ball from Khaleel and fell for 26 off 13 balls.

Rasikh Salam sent back Hardik Pandya and Nehal Wadhera in the same over •BCCI

Rasikh has an impact, again

MI had slowed down a bit after the powerplay but Hardik put them back on track. He hit Axar Patel for a six off the last ball of the eighth over and then smacked three fours and a six off Kuldeep Yadav in the ninth. Tilak, who was batting on a run-a-ball eight till then, also got into the act with a six and a four in Axar's next over.

MI were still playing catch-up when Rasikh, after coming in as Impact Player, pegged them further back with a two-wicket over. Hardik ended up skying a back-of-the-hand slower ball to backward point and Nehal Wadhera guided a length delivery straight to Pant. That left MI needing 117 from seven overs with five wickets in hand.

Tilak, David fight hard but in vain

Tilak and David kept the fight going. Tilak hit Kuldeep for two fours and two sixes in a 21-run 15th over to bring the equation down to 85 from five overs. But another excellent over by Rasikh, which went for only seven, made it 64 required from three.

David took on Mukesh and hit him for two sixes and a four to start the 18th over but was lbw off the next ball. Rasikh went for 16 in the penultimate over but dismissed Mohammad Nabi, which meant it was Tilak or bust for MI with 25 required from the final over.

Tilak went for a risky second run off the first ball of that over only to be caught short, and Mukesh held his nerve for the next five balls to seal the win for DC.

MATCH 44

Rajasthan Royals 199 for 3 (Samson 71*, Jurel 52*) beat Lucknow Super Giants 196 for 5 (Rahul 76, Hooda 50, Sandeep 2-31) by seven wickets

The target of 197 that Lucknow Super Giants set Rajasthan Royals may not have seemed like much at the end of the first innings. After all, over the last four days, targets of 262 and 211 had been chased comfortably, while totals of 257 and 225 were also nearly overrun.

But even so, RR were in a tricky situation at 78 for 3 after 8.4 overs, after ending the powerplay 60 for 1. Ten overs into the chase, with RR needing 116, ESPNcricinfo's forecaster gave LSG an 87.76% chance of winning. But then Sanju Samson joined forces with an out-of-form Dhruv Jurel, both batters scoring half-centuries in a 121-run riposte to LSG's hundred partnership between KL Rahul and Deepak Hooda, and took Royals to victory with an over to spare.

The result was Royals' eighth win in nine games, taking them six points clear of Kolkata Knight Riders in second place, and has all but assured them of a place in the playoffs with five games in hand.

Samson and Jurel keep calm

Jos Buttler and Yashasvi Jaiswal had added 60 off 34 balls. But with two deliveries of the powerplay remaining, Buttler was bowled by Yash Thakur - moving across his crease and missing a full toss that crashed into the base of leg stump. In the next over, Marcus Stoinis had Jaiswal caught at deep cover.

LSG had chosen a black-soil pitch for this contest and brought on 41-year-old legspinner Amit Mishra for the first time this season as the Impact Player. He accounted for RR's Impact Player - Riyan Parag - having him caught at deep cover too soon after conceding a six. RR were in trouble then but Samson and Jurel led them out of it.

While Samson began his innings with form on his side - he was among the top-scorers of the season - Jurel had managed only ten runs in his previous three innings across six matches. They took their time, scoring only three runs off the first eight balls of their partnership, before ransacking the next two overs for 29 runs. Jurel launched Mishra for a six and chipped Thakur for four, while Samson also got three boundaries.

The 14th over, from left-arm quick Mohsin Khan, proved to be the turning point of the game. Jurel was dropped twice in that over by Thakur and hit three fours and a six, eventually finishing unbeaten on 52 off 34 balls. Samson's innings was less fraught with risk and he ended the match with a six over fine leg to remain not out on 71 off only 33 deliveries.

Quinton de Kock lost his stumps to Trent Boult in the first over of the game•BCCI

Not quite a spinners' pitch

There were a few cracks on the pitch in Lucknow, with the ball expected to turn off them. The soil was black too, which has historically been more spin-friendly. When LSG batted, RR's spinners R Ashwin and Yuzvendra Chahal combined for figures of 8-0-80-1. The solitary wicket was Ashwin's - Deepak Hooda caught at wide long-on - and it was only his second wicket in eight games this season.

LSG's spinners didn't have much success during the chase either, even though there wasn't much dew, with Krunal Pandya, Ravi Bishnoi and Mishra bowling a total of seven overs for figures of 1 for 60. While Krunal bowled quicker and flatter to concede only 24 from his four overs, Mishra and Bishnoi proved expensive.

RR restrict LSG at start and finish

Trent Boult did what he almost always does - strike in the first over. Quinton de Kock had begun the match with boundaries off the first two balls, but had his stumps shattered by the third. And in the second over Sandeep Sharma swerved the ball through the gap between Stoinis' bat and pad as he attempted to drive and bowled him.

LSG were 11 for 2 when Hooda joined his captain Rahul, and they went about the recovery at brisk pace, counterattacking by smashing four boundaries in the last two overs of the powerplay. Rahul then took Avesh for 21 in the eighth over, whipping and swinging for six over midwicket and fine leg, and pulling a free-hit for four more. LSG were 94 for 2 at the halfway stage, with Rahul reaching 50 off 31 balls. He and Hooda continued the offensive, picking up 32 off the next two overs. Hooda got to his half-century from 30 deliveries before holing out to a carrom-ball from Ashwin to end his partnership with Rahul on 115 off 62 balls.

With eight overs to go and plenty of wickets in hand, LSG were primed for a strong finish, but it did not happen for them. Even though they lost only two more wickets, they were those of Nicholas Pooran and Rahul - for 76 off 48 balls - and LSG were able to score only 25 runs in the last three overs of their innings.

MATCH 45

Royal Challengers Bengaluru 206 for 1 (Jacks 100*, Kohli 70*) beat Gujarat Titans 200 for 3 (Sai Sudharsan 84*, Shahrukh 58, Swapnil 1-23) by nine wickets

Royal Challengers Bengaluru overcame any vulnerabilities against spin in some style against Gujarat Titans, running down a target of 201 with nine wickets in hand and four overs to spare in Ahmedabad. Virat Kohli's unbeaten 70 off 44 balls - 34 of them against spin - led the charge before a blitz from Will Jacks, who completed his maiden IPL ton on the last ball, helped RCB home with four overs to spare.

RCB took 124 off the 11 overs of spin bowled by Rashid Khan (0 for 51), Noor Ahmad (0 for 43) and R Sai Kishore (1 for 30) as GT were hiding for cover on a surface that became conducive to strokeplay as the game progressed.

Jacks' late assault - he hit four fours and nine sixes in his last 17 balls - helped RCB ransack 58 off two overs when they needed 53 off 36 balls, and in the process he brought up a 41-ball 100. It was an innings that changed speeds in a blink of an eye, and had Kohli gesturing that he missed only a bucket of popcorn and a cold drink from the best seat in the house to witness the Will-storm.

This was all after Gujarat Titans posted 200 for 3 on the back of an unbeaten 84 from B Sai Sudharsan and a 30-ball 58 from Shahrukh Khan. With the track assisting spin at the start of the game, it looked as if GT had enough on the board. Until it wasn't.

RCB's powerplay squeeze

Before the start of Sunday's fixtures, RCB had the second-worst economy rate in the powerplay, their 10.53 being only marginally better than Kolkata Knight Riders' 10.68. But against GT, the RCB bowlers were on the money, and it all started in the first over. Swapnil Singh, playing only his second game in IPL 2024, deceived Wriddhiman Saha by flight, having him caught at short third in an attempt to go inside out.

Thereon, Shubman Gill and Sai Sudharsan merely consolidated. Their attempts to free the shackles did not bear fruit as they could manage only one four in the last three overs of the powerplay to finish on 42 for 1. Glenn Maxwell, back in the XI for RCB, then preyed on Gill's quiet start to have him caught brilliantly at long-on in a diving effort by Cameron Green.

Sai Sudharsan and Shahrukh inject momentum

At 45 for 2 in the seventh over, GT decided to send in Shahrukh at No. 4 and the move paid rich dividends. He got going straightaway, sweeping Maxwell over long-on for six before pulling a not-so-short one between long-on and deep midwicket for four. Shahrukh was asked to be the disruptor and he essayed that role to perfection. He was severe on Karn Sharma, hitting him for two sixes in two overs, which put him out of the attack. He then hit Green for 4, 4, 6 to bring up a 24-ball fifty, his first in the IPL.

1:31

Aaron: Shahrukh made the difference for Titans' batting

Shahrukh's carnage allowed Sai Sudharsan to change gears. He was on 18 off 16 when the powerplay ended, and on 32 off 23 at the 10-over mark. He attacked Karn's legspin before putting away an-almost-perfect yorker from Mohammed Siraj to bring up his half-century off 34 balls. Titans managed to score 106 in the middle overs (7 to 16), the most they have in the phase this season. In fact, GT scored 86 off just 45 balls through the time Shahrukh was in the middle.

Even after Shahrukh's dismissal - castled by a reverse-swinging full delivery from Siraj - Sai Sudharsan did not relent. In his next 15 balls, he scored 34 and was particularly severe on spin - a strike rate of 205 (41 off 20) as opposed to 153.57 (43 off 28) against the quicks. However, the 51 GT managed at the death did seem a tad underwhelming.

Kohli spins it the RCB way

Faf du Plessis targeted Azmatullah Omarzai in the third over of the chase, hitting him for 6, 6, 4 - a sequence that ended with a scoop over the wicketkeeper. But R Sai Kishore, introduced in the fourth over, managed to have him hole out to deep midwicket to break the opening stand. That did not deter Kohli, who lofted Rashid Khan over his head before hitting two sixes in two balls off Sai Kishore's next.

Virat Kohli and Will Jacks finished things off with 24 balls to spare•AFP/Getty Images

It looked like Sai Kishore had managed to deceive him in the flight but Kohli's loft over wide long-off just evaded a leaping David Miller, before he firmly flicked the next one cleanly over wide long-on. He used the sweep to good effect, taking 22 off the shot in six attempts. That Jacks was still only coming to grips with the surface and GT's spinners at the other end seemed to have little effect on Kohli, who slashed one through backward point to race away to a 32-ball fifty.

Jacks cuts loose in the end

The only four Jacks had to his credit before the tenth over was a flashy outside edge after not picking Noor Ahmad's wrong'un. Mohit Sharma's introduction only helped him unleash his full range. He thwacked one over deep midwicket before smacking a slower one over extra cover. He then muscled Sai Kishore and Noor over long-on and deep square leg respectively in successive overs as he moved from a run-a-ball 16 to 44 off 29 inside four overs.

He just upped the destruction a level in Mohit's second over, which went for three sixes - including one off a no-ball - and two fours as RCB came within touching distance. Jacks then went 6, 6, 4, 6, 6 to complete his century as well as RCB's third win in ten outings and a net-run-rate boost.

MATCH 46

Chennai Super Kings 212 for 3 (Gaikwad 98, Mitchell 52, Dube 39*) beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 134 (Markram 32, Deshpande 4-27) by 78 runs

Call them conservative, but Chennai Super Kings successfully backed their method despite not being able to defend 210 in their previous home match against Lucknow Super Giants. The power-packed Sunrisers Hyderabad's drought in Chennai - they have never beaten CSK at Chepauk - continued as they fell short comprehensively despite batting in dewy conditions.

The slowest team in the first two overs and the third-slowest in the powerplay, CSK looked like they were playing the same game again: lose the toss (their eighth lost toss in nine matches), lay a cautious platform, captain Ruturaj Gaikwad scoring around about a hundred, Shivam Dube pushing them over 200... But then it changed in the second innings. CSK must have figured they had got done in by excessive dew, a special innings from Marcus Stoinis and some ordinary fielding from themselves the other night, a combination of events that won't be repeated every night.

On Sunday, it wasn't repeated, after Tushar Deshpande rocked SRH with three wickets in the powerplay. Both Travis Head and Abhishek Sharma found the sweeper on the off side. The big win took CSK from sixth to third on the points table, tied on points with SRH and LSG. SRH were left with questions around their chasing methods: they have lost only one when defending but won only one when chasing. Their run rate when chasing falls three points from their 11.74 in the first innings, and the average comes down from nearly 40 to 23.

Conservative Super Kings

The CSK openers made only one boundary attempt in the first two overs, and then gradually pushed up, largely thanks to expert gap-finding by Gaikwad. The first eight overs brought CSK just 67 runs, out of which Gaikwad scored 44 off 25 with seven fours.

Ruturaj Gaikwad got to a 27-ball fifty with a six•BCCI

The middle-overs press

CSK went the first 10 overs of the last match without a six. Here, they hit the first at the start of the ninth over when Daryl Mitchell welcomed Pat Cummins to the bowling crease by off-driving a slower ball over mid-off. In the same over, Gaikwad repeated the dose to get to 51 off 27. CSK's other end, including extras, had got just 31 off 27 till that point.

However, Mitchell joined the party now, and played a part in keeping CSK going even as Gaikwad managed just 10 off the next 10. In that period, Mitchell made his way to fifty off 29 before holing out to leave CSK at 126 for 3 in 13.3 overs.

The finish

Shivam Dube continued his exceptional season despite good defensive bowling from SRH. He ended up with 39 off 20, hitting four sixes and a four. Gaikwad found a second wind, taking 29 in 10 balls immediately after Mitchell's dismissal. Towards the end, though, he was gassed and kept mis-hitting everything. The mis-hits kept falling safe, bringing down his strike rate. The 19th over, bowled by Jaydev Unadkat, brought no boundary.

MS Dhoni whipped a first-ball four•BCCI

MS Dhoni came out for a customary 5 off 2, and Dube ended with a huge six, but the question remained: had CSK done the right thing by playing in identical fashion to the other night?

The Deshpande blitz

Unlike CSK, Travis Head began with a boundary first ball and a six off the first ball of the next over. Abhishek Sharma matched him with a six off his own. Deshpande, though, came back with a wide slower ball, which Head could send only as far as the sweeper on the off side. Impact Player Anmolpreet Singh fell first ball with a leading edge to one that shaped away.

In his next over, Deshpande had Abhishek caught by the sweeper on the off side again. Abhishek and Head have not put up unbelievable numbers without taking fielders on, but they will be slightly disappointed they both found one of the only two men out.

The middle-overs squeeze

This is where CSK changed their fortunes as compared to the last match. LSG didn't let the CSK spinners bowl in the last match, especially with the dew. Here Ravindra Jadeja got into his work. He conceded just one boundary in his four overs, bowled on the trot. He and Mustafizur Rahman managed to find just enough grip from the surface. A frustrated Nitish Reddy top-edged a short ball from Jadeja before Matheesha Pathirana broke the stump camera with a laser-guided middle-stump yorker to Aiden Markram.

CSK were right. There wasn't to be a repeat of a special chase as they closed out efficiently for a 78-run win.

MATCH 47

Kolkata Knight Riders 157 for 3 (Salt 68, Shreyas 33*, Venkatesh 26*, Axar 2-25) beat Delhi Capitals 153 for 9 (Kuldeep 35*, Pant 27, Varun 3-16, Harshit 2-28, Arora 2-29) by seven wickets

Having just hosted a run-fest where 262 was chased down with eight balls to spare, Eden Gardens reverted to a former template familiar to fans of its home team, and Kolkata Knight Riders returned to winning ways and moved to second place on the IPL table with a confident, net-run-rate-boosting seven-wicket victory over Delhi Capitals.

After a succession of flat pitches, Eden served up one with a little bit of grip, and KKR's bowlers made full use of it after Capitals chose to bat first. Mitchell Starc and Vaibhav Arora took three wickets inside the powerplay, after which the spinners took over, with Varun Chakravarthy and Sunil Narine combining for figures of 8-0-40-4. Reduced to 111 for 8 at one stage, Capitals set KKR a 150-plus target thanks to an unlikely, unbeaten 26-ball 35 from Kuldeep Yadav.

Related

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How many sixes need to be hit before they lose their magic?

With Kuldeep and Axar Patel in their attack, DC had the tools to create a bit of pressure on this pitch, but KKR were well on their way to victory before either spinner had bowled a ball. Phil Salt made his fourth fifty in five home games this season, dominating a powerplay in which KKR rushed to 79 for no loss.

Axar Patel removed both KKR openers when he came on, but it was too little, too late for DC, as Shreyas Iyer and Venkatesh Iyer put on an unbroken 57 off 43 balls to end the match with 21 balls remaining.

KKR now have 12 points from nine games, and a NRR of 1.096, the best of any team in the competition.

Starc vs Fraser-McGurk, a glimpse of the future

Jake Fraser-McGurk faced just seven balls on Monday night, and five of the seven were attempted yorkers, two of which ended up as full-tosses. The other two were banged into a hard length. The bulk of these balls were from Mitchell Starc, but Vaibhav Arora also stuck to the same plan with his two balls. This wasn't two fast bowlers searching for swing from a fullish good length with the new ball. This was death bowling inside the powerplay, and as T20 batting leans more and more towards all-out attack, it's likely we'll see a lot more of it in the future.

On the day, Fraser-McGurk hit a four and a six and picked out deep square leg while looking to flick Starc for another six.

By then, DC had already lost Prithvi Shaw, who had begun ominously with three fours off Starc off the first three balls of the match. He had fallen in innocuous manner, strangling Arora down the leg side.

Arora took one more wicket, delivering a peach that straightened off the deck to hit the top of Shai Hope's off stump. That ball suggested there would be grip for the spinners too, and so it proved.

Phil Salt's successful IPL continued with another fifty•AFP/Getty Images

Chakra-party

Before this match, Varun had endured a difficult season, going at 9.72 while picking up eight wickets in eight games. While Narine had defied flat conditions, particularly in Kolkata, and prevented batters from accessing the boundaries, his spin partner had gone for plenty like every other bowler in KKR's games.

Now, though, Varun had a bit of help from the pitch, and he could have struck first ball had Harshit Rana - who had just dismissed a dangerous-looking Abishek Porel in the previous over - not dropped a sitter off a Rishabh Pant miscue at short third. Pant, though, would go after Varun again in his next over - the 11th of the Capitals innings - and miscue again, with Shreyas pouncing him safely in the covers on this occasion.

Varun was getting the ball to bite on the surface, and he quickly picked up two more wickets, of Tristan Stubbs and Kumar Kushagra - who came on as Impact Sub in a failed attempt to lengthen DC's batting and stem the collapse. With Narine dismissing Axar Patel at the other end, Capitals were eight down inside the 15th over.

They managed to see out their 20, though, with Kuldeep getting them that far with a mixture of skill and luck. He hit two edged fours in his first four balls, and then hit a six off Starc that was very nearly a catch at deep backward square leg, and eventually finished with a control percentage of 41. They were important runs for DC, though, ensuring that they got to 150.

Venkatesh Iyer and Shreyas Iyer took Kolkata Knight Riders home with 21 balls to spare•BCCI

Salt continues his Eden project

It was evident through the initial stages of KKR's chase that the slower ball was gripping the surface and stopping on the batters, but it was also evident that DC's quicks were offering frequent width to free the arms. With Salt and Narine in the form they were in, this was asking for trouble. And the trouble was compounded when Lizaad Williams, who went for 23 in the first over, dropped a straightforward chance off Khaleel Ahmed at the start of the second to reprieve Salt on 15.

The openers raced to 79 for 0 in the powerplay, with Salt, who had the bulk of the strike, reaching a 26-ball half-century in the sixth over.

Narine went after Axar's first ball and perished, picking out deep midwicket in the seventh over while trying to hit with the turn, and Axar bowled Salt with a trademark, inward-angling skidder in the ninth. But KKR's required rate was well below a run a ball, and it remained so even when Williams dismissed Rinku Singh with a good, hard-length ball in the 10th over.

KKR had a long, in-form line of batters still to come, and in the end didn't require Andre Russell, Angkrish Raghuvanshi or Ramandeep Singh to bat, as the two Iyers ticked off the

remaining runs with little fuss beyond a mix-up in the 16th over when the match was already all but won.

MATCH 48

Lucknow Super Giants 145 for 6 (Stoinis 62, Hardik 2-26) beat Mumbai Indians 144 for 7 (Wadhera 46, Mohsin 2-36) by four wickets

Having lost more wickets (4) than they hit boundaries (3) in the powerplay, Mumbai Indians were always going to struggle. Four of the first six overs cost a run a ball or less. Two of the last four suffered the same fate. A total of 144 did not look like it would be enough and so it proved as Lucknow Super Giants secured victory with four wickets to spare and moved into third place on the points table. Really, the only thing that didn't go according to plan for KL Rahul - well two things - was Mayank Yadav leaving the field early on the very night he returned from injury.

Mohsin's missiles

There is almost no relation between Mohsin Khan's amble up to the crease and the ball that he sends down. At times, he gets big on the batter. Other times he gets swing that they aren't expecting. He uses his height to great effect and must have incredible strength in his shoulder. It seems to be where he gets all his pace, which deceived pretty much everybody. He was producing a false shot roughly once every three deliveries.

MI fined for slow over rate

MI captain Hardik Pandya was fined INR 24 lac as his team maintained a slow over rate for the second time during IPL 2024. The rest of the members of the playing XI, including the Impact Player, were each fined INR 6 lac or 25% of their respective match fees, whichever is lesser. A third such offence will result in Hardik being banned for one match.

Rohit Sharma spooned a ball that he saw as hittable straight into the hands of short cover. The MI batter threw his head back in utter disappointment. He was still thinking that should have gone for four. But instead he was the one gone for 4, on his birthday. Nehal Wadhera had cleared his front leg looking to go big. Except he was met with a searing yorker, dipping beneath his bat before he was ready for it and crashing into his stumps.

Stoinis' utility

Marcus Stoinis has a hundred in this tournament, batting at No. 3. He also occasionally opens the bowling for LSG. Imagine what India would do to have a player like that in their T20 squad?

Someone who can bat up the order and give them two or three overs every game. Stoinis knows his limitations. He knows he doesn't have a lot of pace, but that actually worked in his favour when was bowling to Suryakumar Yadav. The attempt to flick a boundary to fine leg ended up as a feather through to the keeper. It was brave of LSG, keeping Stoinis on for a

second over, long after the swing from the new ball had disappeared, against one of the most dangerous batters in the world. But that was probably the plan - deny SKY the pace he likes - and it worked.

Marcus Stoinis scored quickly on a tricky pitch•AFP/Getty Images

MI fizzle

They lost Rohit and Suryakumar in back-to-back overs. They lost Tilak Varma and Hardik Pandya in back-to-back balls. MI were a sinking ship after just 5.2 overs. They could hit only three boundaries in the powerplay, the fewest this season. It was the perfect situation for Ravi Bishnoi to come in and dictate terms. He bowled four overs on the trot, giving away 28 runs and picking up Ishan Kishan's wicket with a gorgeous googly, deceiving the left-hander as he went for a slog across the line and having him caught at short third. Wadhera tried his best from the other end, progressing from 9 off 15 to 13 off 20 to finally 46 off 41. Most of his runs came off Mayank (21 off 12, 2x4s, 2x6s)

Stoinis' warning

Batting average almost 40, strike rate above 150, four wickets from 12 overs bowled, LSG have a cheat code and his name is Stoinis. This chase really got in gear when he pulled Gerald Coetzee for back-to-back boundaries in the third over. Until then the new ball was doing a fair bit and LSG's focus was seeing that spell of play out. Rahul had dropped anchor (5 off 13, before finishing with 28 off 22). He was looking to his partner to make the play and he did. Big time.

Stoinis came into this game with an average of 19 and strike rate of 128 against spin in IPL 2024. But he found Piyush Chawla and Mohammad Nabi just to his liking, taking them for a combined 29 off just 16 balls with four fours and a six. That ended up as necessary insurance because after the fall of his wicket, LSG needed 27 balls to score the remaining 30 runs, losing two wickets as well.

MATCH 49

Punjab Kings 163 for 3 (Bairstow 46, Rossouw 43) beat Chennai Super Kings 162 for 7 (Gaikwad 62, Rahane 29, Chahar 2-16, Brar 2-17) by seven wickets

Chennai Super Kings were left reeling at the Chepauk Stadium as Punjab Kings made it back-to-back wins with a comfortable seven-wicket victory to retain a slim, outside chance at making the playoffs. They have also become the second team to beat CSK five times in a row, an honour they now share with Mumbai Indians.

It was a far cry from PBKS' jaw-dropping success against Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR) that lifted them out of a three-game losing slump. This time their spinners stole the show, restricting CSK to 162 for 7. After Sam Curran opted to bowl on a sweltering evening in Chennai, Rahul Chahar and Harpreet Brar choked the life out of the batting, taking two

wickets apiece and both going boundaryless for their respective four overs. Ruturaj Gaikwad's 62 held together a patchy 20 overs.

CSK were hampered when Deepak Chahar limped off after bowling the first two deliveries of the chase, leaving them a bowler short. Though Richard Gleeson marked his IPL debut with the dismissal of Prabhsimran Singh, 64 off 37 deliveries between Jonny Bairstow and Rilee Roussouw put them ahead of the rate. Both could and perhaps should have seen their side home. But it was eventually Curran and Shashank Singh who waltzed over the line with 13 deliveries to spare.

CSK squeezed by spin at home

To say CSK were stuck midway through their innings would be an understatement. After Ajinkya Rahane finished the powerplay with three successive fours off Sam Curran, the hosts went without a boundary off the bat for all of 55 deliveries - the longest stretch this season, beating Gujarat Titan's 38 against Delhi Capitals.

Full credit should go to the dual spin threat of Brar and Rahul. The left-arm spinner and legspinner, respectively, combined for seven overs on the trot from the sixth to bring the hosts to a standstill. They prised out three wickets to destroy any momentum CSK had after their highest opening stand of the campaign (64). Two of them - Shivam Dube and Ravindra Jadeja - were left-hand batters, as CSK tried to frontload their batting card with left-hand batters to counter the direction of turn of both spinners. Match-ups be damned, it simply did not work.

Brar bowled his four overs - 2 for 17 - on the bounce; wicket-to-wicket, giving the odd one the chance to turn, but largely giving batters nothing to work with. Just as it looked like he would be the main man of the double act, Rahul returned in the 19th and went for just three (more on that later), taking out the leg stump of Moeen Ali - another legbreak - along the way to finish with 2 for 16 himself.

Dhoni finally dismissed...But PBKS had him pegged

OK, he was run-out chasing a second run off the final delivery. But the point still stands - MS Dhoni is yet to be dismissed by a bowler at the 2024 IPL. That's not to say PBKS did not have the measure of him.

Bowling spinners at the death can be risky business. Teams are increasingly doing it, but not often as late as the 19th over, or with a wristspinner with the relative lack of experience of Rahul compared to the likes of Rashid Khan or Yuzvendra Chahal.

But Dhoni has not been the most fluent of batters against spin for some time now, and CSK make sure he comes late enough not to have to deal with the turning ball. Out of the 37 balls he had faced this season before Wednesday, only three were from spinners.

It was a percentage move by PBKS to bowl Rahul in the penultimate over of the innings with Dhoni on strike. Chahar did his job by keeping the ball away from Dhoni's hitting arc,

towards the leg side. Three out of four balls were sent down outside the off stump. The only time Chahar fired one down the leg was when Dhoni tried to create something by moving towards off, and that one missed leg stump by a whisker.

Home comforts for Gaikwad

Who knows how badly things would have gone for CSK were it not for their captain. Gaikwad's fifth 50-plus score of the season was the only score of note and clarity. It also continued his remarkable scoring streak at Chepauk, which now sees him boast 396 runs at this venue, leading the way for a CSK batter at home in an IPL season. The previous best was Devon Conway's 390 in 2023, and Gaikwad has one more knock at home in the regular season to add some gloss to that accolade.

The first 30 of his 62 came in the opening stand with Rahane, but its demise elicited a mini-collapse to 70 for 3. Gaikwad's last 17 runs came off just nine deliveries, which included bringing up a 44-ball half-century with the first six of the innings, closely followed by a second.

With the bowling stocks looking a little light with Matheesha Pathirana and Tushar Deshpande missing through injury and illness, and Mustafizur Rahman now returning to Bangladesh, Gaikwad and the CSK management have much to consider. Thankfully, the captain's form is not a problem, though he'd almost certainly give up his newly-acquired orange cap if it meant winning a toss.

Impact dud

A scuffed boundary beyond the gloves of Jitesh Sharma was met with a look of relief by Sameer Rizvi. Not only was it his first boundary - off his 22nd delivery - but it ended the drought off the bat. A new, unwanted record.

Now 21 off 22, Rizvi, who was substituted in to replace Rahane, decided to puff his chest out. Kagiso Rabada's extra pace, he thought, would allow him to guide more deliberately behind square. Across he stepped, bat face offered fully to ramp the ball into the beyond. Contact with the ball was crisp, probably the cleanest he had managed on the night. Sadly, Harshal Patel's hustle from deep third was rewarded with a catch. The impact substitute has come under scrutiny, posited as a factor for the leap in scoring this season. Here was an example of how it can go wrong.

MATCH 50

Sunrisers Hyderabad 201 for 3 (Nitish Kumar Reddy 76*, Head 58, Avesh 2-39)
beat Rajasthan Royals 200 for 7 (Parag 77, Jaiswal 67) by one run

Till the 19th over of the chase, the highest Rajasthan Royals let the asking rate rise to in a 202 chase was 10.88, which was at the end of the first over. And yet, Sunrisers Hyderabad won by one run. Pat Cummins bowled a superb 19th over followed by Bhuvneshwar

Kumar successfully defending 12 in the final over despite the over-rate penalty giving them one fewer boundary rider.

Even until the last ball, RR remained the favourites, needing two to win, but Rovman Powell missed a calf-high full toss to be out lbw. It was Bhuvneshwar who got their defence to a great start, removing Jos Buttler and Sanju Samson in the first over, but Yashasvi Jaiswal and Riyan Parag made the chase look easy with their fifties. When Jaiswal fell, they needed 67 off 39; when Parag left, they needed 43 off 25. Shimron Hetmyer and Powell looked like cruising it, and then two hits went straight to the fielders, and Cummins swooped in.

This was SRH's fifth score of 200 or more this IPL, but they took the scenic route to get there after choosing to bat. By all accounts, it was a decision informed by their ordinary chasing record and not the conditions. They found themselves having to start off on a sluggish track, which got better as the evening wore off. In fact they themselves scored 153 in their last 12 overs. For the 18 overs of the RR chase, it seemed those first eight overs had cost SRH the game, who now sit among the top four on the points table.

RR spot on with the new ball

Two left-hand batters as openers was the ideal match-up for RR. Trent Boult is anyway a new-ball ace, but now they could bowl R Ashwin too. Boult was denied a wicket first ball as Parag dropped Travis Head at backward point, but the two combined to bowl four overs for just 25 runs. After CSK had shut the SRH openers down with a sweeper on the off side in the powerplay, Boult went the other way, placing two men deep on the leg side and denying them any room. Ashwin was particularly unlucky he didn't have a wicket as he kept beating the bat.

Avesh Khan and Sandeep Sharma reaped the harvest as they got Abhishek Sharma and Anmolpreet Singh with the first ball each of them bowled, resulting in the slowest powerplay for SRH this year: 37 runs.

Head leads, Reddy follows

After the first time-out, SRH seemed to have decided the pitch had improved. The intent changed visibly. Yuzvendra Chahal was at the receiving end of it as Head pulled and drove him for sixes. He went from 27 off 27 to get to his fifty in 37 balls. Nitish Kumar Reddy followed suit, converting his 5 off 10 into a 30-ball fifty. Even he was ruthless against Chahal, resulting in the second-worst analysis for a spinner in the IPL and also Chahal's second-worst figures in all T20 cricket: 4-0-62-0.

Reddy, Klaasen close things off

Nitish Kumar Reddy mixed the orthodox with the unorthodox in an unbeaten 76 off 42•BCCI

Head again hit a bit of a rut after reaching his fifty, which ended with him playing on while trying to ramp a wide yorker. Not before he was reprieved again, this time by the third umpire when his bat was clearly in the air when the wicket was broken.

However, the real damage to RR came from Reddy and Heinrich Klaasen. Reddy ruined Ashwin's neat figures by taking two sixes off his final over. Then Klaasen got stuck into Chahal in the 17th over. The RR bowlers were on point with their plans and execution, and it took improvisation and exceptional hitting from Klaasen to take SRH past 200.

Vintage Bhuvneshwar

Bhuvneshwar got the new ball moving, drawing the outside edge from Buttler first ball and going past Samson's inside edge in the same over. These were his 45th and 46th wickets in the first over in T20 cricket, now only one behind Shaheen Shah Afridi's 47 and level on joint-top at the IPL with 27.

What seemed the perfect chase

Bhuvneshwar found swing in the second over too, but it met the broad swinging bat of Parag, who hit him for two fours and a six. This was nonchalant, disdainful hitting. Jaiswal was more respectful but just as powerful. His shot at the start of the fourth over went straight into Cummins' midriff at mid-off, but the SRH captain dropped it. Then Cummins brought himself on to be hit for two fours and monstrous six over long leg. In the next over, Abhishek Sharma dropped Parag at extra cover. It speaks to the consistency in their hitting that the highest the asking rate hovered around 10.

The chaos

Like Head, Jaiswal played on a low full toss as he tried to ramp it. Parag pulled the momentum back by hitting a six two balls later. Small things happened in the 16th over that look huge in hindsight. Parag hit a full toss from Cummins straight to short fine leg. Then he got too close to a half-volley, and holed out to long-on. SRH had a wicket and a rare over without a boundary.

Powell, though, settled RR's nerves with 15 off the 17th, bowled by Marco Jansen. Hetmyer started the 18th with a huge six. Two dot balls later, he mis-hit a full toss and the game was refusing to die. Dhruv Jurel nailed a leg-side half-volley from Cummins straight down the throat of deep square leg following which Cummins bowled three straight dots at Powell, who hit the last ball for six to tilt the balance again.

After Ashwin handed over the strike to Powell, he used the fielding penalty to take a boundary through the vacant fine-leg region. Poor throws from the outfield allowed Powell take three couples. One more, and it would be over. Perhaps Powell was expecting something close to a yorker because Bhuvneshwar had been nailing them. The full toss took him by surprise, handing RR their first defeat this IPL while chasing.

MATCH 51

Kolkata Knight Riders 169 (Venkatesh 70, Pandey 42, Bumrah 3-18) beat Mumbai Indians 145 (Suryakumar 56, Starc 4-33) by 24 runs

Kolkata Knight Riders further embedded themselves near the top of the IPL table, and Mumbai Indians' hopes of qualifying for the final four took another big hit.

How MI managed to lose a match in which they took five KKR wickets in the first 37 legal deliveries, will require some examination from the franchise brains trust. But essentially, MI didn't go for the kill when they had KKR on the ropes at 43 for 4, then 57 for 5. And although MI closed the innings nicely through Bumrah, their having allowed KKR to recover through an 83-run stand between Venkatesh Iyer and Manish Pandey, would haunt them in the end.

Their own top order was shambolic, as has been the case through the season. But still, thanks to a good innings from Suryakumar Yadav, MI were still in with hope into the death. Mitchell Starc put paid to those hopes, however, and MI were all out for 145 in the 19th over.

Starc locks it down

Despite their faltering start, MI still only needed 51 runs off the last five overs, with Suryakumar at the crease on 56. Andre Russel bowled the 16th over, and Suryakumar will feel he should have done better with the knee-high full toss he got second ball. Instead of launching it into the legside stands, he got a huge top edge that flew towards fine leg, with wicketkeeper Phil Salt able to chase it down and take it comfortably in his gloves.

It was Starc who really ended MI's chances though. He bowled a spectacular 17th over in which he conceded only three runs. And when MI needed 32 off the last two overs, he did concede a six off first ball of the 19th, but had Tim David caught at long on next ball, had Piyush Chawla chip one to extra cover immediately after, then wiped out the innings with a yorker that took out Gerald Coetzee's middle stump.

After a rough start to the IPL, Starc came back in this match with figures of 4 for 33, having also dismissed Ishan Kishan with the new ball.

Venkatesh Iyer brought up a battling half-century • BCCI

Venkatesh Iyer digs KKR out of a hole

Before Starc could work his magic with the ball, KKR needed something to defend. And Venkatesh's 70 off 52 was the spine of KKR's innings. He was quick early on, hitting two fours off his first four balls, before settling down a little while wickets fell at the other end. But to KKR's great credit, their run rate did not slow substantially despite the dismissals. They were 51 for 4 after five overs, 83 for 5 after 10, and got to triple figures in the 12th over of the innings.

This was in large part thanks to Venkatesh, and to Pandey, who kept seeking out boundary opportunities instead of settling too deep into accumulation mode. Pandey was out for 42

off 31 in the 17th over, but Iyer stayed till the 20th, and was the last to be out off the penultimate ball. Of his three sixes, the back away and crash over long off, off the bowling of Hardik Pandya, was the most memorable.

Bumrah almost unplayable

Though MI continue to stink up the IPL, Bumrah is their unerring talisman, today finishing with figures of 3 for 18 off 3.5 overs. In his first over he conceded just two runs, but Hardik did not bring his best bowler back even when KKR were struggling in the first seven overs.

Bumrah then had one modest middle-overs over, in which Pandey hit him for a six and a four.

But at the death, he was exemplary, taking two wickets and conceding just two runs off the 18th over, before hemming Venkatesh in and getting him out off the fifth ball of the last over - the batter having tried to scoop him over the shoulder, only to miss and to have his middle stump knocked out of the ground. He had scored just two runs off the previous four deliveries.

Bumrah keeps the purple cap, though MI's chances of making the playoffs grow remote.

MATCH 52

Royal Challengers Bengaluru 152 for 6 (du Plessis 64, Kohli 42, Little 4-45) beat Gujarat Titans 147 (Shahrukh 37, Tewatia 35, Dayal 2-21, Vyshak 2-23, Siraj 2-29) by four wickets

Four overs of craziness aside, Royal Challengers Bengaluru played the near-perfect game at the M Chinnaswamy Stadium to roll Gujarat Titans over for the second time in a week.

Riding on the back of their seam-bowling success and a blistering opening stand between Faf du Plessis and Virat Kohli, RCB dominated for the first 26 overs of the game. But a middle-order collapse - where GT picked up six wickets for only 25 runs - briefly put them on the back foot. However, Dinesh Karthik (21*) and Swapnil Singh (15*) counterpunched to complete a four-wicket win.

RCB's victory with 38 balls to spare also takes them from tenth to seventh on the points table. They are on eighth points, as are ninth-placed GT, with both sides holding slim chances to make the playoffs.

RCB make use of conditions

Pitch number eight was the same surface on which Sunrisers Hyderabad pumped 287. But Saturday's version of the pitch was different, courtesy the few hours of rain on Friday that made the pitch sweat overnight.

Mohammed Siraj and Yash Dayal utilised that little assistance to move the ball in both directions in the powerplay, and found success with balls from behind a good length. Siraj dismissed Wriddhiman Saha for the fourth time in six innings and then had Shubman Gill

playing away from his body for a catch at deep point. Sai Sudharsan also failed to get going, and GT could post only 23 for 3 in the powerplay, their lowest score of all time in that phase.

M Shahrukh Khan, David Miller and Rahul Tewatia then scored in the thirties to keep the GT innings moving. Despite the occasional boundaries, the RCB seamers did not let them get away.

Vijaykumar Vyshak pushed them back with short balls, as did Cameron Green, and helped by an electrifying fielding effort, the bowlers' combined pressure soon brought about a lower-order collapse. GT slid from 131 for 5 to 147 all out, and their innings had two run-outs including a Kohli direct-hit dismissal of Shahrukh.

Du Plessis, Kohli dazzle

After surviving a close run-out chance on the first ball of the chase, Kohli brushed off all jitters by hitting Mohit Sharma for a six over cover and one more over midwicket in the opening over. Du Plessis then took Josh Little for 20 runs in the next over and RCB were off.

1:46

Was that the best du Plessis knock of IPL 2024?

Du Plessis also took on IPL debutant Manav Suthar and Mohit, and the team fifty was brought up in just 3.1 overs. Kohli then pounced on Suthar for consecutive sixes over long-on. The onslaught continued as du Plessis then reached his fifty off 18 balls as RCB went past their previous-best powerplay score of 88. By the time he was dismissed in the sixth over by Little, RCB had already razed 92 off the target.

Karthik, Swapnil douse fire

From then on, however, wickets started to fall. RCB were probably looking to finish the game quickly to give their slim playoff qualification chances an NRR boost, but their batters fell trying to go after GT's bowlers.

Will Jacks fell to Noor Ahmad's spin while Rajat Patidar, Glenn Maxwell and Green were all dismissed by Little's short balls. When Noor's googly had Kohli edging behind for 42 in the 11th over, RCB had stuttered to 117 for 6.

With four overs of Rashid left - he didn't bowl earlier due to a blow to his shoulder while batting - GT searched for a seventh wicket to put in the ultimate squeeze, but Dinesh Karthik did not let the spinner settle by clubbing three fours in his opening over to give the Chinnaswamy crowd their voice again. When Rashid returned for his second over, Swapnil gave him the same treatment, hitting a six over the bowler's head to secure the two points.

MATCH 53

Chennai Super Kings 167 for 9 (Jadeja 43, Chahar 3-23, Harshal 3-24) beat Punjab Kings 139 for 9 (Prabhsimran 30, Jadeja 3-20, Deshpande 2-35) by 28 runs

Punjab Kings showcased their very best and worst selves all in the course of about 45 minutes and in the end the bad outweighed the good as they lost to Chennai Super Kings by 28 runs.

Sam Curran's men had dominated proceedings right from the toss. A target of 168 should've been well within their reach, especially when they strung together a period of play where they hit six boundaries in 18 balls between the fifth and the seventh overs.

The equation at that point was 112 off 78 with eight wickets in hand. This was not the time to collapse but collapse they did, losing both their set batters, their captain and their finisher. They tumbled from 62 for 2 to 78 for 7. And CSK rose from fifth place to third place.

CSK stutter

It all began with CSK ticking every box they shouldn't tick in a batting innings in T20 cricket. They lost a wicket in the powerplay. Ajinkya Rahane's poor IPL continued with his fifth score of 15 or less. Then just as they were recovering - backing up overs that went for 19 and 9 runs - they lost three wickets in 11 balls, including their top-scorer Ruturaj Gaikwad (32 off 21) and their spin-hitter Shivam Dube (0 off 1). Then just as they were recovering from that - backing up overs that went for 11 and 9 runs - they lost another wicket. Ravindra Jadeja, batting at No. 6, was in during the ninth over and made sure to stay there almost through to finish. His 43 off 26 balls was crucial to the total CSK ended up with.

Chahar's masterclass

Rahul Chahar was once again at the forefront of the PBKS bowling performance, even though he was facing a line-up full of left-handers. He coped by trusting his googly and by staying out of their hitting arcs. These are defensive skills and they are proving more and more valuable. Fifteen of the legspinner's 24 deliveries arrived outside the batter's off stump, or even wider, and fetched him all three of his wickets.

2:13

Rapid Fire review - Will CSK finish in the top four?

Harshal back to his old self

181 runs. That's how many Harshal Patel gave up in his first four games of this season. 181 runs. That's also how many Harshal has given up over his last seven games this season. He's also picked up 13 wickets along the way. He's become a bowler transformed - or so it seems. Really though, a death overs specialist runs the risk of splits like these. It's the difference between executing what you want perfectly and missing your mark by a few inches. Harshal secured two of his three wickets with slow, sharply dipping yorkers. One of them was MS Dhoni for a first-ball duck. He spoke about how he doesn't rely on technique as much as feel, which is why he wasn't at his best at the start of the season; he was rusty. But with overs under his belt, he has gotten better and better.

A strange pitch

This pitch, on first sight, seemed to be pretty good for batting. But eventually it became clear that it was playing some tricks. Harshal mentioned that since it was a day game and the square was so dry he was getting reverse swing from as early when he came on to bowl, in the 10th over. Later, in the evening, the new ball started to deck around. It offered extra bounce, which interfered with the shots that Gaikwad and Dube tried to play, but also kept low, without which Daryl Mitchell might not have been lbw. When the ball got old, it held in the pitch and took turn. Both Chahar and Jadeja produced double-wicket overs.

CSK's bowling leader

CSK have lost Deepak Chahar and Matheesha Pathirana to injury but have been able to stay in the race for the IPL playoffs because Tushar Deshpande has improved beyond sight. He was the one selecting the ball that they were going to use at the start of the game. That is typically the responsibility of a very senior player. This guy was once their net bowler. His rise has been phenomenal. Deshpande took out PBKS' two big guns in the top-order - Jonny Bairstow and Rilee Rossouw - in the same over. His first six balls of the match increased CSK's chances of victory by 18.66%.

1:32

Jaffer: Punjab's batters messed up big time

The recovery

The thing with defending small totals is everybody has to be perfect. CSK had one bowler who was nailing his lengths. Constantly looking to hit the deck, which is where all the vagaries were coming from, whether it was extra bounce, or the ball holding up, or keeping low. Deshpande's upright seam position also helped him get sideways movement. The Rossouw ball nipped in against the angle and left his stumps splayed before he could even react. Beaten for both pace and movement.

But overs five, six and seven cost CSK as Shashank Singh and Prabhsimran Singh went on the offensive. They were pulling off jaw-dropping shots. A ramp over third man for six when there was no room and the ball was climbing. An inside-out drive over cover for four when the ball was darted in on or even outside leg stump.

The collapse

Mitchell Santner has a history of putting in high-impact performances. In his second game for CSK, he hit the last ball for six to win the game. But being a left-arm spinner in a team that already has Jadeja, he tends to ride the bench. This was his 16th game for CSK in five years. He only came in because Mustafizur Rahman had to leave early and Pathirana and Chahar were injured. Still, he is a player who knows his strengths and he backed them, bowling nice and tight on the stumps and asking the batters to hit him to the longer boundary, down the ground. That's how he got Shashank.

In the next, the ninth over, Jadeja took out Prabhsimran. In the next over, Simarjeet Singh got rid of Jitesh Sharma and so on and so on. Five wickets. Sixteen runs. Twenty-eight balls. PBKS kept trying to hit themselves out of trouble. They were unable to soak the pressure; unable to bat at a different gear.

This is the kind of situation that CSK thrive in. So even when there came a point where Ashutosh Sharma was dropped very poorly by Moeen Ali, they had Jadeja up their sleeve and he produced a wicket off the very next ball, Sam Curran falling to another big shot, and then in the same over, Ashutosh too succumbing to a wild swing. That was 78 for 7 and that was the game.

MATCH 54

Kolkata Knight Riders 235 for 6 (Narine 81, Salt 32, Raghuvanshi 32, Naveen 3-49)
beat Lucknow Super Giants 137 (Stoinis 36, Rana 3-24, Varun 3-30, Russell 2-17) by 98 runs

Sunil Narine crashed 81 off 39 deliveries and Ramandeep Singh got only six balls to face and smashed 25 in those. In addition, Phil Salt, Angkrish Raghuvanshi and Shreyas Iyer played aggressive innings. All of which meant that Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR) surged to 235 for 6 in their 20 overs, which in Lucknow - one of the lower-scoring venues in IPL 2024 - was always going to be incredibly difficult to surpass.

The Lucknow Super Giants (LSG) innings didn't really take off. There was a 50-run second-wicket partnership between KL Rahul and Marcus Stoinis, but even that went at too slow a pace (they took 33 balls) to cause serious problems for KKR. Once that stand was broken, the innings fell apart quickly, the last nine wickets falling for 67 runs, as the required rate ballooned out of control.

Varun Chakravarthy and Harshit Rana took three wickets each. Andre Russell took two. And Ramandeep claimed two catches, the first of which was one of the most spectacular of the season.

Sunil Narine brought up his fifty in 27 balls•BCCI

Narine crushes it in the first 12 overs

Salt was the first aggressor, hitting 24 off the first nine balls he faced. But he was soon out for 32 off 14, and from then, it was the Narine show.

Narine warmed up with five fours, then started getting the big hits going at the end of the fourth over, bludgeoning a Mohsin Khan short ball over deep square-leg, clubbing Krunal Pandya over deep midwicket not long after, and later thrashing Yash Thakur over the square-leg boundary. In the middle overs, he dealt almost exclusively in sixes, and by the end of his stay, he had walloped seven, to go with six fours. He holed out to long-off attempting another six off LSG's best bowler Ravi Bishnoi, who was the only one to finish with an economy rate lower than 11.

Ramandeep Singh celebrates after taking a back-tracking blinder•BCCI

Ramandeep plays a cameo to remember

LSG had a good period between overs 14 and 18, where they conceded only 45 while taking three wickets. Thanks to Narine, Salt and Raghuvanshi, with whom Narine shared a 79-run partnership, KKR were headed for a mammoth score. But the slight slowdown might have given LSG a foot in the door.

Ramandeep pushed the total back into gargantuan territory in spectacular style. He took a two in front of square on the leg side to start with, bashed a six over cow corner second ball, bludgeoned one over long-on fourth ball, ramped a four over short third next, then thumped a full toss over midwicket to finish the innings. To recap, he went 2, 6, 1, 6, 4, 6.

As if scoring at a strike rate of more than 400 wasn't impressive enough, he also pulled off one of the catches of the season to get rid of Arshin Kulkarni. Speeding towards the boundary from point, he kept his eyes on a leading edge that had gone high into the air, and put in a spectacular dive to get his hands on a ball whose trajectory he did not seem like he would intersect. He took another catch at deep point later, to dismiss Rahul, the other LSG opener.

Harshit Rana, on return from disciplinary suspension, sent back KL Rahul on his way to a three-for•Associated Press

And then LSG crumble

With a required rate of almost 12 set from the start of the innings, LSG were always going to struggle, given the quality in KKR's attack. They scored 13 off the fourth over, bowled by Mitchell Starc, but then Narine came in with a four-run fifth over, and by the end of the powerplay, the required rate was up near 13.

When LSG tried to hit out, wickets fell rapidly. At no point did they seem to have the measure of this chase. On a slow track, on which KKR's slower bowlers were effective, Rahul's wicket set off a collapse.

MATCH 55

Mumbai Indians 174 for 3 (Suryakumar 102*, Tilak 37, Bhuvneshwar 1-22) beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 173 for 8 (Head 48, Cummins 35*, Hardik 3-31, Chawla 3-33) by seven wickets

A sensational unbeaten 102 off 51 balls from Suryakumar Yadav on the back of Piyush Chawla and Hardik Pandya's three-wicket hauls helped Mumbai Indians (MI) to their fourth win of the season as they got the better of Sunrisers Hyderabad (SRH) by seven wickets in Mumbai. The win also lifted MI out of the bottom of the table to ninth.

A run fest was promised at Wankhede Stadium with SRH visiting. Who would have doubted this considering the last time SRH and MI clashed, record books were rewritten. Instead, the

MI bowlers came to the fore as SRH were restricted to 173 for 8. In reply, the SRH bowlers also got the new ball to move around and got three powerplay wickets.

But Suryakumar decided to do Suryakumar things as he launched an attack on the SRH bowlers, Marco Jansen in particular, to get things back on track. Tilak Varma played the perfect foil with 37 not out off 32 adding 143 off 79 balls with Suryakumar to help MI seal the win in 17.2 overs.

1:14

'Hardik's bowling today a positive sign for India with the World Cup coming'

A T20 or a Test?

First nine balls: 26 for 0.

Next 19 balls: 6 for 3.

Chasing 174 at a venue where scores in excess of 180 have been breached in six out of ten innings this season coming into this game did not feel like a daunting ask, but the SRH bowlers made life extremely tough for the batters. There was a lot of swing and seam available and, initially, the bowlers even struggled to control the swing. They bowled 18 extras in the first three overs, but once they found their lengths, batting started to feel arduous. The ball zipped off the surface, the batters were beaten multiple times, and wickets started to fall.

It was the Test-match length that got the SRH quicks the wickets. Jansen first struck with a seaming delivery that Ishan Kishan could only edge to first slip. And when it's Test-match length we are talking about, how can Pat Cummins not come into the picture? Cummins bowled a sensational first over, a wicket- maiden in which Rohit Sharma was dismissed off a big top edge. Bhuvneshwar Kumar then got Naman Dhir for a nine-ball duck, dismissed flashing to first slip.

Not a single run was scored off the bat between overs 1.3 and 4.4 with MI all over the place.

1:23

Moody: Surya consistently does things very few can

SKY does a SKY

After three overs in which nine runs were scored, Suryakumar decided enough was enough. He first took on Cummins before reserving special treatment for Jansen. He went 4, 4, 6 in the seventh over before swatting Jansen over fine leg for a flat six as overs six and seven yielded a combined 38 runs. From 4 off 7, Suryakumar moved to 32 off 14 in no time and all the initial momentum that SRH had gained was lost.

Tilak played the role of the second fiddle to perfection even as Suryakumar kept on going. In all, Suryakumar walloped Jansen for 32 runs off nine balls, which included four fours and two sixes, and he reached his fifty off 30 balls.

Hardik Pandya and Piyush Chawla took three wickets apiece•AFP/Getty Images

There were a few concerned faces in the MI dugout - and no doubt among people interested in India's fortunes at the T20 World Cup next month - when Suryakumar was seen limping for a bit, but the big hits didn't cease. A Bhuvneshwar slower ball was mowed over long-on before Shahbaz Ahmed was swept twice in two balls. Suryakumar then raced from 82 to 96 in three balls going 4, 4, 6 in the 17th over. And then, with six needed to win and four for his century, he backed away and went inside out over the covers off T Natarajan to finish the job.

This was Suryakumar's second IPL hundred, and sixth in T20 cricket.

Head rides his luck early

It was a strange sort of powerplay with the ball for MI. They didn't bowl badly but hardly found any luck going their way. Travis Head got going with an inside-edged four past leg stump in the first over off Nuwan Thushara and then one more in the second over off debutant Anshul Kamboj. Kamboj should have had his maiden IPL wicket in the next over when he had Head's off stump splat on the ground, but he had over-stepped. Head ended up taking him for 19 in the over, and SRH were away.

Jasprit Bumrah took out Abhishek Sharma, caught behind for 11 off 16, but SRH still managed to reach 56 for 1 in the powerplay. MI would have been miffed because they drew 18 false shots in the first six overs, but only got one wicket to show for their effort.

1:54

Moody: Chawla would have really enjoyed the Klaasen dismissal

Chawla and Hardik turn the tide

Kamboj had another chance to send back Head, but Thushara failed to hang on to a relatively simple chance at deep third in the eighth over. The 23-year-old Kamboj finally had luck going his way when a bail-trimmer sent Mayank Agarwal packing. Thereon it was the Chawla and Hardik show.

At 88 for 2 after ten, SRH were placed comfortably, but Chawla changed things by picking up Head for a 30-ball 48. A slog sweep was smashed straight to deep backward square leg before Hardik took out Nitish Reddy with a short-length ball that was spooned straight up. Chawla then had Heinrich Klassen playing on as SRH slipped from 90 for 2 to 96 for 5 in 11 balls.

Jansen and Shahbaz Ahmed resisted for a bit, but Hardik had them back in the 16th over with SRH at 125 for 7 and soon 136 for 8 with Chawla snaring Abdul Samad. That SRH even breached the 170-run mark was down to Cummins' unbeaten 17-ball 35.

Eventually, it wasn't enough.

MATCH 56

Delhi Capitals 221 for 8 (Porel 65, Fraser-McGurk 50, Ashwin 3-24) beat Rajasthan Royals 201 for 8 (Samson 86, Kuldeep 2-27, Mukesh 2-30) by 20 runs

Sanju Samson's 46-ball 86 went in vain as Delhi Capitals' 221 proved to be too much for Rajasthan Royals to chase. Kuldeep Yadav, Mukesh Kumar and Khaleel Ahmed shared six wickets between them as DC successfully defended their total after being asked to bat, subjecting RR to their second defeat on the trot.

Jake Fraser-McGurk and Abishek Porel set up DC's batting effort as they both hit rapid half-centuries.

R Ashwin, who had come into the game with two wickets in the season, returned a three-wicket haul to slow DC down, but Tristan Stubbs once again provided the hosts with a powerful finish to take them to a total beyond RR's reach.

Fraser-McGurk, Porel bedazzle

Fraser-McGurk walked in to bat with an average of 57.33 and strike rate close to 300 at the Arun Jaitley Stadium. To stop him, Trent Boult started from around the wicket to try and keep him quiet. For one over, it worked.

But when Boult returned for his second over, Fraser-McGurk met him with a loft down the ground for six before hitting him for two more fours in a 15-run over. He then tore into Avesh Khan, starting his first over with three consecutive fours and finishing it by going 6, 4, 6 to bring up his half-century off 19 deliveries.

Ashwin struck in the final over of the powerplay when Fraser-McGurk thrashed a low full toss straight to cover. Shai Hope was then run-out at the non-striker's end as Sandeep Sharma got a hand to deflect Porel's straight drive on to the stumps.

But Porel did not let DC's momentum slip, racing to a 28-ball half-century of his own. He took on Riyan Parag and Yuzvendra Chahal to keep the boundaries coming. Even after Axar Patel fell in the tenth over, Porel took 27 runs off the next two overs. But in the 13th, he became Ashwin's third victim of the night.

Stubbs provides the finish

When Rishabh Pant fell to Yuzvendra Chahal in the 14th over, DC faced a slowdown as Stubbs began slowly. Between the 14th and 17th overs, DC added just 22 runs with Stubbs

on eight off 11 balls. But Stubbs changed it around when he took on Chahal in the spinner's final over. His assortment of sweeps helped take 16 run off Chahal's final over.

Gulbadin Naib was out to Boult next over, but Impact Player Rasikh Salam hit two scoops to take DC past the 200 mark. Stubbs then hit back-to-back sixes to start the final over to ensure DC finished beyond 220.

Samson stands up to DC's bowlers

Khaleel Ahmed had Yashasvi Jaiswal miscuing to mid-off in the first over of the chase, but Samson kept motoring on in the powerplay. Khaleel, Ishant Sharma and Mukesh all bore the brunt of Samson's assault as he raced to 41 off 16. His runs helped RR finish on a strong 67 for 2 after six overs, losing Jos Buttler to Axar in the penultimate ball of the powerplay.

Kuldeep then gave away just 11 runs off his first two overs as Samson and Parag trudged along in a 36-run stand that came off 31 balls. Salam's slower ball ended the partnership when he castled the in-form Parag for 27.

Samson had made just eight runs off nine balls in the partnership with Parag, and the dismissal appeared to bring out a sense of urgency in the RR captain. A six off a free-hit against Kuldeep that brought up his half-century was followed by two sixes and a four off the next over, bowled by Salam. A 17-run over off Ishant was followed by a wayward one from Khaleel, who bowled four wides in a row.

But with the momentum just shifting towards RR, Mukesh had Samson hole out. Hope took a catch running to his left from long-on and almost tripped himself on to the boundary rope. After the third umpire confirmed that it was indeed out, Samson went to the umpire in protest but had to keep walking.

Kuldeep wraps it up

With RR still ending 60 off 26 balls, Shubham Dubey's big shots off Khaleel briefly gave them hope, but Kuldeep's double-wicket 18th over gave a knockout blow.

He first had Donovan Ferreira trapped lbw off a skiddy delivery that was given not-out initially. Then, he tossed up his final ball of the spell wide outside off stump, and Ashwin miscued his slog. He finished with 2 for 25 in four overs, leaving RR needing 37 off the last 12.

Salam and Mukesh closed it out, and DC moved to fifth on the points table with their third home win in a row.

MATCH 57

Sunrisers Hyderabad 167 for 0 (Head 89*, Abhishek 75*) beat Lucknow Super Giants 165 for 4 (Badoni 55*, Pooran 48*, Bhuvneshwar 2-12) by ten wickets

Sunrisers Hyderabad obliterated Lucknow Super Giants, first stifling them with the new ball and then sensationally chasing down 166 in just 9.4 overs - the highest 10-over score in any T20. The massive win lifted them to No. 3 on the points table with 14 points in 12 matches, and also gave them a much-needed net-run-rate boost. The chase was so brutal that LSG didn't even bother with their Impact Player.

A lot will rightly be spoken of the explosive batting of Travis Head and Abhishek Sharma, who got to their fifties in 16 and 19 balls respectively, putting on a hundred between them inside the powerplay for the second time this IPL, both times the highest powerplay scores in all T20 cricket.

Related

'I'm lost for words' - The Travishek show leaves LSG stunned

Mumbai Indians knocked out after SRH demolish LSG

However, it was with the ball that SRH set up the win. Bhuvneshwar Kumar led the way with figures of 4-0-12-2, conceding only singles, completely shutting down the LSG top order, which scored just 66 in the first 11.2 overs. That the top order had not been enterprising enough was underscored by the unbroken 99-run stand off 52 balls between Ayush Badoni and Nicholas Pooran, which eventually proved to be hopelessly inadequate.

Mumbai Indians were collateral damage on the night, knocked out of contention for the playoffs by this result, the first team at IPL 2024 to be officially out.

Bhuvneshwar gets stuck in

A word about the fear surrounding the SRH batters first. It was that fear which, in part, prompted LSG to bat first. And then they ran into Bhuvneshwar, who was unerring in his length and drew movement off the pitch. Quinton de Kock - 66 off 66 off Bhuvneshwar in T20 cricket overall - managed just 1 off 4 off him, those four balls inclusive of a near-dismissal and his wicket, caught superbly by Nitish Reddy at deep-square leg.

Bhuvneshwar Kumar nailed his match-up against Quinton de Kock•AFP/Getty Images

It was a sensational catch made to look easy as Reddy took it over his head, threw it back in the field of play, stepped out and came back to complete the catch, but Sanvir Singh soon outdid him with a low catch diving forward at mid-on to send back Marcus Stoinis. Bhuvneshwar ended the powerplay with 3-0-7-2. Add Shahbaz Ahmed's 2-0-9-0 to that, and LSG had had their worst powerplay of the year: 27 for 2.

IPL debutant, the Sri Lanka legspinner V Viyaskanth, kept the lid on after the powerplay only for Krunal Pandya to inject some momentum into the innings by hitting Jaydev Unadkat for successive sixes, the tournament's 999th and 1000th. The first one was an

extraordinary straight hook to a head-high slower bouncer over long-on. Little did we know the shot would become a mere footnote by the time the night was done.

Badoni, Pooran rescue LSG

KL Rahul, 29 off 33, perished trying to hit the pace of Pat Cummins, and Krunal was run out by the SRH captain and birthday boy as he tried to steal a single when the boundaries were not coming. It had taken 9.1 overs for the first four of the innings, but Badoni and Pooran found the boundary regularly. Badoni led the charge by moving around in the crease and manipulating the field, getting to a fifty in 28 balls. Pooran joined in towards the end, using the pace of T Natarajan and Cummins. Two of the quickest bowlers on display, Cummins and Natarajan, went for 97 between them.

Ayush Badoni gave LSG a much-needed lift • BCCI

Head, Abhishek deliver the knockout punch

LSG tried to make use of the slow pitch by bowling K Gowtham's offspin to the two left-hand openers, which was a sound-enough plan. With Head and Abhishek, though, plans hardly seem to matter. Head pulled Gowtham away for four in the first over, and Abhishek took down Yash Thakur in the second. Again, even Thakur seemed to be bowling to a sound plan: sweeper cover and deep-square leg, bowl into the pitch, but Abhishek pulled him in front of square. So he put two men back on the leg side, and Abhishek made room and carved him through point. By the time they had reached 25 in two overs, plans ceased to matter at all.

Head and Abhishek just picked their spots and sent the ball there no matter the pace on the ball, no matter the length, no matter the fields. All told, the ball took that journey to the boundary once every second ball. You can take your pick from among Head's kneel-down six into the sight screen, Abhishek's languid pick-up over wide long-on off Badoni's offspin, or his extra-cover drive for six to end the game... But try as you may, you will struggle to find a shot more incredible than Head off-driving Ravi Bishnoi off the back foot for a huge six over long-off.

Head ended up with 89 off 30, and Abhishek, 75 off 28. Gowtham's economy of 14.50 was the best among all the LSG bowlers.

MATCH 58

Royal Challengers Bengaluru 241 for 7 (Kohli 92, Patidar 55, Green 46, Harshal 3-38, Kaverappa 2-36) beat Punjab Kings 181 (Rossouw 61, Shashank 37, Siraj 3-43, Swapnil 2-28, Ferguson 2-29, Karn 2-36) by 60 runs

Virat Kohli's breakneck 92 off 47, plus his spectacular direct hit to run Shashank Singh out, were the basis of Royal Challengers Bengaluru's (RCB's) fourth consecutive win, this time against Punjab Kings (PBKS) in Dharamsala. The result kept RCB's hopes of making the IPL 2024 playoffs alive, if only just, but knocked PBKS out of contention.

RCB batted first and blasted their way to 241 for 7, with Rajat Patidar crashing 55 off 23, and Cameron Green hitting 46 off 27. Both had productive partnerships with Kohli, worth 76 off 32 and 92 off 46 respectively.

In response, PBKS started strong, but RCB's spinners - Karn Sharma and Swapnil Singh - were effective through the early middle overs, dismissing Rilee Rossouw in the ninth, Jitesh Sharma in the 11th, and Liam Livingstone in the 12th.

With the required rate now high above the run rate, it was curtains for PBKS. They ended 181 all out after 17 overs.

The Kohli show, Part I

Kohli anyway started the match as the IPL's highest run-scorer. But having been reprieved on zero, he went on to play one of his best innings of a stellar season, finding boundaries through the covers, through midwicket, and down the ground - his footwork often immaculate.

Though he opened the batting, he didn't have a lot of the strike, facing only 14 balls in the powerplay. But before long he was striking at well over 150, as he found capable partners in Patidar (who was the more aggressive partner in their stand), and then Green.

It was a vintage Kohli innings, full of powerful wristy flicks and hard running, though towards the end he also got his six-hitting game going, finishing with six maximums overall.

He seemed poised to make his second triple-figure score of the season, but sliced a wide Arshdeep Singh delivery and was caught at deep cover in the 18th over.

3:06

Dasgupta: 'Patidar is absolutely brilliant against spin'

The Kohli show, Part II

Kohli's wild gesticulations, it turns out, are not the only expenditure of his energy on the field.

Fourth ball of the 14th over into the PBKS innings, they needed 92 runs off 39 balls, and as long as Shashank was at the crease, they had an outside chance. But that's when Sam Curran dropped one towards midwicket and called for two, and that was when Kohli took off from deep midwicket, speeding towards the ball, swooping on it, and skidding it mid-dive towards the one wicket he had to aim at, and found his target.

Shashank was not as committed to the run as Kohli was to this piece of fielding, and Shashank was centimetres short of his ground, not having put in a dive. He was out for 39 off 19 balls, leaving PBKS 151 for 6. They would end up losing their last five wickets for 30 runs.

Karn Sharma celebrates the wicket of Rilee Rossouw, one of his two victims on the night•BCCI

RCB's spinners make big inroads

Before that Kohli run out, however, legspinner Karn and left-arm spinner Swapnil had made vital strikes as well. Swapnil removed Prabhsimran Singh in the first over of the innings, before coming back in the middle overs to get Liam Livingstone tamely offer a leading edge into the covers.

Karn took two big wickets too. He first had the opposition's best batter Rossouw caught at long-on in the ninth over, and then bowled a big, juicy legbreak that clattered into Jitesh's stumps in the 11th over.

But Punjab Kings had started well...

Although they would fall well short, PBKS did look capable of chasing down 242 at the start. They made 75 in the powerplay, thanks largely to Rossouw, who had clobbered seven fours and a six while the fielding restrictions were in place.

Rossouw continued to blast RCB's seam bowlers in particular, motoring his way to a 21-ball half-century, before Karn eventually got him. Jonny Bairstow's 27 off 16, and Shashank's knock were the other serious contributors.

MATCH 59

Gujarat Titans 231 for 3 (Gill 104, Sai Sudharsan 103, Deshpande 2-33) beat Chennai Super Kings 196 for 8 (Mitchell 63, Moeen 56, Mohit 3-31, Rashid 2-38) by 35 runs

Shubman Gill and B Sai Sudharsan ripped up the Chennai Super Kings (CSK) attack and the record books to keep Gujarat Titans' (GT's) playoff hopes just alive. The result, however, punctured CSK's chances and left them facing a tricky route to the playoffs.

Next up, CSK face a super-quick turnaround: they will meet Rajasthan Royals (RR) on Sunday afternoon at Chepauk. They will then run into a resurgent Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) in their last league fixture, in Bengaluru, on May 18. The defeat to GT means their qualification for the playoffs might come down to net run-rates - CSK, though, still have the best NRR among the three teams with 12 points - and one more defeat could leave the defending champions teetering on the brink.

Related

All the records that Shubman Gill and Sai Sudharsan broke

Stats - Shubman Gill and B Sai Sudharsan take IPL century count past 100

GT captain Gill spent some time off the field in their successful defence of 231 because of cramps. But he had already handsomely contributed with the bat in a 210-run partnership

with Sudharsan - the joint-highest opening stand in the history of the IPL. Along the way, Gill and Sudharsan pushed the IPL century count past 100.

The Gill-Sudharsan opening salvo

Gill and Sudharsan are no Travishek. They are more orthodox top-order batters. But on a bouncy, red-soil Ahmedabad pitch on Friday, they showed that they can be just as destructive with their hitting.

GT fined for slow over rate

GT captain Shubman Gill has been fined INR 24 lakhs after his team maintained a slow over rate during the match against CSK in Ahmedabad. As it was his team's second offence of the season under IPL's Code of Conduct relating to minimum over rate offences, the rest of the members of the playing XI, including the Impact Player, were each individually fined either INR 6 lakhs or 25% of their respective match fees.

It was Gill who made the early running when he took left-arm fingerspinner Mitchell Santner for a four and a six in a 14-run opening over. Then, in the final over of the powerplay, Gill played what was arguably the shot of the day. When Simarjeet Singh bowled a blameless back-of-a-length delivery on off, Gill used his gifts to make it look like a bad ball and imperiously swatted it over mid-on for six.

Sudharsan, becalmed in the early exchanges, then caught fire, whacking Ravindra Jadeja for 21 off seven balls at a strike rate of 300. The presence of the spin-hitting Sudharsan meant Jadeja could not bowl more than two overs on the night. Ruturaj Gaikwad turned to Daryl Mitchell's cutters, but he was dispatched for 4-0-52-0.

Sudharsan accelerated so quickly that he and his captain had identical scores at the end of the 16th over: 96 off 48 balls. Gill was the first to bring up his hundred with a four, and four balls later, Sudharsan joined him there with a six.

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Deshpande, Thakur limit damage at the death

In the next over, however, Tushar Deshpande had both Sudharsan and Gill holing out in the space of five balls.

Deshpande could have cut short Gill's innings on 72 had he not dropped him at the long-off boundary - he ended up parrying it onto the rope for six. But he came back strong at the death with his defensive skills on show, with Shardul Thakur for company.

They kept hiding the ball away from the swinging arcs of the GT batters and allowed them to score only 41 runs off the last five overs. Only one boundary was scored off the last three overs, but the chase was always going to be a tall order for CSK.

CSK fail to maximise the powerplay

It became even more difficult for CSK when they were reduced to 2 for 2 within two overs. Rachin Ravindra, who was brought back into the team to beef up the top order, was run out for 1. On the very next ball, Sandeep Warrier bested Ajinkya Rahane in the battle of the Impact Players. Rahane fell for one off five balls.

Captain Gaikwad, who had slid down to No. 3, then picked out one of the only two men on the boundary, off Umesh Yadav for a duck. The early strikes prevented CSK from taking more risks and they managed only 43 for 3 in the powerplay.

Mitchell, Moeen turn up the tempo

Mitchell then gave the chase a leg-up by repeatedly pumping the ball over the top. He even went after GT's ace spinner Rashid Khan, taking him for 18 off seven balls.

At the other end, Moeen struggled to pick Rashid's variations but he lined up Noor Ahmad, the left-arm wristspinner, and tonked him for three successive sixes to start the 11th over.

Mohit Sharma removed Daryl Mitchell, and then Moeen Ali •BCCI

Mohit closes it out for GT

At 119 for 3 in 12 overs, CSK were in with a chance until Mohit Sharma's intervention. Mohit struck with his second ball, a well-disguised knuckle ball, which tricked Mitchell into skying a catch to long-off for 63 off 34 balls. In his next over, he dug an on-pace delivery into the surface and had Moeen holing out for 56 off 36 balls.

Mohit also snagged Shivam Dube for 21 off 13 balls and came away with 3 for 31 - the best figures on the day.

When GT and CSK last met at this venue, in a three-day IPL final last season, Mohit couldn't get the job done. On Friday, though, his execution was so good that CSK fell well short, despite MS Dhoni's cameo at the end.

MATCH 60

Kolkata Knight Riders 157 for 7 (Venkatesh 42, Rana 33, Chawla 2-28, Bumrah 2-39) beat Mumbai Indians 139 for 8 (Kishan 40, Tilak 32, Chakravarthy 2-17, Russell 2-34, Harshit 2-34) by 18 runs

On an evening that started with the ball swinging around like a boomerang following plenty of rain in Kolkata, Kolkata Knight Riders' spin twins - Varun Chakravarthy and Sunil Narine - stifled Mumbai Indians' chase to seal a playoffs berth for their side, with an almost-certain finish in the top two as well.

After MI were set 158 runs in 16 overs, Varun and Narine started the strangle that saw MI score just 22 runs in the five overs after the powerplay for two wickets that mounted the pressure on the visitors.

Suryakumar Yadav and Tim David had no choice but to go after the quicks and fell to Andre Russell's variations that saw MI stumble to 92 for 5 and there was no coming back from there, barring a late cameo from Tilak Varma. He reduced the equation to 22 required from the six balls, but his wicket early in the last over eventually handed MI their ninth loss in 13 matches.

Ramandeep fined for code of conduct breach

KKR batter Ramandeep Singh has been fined 20% of his match fees for breaching the IPL Code of Conduct during the match against MI. Ramandeep committed a Level 1 offence under Article 2.20, which covers all types of conduct that's contrary to the spirit of the game. He admitted to the offence and accepted the match referee's sanction.

After rain had delayed the start of the game by an hour and 45 minutes, the match was reduced to 16 overs a side. Even though KKR lost their openers early, Venkatesh Iyer and some lower-order hitting powered them to 157, which may have seemed short early on but proved to be enough.

The strangle from Narine and Varun

Rohit Sharma was struggling for runs and scored at under run a ball in the first six overs. So the onus of hitting was on Ishan Kishan who flat-batted his way to 37 off 17 in the powerplay (which was five overs for this game). He largely peppered the square boundaries, the highlight being a four with a reverse hit followed by a six with a pull at the end of the powerplay to take MI to 59.

Varun Chakravarthy celebrates after getting Rohit Sharma out • AFP/Getty Images

But Narine was ready with his riposte in his next over and had Kishan hole out for 40. With the spin on from both ends that featured a lot of stump-to-stump bowling and 17 consecutive boundary-less balls, Rohit's struggle ended on 19. Suryakumar Yadav and Tilak also hardly attacked the spinners and the equation soon became 77 required from 36.

Russell then got the ball. His scrambled seam snared Suryakumar and the slower ball removed David. In between, Varun had Hardik Pandya caught for 2 to add to MI's woes.

The equations like 57 needed from 18 have become all the more achievable in this IPL, and Tilak kept MI's flame burning when he took on Harshit Rana in the 14th over for 16 runs by dispatching his slower ones to the ropes. No. 8 Naman Dhir took inspiration from Tilak to smash Russell for a couple of sixes and a four for a 19-run over that brought MI back in the game. With 22 needed from six, Dhir and Tilak fell in the first three deliveries of the last over, which sealed MI's fate.

There's always some Bumrah magic

You didn't have to guess that the KKR openers would come out all guns blazing in this shortened game. Phil Salt kicked off the innings with a first-ball six against Nuwan Thushara

but fell in the same over. From the other end, Bumrah showed some magic Narine had no answer for.

Bumrah's first ball was a yorker that tailed in just a bit at the end from outside off. Narine, who had shouldered arms to it, was flabbergasted by the late movement that took the base of the off stump. It was Narine's first duck of this IPL.

Proactive Venkatesh takes charge

The ball was swinging and troubling the batters in overcast conditions. After the hard-hitting openers were dismissed back and Russell was yet to walk out, Venkatesh took charge of the innings. He went down the track, rocked back to pull the short balls, and used his reach to score 25 off 10 in the powerplay. It also included 14 off five balls against Bumrah.

Venkatesh enjoyed some luck too, as edges evaded the fielders and his proactive approach helped KKR collect 77 in the first eight overs, all bowled by fast bowlers.

Chawla vs Russell hogs the limelight

But spin struck first ball when Piyush Chawla had Venkatesh hole out for 42 off 21. Out walked Russell and smoked Chawla over his head for a six and a four in his next two overs, along with a drill through the covers. Chawla moved his field around, stationed a fielder at the rope right behind the umpire for the straight hit and varied his pace even beyond 110kph while Russell took KKR past 100. After being hit for another six in the 13th over, this time by Rinku Singh, Chawla had the last laugh as Russell skied a 117kph thunderbolt to deep midwicket.

Thushara and Bumrah then sent down a flurry of yorkers in the last two overs and it was only because of a six each from Rinku and Ramandeep Singh that KKR crossed 150.

MATCH 61

Chennai Super Kings 145 for 5 (Gaikwad 42*, Ashwin 2-35) beat Rajasthan Royals 141 for 5 (Parag 47*, Simarjeet 3-26, Deshpande 2-30) by five wickets

Chennai Super Kings signed off their home league campaign with a win, giving themselves a decent chance of coming back to Chennai for the last two playoff games. Despite losing their 11th toss out of 13 and being asked to field in the afternoon heat 40 hours after finishing their last match in Ahmedabad, the CSK bowlers used a slow pitch expertly to keep Rajasthan Royals down to 141, which they chased down with relative ease.

The slow pitch was right up the home bowlers' alley, and they kept Royals quiet in a wicketless powerplay after which Simarjeet Singh kept getting wickets every time Royals tried to push back. Royals never really succeeded in mounting an attack, which CSK's New Zealand batters, Rachin Ravindra and Daryl Mitchell, successfully did to put their chase on course with a Shivam Dube putting them on top.

Related

The CSK remix ft. Simarjeet Singh

Samson: Losses make it 'challenging to focus on the controllables'

As it happened - Royals slip to third straight defeat

The win took CSK up to 14 points from 13 matches, level with Sunrisers Hyderabad who have a game in hand, and two points clear of the nearest challengers outside the top four. Royals suffered their third straight defeat, which will be a cause for concern for them going into the playoffs, especially with Jos Buttler not expected to be available for the final week.

RR's power-less-play

These are the two slowest teams in the first two overs of the IPL. They like to suss the pitch out before they start attacking. Royals stayed true to form, scoring just seven off the first two, but they couldn't kick on even after that with Tushar Deshpande, Maheesh Theekshana and Shardul Thakur giving them nothing to drive. Their 42 for 0 was the slowest wicketless powerplay of IPL 2024, one run behind their 43 for 0 against Punjab Kings, but that came in a small chase.

Simarjeet Singh exults after dismissing Jos Buttler•BCCI

Simarjeet cashes in

Usually CSK go to Ravindra Jadeja in the seventh over, but perhaps because of the right-left combination, which didn't let their orthodox spinners bowl in their last match against Gujarat Titans, they bowled Simarjeet in the seventh over. Playing only his third match this year, Simarjeet had ground to make up after going for 60 in that Titans match. On this slow pitch, he was immediately on target: hard lengths and no room. When Yashasvi Jaiswal tried to take him on, the ball got big on him and resulted in a skier to cover. In his next over, Simarjeet became the beneficiary of an odd shot from a frustrated Buttler: a ramp on a slow pitch with fine leg back on the fence.

With Royals' only left-hand top-order batter gone, Jadeja rattled through his four overs for just 24 runs to go with Theekshana's four overs for 28. Sanju Samson just kept looking for singles while Riyan Parag tried the odd boundary. It seemed as if Royals had decided they needed to get somewhere around 160 and not aim too high.

The final kick doesn't arrive

Even to get to 160, they would need two a ball for the last six overs after getting to 89 for 2 in 14 overs, which is when the spinners bowled out. Royals were banking on cashing in on pace, but just when they tried to go hard they handed Simarjeet another wicket: Samson caught at mid-off. Again Royals were pushed back.

Deshpande and Thakur stuck to their plans in the death overs, and Royals never got the big overs. Only Parag's 47 off 35 took them to 141, which was 23 less than the lowest total successfully defended in this IPL. Royals attacked just 30 balls in their innings, the sixth-lowest figure this season in non-all-out innings when setting a target.

Shivam Dube played a crucial cameo after CSK had gone 39 balls without a boundary•Associated Press

Ravindra, Mitchell get chase going

CSK have been the only team slower than Royals in the early goings but they were mindful of not letting the bowlers settle into their defence. Ravindra flicked Sandeep Sharma for a six over midwicket in the second over, and went after compatriot Trent Boult in the third. Even though R Ashwin got Ravindra out in the fourth, Mitchell kept up the intent. Their 56 for 1 was their fourth-highest powerplay of this IPL.

Royals claw back but Dube breaks chase open

In the middle overs, Royals clawed their way back. Yuzvendra Chahal got Mitchell, the spinners kept Moeen Ali and Ruturaj Gaikwad quiet, Moeen got out for 10 off 13, and 39 balls went without a boundary. Still it was 50 needed off seven overs. This was when Ashwin came on to bowl his last over with Dube on strike. Dube took the veteran spinner on for 6, 4, 4, with a leg-side wide in between, and while Ashwin came back with Dube's wicket, CSK needed 35 off the last six.

Captain Gaikwad stayed true to his anchor role for this chase, and saw his team home despite Jadeja getting himself out obstructing the field.

MATCH 62

Royal Challengers Bengaluru 187 for 9 (Patidar 52, Jacks 41, Salam 2-23, Khaleel 2-31) beat Delhi Capitals 140 (Axar 57, Dayal 3-20, Ferguson 2-23) by 47 runs

A fifth successive win not only kept Royal Challengers Bengaluru in contention for a playoffs spot but also lifted them to fifth spot on the points table, just above Delhi Capitals who have the same points as RCB but an inferior net run rate.

The M Chinnaswamy had gone all quiet when RCB lost Faf du Plessis and Virat Kohli inside four overs. It seemed their batting troubles from the start of the season had come back to haunt them. Will Jacks and Rajat Patidar put to rest any such worries with a counter-attacking partnership, but the DC bowlers struck back with a near-perfect death-overs show to restrict RCB to 187 for 9.

With the Bengaluru crowd firmly behind them, the RCB bowlers had their tails up. They reduced DC to 30 for 4, which included the massive wicket of Jake Fraser-McGurk, who was run out at the non-striker's end after a straight drive from Shai Hope deflected off Yash Dayal's fingers onto the stumps.

The Kohli-Ishant duel lights up the start

In his 250th IPL outing, Kohli had a relatively easy opponent first up: Ishant Sharma, against whom he had scored 93 off 67 balls without being dismissed. He kept out a sharp inswinger on the first ball of the match and then pulled one over square leg for a six on the last ball of the opening over.

Ishant Sharma had the last laugh in his duel against Virat Kohli•BCCI

In Ishant's next over, he hit a four - via an outside edge - and a crisply-timed no-look shot over wide long-on for a six off successive balls before nicking one behind to the wicketkeeper. With a 13-ball 27, Kohli made his intent clear but failed to do justice to the Midas touch he seemed to be in.

Patidar and Jacks make DC pay

Before Sunday, Patidar had been dismissed by pace in eight of his 11 outings in IPL 2024. But here, he raced to 15 off eight balls with the help of three fours in a Mukesh Kumar over. When Axar Patel, the stand-in captain for DC, brought himself on in the sixth over, Patidar duly slogged him over deep midwicket. He also tore into Kuldeep Yadav, bashing him straight over his head.

At the other end, Jacks also hit Kuldeep for a six in each of his first two overs as RCB put the dismissals of their openers behind them. Thanks to the assault from Patidar and Jacks, RCB scored 49 in the four overs after the powerplay. In the process, Patidar brought up his fourth half-century in his last five innings, and his first in Bengaluru this season. That the fielders missed four chances in 11 balls, including two dropped catches in a Kuldeep over, did not help DC.

DC fight back through Khaleel, Salam

DC brought Rasikh Salam on in the 11th over and he could have dismissed Patidar first ball but Axar failed to hang on at cover. But Salam exacted revenge in his next over with a hard-length ball. Patidar looked to force it over the off side off the front foot but ended up miscuing it towards cover, where Axar moved to his right to pouch that. That brought curtains to his 88-run stand with Jacks, who fell soon after to Kuldeep.

Khaleel Ahmed came away with 4-0-31-2•BCCI

But Mahipal Lomror and Cameron Green combined to take 22 off Kuldeep's final over, the 17th of the innings, to raise RCB's hopes. Khaleel Ahmed, who was taken for 23 in his first two overs, struck twice in three balls in the 18th over to dismiss Lomror and Dinesh Karthik. He finished with figures of 2 for 31 from his four overs. Salam got rid of Swapnil Singh and returned 2 for 23 from his three. DC conceded only 40 in the last four overs, and picked up five wickets, to keep RCB under 200 on a surface where the ball was gripping.

Axar fights a lone battle

Fraser-McGurk played true to his form and struck left-arm spinner Swapnil for a massive six over wide long-off to get going. Among those who have faced at least 30 balls of spin in IPL 2024, no batter strikes it higher than Fraser-McGurk's 262.85. But a lucky break for RCB meant the DC opener walked back cheaply.

This was after David Warner, back in the side after missing four matches, was out for 1 off two. Dayal had bounced out Abishek Porel cheaply. It was only the second time this season that RCB picked up four wickets inside the powerplay - earlier, they had done so against Sunrisers Hyderabad.

In the middle overs, RCB seamers had a clear plan of hitting the good length and denying the batters room to free their arms. Between overs eight and 11, they bowled 16 deliveries on either good length or just short of it, and gave away just 15 runs off them.

Only Axar, leading for the first time in the IPL, managed to offer some resistance with his second half-century of the season. He bookended Jacks' only over with sixes to bring up his fifty off 30 balls. But long before he top-edged Dayal over backward point, where du Plessis back-tracked and took a tumbling catch, the result was a foregone conclusion.

MATCH 63

Match abandoned without a ball bowled Gujarat TITans vs Kolkata Knight Riders

A combination of lightning and rain forced the first abandoned game of IPL 2024 in Ahmedabad on Monday, and in the process confirmed two things: Kolkata Knight Riders' top-two finish in the league stage and Gujarat Titans' elimination from playoff contention.

Only a win could've kept eighth-placed GT in the hunt, but rain did not even allow for a toss. Such was the storm's intensity that some floodlights were also affected; banners in the stadium that got torn earlier ended up wrapping the floodlights in such a way that they needed to be manually removed.

GT's task was uphill anyway. With the season's lowest net run-rate of -1.063, they were only mathematically alive as even two big wins in their last two games could've still left them short. KKR were almost assured of a top-two finish courtesy their dominating net run-rate of 1.428 after 12 games, but a 19th point in their tally sealed that.

This is the first time that GT have not qualified for the IPL playoffs since they joined the competition before the 2022 season. They have a consolation game against Sunrisers Hyderabad next on May 16.

Monday's game could've given KKR a chance to ease Rahmanullah Gurbaz, the wicketkeeper-batter, into the XI. Gurbaz is the likely replacement in their XI once Phil Salt leaves to join his national team camp.

For KKR, their next aim is to finish the league stage at No. 1, something they have never achieved before. If they beat Rajasthan Royals in their last league game on Sunday, they are

assured of that. They would also be assured of No. 1 if RR fail to collect two wins in their last two matches, which includes the KKR fixture.

Even if KKR do not finish first, they wouldn't mind it much. The only two times they finished second on the IPL points table (2012 and 2014), they ended up as IPL champions.

MATCH 64

Delhi Capitals 208 for 4 (Porel 58, Stubbs 57, Naveen-ul-Haq 2-51) beat Lucknow Super Giants 189 for 9 (Pooran 61, Arshad 58*, Ishant 3-34) by 19 runs

Delhi Capitals signed off the league stage with a 19-run win over Lucknow Super Giants in Delhi, and kept themselves in contention for a top-four finish, even if only mathematically. LSG, with one more game left against Mumbai Indians, aren't out of the running either, but both teams will have to depend on other results to go their way if they are to make the top four.

From 44 for 4 in a chase of 209, LSG took the contest to the last over thanks to Nicholas Pooran's 61 and Arshad Khan's unbeaten 58 from No.8 . However, Rasikh Salam defended 22 off the final over to hand DC their seventh victory of IPL 2024.

On a high-scoring surface, DC had to post 200 or above to have a shot at collecting two points. After being asked to bat, Abishek Porel and Tristan Stubbs shone with fifties to power DC to 208 for 4. With the ball, Ishant Sharma ripped through LSG early on with three wickets and even though Pooran and Arshad tried their best, LSG kept losing wickets at the other end and eventually fell short.

Hope and Porel's powerplay

DC lost their aggressive opener Jake Fraser-McGurk in the first over when he was caught at long-on off the left-arm quick Arshad. But Porel and Shai Hope didn't let the wicket slow them down. After smashing six off Mohsin Khan, Porel pummeled three fours and a six in Arshad's second over. In the following over, Hope targeted Yuvraj Singh and hit 4,4, and 6. By the end of four overs, DC had raced to 51 for 1. The duo didn't spare Naveen-ul-Haq either as he ended up conceding 17 runs off his first over. DC ended the powerplay on 73 for 1, with Porel batting on 43 off 16.

The middle-overs slowdown

Porel raced to his fifty in 21 balls but hit only eight runs off his next 12 balls, thanks to LSG's spinners who exerted pressure in the middle overs. Rahul brought in Ravi Bishnoi immediately after the powerplay and bowled Krunal Pandya and Deepak Hooda from the other end. Bishnoi broke the 92-run second-wicket stand between Porel and Hope in the ninth over, when Hope thrashed a full-length wide delivery straight to cover, where Rahul took a stunning low catch to dismiss him for a 27-ball 38. After only 17 came off the next 15 balls, Porel fell to Naveen's slower ball, trying to go big. Bishnoi finished with 1 for 26 from his four overs, as DC accumulated just 42 runs from overs 7 to 12.

The Delhi Capitals players make their feelings clear after getting Nicholas Pooran out•BCCI

Stubbs blitz lifts DC

After 15 overs, DC were 136 for 3 and the 200 mark looked far away. But they still had Stubbs. After scoring seven off his first nine deliveries, he took off, first smashing Arshad for two fours and a six in the 16th over and then Naveen for two sixes and a four in the 19th to get to his fifty in 22 balls. His unbeaten 57 off 25, and a quickfire 33 from Rishabh Pant, lifted DC to 208 for 4, with 72 runs coming off the final five overs.

Ishant rips through LSG

Ishant, the Impact Player, made an impact straightaway, removing three big guns - Quinton de Kock, KL Rahul and Deepak Hooda - in his first three overs. Axar Patel's dismissal of Marcus Stoinis - stumped by Pant - meant LSG were reeling at 44 for 4 in no time.

Pooran's counter-attacking fifty

Despite the early blows, LSG were still in the game thanks to Pooran's big hitting. He hit Axar for 4, 6, 4, 6 just after the left-arm spinner had removed Stoinis off his first ball. He went on to smash four more fours and two more sixes after that over - this included a reverse-sweep over extra cover for a six off Kuldeep Yadav. At the halfway stage, LSG were 97 for 5. Pooran, however, fell to Mukesh Kumar's slower short ball, angled away from his hitting arc, slicing it to Axar at extra cover to depart for a 27-ball 61. At 101 for 6, it seemed like LSG had lost control of the chase.

Arshad goes bang, bang

There was more entertainment when Arshad came out all guns blazing. Striking at 175.5, the left-hand batter muscled five sixes and three fours to keep LSG in the game till the very end. His unbeaten knock brought down the equation to 29 off the last 12. But Mukesh and Rasikh finished with two excellent overs at the death, denying him any more boundaries, and LSG fell 19 short of DC's total.

MATCH 65

Punjab Kings 145 for 5 (Curran 63*, Avesh 2-28, Chahal 2-31) beat Rajasthan Royals 144 for 9 (Parag 48, Ashwin 28, Curran 2-24, Chahar 2-26, Harshal 2-28) by five wickets

Form can change quickly in T20s, and in a league like IPL the non-stop action can quickly turn the tide too. Rajasthan Royals (RR) became the second team to prove that in this IPL after Royal Challengers Bengaluru. But unlike RCB, who have won five matches straight, RR have now lost four in a row after winning as many on the bounce to hurt their chances of a top-two finish.

The latest loss came in Guwahati, where Sam Curran and the rest of the Punjab Kings (PBKS) bowlers combined to first restrict RR to 144. Curran, who picked up 2 for 24, led PBKS'

charge with the bat with an unbeaten 63 to complete the chase with seven balls and five wickets to spare. That, after PBKS had slipped to 48 for 4 in eight overs.

Curran's heroics spoiled local boy Riyan Parag's day, who scored 48, exactly one-third of RR's total.

Curran rings in the changes

Sanju Samson had opted to bat in the first game at the Barsapara Stadium this IPL. And after four overs, the game wasn't going either ways, with RR on 31 for 1. Curran had Yashasvi Jaiswal chopping on off the fourth ball of the day after the first one was driven through cover for four.

Samson hit three boundaries off his first eight balls, with a punch off Arshdeep Singh from the full face of the bat. At the other end, Tom Kohler-Cadmore, who came in for Jos Buttler, had started rather sedately.

Curran then introduced Nathan Ellis for the fifth over. Ellis bowled cutters on a slow pitch where the ball seemed to stop, and even banged some on a hard length to test the batters. And that is when RR slowed down. The next 3.2 overs went for only 11 runs, with both Samson and Kohler-Cadmore departing for 18.

Parag, Ashwin fight in middle overs

PBKS bowled ten dot balls in three overs, starting with the sixth one. While Ellis and Harshal Patel used the variations to great effect, Rahul Chahar found turn. With two right-hand batters in Parag and R Ashwin at the crease, Curran gave the ninth over to left-arm spinner Harpreet Brar. But Ashwin managed a streaky boundary to get ten off the over.

RR had only 68 on the board after 11 overs, when Ashwin counterattacked. He slogged Chahar over midwicket for six, before reverse sweeping and lofting him over the covers for four. But Arshdeep ended Ashwin's party in the next over by having him caught at deep point after an entertaining 28 from 19 balls.

Riyan Parag fell two short of a half-century•BCCI

Parag, though, continued to fight, even as RR were 102 for 6 midway into the 15th over. By then, Curran had removed Dhruv Jurel for a duck, while Chahar had Rovman Powell caught and bowled for 4. The death overs (17-20) began with RR on 113, before Parag walloped and sliced Arshdeep for consecutive fours.

PBKS denied Parag the strike in the entire 19th over. Come the 20th, Harshal trapped Parag for 48 with his trademark dipping, slow full toss, as the Purple Cap switched heads again, with Harshal finishing the day on 22 wickets, two ahead of Jasprit Bumrah.

Curran, Jitesh spoil RR's top-two chances

No. 6 Jitesh Sharma had joined Curran at the crease after RR slowed the chase down. Despite Rilee Rossouw counterattacking after the early loss of Prabhsimran Singh - it was an IPL record 28th time that Trent Boult had struck in the first over - RR had PBKS at 37 for 3 after five overs. When Yuzvendra Chahal had Jonny Bairstow caught at long-on for a scratchy 14 off 22, PBKS were reeling at 48 for 4.

But Jitesh and Curran didn't allow RR to run away with the game just yet. Jitesh pulled his second ball for six, before Curran managed a lucky four off the bottom edge off Chahal. They kept ticking over singles while also finding the occasional boundary, with Curran swiping Chahal wide of long-on, swatting Ashwin to deep extra cover, and whipping Boult behind square, all in consecutive overs.

The required rate had risen up to 9.33 an over with six overs left, when both Jitesh and Curran pumped a six each off Ashwin. But Jitesh was caught off Chahal in the next over, before PBKS brought on Ashutosh Sharma as an Impact Sub, and the match was soon over.

Ashutosh ramped Avesh for four, before Curran and Ashutosh smashed three sixes in the space of five balls to level scores and soon seal victory.

MATCH 66

Sunrisers Hyderabad vs Gujarat Titans Match abandoned without a ball bowled

Sunrisers Hyderabad sealed a place in the playoffs of IPL 2024, with one point from their washed-out game against Gujarat Titans ensuring they will finish the league stage in the top four. They now have 15 points with one game remaining, against Punjab Kings on May 19.

It was their first playoff qualification since IPL 2020, after finishing last in the league in 2021 and 2023, and in eighth place in 2022.

SRH's hopes of a top-two finish, however, took a hit. They can still achieve it - they need to beat PBKS and hope that Rajasthan Royals, who currently have 16 points, lose their last league game against table-toppers Kolkata Knight Riders - but it is no longer entirely within their hands.

GT's campaign came to a gloomy end, with their last two matches - against KKR at home on May 13 and this one in Hyderabad - washed out without a ball bowled. They finished the season with 12 points, which currently puts them third from bottom, but they could slip down one place if PBKS beat SRH.

The Rajiv Gandhi International Stadium was under covers for most of Thursday evening. A brief dry spell led to the announcement of an 8pm toss and an 8.15pm start, but rain returned almost immediately, and did not let up in any meaningful way thereafter. The match was called off at 10.10pm, two hours and 40 minutes after its scheduled start.

MATCH 67

Lucknow Super Giants 214 for 6 (Pooran 75, Rahul 55, Thushara 3-28, Chawla 3-29) beat Mumbai Indians 196 for 6 (Rohit 68, Dhir 62*, Bishnoi 2-37, Naveen 2-50) by 18 runs

On a bittersweet evening for Mumbai Indians (MI) fans at the Wankhede Stadium, a high-octane Rohit Sharma fifty gave them something to be happy about, but they also saw their side slump to their tenth defeat of the season to finish bottom of the points table.

The victors, Lucknow Super Giants (LSG), too, were left with a what-could-have-been feeling as their seventh win of the season took them to the important landmark of 14 points, but a straggling net run-rate of -0.667 left them just outside the top four. In any case, despite scoring 214 batting first, LSG needed an impossible margin of victory to get their NRR where it would have been useful.

On the night, it was Nicholas Pooran who rescued LSG from a familiar situation. With their top order struggling again, his 29-ball 75 brought life to a sluggish innings against an inexperienced MI attack that played without Jasprit Bumrah, Arjun Tendulkar his replacement.

MI began the chase in dazzling fashion on the back of Rohit's barrage of boundaries on either side of a short rain delay, but they slid from 88 for no loss to 120 for 5 in the middle overs, effectively ending their chances of putting up a realistic fight.

The result meant MI, under new captain Hardik Pandya, finished last for the second time in three seasons. LSG will end up missing the playoffs for the first time in their three-season history.

3:21

McClenaghan: Rahul could have gone harder

Pooran goes 360!

LSG gave Devdutt Padikkal another go this season at the top. But he finished the way he had started, with a duck.

Nuwan Thushara got the new ball to sling into Padikkal, and Tendulkar too troubled No. 3 Marcus Stoinis early with the swinging delivery. Piyush Chawla also kept LSG quiet enough to prise out Stoinis and Deepak Hooda in quick succession, and at 69 for 3 in the tenth over, LSG's innings was moving without direction.

But Pooran changed that, even masking KL Rahul's inability to get quick runs. As Rahul moved to only 40 in his first 33 balls, Pooran bashed 22 runs off Anshul Kamboj's 12th over, and then hit consecutive sixes off Hardik in the 13th.

He saved his best for the 14th when Tendulkar's first two balls went for 12, and after an injury forced the bowler to leave the field, replacement bowler Naman Dhir got pummelled for two sixes. That over went for 29.

Not all of Pooran's shots were pretty, but he rode his luck. Even though he and Rahul fell as part of three wickets in three balls, their partnership and the late assault from Ayush Badoni (22 in ten balls) gave LSG 214 for 6.

1:59

A season to forget for Hardik Pandya and Mumbai Indians

Rohit finishes on a high

Rohit came into the match with scores of 6, 8, 4, 11, 4 and 19. Among India's batters for the T20 World Cup, he was the most out of form. But, on his way out of the season, Rohit batted the way he was expected to when captaincy was taken away from him at the start of IPL 2024.

He hit boundaries on either side of the wicket alongside new opening partner Dewald Brevis to get MI off the blocks early in the 215 chase. He also made up for a streaky early boundary to hit Matt Henry for sixes over midwicket and long-off in the second over.

Then, through the fifth, sixth, and seventh overs, Rohit enjoyed the pace-on deliveries and hammered Mohsin Khan and Naveen-ul-Haq for six fours and a six in the space of 18 balls. It got him to his fifty in 28 balls and put MI ahead in the chase.

Krunal, Bishnoi trigger collapse

But MI and Rohit found themselves in a squeeze as the LSG spinners came on. Krunal Pandya and Ravi Bishnoi, occasional boundaries aside, made an impact with tidy spells to slow MI down. The two of them also took sharp outfield catches to help LSG's cause.

After holding on to a spectacular sliding catch at long-off to dismiss Brevis in the ninth over off Naveen, Krunal got Suryakumar Yadav sweeping to deep third for a three-ball duck in the tenth over. Bishnoi, who took the tough juggling catch for that Suryakumar dismissal, then had Rohit slicing to Mohsin at short third in the 11th.

Hardik couldn't do much, and Nehal Wadhwa then became Bishnoi's second victim. All told, the six overs Bishnoi and Krunal bowled between eight and 17 gave away 44 runs and netted three wickets.

2:36

McClenaghan: 'Piyush has probably bowled himself to a contract in IPL 2025'

Dhir shows his worth

With Ishan Kishan looking off-colour from No. 4, MI's game looked done after Wadhwa's dismissal in the 15th over. But Dhir gave the home fans some positives for next season with a dazzling unbeaten 28-ball 62 that took MI to 196.

His second boundary of the evening, a scoop off a short ball behind the keeper, showed off his intent, and he followed it up with more big shots.

The three sixes in the space of five balls across the 19th and 20th overs gave MI a bit of hope, but another spectacular fielding effort from Krunal on the boundary line stopped a second six to start the final over, and that took the wind out of the chase.

MATCH 68

Royal Challengers Bengaluru 218 for 5 (Du Plessis 54, Kohli 47, Patidar 41, Green 38, Thakur 2-61) beat Chennai Super Kings 191 for 7 (Ravindra 61, Jadeja 42*, Dayal 4-42) by 27 runs

Virat Kohli was nearly in tears. Faf du Plessis could not contain his joy. MS Dhoni was nowhere to be seen after the game. All of it summed up the drama of the night in Bengaluru, as Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) won their sixth game on the trot in IPL 2024 to knock Chennai Super Kings (CSK) out and make the playoffs.

RCB have been in this situation many times - needing a win in their last league match to make it to the knockouts. They were at the same venue last year, where they managed to post a tall score featuring a Kohli century, only for a Shubman Gill ton to overshadow it all and knock them out. On Saturday, they found themselves in a similar situation again.

RCB were asked to bat first. They posted 218 and needed to win by at least 18 runs to knock CSK out. They were helped by blazing starts from Kohli and du Plessis with cameos from Rajat Patidar and Cameron Green.

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[How du Plessis-Kohli masterclass revived RCB after rain break](#)

[Yash Dayal's year - stung by Rinku to stinging CSK](#)

[Du Plessis: 'I dedicate the Man of the Match to Yash Dayal'](#)

[Stats - RCB do six in a row, and Kohli does it in sixes](#)

[Ball-by-ball - Ferguson and Dayal deny Dhoni and Jadeja in dramatic finish](#)

CSK came within touching distance. They needed 10 off the last two balls to qualify with Ravindra Jadeja, the batter who hit a six and four to win CSK their fifth title last year, on strike. But Yash Dayal bowled two off-pace length balls to deny Jadeja and CSK. This was after being taken for a massive six on the first ball of the last over by MS Dhoni, and then using the back-of-the-hand slower one to have him caught at deep square leg.

CSK hopes dipped at that moment and RCB never let them back.

[Kohli, du Plessis and the rain break](#)

Kohli has reinvented himself this season like none other. He is leading not just the pack of run-scorers this season (708) but also that of six-hitters with 37 to his name. Tushar Deshpande delivered a couple of length ball that he duly deposited into the stands. Du Plessis also struck one off Shardul Thakur when rain hit pause on RCB's charge at 31 for 0 in three overs.

The 40-minute intervention seemed to have changed the track, with both Maheesh Theekshana and Mitchell Santner bowling seven dots in the two overs since resumption. RCB finished the powerplay at 42 for none, their joint-lowest score this season alongside the 42 for 3 they made against CSK in the season opener.

Kohli tried to break the shackles with sixes off Santner and Ravindra Jadeja but holed out to wide long-on. Du Plessis, though, hit two sixes and a four of a Jadeja over to get to a 35-ball fifty after being on 29 off 28 at one point.

Patidar, Green and a tall finish

That Patidar takes down spin is an open secret, and he proved it with a massive hit over long-off off Theekshana, who was the most economical CSK bowler. But he loves playing fast bowlers more. And that facet came to the fore with the ease he hit Simarjeet Singh for a four and six off successive balls. He continued his unhindered strokeplay against Deshpande and Thakur to super-charge RCB's progress, along with Green, who showed his power game to full effect.

Green slapped Simarjeet through point before hammering Theekshana straight down the ground. He then hit Thakur for back-to-back sixes as RCB crossed 200 for the sixth time this season, becoming the third team to do so in an IPL season.

The result? CSK leaked 63 at the death (overs 17 to 20), the most they conceded in the phase in the entire season. The presence of dew meant they were not able to grip the ball and use the assistance the pitch had, especially when off-pace length balls were dug in.

Dinesh Karthik and Mohammed Siraj celebrate RCB's win • BCCI

Ravindra and Jadeja, the bright spots in the chase

After Glenn Maxwell, brought back in place of Will Jacks, struck first ball to have Ruturaj Gaikwad caught at short fine leg. Dayal then had Daryl Mitchell miscue to wide mid-off. CSK's charge in the powerplay was led by Rachin Ravindra, with some assistance from Ajinkya Rahane.

Rahane targeted Dayal and hit a six and two perfectly-timed fours off him. He added 66 off 41 for the third wicket with Ravindra, whose gameplan seemed quite simple - to slice the length balls square through off.

Like he did and succeeded against Maxwell in the first over. He would use even the slightest of width - like Mohammed Siraj provided in the fourth over - to thrash it through point,

while the short-of-good-length ones would either be ramped over short third or heaved through midwicket. He brought up his half-century off 31 balls and looked good to be the difference, before a mix-up with Shivam Dube saw him be run out.

Thereon, dew was a constant presence in the middle, which made RCB reluctant to bowl spin. That helped Ravindra Jadeja, who walked in after Ravindra's dismissal, to get into the groove quickly. An off drive against Green got him going before he hit a six each of Dayal, Siraj and Lockie Ferguson. Despite middling almost everything, it was not enough to see the side through.

Contrasting middle overs

In hindsight, the middle overs proved to be the difference between the two teams. It was the phase in which Patidar and Green showed RCB the way. It was the phase where RCB scored boundaries at will. It was the phase that set them up for a tall final flourish with the bat.

RCB scored 113 runs in overs 7 to 16, and lost just two wickets. But CSK could not quite capitalise in the phase, and could score only 80. What's more, they lost four wickets in the phase, one each in the 12th, 13th and the 14th to be devoid of any momentum. One of those was all du Plessis' brilliance. Mitchell Santner had creamed a lofted off drive off Siraj that seemed to clear mid-off. But du Plessis swiftly moved to his right and timed his leap perfectly to pluck out a one-handed stunner. CSK, as a result, went from 115 for 3 to 129 for 6 in the space of 13 balls.

It prompted Dhoni to walk out to bat at the earliest point this season. And even his 25 off 13 was not enough for a possible fairytale ending, if it indeed is one.

MATCH 69

Sunrisers Hyderabad 215 for 6 (Abhishek 66, Klaasen 42, Arshdeep 2-37) beat Punjab Kings 214 for 5 (Rossouw 49, Taide 46, Natarajan 2-33) by four wickets

Prabhsimran Singh and Atharva Taide put on 97 for the first wicket off 55 balls, Rilee Rossouw hit 49 at a strike rate above 200, and Jitesh Sharma provided the closing fireworks, with 32 not out off 15. They set Sunrisers Hyderabad (SRH) 215 to win.

And still it wasn't enough for Punjab Kings (PBKS). Not nearly enough to halt the batting juggernaut that SRH have been in IPL 2024. They lost their best batter Travis Head first ball, but raced through the powerplay thanks to Abhishek Sharma and Rahul Tripathi, who hit 66 off 28 and 33 off 18 respectively, propelling the team to 84 for 2 at the end of their first six overs.

From then, the scoring didn't really slow until the target was within sight. Heinrich Klaasen led SRH to the brink of victory with 42 off 26. The winning runs were hit with five balls to spare.

Dare we say something about the bowlers? Only SRH's T Natarajan escaped with decent figures, taking 2 for 33.

SRH now move into second on the points table. That they would finish their and play the Qualifier 1 against Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR) was confirmed after Rajasthan Royals' last league match against KKR in Guwahati was washed out.

1:55

Should Rahul Tripathi play the playoffs for SRH?

Abhishek lights up Hyderabad one last time in IPL 2024

In what was their last home game this season, Abhishek gave the SRH faithful a show to remember a batting-powered season by. He smashed his first two sixes over fine leg, when bowlers delivered short-of-a-length balls into the body, and went on to hit six sixes in all, in addition to five fours. Most of these relied on excellent timing, but there was luck there too - one of the sixes came off the outside edge.

He sped past 50 off 21 balls, but this was only his third-fastest half-century this season - he had hit fifties off 16 and 19 balls in the weeks gone by.

Abhishek's 72-run partnership with Tripathi, which came off 29 balls, was the foundation of SRH's chase. Even after they were parted, the required rate seemed tame.

Klaasen plays a measured innings

As good as Abhishek's fireworks were, SRH still needed 86 off the last 59 balls after he was out, and Klaasen delivered one of his more chilled-out innings. He still hit sixes when it felt good, of course, the most spectacular being the back-foot six down the ground off the bowling of Harpreet Brar, who had just delivered a standard length ball outside off stump.

But as wickets fell around him, it needed someone to take responsibility and massage the chase home. Klaasen was bowled by Brar with SRH needing seven to win off 11 balls. But he had got them close enough.

3:03

'Punjab should hold on to their Indian players'

Prabhsimran and Taide's opening mayhem

PBKS had reason to hope they would get a closing win for this season, though, and finish outside the bottom two, mainly because of the start they had in the game. Prabhsimran was outstanding on the leg side, hitting all his four sixes there in his 71 off 45. Taide made 46 off 27.

A match-defining four overs

There was something of a slowdown after Vijayakanth Viyaskanth, the young legspinner from Jaffna, took Prabhsimran's wicket in the 15th over. Although Jitesh finished strong, perhaps overs 15 to 18 (both inclusive) was when PBKS lost their way. They had been 151 for 1 at the start of that passage, looking poised to push 250. By the end of the 18th over, they were 186 for 5.

MATCH 70

Rajasthan Royals vs Kolkata Knight Riders Match abandoned without a ball bowled

Rain in Guwahati denied hosts Rajasthan Royals a shot at a top-two finish in the final league fixture of IPL 2024. The game was abandoned, without a ball being bowled, at around 10.50pm local time, meaning RR ended the league phase with four losses in a row, followed by this washout, to finish third with 17 points.

Sunrisers Hyderabad also had 17 points, having successfully chased down 215 against a severely depleted Punjab Kings side earlier in the day, but they stayed second, thanks to a superior net run-rate. Pat Cummins' SRH will now face table-toppers Kolkata Knight Riders in the first qualifier in Ahmedabad on May 21. As for Royals, they will run into a red-hot Royal Challengers Bangalore side, which is on a six-match winning streak, in the Eliminator the next day at the same venue.

KKR's players might have to rock up cold in the playoffs, with their last two league games having been abandoned without a ball being bowled. Especially Rahmanullah Gurbaz, Phil Salt's potential replacement, who is yet to play his first game this IPL. His last outing with the bat was for Afghanistan in mid-March.

Royals have similar concerns around their overseas players. Their finisher Shimron Hetmyer was originally deemed fit for Monday's fixture, but eventually didn't make it to the XI or the Impact subs bench, with RR captain Sanju Samson suggesting that they had to make some last-minute changes to their team.

Hetmyer hasn't played since failing to finish a tense chase against SRH along with Rovman Powell on May 2. Tom Kohler-Cadmore, who is somewhat of a like-for-like replacement for Jos Buttler, had a fairly rough initiation into the IPL, managing 18 off 23 balls against Punjab Kings in much drier conditions in Guwahati on May 15.

The Guwahati surface was under covers for the most of Monday evening before the rain briefly relented to allow the toss for a seven-over shootout, which was scheduled to restart at 10.45pm local time. However, soon after KKR won the toss and chose to bowl, the rain returned to force a damp end to the league phase.

MATCH 71 QUALIFIER 1(N)

Kolkata Knight Riders 164 for 2 (Shreyas 58*, Venkatesh 51, Natarajan 1-22) beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 159 (Tripathi 55, Starc 3-34, Varun 2-26) by eight wickets

Travis Head and Abhishek Sharma are used to going bang, bang and pretty much killing off games in the first six overs at IPL 2024. But in the first qualifier in Ahmedabad, it was Mitchell Starc who went bang, bang, bang in the powerplay to secure Kolkata Knight Riders' spot in the IPL final on Sunday in Chennai.

After Starc scythed through SRH's top order in an opening spell of 3-0-22-3, Varun Chakravarthy took over in the middle overs to help dismiss SRH for 159 in 19.3 overs.

Related

Starc bowls Head to win bragging rights

In reply, Shreyas Iyer and Venkatesh Iyer made unbeaten half-centuries as KKR ran down the target with more than six overs to spare.

Sunrisers Hyderabad will face the winner of the Eliminator between Rajasthan Royals and Royal Challengers Bangalore, for a shot at a rematch with KKR in the final.

Swingin' Starc

Starc's first ball to Head was an outswinger that was squeezed to extra cover. His second threatened to angle in, but swung and seamed away late to breach the defences of Head and leave his stumps splayed.

Travis Head had his stumps cleaned up second ball, bagging his second duck in a row • Associated Press

Head was gone for a duck. This was the fifth time that Starc had taken out Head across formats - four of those wickets ducks.

In the second over, pacer Vaibhav Arora, who was picked ahead of spinner Anukul Roy on a surface that was a mix of red and black soil and had some early moisture, had Abhishek Sharma scooping a catch to Andre Russell at short cover for 3.

SRH plunged into further trouble when Starc snagged Nitish Kumar Reddy (9) and Shahbaz Ahmed (0) off successive balls in his third over. Starc could have also dismissed Rahul Tripathi in his second over when he speared in a yorker that struck him flush on his boot and would have cannoned into leg stump. But KKR decided against a review and SRH went on to finish the powerplay on 45 for 4. Only twice in 14 innings have SRH scored fewer runs in the powerplay in IPL 2024.

Tripathi counters KKR

Tripathi, who kept his place at No. 3, repaired SRH's innings with a half-century. He combined power with invention to manufacture scoring opportunities. He whacked Arora over midwicket and ramped a bouncer from Harshit Rana for six. He reached his fifty off 29 balls when he reverse-swept Varun for four.

Rahul Tripathi hit a fifty off 29 balls•Associated Press

Tripathi, however, could not press on as Russell capitalised on a mix-up to run him out for 55 off 35 balls. Tripathi was so distraught that he sat on the stairs in Ahmedabad, with his head buried in his knee, for a long time. That image of Tripathi summed up SRH's night.

Varun's variations

Heinrich Klaasen had taken Sunil Narine for 16 off eight balls, but KKR's other mystery spinner, Varun Chakravarthy, struck in his first over to cut Klaasen's innings short on 32 off 21 balls. Varun darted one into the pitch and didn't allow Klaasen underneath the length as he dragged a catch to deep midwicket. He then pinned Bhuvneshwar Kumar lbw with a wrong 'un in the 16th over that cost KKR just one run. It was Varun's 40th wicket in 27 IPL innings since the 2023 season started. No other spinner has more wickets than Varun during this period.

At 126 for 9 in 16 overs, SRH were in danger of being bundled out for a sub-140 total, but Cummins' 30 off 24 balls hauled them to a more respectable 159.

Varun Chakravarthy finished with 2 for 26 off his four overs•Associated Press

KKR ace the chase

After doing a good job behind the stumps, Rahmanullah Gurbaz eased himself in with the bat in what was his first outing this season.

Phil Salt had left the IPL to link up with the England side, and Gurbaz slotted into his role and picked off 23 off 14 balls. He hit four boundaries and when he aimed for a fifth, T Natarajan had him holing out in his first over.

Three overs later, Cummins bounced out Narine for 21 off 16 balls, but KKR's openers had already done enough damage in the powerplay by slashing 63 runs off their target.

The Iyers - captain Shreyas and Venkatesh - then struck up an unbroken 97 partnership for the third wicket off only 44 balls to turn their chase into a cruise. Along the way, both batters posted half-centuries and it was Shreyas who finished it off in grand style in the 14th over, with a sequence of 6, 4, 6, 6 off Head.

MATCH 72 ELIMINATOR 1

Rajasthan Royals 174 for 6 (Jaiswal 45, Parag 36, Siraj 2-33) beat Royal Challengers Bengaluru 172 for 8 (Patidar 34, Kohli 33, Lomror 32, Avesh 3-44, Ashwin 2-19) by four wickets

Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) came into the IPL 2024 Eliminator with six successive wins behind them, and Rajasthan Royals (RR) with five successive winless games. But there really is no such thing as momentum in sport, and certainly not in a sport as fickle as T20.

Royals won an important toss, and their bowlers delivered a superb performance to restrict RCB to 172 at a venue where dew makes chasing significantly easier than setting targets.

It was a game of two halves, as RR got over the line with an over to spare despite a number of nervy moments in their chase.

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The Dhruv Jurel run-out: 'I just don't think you can give it out,' says Tom Moody

Dinesh Karthik gets reprieve in contentious lbw call

It was also a game of two ends. One square boundary in Ahmedabad was significantly longer than the other, and the RR bowlers used this asymmetry brilliantly. RCB scored 51 for 6 in their odd-numbered overs, when the longer boundary was to the leg side for the right-hand batter, and 121 for 2 from the other end.

It wasn't a coincidence that Trent Boult, R Ashwin and Avesh Khan, RR's best bowlers on the night, did the bulk of their bowling from the favourable end.

The imbalance existed even when RR batted: 111 for 1 in ten overs from one end, and 63 for 5 in nine overs from the other. It helped RR that they had right-left pairs occupying the crease for longer than RCB did, but not to a massive extent.

In the end, it came down to the total RCB put on the board. Faf du Plessis, their captain, admitted that they were about 20 runs short. He felt it was a 180 pitch when RCB batted, and a significantly higher-scoring one, thanks to the dew, when RR chased.

RR are now through to Qualifier 2 against Sunrisers Hyderabad (SRH) in Chennai on Friday. For RCB, this is another trophyless season but one that will be remembered fondly for many years to come.

ESPNcricinfo Ltd

Trent Boult vs RCB

The game of two ends began early. Boult swung the new ball in an opening spell of three overs, and was inch-perfect with his lines and lengths: no room for the batters to free their arms, and no slot balls or long-hops. He conceded just six runs and two leg-byes in those three overs, and had du Plessis caught at deep midwicket to end an opening stand of 37.

At the other end, though, RCB clattered 42 in three overs. Virat Kohli, using his feet routinely to step out or make room, looked ominous while rushing to 30 off 19 by the end of the powerplay.

Chahal gets Kohli; Ashwin applies the squeeze

Boult gave way to Ashwin from the end with the long leg-side boundary (for the right-hand batter), and that end continued to be hard to score off. Ashwin bowled beautifully, bowling at high pace - either into the pitch or right up at the batters' feet - while offering no room, and primarily using his carrom and reverse-carrom variations against RCB's right-hand batters.

But he was also aided by the end he bowled from, and the fact that his first two overs came soon after RCB had lost big wickets. He bowled the seventh over soon after Boult had taken out du Plessis, and the ninth immediately after Kohli had fallen to Yuzvendra Chahal.

Kohli's slog-sweep has been one of the stories of IPL 2024. The shot, brought out of cold storage after many years, has allowed Kohli to overturn a long-standing issue of slow scoring against spin, and given him an extra gear through the middle overs. On this day, though, he was out to his first slog-sweep, caught on the midwicket boundary.

1:21

Moody on Maxwell's duck: Reckless cricket and absolute brain fade

Ashwin, Avesh keep RCB in check

RCB kept playing their shots when they could attack the short leg-side boundary, and took Chahal for 13 in the tenth over and Avesh for 13 in the 12th. In between, Dhruv Jurel, running in from long-on, put down a sitter to reprieve Rajat Patidar when he miscued a big hit off Ashwin.

But Ashwin didn't let RR worry about that miss for too long, inducing a mis-hit from Cameron Green in the 13th over - his fourth - and following up with the dismissal of Glenn Maxwell, who ended a lean season with the bat by attempting to hit his first ball for six and picking out long-on.

Chahal bowled another expensive over, conceding 19 in the 14th, and when Patidar hooked Avesh for six at the start of the 15th - it was RCB's first boundary in an odd-numbered over - it looked as though a 190-ish total was possible. But Avesh got a shortish delivery to get big on Patidar next ball, and caused him to miscue to a backtracking mid-off fielder.

He could have had two in two, producing a perfect first-ball inducker to have Dinesh Karthik adjudged lbw, only for the decision, reviewed by the batter, overturned when the third umpire seemed to mistake bat hitting pad for an inside edge on to pad.

Karthik remained scratchy while scoring 11 off 13 in what is likely his final innings at the senior level, Avesh eventually getting him with a hard-length legcutter that climbed steeply on him in the 19th over. Mahipal Lomror gave RCB a bit of impetus towards the end with 32 off 17, which featured two leg-side sixes off Chahal, but their total of 172 seemed inadequate at the innings break.

1:22

What made Boult so effective against Kohli and du Plessis?

Jaiswal puts Royals on track

There were two dropped chances early in the chase. The first was a difficult one - Green throwing himself to his right at slip and putting down an edge from Yashasvi Jaiswal in the third over - and the second a sitter - Maxwell shelling Tom Kohler-Cadmore at deep square-leg in the fifth. The two openers peppered the boundary either side of those misses - Yash Dayal particularly unfortunate to concede three fours to Jaiswal soon after having him dropped off his bowling - and RR ran to 45 for no loss by the end of the fifth.

Lockie Ferguson ended the powerplay with an excellent sixth over, conceding just two and bowling Kohler-Cadmore with a slower yorker. RR were still well on top, though, a fact they emphasised when Jaiswal and Sanju Samson took 17 runs - including a six and two fours, all towards the shorter boundary - off Swapnil Singh's left-arm spin in the seventh over.

Shimron Hetmyer's boundaries kept Rajasthan Royals in control of the chase • Associated Press

Royals stutter but complete the job

Green came on in the tenth over and began to make a serious impact with his hard lengths, conceding just 11 runs in three overs while having Jaiswal caught behind while attempting a scoop. He also helped run Jurel out, fumbling a brilliant, one-bounce throw from Kohli in the deep but somehow managing to break the wicket with the ball still in contact with his hands.

At the other end, RR lost Samson, leaving his crease too early to be stumped off a deliberate off-side wide from Karn Sharma. At the end of the 14th over, Royals were four down and needed 58 off 36.

One big over would close that gap, and it came in the 16th, with Shimron Hetmyer and Riyan Parag taking 17 off Green's fourth. Then Hetmyer hit Dayal for a pair of fours in the 17th, bringing the equation down to 19 off 18.

There was still time for one last twist, however, with Mohammed Siraj bowling Parag for 36 with a full, straight one that he played across, and finishing the over by inducing a miscue from Hetmyer.

It left Royals needing 13 from 12 with two new batters at the crease, and an unlikely RCB win was still on the cards. Rovman Powell, though, finished it off, finding a bit of luck early in the 19th with a pair of edged fours off Ferguson before completing the job with a stylish straight six.

MATCH 73 QUALIFIER 2(N)

Sunrisers Hyderabad 175 for 9 (Klaasen 50, Avesh 3-27, Boult 3-45) beat Rajasthan Royals 139 for 7 (Jurel 56, Shahbaz 3-23, Abhishek 2-24) by 36 runs

"There's nothing more satisfying than hearing a big crowd go silent." Pat Cummins, November 18, 2023. The next day he took Virat Kohli's wicket and made a ground with 100,000 people feel like a ghost town.

"We have earned the right to have one of those days and still win tournaments." Pat Cummins, May 21, 2024. It's taken a little while longer for him to walk the talk but boy when he says something we best listen. Sunrisers Hyderabad marched into the final of IPL 2024 and this time they did it with their bowling.

It looked like Rajasthan Royals had won a crucial toss and they did the right thing by opting to chase. One square boundary was significantly shorter than the other (61m vs 72m) and asymmetry like that makes it really hard to defend totals, especially if the dew came in, but it didn't. All of a sudden SRH had a dry ball and a dry pitch. And they worked a miracle on that.

SRH stun RR with spin

Shahbaz Ahmed originally came into this game to try and shore up a stop-start batting innings. It was the second time in two playoff games that SRH had to pull the Impact Player trigger early. He made 17 in a partnership of 43 with Heinrich Klaasen to push the total up to 175. But that total looked light when Yashasvi Jaiswal raced to 41 off 19 balls. The game was slipping away. Except it had also shown SRH a way to claw back. Jaydev Unadkat's first over - the seventh - showed signs of how much the ball was gripping. SRH had no specialist spinner in their line-up but in conditions like these you don't need specialists. You just need people that can turn the ball and hold a line. Shahbaz did that and more, winning a match-up he was second-favourite in. Bowling into the left-hander's hitting arc, he handed Jaiswal his first dismissal to spin since IPL 2022.

Hetmyer fined for Code of Conduct breach

Shimron Hetmyer has been fined 10% of his match fees for breaching the IPL Code of Conduct during the Qualifier 2. He committed a Level 1 offence under Article 2.2 of the IPL Code of Conduct. He admitted to the offence and accepted the match referee's sanction.

Cummins brought Abhishek Sharma, who had bowled only three overs this campaign, from the other end. He even called Aiden Markram to roll his arm over. The pitch was now taking handsome amounts of turn and Cummins used any means in his armoury to exploit it. SRH produced a 33-ball period without a single boundary using bowlers whom they haven't really had to turn to but were there now at this crucial time. This 33-ball period also included four wickets. Shahbaz who hadn't picked up a wicket since April 5 turned up with 4-0-23-3 tonight. Abhishek, who had bowled his full quota of overs only twice before Friday, finished with 4-0-24-2.

Klaasen gamechanger

SRH have one of the world's best batters as a finisher and that played a big part in their win. Heinrich Klaasen does not need any protection. He does not need his entry point to be delayed because he has the ability to move through the gears. He can resurrect a failing innings with risk-free shots and still find ways to hit boundaries when he needs to. He was 21 off 20 balls in the 13th over. SRH were 108 for 4 at that point. Batting in Chennai is tricky because of the slowness of the pitches here. Mis-hits can still go for four in the powerplay when there are only two fielders outside the circle but that luck runs out once the field restrictions are lifted. Klaasen understood this nuance and waited for his moments; his match-ups. He has an excellent one against Yuzvendra Chahal and that's whom he targeted, hitting two mighty sixes, including one to the long boundary. The back-foot drive over extra cover was breathtaking.

Heinrich Klaasen brought out his vertical-bat pull against spin•BCCI

Royal pains

Looking back now, all the good work RR did feels bittersweet. Trent Boult gave them a first-over wicket for the seventh time this season breaking a partnership that has rewritten history. Abhishek and Travis Head have been scoring their runs at 13.64 an over, the best in IPL history (min 300 runs scored).

Sandeep Sharma bowled 18 slower balls in his spell for just 17 runs and picked up the wicket of Head. His yorker, where he changed his action to be extra slinky, slipped underneath Klaasen in prime hitting form and knocked out his stumps. RR gave away only 12 runs in the last two overs with Avesh Khan executing his yorkers near perfectly. He dismissed Nitish Kumar Reddy, who actually had a decent plan against those yorkers - the reverse scoop because there was no one on the deep-third boundary - by refusing to give him a ball to get underneath. It was high quality planning and execution.

Royals' batting gets stuck again

RR's strength in their bowling comes at a price. The batting depth. And they felt it all the more acutely because Jos Buttler has left to link up with the England squad to prepare for the T20 World Cup and Shimron Hetmyer has been carrying an injury. They tried covering up for it by sending R Ashwin at No. 6 but it didn't work.

Tom Kohler-Cadmore, who was brought in to open the batting in place of Buttler, looked out of his depth, scoring 6 off 13 before being dismissed for 10 off 16. Sanju Samson made a mistake under pressure, looking to access the long boundary and getting caught for 10 off 11. Riyan Parag was facing 3.3 degrees of turn on average and he too made the wrong call, looking to hit across the line and getting caught off the top edge for 6 off 10. Dhruv Jurel fought hard for a while, scoring 56 off 35 balls, but the balance of power never really looked like it was shifting.

SRH have produced some scintillating performances in this IPL but this - winning with their weaker suit - was special. They're going to be a serious threat to Kolkata Knight Riders on Sunday.

MATCH 74 FINAL

Kolkata Knight Riders 114 for 2 (Venkatesh 52*, Gurbaz 39) beat Sunrisers Hyderabad 113 (Cummins 24, Russell 3-19, Starc 2-14) by eight wickets

Just like the 2015 World Cup final, Mitchell Starc led the rout of the second-best team of the tournament as Kolkata Knight Riders fashioned the most one-sided IPL final to secure their third title. Starc started with arguably the ball of the tournament, and the most complete attack of the tournament was too good for Sunrisers Hyderabad on a pitch that offered seam movement for at least seven overs followed by grip off the surface too. SRH were bowled out for the lowest total in an IPL final, 113, which KKR chased down with 57 balls to spare thanks to Venkatesh Iyer's blitz of 52 off 26.

Five of the six bowlers used by KKR took a wicket in their first over, including a golden duck for SRH's talisman Travis Head to Vaibhav Arora in the second over. It is hard to find fault with SRH who had to take risks while KKR's strategy was straightforward: with the ball moving, just minimise the bad balls and experiment less. Whenever SRH looked to force the pace, they ended up losing wickets.

Scintillating Starc

Starc didn't quite start the tournament the way he would have wanted after becoming the costliest player in IPL history, but he turned up for the playoffs all right. The first ball of the match swung away to beat Abhishek Sharma, who was taking first strike after Starc bowled Head second ball in the Qualifier 1. By the end of the over, Starc had worked himself into enough of a rhythm to pitch the ball on leg and hit the top of off. It was an unplayable delivery at Starc's pace. You could forgive Abhishek for not lunging forward because it was pitched on a good length and the movement was late.

Abhishek Sharma could not keep out Mitchell Starc•BCCI

Head got on strike only last ball of the second over, which is when Arora started on a good length outside leg, and swung and seamed it to finish just outside the top of off. Head pushed at it, edged, and was caught behind.

While Arora mixed up his inswing with various-paced short balls, Starc kept using the scrambled-seam ball to threaten both the edges. One outside edge flew wide of slip, before Rahul Tripathi fell off a top edge as he tried to push back.

Rana starts the second slide

Seeing how the ball was moving, KKR used just the two bowlers in the powerplay, but Arora went for 17 in the final powerplay over, taking SRH up to 40 for 3. That seemed like a

situation from which SRH could salvage the game, especially with an Impact Player up their sleeve.

It wasn't to be. In his first over, Harshit Rana bowled three straight slower balls before bowling the hard length at 146kmph and managing seam movement against the angle. Nitish Reddy had no choice but to go after it, and all he managed was an edge through to the keeper.

Harshit Rana was flying high in the final •Associated Press

Aiden Markram and Heinrich Klaasen were now SRH's last hope really. They batted cautiously together for three overs but when Markram tried to take Andre Russell on, he found long-on. Soon after Varun Chakravathy produced the wicket of Shahbaz Ahmed with a top edge on the sweep from well outside off.

In the next over, the Impact Player Abdul Samad gave Russell his 18th wicket of this IPL, the most he has taken in one edition. Rana came back to get Klaasen playing on to a slower ball. Russell would go on to add a 19th to his tally when ending the innings with Pat Cummins' wicket in the 19th over.

Not before Cummins managed the top score to take SRH past 100.

The chase as one long celebration

KKR continued their domination of Bhuvneshwar Kumar by charging at him even though they lost Sunil Narine for 6 off 2 at the other end. Venkatesh hit Bhuvneshwar for two straight sixes in a 20-run third over, and when he and Rahmanullah Gurbaz took another 20 off T Natarajan in the sixth over, KKR had put together the most in a powerplay in an IPL final (72).

Gurbaz hit boundaries post the powerplay, but didn't have the benefit of a review because of a technology breakdown when given out lbw for 39. That only allowed captain Shreyas Iyer to be in the middle for the winning moment after a tough year for him in which he has lost his place in and retainer with the Indian national team.